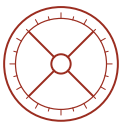
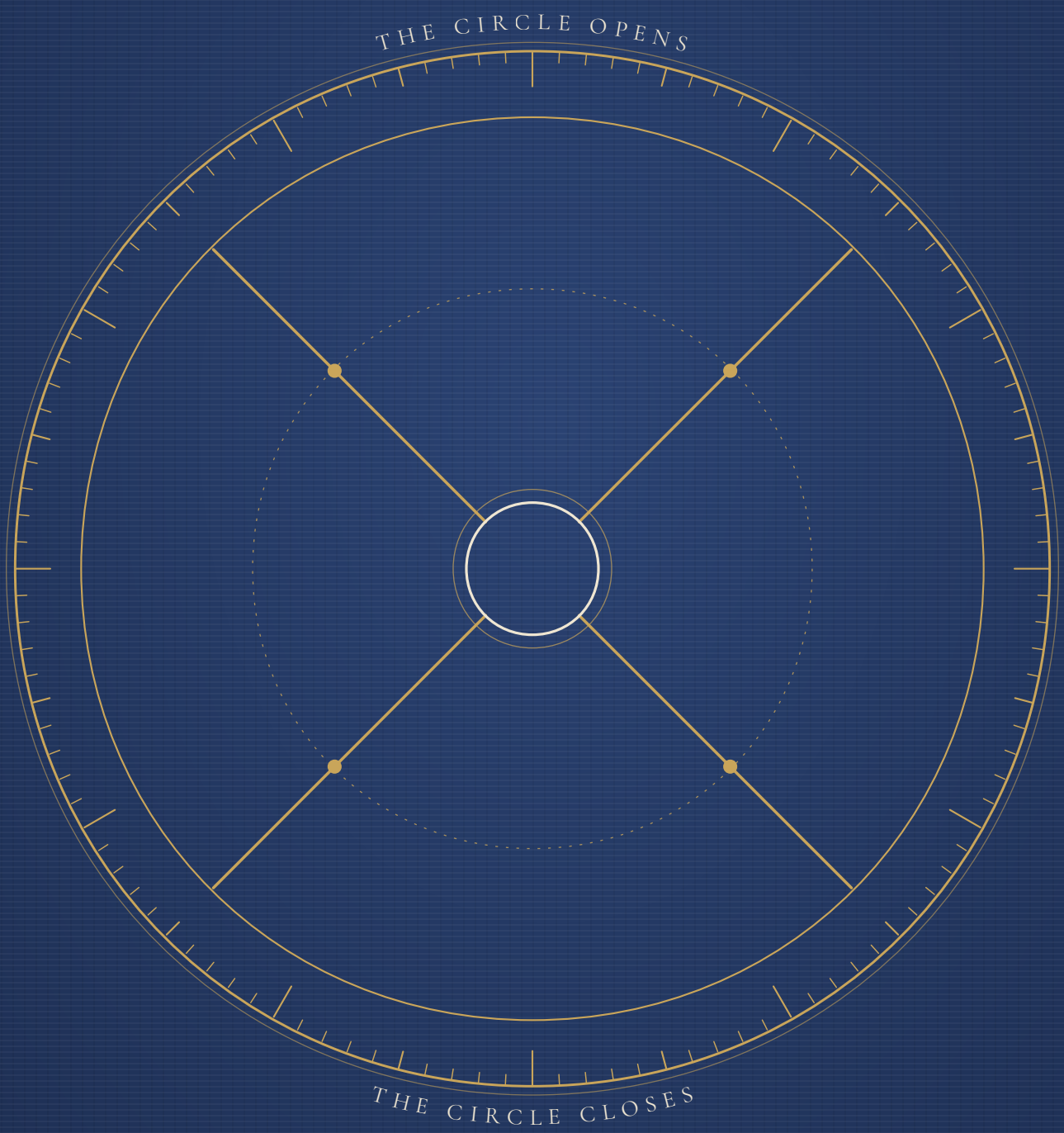
Who Shall Be Able to Stand?




THE CIRCLE OPENS
THE CIRCLE CLOSES

Who Shall Be Able to *Stand?*



Stasiological Eschatology, the Chiasmus of Plague and Hand, and the Unarmed Witness in Stephen King's The Stand

A DISSERTATION IN COMPARATIVE LITERATURE, POLITICAL THEOLOGY, AND THE PHILOSOPHY OF CATASTROPHE

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
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22 October 2026



Abstract

This dissertation offers a full philosophical, theological, and comparative reading of Stephen King's *The Stand* (1978; *Complete & Uncut Edition*, 1990). It proposes a new interpretive framework, *stasiological eschatology*, for reading both the novel and the wider literature of civilizational ending. The usual reading treats the book as a Manichaean showdown between Good and Evil, the framing its own first jacket proposed, or as a Tolkienian quest retold in American vernacular. I argue instead that the novel's governing intelligence lies in its title. The Indo-European root **steh₂-* ("to stand") has descendants that map closely onto the problems the narrative poses in sequence. In Greek these include *stasis* (at once "standing" and "civil war"), *anastasis* ("resurrection"), *apostasis* ("defection"), *ekstasis*, *hypostasis*, and *stauros* ("upright stake," hence "cross"). In Latin they include *status*, *constitutio*, *testis*, and *superstes*. In German there is *Bestand* ("standing-reserve").

The mapping runs as follows. The weaponized influenza is *Bestand* that has escaped its frame. The post-plague polities of Boulder and Las Vegas are rival constitutions, and their antagonism is *stasis* in Thucydides' sense. Randall Flagg, "the last magician of rational thought," is a figure without *hypostasis* whose power lies in turning persons into standing-reserve. The titular stand is neither battle nor victory. It is the unarmed posture of the witness (*testis*, *superstes*, *martys*). The witnesses are sent west on foot, without supplies, in the clothes they stand in. They stand as a third party before sovereign violence, and they are vindicated by no act of their own. What vindicates them is the self-inversion of that violence's own instrument.

I call this self-inversion *the chiasmus of plague and hand*. The novel opens with a human artifact producing something that looks like an act of God. It closes with an act of God carried out through a human

artifact. I read the novel alongside its originators (Revelation, Exodus, Daniel, Malachi; Augustine, Boethius, Milton, Bunyan; Hobbes, Locke, Vico, Rousseau; Kierkegaard, Dostoevsky, Nietzsche; Weber, Schmitt, Benjamin, Heidegger, Arendt, Horkheimer and Adorno, Girard, Agamben) and its comparative kin (Shelley, London, Stewart, Camus, Lewis, Matheson, Miller, Dick, Le Guin, Saramago, Butler, McCarthy, Mandel). The reading shows that the novel's recursive frame places its eschatological event inside Vico's *ricorso* and Benjamin's cycle of mythic violence. That frame consists of "The Circle Opens," "The Circle Closes," and a final image of a wheel on which no man can stand for long. The novel's architecture is therefore a cross (*chi*, X) inscribed in a circle: a wheel whose rim is recurrence and whose hub is the stand.

On this reading, Stu Redman's closing "I don't know" becomes the novel's most rigorous philosophical statement: the stand cannot be institutionalized, only witnessed. The study concludes that *The Stand*, for all its formal impurity, is a major American contribution to political theology. It anticipates current debates on biopolitics, manufactured risk, testimonial ethics, and the post-secular, and its apparent naïveté hides a sophisticated theory of non-sovereign agency.

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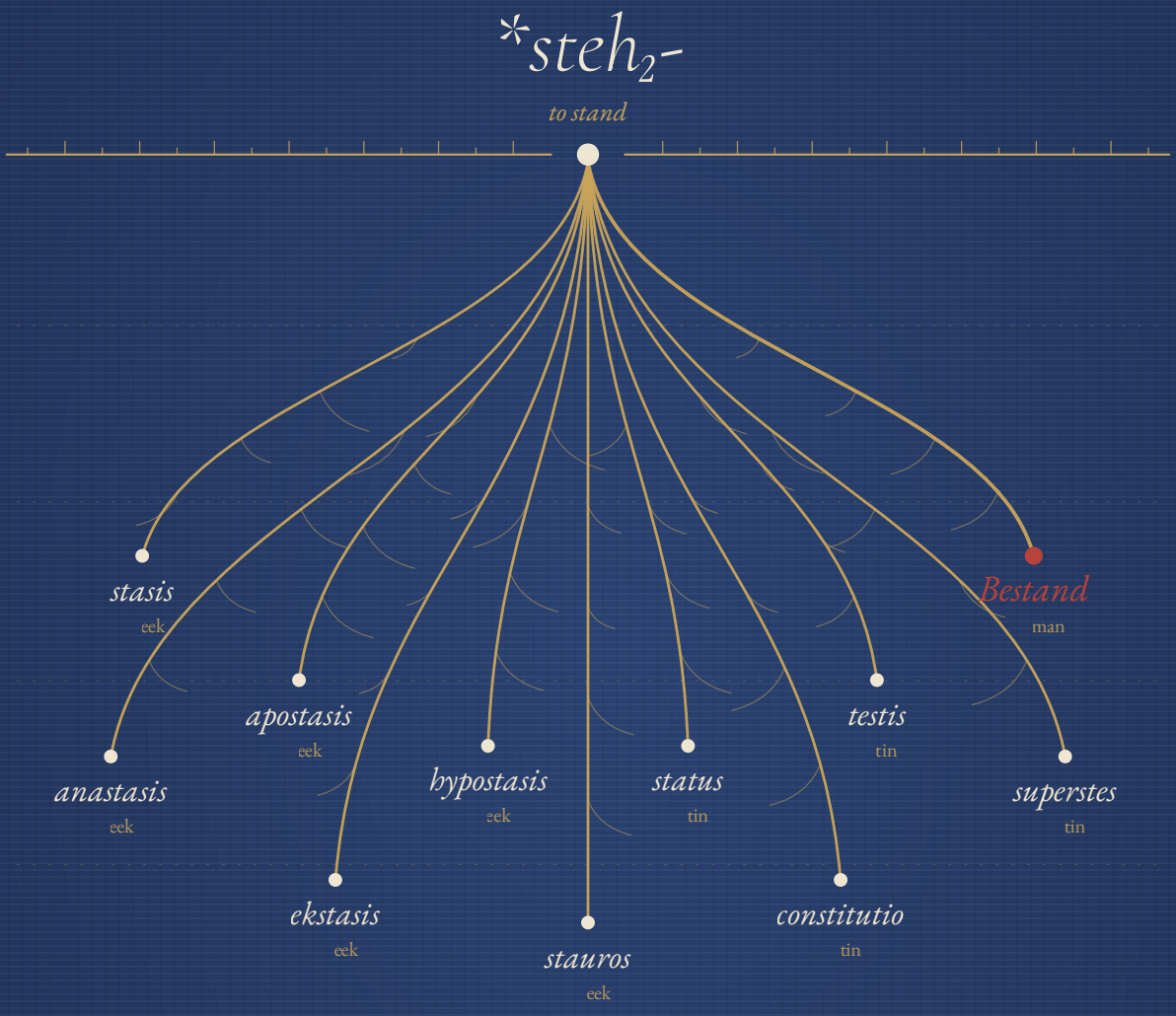
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Note on Editions, Citation, and Reference

Unless otherwise indicated, *The Stand* is cited from *The Stand: The Complete & Uncut Edition* (New York: Doubleday, 1990). This is the text King's preface offers to his Constant Reader as the book its author originally intended. Pagination differs across the hardcover, mass-market, trade, and digital printings of that edition, so references are by Book rather than page: I, "Captain Trips"; II, "On the Border"; III, "The Stand"; plus the frame sections "The Circle Opens" and "The Circle Closes." The 1978 Doubleday text is labeled *1978* wherever its readings differ.

Scripture is quoted from the Authorized (King James) Version. Its idiom saturates the American Protestant speech the novel imitates, and it keeps the verb "stand" in passages where modern translations often drop it. Classical, patristic, and early-modern sources are cited by their standard divisions; Vico is cited by the paragraph numbers of the 1744 *Scienza nuova*. Translations from Greek, Latin, German, French, and Italian are mine unless a published translation is named in the Bibliography (Part VI). Quotations from the novel are kept brief and serve the analysis.





Introduction

The Root and the Remnant



For the great day of his wrath is come; and who shall be able to stand?

(Revelation 6:17)

...stand only and behold
God's indignation on these godless poured
By me.

(Milton, *Paradise Lost* VI.810–12)

I. The Problem of the Popular Sublime

The Stand holds one of the strangest positions in the American literary field. It is among the most widely read novels of the late twentieth century and among the least theorized. Its popular standing is not in question: it was highly acclaimed by critics, is considered one of King's best novels, and has been included in lists of the best books of all time, and the 1990 restoration, at 1,152 pages King's longest stand-alone work, became a number-one bestseller. Academic criticism, though, has engaged the book only now and then, and usually from the defensive crouch forced on the champions of "genre" writers. The temperature of that crouch showed in 2003, when Harold Bloom greeted the National Book Foundation's award of its medal for distinguished contribution to American letters to King as "another low in the shocking process of dumbing down our cultural life." The scholarship that does exist has done essential work placing King within the Gothic and naturalist traditions: Douglas E. Winter's early monograph (1984), Tony Magistrale's studies of King's American Gothic (1988, 1992), and Heidi Strengell's account of his fusion of the Gothic with literary naturalism (2005). It has less often asked what kind of *thinking* a novel like *The Stand* does. The neglect is not merely sociological. It is hermeneutic, and its causes are instructive.

Twentieth-century criticism perfected a set of instruments: New Critical attention to verbal texture, deconstructive attention to the sentence that undoes itself, and the historicist reconstruction of discursive context. All three are calibrated to find intelligence in dense prose. The intelligence of *The Stand* is mainly not textural but architectonic. It lies in:

- the arrangement of episodes;
- the distribution of positions across a large cast;
- long-range rhymes between images separated by eight hundred pages;
- a vocabulary of scriptural allusion that the characters speak as everyday idiom rather than as citation;
- and the decision, the most consequential in the book, to name the whole work after a posture rather than an event.

A reader trained to look for thought in sentences will find in King's sentences a talkative, colloquial, sometimes slack vernacular, and will conclude that thought is absent. A reader trained to look for thought in structure will find something closer to a *summa*. Around the single premise of near-total depopulation, the novel convenes almost every major position in the Western argument about political order, the nature of evil, providence, and the end of history, and sets them to work against one another.

This dissertation reads as the second reader would, under the sign of what may be called the *popular sublime*. Burke located the sublime in terror and magnitude. Kant's "mathematical" sublime lies in the imagination's humiliation before a magnitude it cannot grasp in a single intuition, and in reason's consequent discovery of a faculty adequate to the idea of totality (*Critique of Judgment*, §§25–27). *The Stand* works in both registers at once. There is the terror of an engineered strain of influenza that kills over 99 percent of the world's population. And there is the arithmetical sublime of a narrative so long that reading it becomes a test of endurance. King's habitual address to his audience, *Constant Reader*, is itself a stasiological term (as Chapter 1 will show):

constans, from *con-stare*, "to stand firm together." The reader of the restored text is asked to stand, and the asking is part of the form.

King's own poetics, set out three years after the novel in *Danse Macabre* (1981), gives an initial bearing. That book's informal theory is organized around archetypes and what King calls "Dionysian horror". It holds that the seeds of effective horror lie in the cultural climate and political currents of the moment, and it gives the genre a paradoxical job: transgressive in its materials, conservative in its function, reaffirming the norm by staging what happens when it is violated. *The Stand* goes beyond this account. It begins as horror (the plague), becomes epic (the journeys), turns political (the two constitutions), and ends as something without a stable genre name: an eschatology that refuses to end. The norm it reaffirms cannot be the suburban order whose violation horror classically stages, because that order has been wiped out before Book I is over. It is an older and more fragile norm, the one King's 1990 preface names when it calls the book "this long tale of dark Christianity."

II. Three Received Readings and Their Remainder

Three interpretive frames have governed the novel's reception, both in criticism and in the vast culture of commentary a book this popular generates. Each is correct as far as it goes. Each leaves something unexplained, and those leftovers, taken together, are the problem this dissertation addresses.

(a) The Manichaean epic. The first and most durable frame is printed on the book itself. The 1978 jacket presented the novel as an "epic of final confrontation between Good and Evil". It presented its antagonist as a drifter of a hundred aliases in whom Satan's hour had come round again, a phrase lifted from Yeats's "rough beast, its hour come round at last," which already signals the novel's apocalyptic intertexts. Later publisher's copy sharpened the dualism, describing Flagg as a man who "delights in chaos and violence." The frame is Manichaean in the technical sense: two substantial principles, each with its own

power, contesting a single field. The novel resists it at three decisive points.

1. **The city of the Dark Man is the most orderly polity in the book.** Flagg's Las Vegas restores its power grid, punishes narcotics with crucifixion, disciplines labor, and readies combat aircraft while the Boulder Free Zone is still arguing about who sits on its committees. Whatever Flagg delights in, it is not chaos. The summary of the 1994 adaptation is more accurate than the 1978 jacket when it says he builds "a harsh authoritarian society."
2. **The climax contradicts the dualist logic of combat.** The champions of the good do not fight. They are taken without resistance and destroyed together with their enemies.
3. **The frame cannot account for the novel's most theologically exact moment.** Glen Bateman, brought before Flagg, discovers that his adversary is, in the strict sense, *nothing*, and he laughs. Laughter at the nullity of evil is not a Manichaean gesture. It is an Augustinian one, the gesture of a theology for which evil is *privatio boni*, a parasitic absence with no being of its own (*Enchiridion* 11; *Confessions* VII.12).

Augustine, it is worth recalling, spent nine years as a Manichaean "hearer" before his conversion. *The Stand* repeats his journey: a Manichaean surface laid over an Augustinian depth.

(b) The Tolkienian transposition. The second frame is King's own and the one repeated most often. For a decade, he has said, he had wanted to write a fantasy epic on the model of *The Lord of the Rings*, but set in America. In the event, the hobbit became a Texan named Stu Redman, the Dark Lord became a merciless, supernatural drifter named Randall Flagg, and Las Vegas took the role of Mordor. The analogy is illuminating, and Chapter 1 pursues it. But it hides as much as it shows. Tolkien's epic culminates in *The Return of the King*; King's has no king to return. The political imagination of *The Stand* is republican to the root. What returns in Boulder is not a monarch but the constitutional order of the dead republic, reconvened by its survivors in an as-

sembly that opens with the national anthem. An epic without a king (save the one on the title page) is a different kind of epic, and that difference is the subject of Chapter 4.

(c) The sociological laboratory. The third frame descends from George R. Stewart's novel *Earth Abides*, which King has named as one of his main inspirations. It reads the novel as an experiment in social reconstruction: which institutions must be rebuilt, in what order, and by whom, when ninety-nine of every hundred people are dead. Book II rewards this reading generously. The Free Zone must restore electrical power, bury the dead, police a population with no police, and wait to learn whether children born to immune parents will live. But the sociological frame cannot explain three things:

- why the novel's professional sociologist, Glen Bateman, ends his most famous lecture not with a finding but with a theological claim: that "human society was made in the image of His opposite number, and is always trying to get back home";
- why the Free Zone's decisive act is not an institutional decision but a prophetic command;
- why the restoration of order in Boulder appears, in the closing chapters, as the start of a new danger rather than the reaching of a goal.

Each frame isolates one register (moral, mythic, sociological), and each leaves the same residue:

1. the passivity of the climax;
2. the orderliness of evil;
3. the cyclicity of the frame, in which the last pages of the 1990 text bring Flagg back to life on a distant shore;
4. the title.

No reading that treats "the stand" as a synonym for "the final battle" can account for a final battle in which no one on the side of the good lifts a hand.

III. The Title as Theory: Toward a Stasiology

Consider, then, the title as a theory. In American English the noun *stand* is loaded to a degree few common words are.

- **Heroic defeat.** It names the defeat of the armed few: the "last stand" of the Alamo (1836) and of the Little Bighorn (1876). Richard Slotkin has shown these to be load-bearing in the national mythology of "regeneration through violence" (Slotkin 1973; 1985).
- **Testimony.** It names the place where testimony is given. In an American courtroom one *takes the stand*, and the witness box is simply *the stand*.
- **Conscience.** It names the posture of conscience: "Here I stand; I can do no other." Luther may or may not have spoken those words at Worms in 1521; they appear in the early printed accounts but not in the official transcript. Max Weber chose them, near the close of "Politics as a Vocation" (1919), as the emblem of political maturity.
- **The Cold War.** It names that era's characteristic condition, the *standoff*, and its typical military dispositions, *standing by* and *standing down*.
- **A founding fear.** It names a fear at the base of the republic. Among the grievances in the Declaration of Independence is that the king "has kept among us, in times of peace, Standing Armies without the Consent of our legislatures."
- **The eschatological question.** In the scriptural idiom that King's Methodist childhood put at his disposal, it names the eschatological question above all others: "who shall be able to stand?" (Revelation 6:17); "who may abide the day of his coming? and who shall stand when he appeareth?" (Malachi 3:2).

Against that question stands the instruction that defines the novel's climax: "Fear ye not, stand still, and see the salvation of the LORD" (Exodus 14:13); "Ye shall not need to fight in this battle: set yourselves, stand ye still, and see the salvation of the LORD" (2 Chronicles 20:17); "take unto you the whole armour of God, that ye may be

able to withstand in the evil day, and having done all, to stand" (Ephesians 6:13). When King himself wrote the script for the 1994 adaptation, he put the verb at the center of Mother Abagail's charge to the men she sends west. She assures them that "with God's help, you will *stand*, and be true." The stand is a command to be faithful, not a command to fight.

I call the theory this title encodes a *stasiology*. The word has occasionally been proposed in political science for the study of parties, using *stasis* in its sense of "faction." I re-derive it here to mean the study of *standing* in every sense the Indo-European root *$*steh_2$- has produced:

- the political: *stasis* as civil war; *status* as the State; *constitutio* as founding;
- the testimonial: *testis*, the third who stands by; *superstes*, the one who stands over an event and survives to speak of it;
- the ontological: *hypostasis*, substance; *ex-sistere*, existence;
- the ecstatic: *ekstasis*;
- the eschatological: *anastasis*, resurrection;
- the technological: *Bestand*, Heidegger's "standing-reserve";
- the apostatic: *apostasis*, the standing-away of defection;
- the cruciform: *stauros*, the upright stake that became the Cross.

Chapter 1 sets out this lexicon. The claim of this dissertation is that King's novel unfolds these senses in narrative order, whether or not King ever opened an etymological dictionary. It distributes them across its episodes, so that the plot becomes an argument about which kinds of standing remain possible once the State that used to stand for its citizens has fallen.

> **Thesis.** *The Stand* is a stasiological eschatology: a narrative inquiry into what it means to stand once the State has fallen. It answers by distinguishing three postures of standing: standing-reserve (*Bestand*), embodied in Flagg's Las Vegas; standing-together (*constitutio*), embodied in the Boulder Free Zone; and standing-as-witness (*testis*, *superstes*, *martys*), embodied in the unarmed men who walk west. Through the chiasmus of plague and

hand, it shows that only the third escapes the wheel of *stasis*, and that it escapes only for an instant.

Four subsidiary claims spell out the thesis.

1. The philological claim. The semantic field of **steh₂-* is the novel's deep grammar. Its senses are not packed into each use of the word, a fallacy James Barr warned against long ago. They are spread across the plot in an order that is itself an argument:

- *status* falls (Book I);
- *ekstasis* sorts the survivors (the dreams);
- *constitutio* and *Bestand* rise as rival answers (Book II);
- *apostasis* tests the first answer (Harold, Nadine);
- *testis* and *superstes* answer the second (Book III);
- *anastasis* frames the whole (Peter's recovery; Flagg's return).

2. The structural claim. The novel is organized by a chiasmus, a mirror-image crossing of two terms.

- In Book I, a human artifact, a weaponized influenza, escapes through the failure of a human hand: the containment that does not hold. The resulting catastrophe is so vast and indiscriminate that it takes on the outward form of what insurers call an "act of God."
- In Book III, an act of God (the hand that takes shape in the air above Las Vegas) detonates a human artifact, a nuclear warhead scavenged from the desert. Seen from a distance, for instance from the ravine where Stu Redman lies with a broken leg, this catastrophe has the outward form of a human accident.

Human cause with a divine appearance; divine cause with a human appearance: A–B–B–A. This is the narrative form of a theodicy. The God of *The Stand* introduces no new evil into the world. He re-routes the evil human beings have stockpiled. That enacts Augustine's dictum that God "judged it better to bring good out of evil than to permit no

evil to exist" (*Enchiridion* 27), and Joseph's word to his brothers: "ye thought evil against me; but God meant it unto good" (Genesis 50:20).

3. The political-theological claim. Boulder and Las Vegas stage the two degenerate solutions that modern political theology hands down:

- **Constitutional repetition**, which reproduces *stasis*. In the Free Zone's last days it ends with a newly elected sheriff whose first priority is to arm and enlarge the police force.
- **Sovereign *Bestand***, which perfects *stasis* by abolishing every standing except the sovereign's.

The novel places the stand outside both, in a self-emptying (kenotic), unarmed, testimonial non-sovereignty. Men are sent on foot, without food, in the clothes they stand in, a near-verbatim enactment of the Gospels' mission instructions (Luke 9:3; 10:4). One man, left behind with a broken leg, urges the others on without him, telling them God will provide for him: the very words Abraham spoke to Isaac on Moriah (Genesis 22:8).

4. The temporal claim. The frame ("The Circle Opens," "The Circle Closes") and the final image of the wheel place the eschatological event back inside cyclical time: Vico's *ricorso*, Boethius's *rota Fortunae*, Benjamin's "cycle maintained by mythic forms of law." The novel therefore ends not in apocalypse but in a decisive moment (*kairos*) within the cycle. Fran's last question is whether people ever learn, and Stu's answer is the deliberately ambiguous "I don't know." I read it as *docta ignorantia*, learned ignorance: the only honest posture for a witness who refuses to turn testimony into an institution.

Table 1 The three postures of standing in *The Stand*

Dimension	*Bestand* (standing-reserve)	*Constitutio* (standing-together)	*Testimonium* (standing-as-witness)
Locus	Las Vegas	The Boulder Free Zone	The road west; the cages; the ravine
Exemplary agents	Flagg; Lloyd Henreid; the Indian Springs technicians	The seven-member committee; the ratifying assembly	Glen, Larry, Ralph, Stu; Tom Cullen; Dayna Jurgens; Whitney Horgan

Dimension	*Bestand* (standing-reserve)	*Constitutio* (standing-together)	*Testimonium* (standing-as-witness)
Relation to violence	Sovereign exception (crucifixion); stockpiled force (jets, warhead)	Law-preserving; espionage; finally, armed deputies	Unarmed; unprovisioned; non-resisting
Temporal mode	The instantaneous command	Repetition (re-founding the dead republic)	*Kairos*: interruption of the cycle
Philosophical originators	Hobbes; Schmitt; Heidegger; Horkheimer–Adorno	Locke; Rousseau; Burke; Tocqueville; Arendt	Exodus 14:13; Luke 9–10; Milton; Kierkegaard; Benveniste; Agamben
Fate in the novel	Annihilated by its own standing-reserve	Drifts back toward *stasis*	Vindicated, not victorious

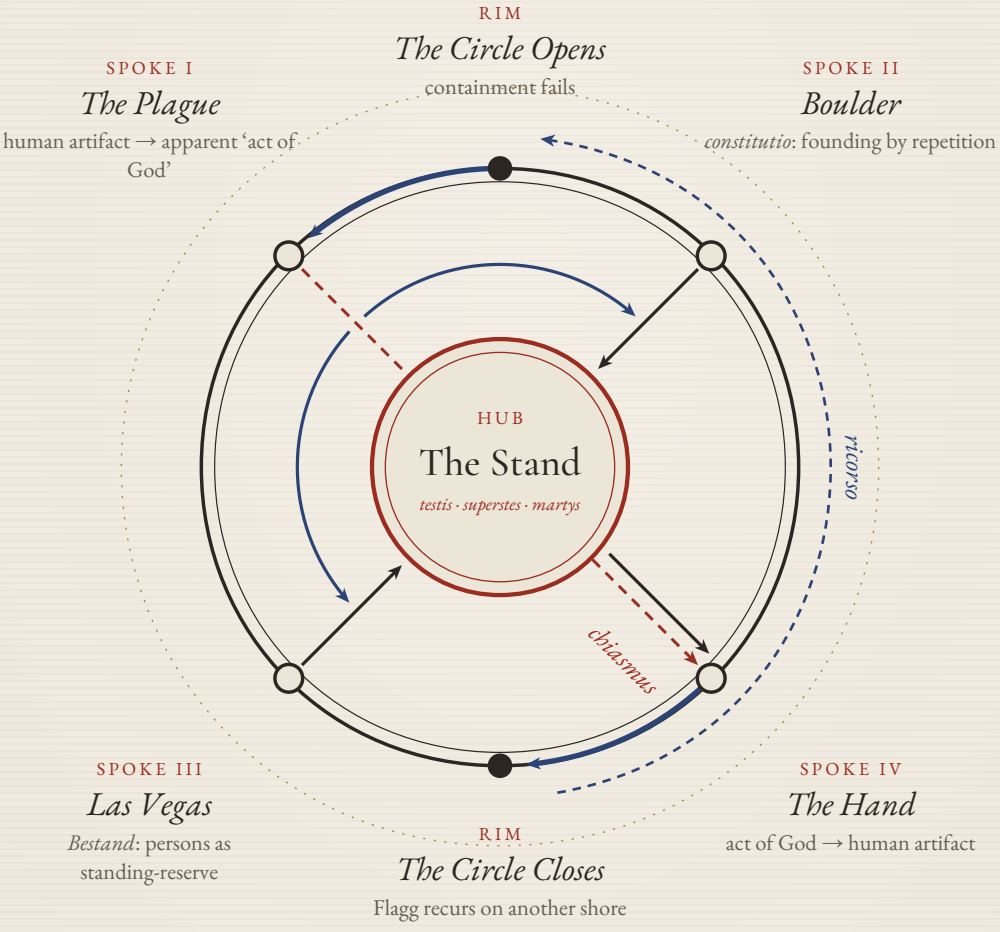
These claims converge on a single figure. *Chiasmus* comes from the Greek *chiazein*, "to mark with the letter chi (X)," the cross-shaped letter that is also the first letter of *Christos*. Draw the novel's chiastic core (plague/hand) inside its circular frame (Opens/Closes), and the result is a cross within a circle: a wheel with spokes. The novel's form is the image with which the 1990 text ends: "Life was such a wheel that no man could stand upon it for long. And it always, at the end, came round to the same place again."

Boethius taught that Fortune's wheel grips hardest those who live on its rim, and loosens its hold the closer one comes to the unmoving center, where providence rather than fate governs (*Consolation of Philosophy* IV, prose 6). Read through this cosmology, a phrase from the novel's portrait of its antagonist takes on a precise sense: "He's always outside. He came out of time. He doesn't know himself." A being who is always outside lives on the rim. Whatever lives on the rim is carried round to the same place again. So the being who is "always outside" is exactly the one who must recur, as Flagg does in the epilogue.

The witnesses approach the hub. They do not recur; they are consumed. The stand is the still point of the turning world, the point where, in Eliot's *Burnt Norton* (1936), "the dance is." And the dance, as the novel's first Spanish title, *La danza de la muerte* ("The Dance of Death"), already knew, is a dance of death.

Figure 1

The architecture of *The Stand* as a wheel



The architecture of The Stand *as a wheel: chiastic spokes (Plague, Hand) inside a circular frame (Opens, Closes), converging on the hub of testimony.*

The dissertation claims nine contributions:

1. **A stasiological lexicon** that makes the title the key to the novel's conceptual architecture (Chapter 1).
2. **A reading of King's misremembered origin story** (an aerial weapons test recalled as a road accident) as the primal scene of the novel's horizontal theology (Chapter 1).
3. **The identification of the text's "Millerite" condition**: an apocalypse repeatedly re-dated, disproved by events without being discredited (Chapter 1).
4. **A reading of the plague as *Bestand***, and of Las Vegas as a standing-reserve city rather than a "Sin City." The novel's evil is managerial, not orgiastic (Chapters 2, 4, 5).
5. **The chiasmus of plague and hand** as the form of a non-interventionist theodicy (Chapters 2, 7).
6. **A theory of the unarmed witness**, grounded in Benveniste's distinction between *testis* and *superstes* and in the American idiom of "the stand" as the place of testimony (Chapter 7).
7. **A demonstration that Locke's "appeal to Heaven" and Benjamin's "divine violence" are made literal** in the destruction of Las Vegas. The earth swallowing Korah's faction (Numbers 16) is their shared model (Chapter 7).
8. **The identification of Malachi 3:2's parallel phrasing** ("who may abide… who shall stand") as the hidden scriptural hinge joining *Earth Abides* and *The Stand* (Chapter 8).
9. **A reading of "I don't know" as *docta ignorantia***, aligned with the last sentence of Freud's *Civilization and Its Discontents* and with the Boethian cosmology of the wheel (Conclusion).

IV. Method: Distributed Polysemy and Comparative Eschatography

Three kinds of relation govern the use of sources here, and it helps to separate them at the outset.

- **Genetic** relations are documented sources: texts and events King has named as formative (Tolkien, Stewart, the Hearst case, the Utah spill), plus the scriptural and liturgical idiom of the culture that formed him.
- **Genealogical** relations are conceptual ancestries: ideas that reach the novel through the long mediation of a culture rather than by citation. Hobbes and Locke arrive through the American constitutional tradition, Augustine through Protestant preaching, Rousseau through the sociology Glen Bateman taught.
- **Analogical** relations link *The Stand* to comparative works by what Wittgenstein called family resemblance rather than by influence.

Claims of the first kind concern how the novel came to be; claims of the second, what it inherits; claims of the third, what it means when placed in a field. The three are never conflated.

The method of interpretation is philological and theological, and it borrows from four sources.

- **Auerbach.** From Erich Auerbach's "Figura" (1938) it takes a model of realism in which an event's historical density is intensified, not diminished, by its typological link to another event. Mother Abagail is a 108-year-old Black farm woman from Nebraska *and* a figure of the prophetess. The second identity is read through the first, not in place of it.
- **Frye.** From Northrop Frye (*Anatomy of Criticism*, 1957) it takes the concept of displacement (the adaptation of mythic structure to the standards of plausibility) and the opposition between apocalyptic and demonic imagery: the city and the garden against the wasteland and the tyrant's capital, the sheepfold against the beasts of prey.

- **Ricoeur.** From Paul Ricoeur (*The Symbolism of Evil*, 1960) it takes both an axiom ("the symbol gives rise to thought") and a typology of the myths of evil's origin. *The Stand* layers all four of Ricoeur's myths:
  - the creation-drama of combat governs its surface (Flagg against Abagail's God);
  - the Adamic myth of evil entering through human freedom governs its account of causes (the laboratory, Harold's ledger);
  - the tragic myth of a fate decreed in advance governs Nadine, who knows herself to be "promised";
  - the myth of the exiled soul governs Flagg's endless wandering.
- **Barr (the safeguard).** James Barr's *The Semantics of Biblical Language* (1961) demolished the "root fallacy" and the "illegitimate totality transfer," by which theologians loaded every occurrence of a Hebrew or Greek word with its full etymology. Nothing here depends on the claim that every "stand" in King's novel carries every sense of $*steh_2$-. The claim is structural: the narrative *distributes* the senses across its episodes. I call this *distributed polysemy*, and it is a property of plots, not of words.

Two further commitments complete the method. The first comes from Fredric Jameson's "Reification and Utopia in Mass Culture" (1979): mass-culture texts should be read as places where utopian longing is both awakened and managed. Boulder is such a place, a utopian moment administered back into repetition. The second is comparative. I use the coined term *eschatography* (the writing of last things) for the body of narratives of civilizational ending, and *comparative eschatography* for their systematic comparison. Frank Kermode's *The Sense of an Ending* (1967) remains the founding exercise in that comparison. Throughout, the author's intention is treated as evidence of how the novel came to be, not as a limit on what it means. E. D. Hirsch's distinction between meaning and significance is respected without being allowed to stop interpretation.

V. Synopsis of the Argument

- **Chapter 1** reconstructs the novel's genesis: the abandoned Hearst novel; King's misremembering of the 1968 Skull Valley sheep kill; the Tolkienian ambition; and a four-way inheritance from Stewart, Terry Nation, Michael Crichton, and an apocalyptic radio preacher. It then traces the unstable textual history across the 1978, 1985, and 1990 versions before setting out the stasiological lexicon.
- **Chapter 2** reads the superflu through four lenses: Heideggerian *Bestand*, Perrow's "normal accident," Kant's "contranatural end," and an inversion of Sontag's critique of illness as metaphor. It reads Stu Redman's captivity at Stovington, through Foucault's plague town and Agamben's "bare life," as the novel's first stand.
- **Chapter 3** turns to the ruins:
  - Vico's "barbarism of reflection" and its *ricorso*;
  - Fran Goldsmith's burial of her father as Antigone's act;
  - Larry Underwood's passage through the Lincoln Tunnel as a Dantean and Augustinian conversion;
  - the dreams as an "oneiric franchise" (a vote cast in dreams);
  - Glen Bateman's sociology lecture as Rousseau's *Second Discourse* compressed into seven numbers.
- **Chapter 4** reads the two cities as rival constitutions. Boulder is read through Arendt, Burke, Tocqueville, Schmitt, and Bercovitch's American jeremiad. Las Vegas is read through Hobbes, Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, Plato's "feverish city," and Girard's founding murder.
- **Chapter 5** reads Flagg as "the last magician of rational thought": the dialectic of enlightenment personified, *Gestell* (the technological framework) given a face, and evil as *privatio boni*, Peer Gynt's onion without a core.

- **Chapter 6** dissects apostasy in four characters:
  - Harold (Nietzschean *ressentiment*, Dostoevsky's Underground Man, Aristotle's Syracusan love-quarrel, Girard's triangle);
  - Nadine (Kierkegaard's demonic despair);
  - Lloyd (Royce's loyalty perverted, Arendt's banality);
  - the Trashcan Man (Günther Anders's "Promethean gap," Tolkien's Gollum).
- **Chapter 7**, the center of the dissertation, reads the stand proper:
  - Mother Abagail as prophetess, including the critique of the "magical Negro" trope;
  - the mission instructions, Locke's appeal to Heaven, and Kierkegaard's teleological suspension of the ethical;
  - Milton's "They also serve who only stand and wait";
  - the testimonial theory of *testis* and *superstes*, and Glen's laughter;
  - and the Hand itself, through Daniel 5, Exodus 8:19, *Paradise Lost* VI, Luke 10:18, Benjamin's divine violence, and Hölderlin's "Patmos."
- **Chapter 8** places the novel among thirteen works, from Shelley's *The Last Man* to Mandel's *Station Eleven*, organized around the scriptural pairing of abiding and standing.
- **The Conclusion** reads the novel's ending (Tom Cullen's return, Peter's birth and survival, the arming of Boulder, Stu and Fran's departure, Flagg's recurrence) as a Boethian cosmology of wheel and hub. It defends "I don't know" as the novel's final and most demanding philosophical act.





Chapter 1

Genesis of a Stand

The Hearst Fragment, the Skull Valley Sheep, and the Unstable Body of the Text



Apocalypse can be disconfirmed without being discredited.
(Frank Kermode, *The Sense of an Ending*, 1967)

1.1 The House on Value Street: Terror, Conversion, and the Novel as Explanation

Every account of how *The Stand* came to be must begin with a failure. In *Danse Macabre*, King writes at some length about the novel's origins, one of which was the Patty Hearst case. There he describes trying to fictionalize Hearst's kidnapping by the Symbionese Liberation Army through multiple drafts and from various angles, before deciding he could not finish it to his satisfaction. The book survives only as a title, *The House on Value Street*, the name of the fictional SLA's headquarters.

His stated motive was to understand: "it seemed that only a novel might really succeed in explaining all the contradictions." The sentence deserves more pressure than it has received, because the Hearst affair was a contradiction in an almost logical sense:

- An heiress was abducted from her Berkeley apartment on 4 February 1974.
- Two months later, under the *nom de guerre* "Tania," she announced that she had joined her captors.
- On 15 April she appeared on a bank's surveillance film holding a carbine.
- On 17 May six members of the cell, including its leader Donald DeFreeze, died in a Los Angeles house fire broadcast live to the nation.
- Her 1976 trial turned on whether her conversion had been a conversion at all. The defense called her situation "coercive persua-

> sion," borrowing vocabulary from the thought-reform research of Robert Jay Lifton and others. The question was whether, under such pressure, a will can be said to have stood anywhere.

The question that defeated King's realist novel, *can a captured will be said to stand?*, is the seed from which the fantastic novel grew.

King has recorded the moment of transformation with unusual precision. Sitting at his typewriter one day, just to write something, he typed: "The world comes to an end but everybody in the SLA is somehow immune." His next line welcomed the end of gasoline shortages, a thought whose cheerfulness he recognized as horrible. The fragment holds three of the novel's governing ideas in embryo, and the finished book inverts each of them.

First, the fragment is a revolutionary's wish come true. The apocalypse finishes the cell's program by other means: the old world is abolished and only the vanguard is spared. The SLA's famous slogan, "Death to the fascist insect that preys upon the life of the people," is extended from the insect to the species.

Second, it is a consumer's wish come true. Written after the 1973–74 oil embargo, the line about gasoline imagines catastrophe as the end of scarcity by subtraction. The theme survives in the post-scarcity economy of the Free Zone, where goods lie everywhere for the taking. Conflict there must therefore come from something other than want: from comparison, desire, and pride. Rousseau called this source *amour-propre*; Hobbes, in the third of his "causes of quarrel," called it glory (*Leviathan*, ch. 13). This is the novel's quiet refutation of every materialist theory of conflict, as Chapter 6 shows: Harold Lauder lacks nothing the dead world can supply.

Third, it identifies immunity with a sect, and the finished novel takes this identification apart with great care. Immunity in *The Stand* is randomly distributed. It confers no merit and implies no doctrine; the immune are a remnant without a creed. The sect structure that the fragment attached to immunity moves instead to Las Vegas, where a charismatic leader, an apocalyptic program, and discipline enforced by public killing rebuild the SLA's form at the scale of a city. Accounts of

Danse Macabre name DeFreeze alongside an accidental chemical weapons spill in Utah as the novel's sources of inspiration. The passage from DeFreeze to Flagg is the passage from a political terrorist to a metaphysical one.

The Hearst problem itself does not disappear; it is redistributed. Its most exact counterpart is Lloyd Henreid. He is a petty criminal left starving in a Phoenix cell when the State that imprisoned him collapses. Pushed to the edge of cannibalism, he is rescued by a stranger who arrives with food and a key, and he stays loyal to his rescuer until death. This is precisely captivity followed by conversion: the structure the Hearst defense called coercive persuasion, and which the popular vocabulary of the 1970s, after the Stockholm bank siege of August 1973, was learning to call by another name. The novel asks of Lloyd what the trial asked of Hearst: is a loyalty formed in starvation really loyalty? King's answer, developed in Chapter 6, is that it is loyalty without an object, fidelity as pure form, and that this is exactly what a sovereign of *Bestand* needs.

There is a precise precedent for this alchemy, by which a terrorist cell becomes a metaphysics. Dostoevsky's *Demons* (1871–72) began as a polemical novel about the Nechayev affair, the 1869 murder of the student Ivanov by a revolutionary cell in Moscow. It ended as a theology of possession. Its epigraph comes from Luke's account of the Gadarene demoniac, whose name is Legion and whose devils, cast into swine, rush down a steep place into the lake (Luke 8:32–36). The cell's members become instruments of an emptiness at the novel's center, Nikolai Stavrogin. Commentators have long derived his name from the Greek *stauros*, "cross," and his final letter confesses that nothing has come from him but negation.

King's path from *The House on Value Street* to *The Stand* follows Dostoevsky's with uncanny fidelity: a real cell, a failed realism, a turn to the metaphysical, and at the center a charismatic emptiness with a hundred names. Flagg is King's Stavrogin, *stauros* and all, since the cross, as Section 1.6 shows, is itself a stasiological word.

1.2 The Misremembered Truck: Dugway and the Accident as Primal Scene

The second source is a memory, and the memory is wrong. After moving with his family to Boulder, King saw a *60 Minutes* segment on chemical-biological warfare and never forgot its footage of test mice shuddering, convulsing, and dying in twenty seconds or less. The footage reminded him of a chemical spill in Utah that had killed many sheep. As King remembered it, canisters on their way to a burial site fell off a truck and ruptured.

The historical event was different. In March 1968, thousands of sheep (the commonly cited figure is about six thousand) died in Utah's Skull Valley, downwind of the Army's Dugway Proving Ground. Earlier that day an aircraft had carried out an open-air spray test of the nerve agent VX. The Army long resisted admitting responsibility. The episode fed the public alarm in which Richard Nixon renounced offensive biological weapons in November 1969, and the United States signed the Biological Weapons Convention in 1972.

The discrepancy is not an error to correct but a fact to read. In the historical event, death came from the sky: an aircraft, a spray, a wind. In King's memory, it came off the back of a truck. The translation moves the origin of catastrophe from the vertical axis (the axis of heaven, of the bomber, of every traditional image of judgment) to the horizontal axis of the American road.

The novel's first event follows the memory, not the history. A car carrying a dying security guard and his family, fleeing a containment that has failed, crashes into the gas pumps of Bill Hapscomb's Texaco station in Arnette, Texas. Every element of the genesis meets in that scene:

- the Hearst fragment's joke about gasoline;
- the misremembered truck;
- the highway;
- the filling station as the communal hearth of a small town;

- the contingency of a car accident.

The vertical axis is held in reserve. It returns only at the end, when a hand appears in the sky over Las Vegas. The chiasmus that organizes the whole novel is already latent in the gap between what happened at Dugway and what King remembered: death sent along the road by human beings, and death sent down from the sky by God through a human weapon.

The memory drifts in time as well as space. King recalls that the Utah incident later became the basis of the film *Rage*, starring George C. Scott, and that he was already deep into *The Stand* before the film came out. But *Rage* opened in 1972, about two years before King moved to Boulder. The genesis narrative is itself a small origin myth, assembled after the fact, in which the author reaches his subject before the culture does. Pointing this out is no criticism of King; it describes how origin stories work. It also justifies this chapter's method, which treats King's account of the genesis not as testimony to be believed or disbelieved but as a text to interpret. That account turns contingency into meaning, which is what the novel will do on a continental scale.

The *60 Minutes* mice deserve their own gloss. The laboratory animal is the novel's first figure of the human. Stu Redman's ordeal at the plague center in Stovington, Vermont, is the ordeal of the mouse that does not die. He is watched through glass, sampled, monitored, and finally marked for disposal. Chapter 2 reads his captivity, through Foucault's plague town and Agamben's *homo sacer* (the life that can be killed with impunity), as the novel's first stand.

The genealogy reaches back further. *The Stand* reworks the scenario of King's earlier short story "Night Surf". That story's teenage survivors of a superflu have, before the story opens, burned a dying man on the beach in a parody of sacrifice. The novel's germ is a scapegoat ritual. René Girard argued that plague in literature and myth figures a "sacrificial crisis": the differences that structure a society collapse, and communities resolve the crisis by collectively murdering a victim ("The Plague in Literature and Myth," 1974). The mature novel splits the burning of "Night Surf" between Las Vegas, which crucifies, and the

Trashcan Man, who burns. As Chapter 7 argues, it ends by breaking the sacrificial mechanism itself.

1.3 An Epic Without a King: Tolkien Transposed

King planned *The Stand* as an epic in the manner of *The Lord of the Rings*, set in contemporary America, and the correspondences are systematic enough to tabulate.

Table 2 **The Tolkienian transposition and its alterations**

Tolkien	King	What the transposition alters
The Shire	Arnette, Texas; Ogunquit, Maine	Provincial origin kept; pastoral innocence withdrawn
The hobbit	Stu Redman, a Texan	The small hero becomes the laconic working man
Sauron; the Eye	Flagg; his eye; his crows	The Dark Lord becomes a drifter: mobile, serial, rootless
Mordor / Barad-dûr	Las Vegas	The fortress of darkness becomes a city of light and electricity
The Fellowship	Stu, Larry, Glen, Ralph (with Kojak)	The questers carry no weapon and no object to destroy
The Ring	The warhead	The weapon is never held by the good
Gollum	The Trashcan Man	Spared not by pity but because he is useful
Mount Doom	The execution in Las Vegas	The "turn" is literal fire
The Return of the King	The return of the Constitution	An epic without a monarch
The Scouring of the Shire	The arming of Boulder	Home must be policed; the victors arm themselves
The Grey Havens	Stu and Fran's departure for Maine	The saved place is "not for" those who saved it

The two most revealing alterations concern the Ring and the King.

The Ring. In the Foreword to the second edition of *The Lord of the Rings* (1966), Tolkien rejected the reading of the Ring as the atomic bomb, with an argument that bears directly on King. Had the Second

World War inspired or directed the story, he wrote, the Ring would surely have been seized and used against Sauron. The Dark Lord would have been enslaved rather than annihilated, and Barad-dûr occupied rather than destroyed.

Transposing Tolkien into the nuclear age, King does what Tolkien said the allegorist would do: he makes the Ring a bomb and has it used against the Dark Lord. Yet he keeps the Tolkienian ethic that the allegorist would have betrayed. No one on the side of the good touches the weapon. The Dark Lord's own servant carries it into Mordor, and a hand belonging to no combatant sets it off. The solution threads the needle Tolkien set: the weapon destroys its master, and the good are not corrupted by wielding it.

The Gollum function is kept, with a decisive difference. Gandalf's prophecy, "the pity of Bilbo may rule the fate of many," grounds Gollum's providential role in an act of mercy by the good. The Trashcan Man is spared not by pity but because he is useful. Flagg indulges him because a pyromaniac with a genius for finding things that burn is valuable to a sovereign building an arsenal. The Tolkienian axiom that "oft evil will shall evil mar" is retained, but its mechanism changes:

- In Tolkien, the good's pity opens the gap through which providence acts.
- In King, the wicked's use of a tool opens it.

The theological difference is considerable. Tolkien's providence works through the virtue of the good; King's works through the vice of the wicked. That is a darker and more strictly Augustinian economy, in which God's action consists of turning evil against itself.

This is also why King's climax is, strictly speaking, a *eu*-catastrophe. Tolkien's essay "On Fairy-Stories" (1947) coined the term for "the sudden joyous 'turn'" of the happy ending. It is a grace "never to be counted on to recur," which does not deny sorrow and failure but denies "universal final defeat," and whose supreme instance is the Resurrection. King makes the word literal. The good overturning (*eu* + *katastrophē*) arrives as an actual catastrophe: a nuclear detonation that con-

sumes the righteous along with the wicked. This is the dark Christianity the 1990 preface claims for the book, a eucatastrophe whose joy is visible only from far off, in the mushroom cloud seen from a ravine.

The King. The second alteration is political. Tolkien wrote to his son Christopher in November 1943 that his political opinions leaned "more and more to Anarchy (philosophically understood, meaning abolition of control not whiskered men with bombs)—or to 'unconstitutional' Monarchy" (*Letters*, no. 52). King's novel inverts both halves of that preference.

- Its good polity is constitutional, not monarchical.
- Its anarchy is exactly the kind Tolkien excluded: men (and a woman) with bombs. Harold Lauder and Nadine Cross have their dynamite; the Trashcan Man has his warhead.

By the meaning of his name, the novel's hero is not a king but a steward. "Stuart" comes from the Old English *stigweard*, keeper of the hall. Stu Redman, who chairs the Free Zone's founding assembly, governs a realm with no king to wait for. Tolkien's Stewards of Gondor held power in trust for a returning royal line; King's steward holds it in trust for no one. The epic without a king (save the one on the title page) is the epic of a republic, so its crisis is not usurpation but *stasis*.

The Shire. Tolkien's hobbits come home to find the Shire occupied and must scour it by force. Frodo, who will not draw his sword against hobbits, cannot stay: "I tried to save the Shire, and it has been saved, but not for me." The ending of *The Stand* rewrites both episodes. Boulder needs no scouring, since it has not been occupied, but it arms itself anyway. Stu and Fran, like Frodo, discover that the place they saved is not for them. They leave not for the Undying Lands but for the cold Atlantic coast of Maine, toward a home rather than a heaven, and that measures King's distance from Tolkien's consolations.

1.4 The Triangulated Inheritance: Stewart, Nation, Crichton, and the Radio Preacher

Tolkien supplied the epic shape; the materials came from elsewhere.

- King drew on earlier literary and film treatments of a superflu that wipes out most of the world, notably George R. Stewart's 1949 novel *Earth Abides* and the 1971 film *The Andromeda Strain*.
- King nearly stopped writing the novel when he came across Terry Nation's series *Survivors*.
- One reported source of the 1978 text was the doomsday proclamations of a Midwestern preacher on religious radio.

These sources do not converge. They pull in different directions, and the tension produces the novel's characteristic formal impurity.

Stewart. *Earth Abides* (1949) follows Isherwood Williams, a graduate student in geography, through the aftermath of a plague that leaves a scattered remnant in the San Francisco Bay Area. Its intelligence is ecological and its temper agnostic. Ish watches rats, ants, and cattle boom and crash in great population cycles. He tries and fails to pass literacy on to the children of his small "Tribe," and his geologist's hammer becomes, against his will, a sacred object. He dies as "the Last American," among grandchildren who hunt with bows and arrows and regard him with reverent incomprehension. The title comes from Ecclesiastes 1:4: "One generation passeth away, and another generation cometh: but the earth abideth for ever."

Chapter 8 will show that "abide" and "stand" appear together as parallel verbs in Malachi 3:2 ("who may abide the day of his coming? and who shall stand when he appeareth?"). The two great American plague novels of the twentieth century accordingly divide that verse between them. For now it is enough to note the difference in kind: Stewart writes about the earth abiding after man; King writes about man standing before God.

Nation. Terry Nation's *Survivors* (BBC, 1975–77) followed a middle-class Englishwoman, Abby Grant, through a Britain emptied

by plague. It was relentlessly practical: seed, fuel, medicine, leadership, rebuilding a rural economy. Its very existence nearly ended King's project. His solution, implicit in the finished book, was to differentiate by altitude: where *Survivors* stays at the level of logistics, *The Stand* rises to theology.

Crichton. Michael Crichton's *The Andromeda Strain* (novel 1969; Robert Wise's film 1971) supplied a third register, the technoscientific procedural. It has sealed laboratories, codes and protocols, and a faith that expertise can contain what expertise has released. Much of Book I is written in this mode: the military command, the epidemiologists, the plague center at Stovington. Its systematic collapse is part of the novel's argument. The procedural ends when the people running the procedures die, and the narrative must then find another mode.

The radio preacher. The fourth source supplies that mode. American premillennial dispensationalism (the belief that history is moving through divinely set eras toward the Rapture and Christ's return) had its biggest popular boom in the 1970s. Hal Lindsey's *The Late Great Planet Earth* (1970) became the decade's best-selling nonfiction book, and films such as *A Thief in the Night* (1972) carried the Rapture into church basements across the country (Boyer 1992). The radio preacher whose prophecies reportedly helped seed the novel belongs to this culture. The culture, in turn, belongs to a decade that gave it material:

- Watergate, the oil embargo, the fall of Saigon, and stagflation;
- the swine-flu vaccination campaign of 1976, mounted against the specter of a repeat of 1918 and halted that December amid reports of Guillain-Barré syndrome;
- in the same year, Alfred Crosby's history *Epidemic and Peace, 1918*, which recovered a catastrophe American memory had largely suppressed.

The Stand was published on 3 October 1978. About six weeks later, more than nine hundred followers of Jim Jones died at Jonestown in Guyana: a charismatic leader's settlement in the wilderness ending in

mass death. The novel did not foresee Jonestown. It belonged to the culture that produced it.

Five sources, then, and five registers:

1. political terror (the SLA);
2. the technoscientific procedural (Crichton);
3. religious prophecy (the radio preacher);
4. mythic quest (Tolkien);
5. ecological and sociological reconstruction (Stewart and Nation).

The novel's formal impurity (its lurches from procedural to picaresque, from romance to political debate, from realism to miracle) is the trace of their contest. One might say the genres of *The Stand* are themselves in *stasis*: factions fighting for control of a single body, none able to impose its law on the others.

King recounts in *On Writing* (2000) that the manuscript stalled for weeks in the Boulder section. The block broke only when he saw that his survivors were drifting toward rebuilding the very world that had destroyed itself; the dynamite in the closet was his solution. The anecdote is usually told as a lesson in craft. It is better read as an admission that the sociological register, left to itself, could only reproduce the old world. To escape that reproduction, the novel needed an eruption from another register: violence, then prophecy, then miracle. The bomb in the closet is the point where the genres' civil war breaks into open fighting.

1.5 The Accounting Department as Censor: 1978, 1985, 1990, and the Millerite Text

The Stand is not one text but a sequence of versions.

- **1978.** The Doubleday first edition ran to 823 pages.
- **1985.** The paperback made minor revisions and moved the action forward from 1980–81 to 1985–86.

- **1990.** The *Complete & Uncut Edition* restored more than three hundred pages of text removed from the original manuscript, revised the order of chapters, moved the setting forward again to 1990, and updated the cultural references to match.

King's preface explained that about four hundred pages of manuscript had been cut from the final draft, not for editorial reasons but "at the behest of the accounting department". It also admitted that he had not restored all of them. Meanwhile, publisher's copy advertised "more than five hundred pages" of previously deleted material, along with new material written for the occasion, and promised that the book now began and ended differently. The revision also inserted references to AIDS, although the 1978 novel owed nothing to that epidemic.

The numbers do not reconcile (three hundred, four hundred, five hundred), and the mismatch is instructive. There is no original text to recover. A market constraint shaped the 1978 text; the author's revision, informed by twelve more years of history, shaped the 1990 text; and the "restoration" is a second composition dressed as a recovery. Jerome McGann's *A Critique of Modern Textual Criticism* (1983) taught textual scholarship to treat a work as a social product whose makers include publishers and their accountants. John Bryant's *The Fluid Text* (2002) taught it to read revision as a record of an author's changing relationship to a work. *The Stand* is a model fluid text, and its fluidity has a theme: it is an apocalypse that has been repeatedly re-dated.

The novel's "present" moves from 1980 to 1985 to 1990. Each time, the catastrophe is placed in the reader's near future or immediate present, and each time the passing of the appointed date disproves it without discrediting it. Kermode identified this as the extraordinary resilience of apocalyptic thinking. Its classic American instance is William Miller's movement. It recalculated the Second Coming from 1843 to the spring of 1844 and finally to 22 October 1844, the "Great Disappointment," exactly one hundred and eighty-two years before the date on this dissertation's title page. The movement survived the disappointment by reinterpretation. *The Stand* is, in this precise sense, a

Millerite text. Its re-datings are not mere modernizations. They are the textual form of an eschatology that must keep being postponed in order to stay imminent.

The 1990 insertions add a further layer by stacking two images of epidemic. The 1978 superflu was a Cold War artifact, a military pathogen born of the logic of deterrence. The 1990 text was written the year after Susan Sontag's *AIDS and Its Metaphors* (1989), the sequel to her *Illness as Metaphor*, which was published, like *The Stand*, in 1978. Sontag argued that AIDS had been made to carry the metaphor of plague as punishment, and the 1990 text overlays the Cold War artifact with references to that most moralized epidemic of the century. The novel's account of causes stays rigorously human: the superflu is no judgment but an industrial accident. Its revised surface, though, now carries traces of a culture eager to read disease as a verdict. Chapter 2 argues that this tension, between a plague that means nothing and a world that insists on making it mean something, is one of the novel's central subjects.

The fluidity extends across media. King himself wrote the four-part ABC miniseries broadcast in May 1994, directed by Mick Garris. The 2020 serial adaptation closed with a new ending that expanded the novel's last chapters and epilogue, adding a stop at a deserted Nebraska farmhouse on Stu and Fran's journey back to Maine. That adaptation reached audiences in the first winter of the COVID-19 pandemic. The novel's fourth "present" (neither 1980, nor 1985, nor 1990, but the year of an actual respiratory pandemic) was supplied not by revision but by history.

Even the novel's translations rehearse the interpretive problem this dissertation addresses. The Spanish edition first appeared as *La danza de la muerte*, "The Dance of Death," and a later edition was retitled *Apocalipsis*. The two titles name the two readings between which the book has always swung:

- the *danse macabre*, in which death levels every rank and leads pope and peasant in a single dance: the plague's democracy;

- the *apokalypsis*, the unveiling in which a hidden order is revealed and judgment is given.

Book I is a dance of death; Book III is an apocalypse; and the stand is the hinge between them.

1.6 The Stasiological Lexicon

The Indo-European root *$*steh_2$-* ("to stand, to be standing, to set up") is among the most productive in the language family. Its descendants in Greek, Latin, and the Germanic languages form a vocabulary in which nearly every problem of *The Stand* already has a name. Table 3 sets out the main forms and where they appear in the novel.

Table 3 The stasiological lexicon

Form	Language	Root sense	Developed sense	Locus in *The Stand*
stasis	Greek	a standing, position	faction, civil war; (med.) arrest of flow	Boulder vs. Las Vegas; Harold's sedition; death by choking
apostasis / apostasia	Greek	standing away	defection, revolt	Harold and Nadine (their inverse: Dayna, Whitney)
anastasis	Greek	standing up again	resurrection	Peter's recovery; Stu's return; Flagg's demonic re-arising
ekstasis	Greek	standing outside oneself	trance, rapture	Shared dreams; the Trashcan Man's fire; Abagail's visions
hypostasis	Greek	standing-under	substance; (theol.) person	Flagg's lack of one: "He doesn't know himself"
stauros	Greek	upright stake	the Cross	Crucifixions in Vegas; Nadine *Cross*
status	Latin	condition, standing	the State	The collapsed federal apparatus; Stovington
constitutio	Latin	a setting-up together	founding charter	The Free Zone's re-adoption of the dead republic's order
constans	Latin	standing firm together	constancy	King's *Constant Reader*
testis (*tri-st-i-)	Latin	the third who stands by	witness at law	Glen, Larry, Ralph before Flagg; "the witness stand"

Form	Language	Root sense	Developed sense	Locus in *The Stand*
superstes	Latin	one who stands over	survivor; eyewitness	The immune as survivor-witnesses; Fran's diary
ex-sistere	Latin	to stand forth	existence; Heidegger's *Ek-sistenz*	Abagail's wilderness; the survivors' exposure
destinare	Latin	to make stand fast	to destine	Nadine as "promised"
Bestand	German	stock, holding	Heidegger's "standing-reserve"	Project Blue; the warhead; the jets; "my life for you"
Aufstand / Widerstand	German	standing-up / standing-against	uprising / resistance	The SLA germ; the non-violent stand
Verstand / understand	German / English	standing under or among	understanding	"I don't know"
standard	Old French *estandart*	(prob.) Frankish "stand firm"	battle-flag, rallying point	Randall Flagg

Several entries need comment.

Stasis. The Greek word means a standing or position. From the fifth century BCE it also means faction and civil war: the condition in which the citizens of a single *polis* "take their stand" against one another. Its classic analysis is Thucydides' account of the civil war at Corcyra (III.82–83). There, in the most famous sentence in Greek political thought, "words had to change their ordinary meaning" to fit the new reality: reckless daring became loyal courage, and prudent hesitation became disguised cowardice. Nicole Loraux (*The Divided City*, 1997) showed that the Greeks understood *stasis* as a quarrel within the family of the city. Giorgio Agamben (*Stasis*, 2015) showed that it marks the threshold where the household's quarrels become the city's.

Both insights bear on *The Stand*. The war between Boulder and Las Vegas is literally a civil war among the survivors of a single republic, and Harold Lauder's sedition begins as household jealousy (a love triangle) before it becomes a bomb. The medical sense completes the picture: *stasis* is also the stopping of a flow, of blood or breath, and the superflu kills by choking.

Apostasis. To "stand away" is to defect. The novel's stories of defection (Harold's and Nadine's, from Boulder) and its counter-stories of

fidelity under pressure (Dayna Jurgens's and Whitney Horgan's, in Las Vegas) make up a systematic study of apostasy (Chapter 6).

***Testis* and *superstes*.** Émile Benveniste (*Le Vocabulaire des institutions indo-européennes*, 1969) distinguished two Latin words for "witness."

- *Testis*, from **tri-st-i-*, is "the one who stands as third": the party who stands by when two others make a contract or a dispute, and whose presence guarantees the transaction.
- *Superstes*, from *super-stare*, is "the one who stands over" an event: someone who has lived through it from start to finish, survived it, and can therefore bear witness to it.

Agamben made the distinction central to *Remnants of Auschwitz* (1998). *The Stand* activates both senses with remarkable precision. The plague's survivors are *superstites* in the literal sense: they stood over the event and lived. The men who walk to Las Vegas stand as *testes*, third parties between the two cities, before a sovereign who would have them stand trial. The American idiom (the witness *stand*, to *take* the stand) completes the circuit: the novel's title names the witness box.

***Bestand*.** In "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954), Heidegger argued that modern technology reveals beings as *Bestand*, "standing-reserve." They are no longer objects that stand over against us but stock, held ready on call for further use. His examples include the Rhine dammed for hydroelectric power and, in a passage that might have been written for Book III, an airliner standing on the runway. That airliner, he says, appears not as an object but as standing-reserve, kept ready to ensure the possibility of transport. All of the following are *Bestand* in exactly Heidegger's sense:

- the stockpiled pathogen of Project Blue;
- the jets Flagg's men prepare at Indian Springs;
- the warhead in the desert;
- and finally the persons whose whole being is reduced to availability, as in the Trashcan Man's "my life for you."

Stauros. The Greek word for the upright stake on which the condemned were executed, and hence for the Cross, comes from an extended form of the same root. Las Vegas crucifies; one of its defectors is named Nadine Cross; and Dostoevsky's empty center, Stavrogin, carries the word in his name.

Constans. King's habitual address to his audience, *Constant Reader*, is itself stasiological: *constans*, from *con-stare*, means "standing firm together." The 1990 preface presents the restored text to the reader under this name, and the reader who persists through 1,152 pages practices the virtue the word names.

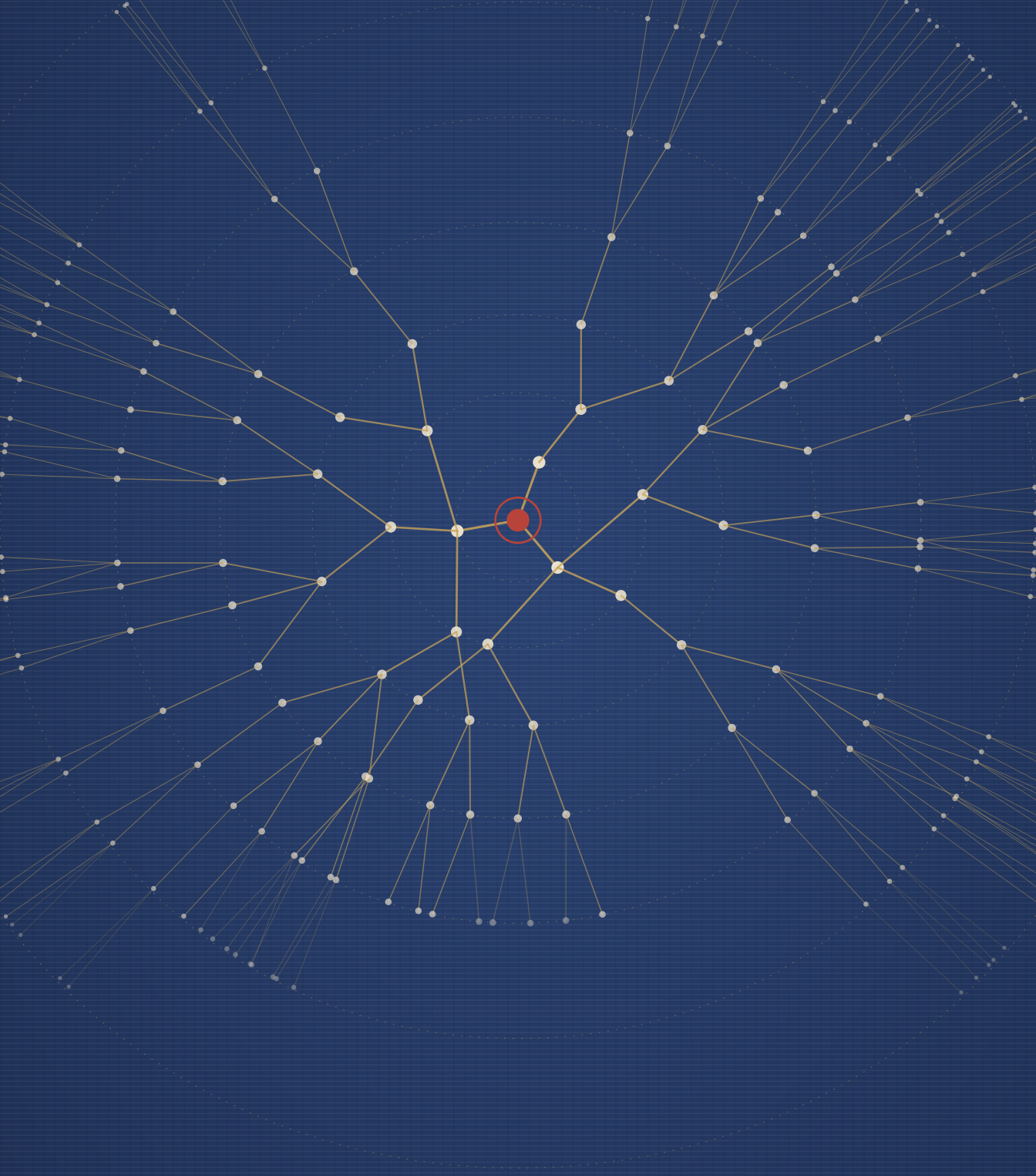
Standard. The banner around which an army rallies, the point where it takes its stand, is called a *standard*. The word comes from the Old French *estandart*, most probably from a Frankish compound meaning "stand firm," though a derivation from Latin *extendere*, "to stretch out," has also been proposed. The novel's antagonist is named for this object. Randall Flagg is a flag: a standard, a rallying point, the banner under which a faction takes its stand. His first name, Randall, comes from the Germanic *rand* ("shield-rim") and *wulf* ("wolf"), giving "shield-wolf" for a figure who commands wolves. Name-based criticism can neither prove such a coincidence intentional nor afford to ignore it.

Nothing in this lexicon depends on King's having known it. The claim, as stated above, is structural rather than intentional, and the principle of distributed polysemy protects it from Barr's critique. No single use of "stand" in the novel carries the full weight of the root. Read as a sequence, though, the plot passes through its senses one by one: *status* falls, *ekstasis* sorts, *constitutio* and *Bestand* contend, *apostasis* tests, *testis* and *superstes* answer, *anastasis* frames. One need not accept Heidegger's maxim that "language speaks" (*Die Sprache spricht*, 1950) in its full ontological form to grant a more modest point: a title chosen for its resonance carries the meaning-memory of its words into the work it names. King called his novel *The Stand*. The chapters that follow take him at his word, and take the word at its root.

The lexicon has one final consequence. If the novel's deepest question is what it means to stand, then its deepest *crisis* is the fall of the in-

stitution that used to do the standing for its citizens. That institution is the State, *status*: the condition of standing made permanent and impersonal. Its fall is the subject of Book I and of Chapter 2. It begins, as every stand in this novel begins, with a failure of containment, and with a man in a Texaco station watching a car come toward the pumps.





Chapter 2

Captain Trips

Plague as Standing-Reserve and the Contranatural End



And I looked, and behold a pale horse: and his name that sat on him was Death, and Hell followed with him. And power was given unto them over the fourth part of the earth, to kill with sword, and with hunger, and with death, and with the beasts of the earth.

(Revelation 6:8)

...das widernatürliche (verkehrte) Ende aller Dinge, welches von uns selbst, dadurch daß wir den Endzweck mißverstehen, herbeigeführt wird.

[*...the contranatural (perverted) end of all things, which we ourselves bring about by misunderstanding the final end.*]

(Kant, "Das Ende aller Dinge," 1794)

Book I of *The Stand* is the only movement of the novel whose protagonist is a thing rather than a person. The thing has an official name, Project Blue, and a set of popular ones: superflu, tubeneck, and, most durably, Captain Trips. In the novel's account it is engineered as a constantly mutating virus, and it kills ninety-nine and four-tenths percent of the world's population within weeks.

The fourth seal of the Apocalypse frames what follows with unusual precision. Its rider receives four instruments: the sword, hunger, "death," and the beasts of the earth. "Death" (*thanatos*) here carries the sense the Septuagint gave it when it translated the Hebrew *deber*, "pestilence," in Ezekiel's list of the "four sore judgments" (Ezekiel 14:21). Book I uses all four:

- **The sword:** Starkey runs a draconian regime of blockades in which civilians and journalists are killed.
- **Hunger:** Lloyd Henreid starves in a Phoenix cell, forgotten by the State that locked him in.
- **Pestilence:** the superflu itself.
- **The beasts:** as Section 2.2 will show, the plague's peculiar zoology spares the wolf, and the wolf belongs to Randall Flagg.

This chapter argues four theses about the thing at the center of Book I.

1. **The accident.** The plague is a *normal accident* in Perrow's sense. Its escape exposes the State as a structure of what Beck called *organized irresponsibility* (2.1).
2. **Its ontology.** The pathogen is Heideggerian *Bestand* (standing-reserve) in its purest form, and its escape is the moment at which standing-reserve becomes history (2.2).
3. **Its semiotics.** The plague inverts the military metaphor of illness that Sontag criticized. In doing so the novel separates the cause of catastrophe from its meaning, and moves theodicy from causation to vocation (2.3).
4. **Its form.** Narratively, Book I is a *danse macabre* that repeats the Thucydidean sequence of plague followed by *stasis*. Politically, it culminates in the death of the *katechon*: the State that restrained the end dies by its own hand and universalizes the end as it dies (2.4, 2.6).

Between these sits the novel's first stand, which is Hobbesian, armed, and self-preserving. It is enacted in a sealed room in Vermont (2.5), and it sets the baseline against which the last stand must be measured.

2.1 Project Blue and the Normal Accident

The restored text begins not in Arnette but in the desert, and it begins with a delay. In "The Circle Opens," the prologue of the 1990 text, a pathogen breaches containment at a secret installation in California. The automated lockdown is slow to engage, and in that lag the guard Charles Campion escapes by car with his wife and small daughter. He dies at a filling station in the fictional East Texas town of Arnette, having carried the virus there as its index case. The apocalypse therefore begins as an interval of seconds between alarm and seal. Book I stretches that interval to the scale of a continent.

Six years after the novel appeared, the sociologist Charles Perrow named the kind of event it narrates. *Normal Accidents* (1984), written after the partial meltdown at Three Mile Island on 28 March 1979, argued that certain technological systems make catastrophe a structural property rather than an aberration. Two features define such systems:

- **Interactive complexity.** Components interact in sequences no designer anticipated and no operator can see.
- **Tight coupling.** Processes run without slack, buffer, or time for intervention, so a local failure spreads before anyone can understand it.

In these systems accidents are "normal." The word does not mean frequent. It means inevitable: the accident comes from the system's architecture, not from anyone's incompetence or malice.

Project Blue is a normal accident in exactly this sense, and the novel records the fact precisely. Nothing in "The Circle Opens" turns on villainy. The lockdown is automated so that mechanical certainty can replace human judgment. Its single failure, a lag, opens the one gap through which the system's only uncoupled component can pass: human fear. The circle opens *because* it was a circle, a closed system whose closure depended on a single unwatched mechanism. The novel's founding geometry is therefore a broken ring. The prologue's title is not decoration. It is the first statement of the figure that will close the book.

The novel's first human act is, strictly speaking, the desertion of a post. Campion's job was to stand guard, and his first decision is to stop standing. Latin calls the sentry's post a *statio*, from *stare*, "to stand." Through the waystations of the Roman road network, the same word gives English its "station." So the plague's first journey runs, with a philological exactness nobody designed, from one *statio* to another: from the guard-post Campion abandons to the service station into whose pumps he crashes. The word has a third sense, a liturgical one. In ecclesiastical Latin *statio* named the vigil of the faithful, and the Stations of the Cross descend from it. That sense waits at the far end of

the novel, in a city of crosses (Chapter 4). Table 3 needs a supplement accordingly. *Statio*, the post that is kept or deserted, is the military form of standing, and Book I opens with its abandonment.

The coupling that turns a local failure into a national one lies outside the laboratory, in the infrastructure of American mobility. The Federal-Aid Highway Act of 1956 created the National System of Interstate and *Defense* Highways. It was justified partly as civil-defense infrastructure, a way to evacuate cities under nuclear attack. A Defense Department pathogen therefore crosses the continent on defense highways. The network built to survive the war the pathogen was designed to fight is what couples the catastrophe to the nation. This is the first appearance of what Chapter 7 will call *the self-inversion of the instrument*: the infrastructure of security becomes the vector of extinction. It also turns the road novel inside out. Kerouac's highway was a line of flight; King's is a line of transmission.

Ulrich Beck's *Risikogesellschaft* (1986), published in the year of Chernobyl, supplies the political sociology that Perrow's engineering analysis lacks. For Beck, late modernity is defined by "manufactured" risks. These dangers are produced by modernization itself, cannot be perceived by the senses, can be read only through expert knowledge, and are therefore shielded from public challenge by the same institutions that create them. Beck's name for the resulting condition is *organisierte Unverantwortlichkeit*, "organized irresponsibility" (1988): a system in which everyone follows procedure and no one is answerable. Book I is the most complete fictional anatomy of that condition. The pathogen exists as a State secret, so the public can neither perceive it, nor name it, nor contest it until it is everywhere. Once it is everywhere, the institutions that made it devote all their energy to hiding the fact.

The novel's premise was anticipation rather than fantasy, and its history can be dated.

- **1975.** King began *The Stand* in the year the Biological Weapons Convention entered into force.

- **Behind the treaty.** The Convention followed Nixon's renunciation of offensive biological weapons in November 1969, which followed the Skull Valley sheep kill of March 1968 (Chapter 1).
- **1977.** With the manuscript in progress, the U.S. Army disclosed to a Senate subcommittee that between 1949 and 1969 it had conducted some 239 open-air tests of biological simulants over populated areas. These included the 1950 "Sea-Spray" release of *Serratia marcescens* over San Francisco Bay and the 1966 dispersal of *Bacillus globigii* in the New York subway. The citizen as unwitting test subject is the historical ground of Stu Redman's captivity (2.5).
- **1979.** The sequel is more striking still. In April, six months after *The Stand* appeared, anthrax spores escaped from a Soviet military microbiology facility at Sverdlovsk and killed several dozen people; Matthew Meselson's 1994 field investigation documented sixty-six deaths. Officials attributed the outbreak to contaminated meat until 1992. The first lethal escape of a weaponized pathogen from a military facility followed King's fiction by half a year, and so did the cover-up.

The cover-up is the real subject of Book I, and it reveals what the State essentially is. Max Weber observed that the "official secret" (*Amtsgeheimnis*) is bureaucracy's specific invention: the means by which administration turns knowledge into power and shields itself from scrutiny. The novel stages the moment when the secret outranks the citizen. Starkey, though privately compassionate, works to conceal the accidental outbreak and the pandemic that follows for as long as he possibly can. The violence escalates as the secret fails, and it reaches all the way to the quarantined town where the story began. Cicero gave Roman public law its supreme maxim, *salus populi suprema lex esto* (*De legibus* III.8), "let the safety of the people be the supreme law." Hobbes made the same idea the definition of the sovereign's office: "the procuration of the safety of the people" (*Leviathan*, ch. 30). Book I shows the maxim inverted into *arcanum imperii suprema lex*, "let the secret of rule be the supreme law." Faced with the failure of its own security ap-

paratus, the State sacrifices the people to the secret. Section 2.6 argues that this inversion is the first symptom of a death.

2.2 The Stockpile of Death: Heidegger's *Bestand*

Chapter 1 introduced Heidegger's *Bestand*. Here the concept must be tested against the thing itself. In "Die Frage nach der Technik" (1954), Heidegger argues that modern technology does not merely use beings. It "challenges them forth" (*herausfordern*), ordering them to stand ready for further ordering. The decisive formulation is built almost entirely from the vocabulary of standing and setting: everything is ordered *auf der Stelle zur Stelle zu stehen*, "to stand on the spot at our disposal." Then: *Das so Bestellte hat seinen eigenen Stand. Wir nennen ihn den Bestand.* "What is ordered in this way has its own standing. We call it the standing-reserve."

A philological caution in Barr's spirit is needed here, because the passage braids together two roots.

- *Stehen*, *Stand*, and *Bestand* descend from **steh₂-*, "to stand."
- *Stellen*, *Stelle*, and *Ge-stell* descend from a different root, **stel-*, "to set, to place." *Ge-stell*, "enframing," is Heidegger's name for the essence of technology.

Heidegger's thought lives in the friction between the two. The *Ge-stell* sets upon beings (*stellt*) so that they stand (*stehen*) as stock. *Bestand* is therefore standing that has been *set*: commandeered, coerced, standing as mere availability. The distinction turns out to be decisive for this study. The witness's stand in Book III is the one form of standing in the novel that cannot be set. Nothing can command it into place; it can only be taken.

Heidegger's examples are a hydroelectric plant on the Rhine and an airliner on a runway. The airliner, he says, appears not as an object but as stock, held ready to secure the possibility of transport. Project Blue's pathogen is a purer case than either. A dam is at least used, and an airliner at least flies. A strategic pathogen exists *in order not to be used*: its

whole being is readiness. Bernard Brodie stated the logic of the nuclear age in *The Absolute Weapon* (1946). From now on, he argued, the chief purpose of a military establishment must be to avert wars rather than win them. Under deterrence a weapon fulfills its function by standing ready, and it fails by being used. The superflu is *Bestand* in absolute form: death held in reserve, a stockpile whose only legitimate way of existing is to remain a stockpile. Its escape is therefore an ontological event and not only a technical one. Standing-reserve becomes history. Something that existed only as potential becomes, within one delayed second, the most actual fact on earth.

The pathogen's design deepens the analysis. An adaptive immune response is an act of recognition: it learns a form and remembers it. A virus engineered to keep changing its form defeats recognition as such. It is stock without a stable stand, *Bestand* without *Stand*. In this it is the biological double of the novel's antagonist, the man of a hundred names who "doesn't know himself" and who comes walking out of the road-haze of Book I while the plague spreads. Virus and Walkin Dude share an ontology of instability. Both are protean, both travel by road, and both are legion: "My name is Legion: for we are many" (Mark 5:9). The novel gives them simultaneous births, and Chapter 5 will argue that it also gives them the same metaphysical status. Each is a being without *hypostasis*, a power that consists entirely in passing through others.

Heidegger's thought has an infamous shadow, and the novel's moral intelligence shows most clearly against it. In the Bremen lectures of 1949, Heidegger called mechanized agriculture "in essence the same" as the manufacture of corpses in gas chambers and extermination camps, the blockading and starving of whole countries, and the manufacture of hydrogen bombs. Critics from Philippe Lacoue-Labarthe onward have treated the sentence as a scandal of thought, not merely of taste. By locating evil in the impersonal destiny of *Gestell*, it dissolves the difference between processing nature and murdering persons, and with that difference it dissolves the possibility of responsibility.

The Stand refuses this leveling at every turn. It insists on the difference between an accident and a decision. It follows the chain of com-

mand up to the man who gives the order, and it makes him pay in his own person (2.6). The novel accepts Heidegger's diagnosis that the age turns everything, death included, into stock. It rejects the ontology that would excuse anyone for it. Somebody signed for the stockpile.

Lewis Mumford had already named the institutional body of *Bestand*. In *The Myth of the Machine* (1967) he described the "megamachine," the first great machine in history, whose parts were human beings organized by bureaucratic command. It was assembled in the Bronze Age to raise the pyramids. His second volume (1970) carried the modern version in its title: *The Pentagon of Power*. Project Blue is the Pentagon's megamachine yielding its purest product. Glen Bateman's lecture (3.6) will put the pyramid at the fourth step of the human descent, and Las Vegas will rebuild the megamachine out of survivors (Chapter 4). The novel's history of standing-reserve runs from the pyramid to the pathogen and back to the pyramid.

One further detail carries the analysis from ontology into political theology: the plague is zoologically selective. The superflu kills not only people but most domestic animals, dogs included, while wolves and other wild creatures are spared; Glen Bateman's dog is one of the rare canine survivors. The German word for livestock is *Viehbestand*. Domestication is the original standing-reserve, the Neolithic conversion of animals into stock. The laboratory's standing-reserve annihilates the Neolithic one. Its victims are humanity and humanity's oldest companion species; its heir is the wolf.

The political theology follows directly. *Lupus est homo homini*, Plautus wrote (*Asinaria* 495), "man is a wolf to man," and Hobbes made the phrase emblematic of the natural condition. In *The Stand* the wolves are Flagg's, and the surviving dog keeps faith with the men who will stand. Kojak belongs to the line of Odysseus's Argos, the only creature who recognizes his master after twenty years (*Odyssey* XVII. 290–327), and he will keep watch with Stu Redman in the ravine (Chapter 7). The plague sorts the animals before the dreams sort the people. The wild survives and the domestic nearly perishes, and the humane must be rebuilt from a remnant of the domestic: a man, a woman, a dog.

2.3 Sontag Inverted: The Military Metaphor Made Vehicle

The Stand appeared in the same year as Susan Sontag's *Illness as Metaphor* (1978), and the coincidence is instructive. Sontag argued that the great diseases of modernity, first tuberculosis and then cancer, had been weighed down with metaphors that harm the sick. Cancer in particular was described in a military idiom: invasion, colonization, defenses, and the "war on cancer" that Nixon declared in 1971. Her conclusion was that illness "is *not* a metaphor," and that the healthiest way of being ill is the one most purified of metaphorical thinking.

The novel performs an exact inversion of the figure Sontag criticized. I. A. Richards (*The Philosophy of Rhetoric*, 1936) distinguished a metaphor's *tenor*, the thing spoken of, from its *vehicle*, the figure that carries it. In the "war on cancer," illness is the tenor and war is the vehicle. In *The Stand* the illness literally is a weapon, so the military metaphor is no metaphor at all. More precisely, the figure runs backward. The plague becomes the vehicle, and the tenor is the war: the Cold War, with its stockpiles, deterrence, and secrecy, made biologically visible. Sontag's complaint was that we speak of disease as if it were war. King's novel shows a war that has become a disease.

The popular names confirm the inversion. The virus's nickname is "Captain Trips," and under it the disease spreads around the globe.

- **"Captain Trips"** was the nickname of the Grateful Dead's Jerry Garcia. In two words it fuses a military rank with the psychedelic "trip," joining the Pentagon and Haight-Ashbury, the two Americas of 1967–68 that faced each other across the barricades of the decade. The counterculture names the military's weapon; the Summer of Love names the plague.
- **"Tubeneck"**, the clinical nickname, records the disease's signature: the throat swells and the victim chokes. Here the medical sense of *stasis* in Table 3, the arrest of a flow, becomes the plague's way of killing.

The organ the plague closes is the organ of breath and voice. In Greek and Latin, breath is *pneuma* and *spiritus*, and the Pentecost of Acts 2 is the gift of breath as speech, with tongues of fire on every head. The superflu is an anti-Pentecost: it takes breath and closes throats, a Babel of silence. It is not by chance, then, that the first great voice of the reconstruction belongs to a man who cannot speak (Nick Andros, Chapter 4), or that the survivors' first community is gathered not by speech but by dream (3.5).

The novel's moral stance toward the plague is subtler than either of the two positions Sontag set against each other, the punitive theology she deplored and the de-moralized clinic she recommended.

On one side, the novel denies the plague any meaning as judgment. Immunity is distributed without regard to virtue. The first survivor we meet is a laconic factory worker, the second a pregnant college student, and the immune include saints and spree killers alike. Death takes the just and the unjust without distinction. Nothing in the narrative ratifies the plague as punishment. This holds even though the 1990 revision, written in the shadow of *AIDS and Its Metaphors* (1989), lays references to the century's most moralized epidemic across the surface of the text.

On the other side, the novel insists that the disease has an author, which Sontag's clinical purism does not. The disease is not natural; it is a policy. Harold Lauder is among the first characters to reason his way to this truth. When Fran repeats the radio's soothing explanation, Harold dismisses it on the grounds that nature does not work that way.

The novel thereby separates two things that the metaphor of plague-as-judgment fuses: *cause* and *meaning*. The plague has a cause (Project Blue) and no meaning (no verdict). Whatever meaning it acquires arrives only afterward, in the survivors' response: in what they dream, where they walk, and what they build. The novel moves theodicy from causation to vocation, and this is its first deep departure from both the Puritan tradition and that tradition's secular critics.

Defoe's saddler in *A Journal of the Plague Year* (1722) held natural and providential causation together in a single event: the infection

spread by ordinary contagion and was at the same time a visitation. King pulls the two apart and gives each its own catastrophe. Natural (that is, human) causation governs the plague; providential causation governs the Hand. The chiasmus at the core of this dissertation's thesis is Defoe's dual causation unfolded into narrative time.

2.4 Girard's Plague and the *Danse Macabre*

The Western literature of plague begins with a sequence that *The Stand* repeats on a continental scale.

- **Pericles' Funeral Oration** (Thucydides II.35–46) is the supreme celebration of the city and its dead.
- **The plague of 430 BCE** follows immediately (II.47–54). Thucydides records that it threw the burial customs into confusion, so that people disposed of their dead however they could (II.52.4). He records that it began a new lawlessness (*anomia*) in the city: "neither fear of the gods nor law of men held anyone back" (II.53.4).
- **The civil war at Corcyra** (III.82–83) arrives in the third book as the plague's political sequel. There *stasis* rewrites the meanings of words.

Plague, then *stasis*: that is the order of Thucydides' *History*, and it is the order of King's novel. Book I is the plague of Athens; Books II and III are Corcyra.

Lucretius ended the *De rerum natura* with the same Athenian plague (VI.1138–1286). The poem closes without consolation, on mourners who would rather fight bloody battles over funeral pyres than abandon their dead. The great Epicurean poem of nature ends in a pestilence and a brawl over burial, which is exactly where Book II of *The Stand* will begin (3.1–3.2).

René Girard's "The Plague in Literature and Myth" (1974) gives this tradition its theory. For Girard, plague in literature figures, at bottom, the "sacrificial crisis." The distinctions that structure a com-

munity collapse; rank, kinship, and law dissolve into reciprocal violence. Myth resolves the crisis through the collective expulsion or murder of a single victim who is blamed for the whole contagion. Plague, in Girard's account, means undifferentiation: it takes rich and poor, king and slave, and in taking them all it erases the differences on which order rests. The paradigm is Sophocles' *Oedipus Tyrannus*. It opens on a plague in Thebes and ends with the discovery that the king who leads the investigation is the culprit he is looking for.

The State in Book I of *The Stand* is Oedipus. It conducts the investigation of the plague (the quarantine of Arnette, the plague centers, the epidemiologists, the cordons), and it is also the plague's author. Its chief investigator discovers that he is the criminal, and the Oedipal resolution follows with tragic exactness: Oedipus blinds himself, and Starkey takes his own life in his last scene. Starkey's death by a self-inflicted gunshot wound heads the list of deaths in the chapter, alongside physicians lost to the superflu.

Between discovery and self-punishment, however, Starkey does something no Sophoclean hero does, and it reveals the Cold War's peculiar relation to the sacrificial mechanism. Girard's myths resolve their crises by finding a scapegoat. The American State knows it will be identified as the guilty party, so it makes identification impossible. In Starkey's briefing, the controlling aim is stated without euphemism: the world must never learn that this catastrophe was artificial and American-made. The means is to universalize the plague so that its point of origin vanishes into its ubiquity. If every nation is infected, no nation can be singled out. The State escapes the role of scapegoat by making undifferentiation total. This is the negative image of the Girardian resolution. It is not all against one but all made equal to all, so that no one remains to be against.

Girard's last book, *Achever Clausewitz* (2007; *Battling to the End*, 2010), read Clausewitz's "escalation to extremes" (*Steigerung zum Äußersten*) as the apocalyptic logic of mimetic rivalry freed from every restraint. Rivals imitate each other's violence until the escalation consumes them both. Starkey's order is the purest literary instance of that logic. Facing the prospect of a devastated America among intact rivals,

the State ensures that its rivals are devastated too, preserving its relative position at the cost of its absolute one. Mimetic rivalry reaches its end in a vial. Clausewitz believed that reality would always moderate "absolute war"; here it is achieved without a battle.

The plague's narrative form is older than any of these theories. Book I is a *danse macabre*. The medieval Dance of Death shows the living of every estate in a chain (pope, emperor, cardinal, king, merchant, laborer, child), each led into the dance by a skeletal partner who takes him by the hand. Its classic sites are the mural at the Cemetery of the Holy Innocents in Paris (1424–25), Bernt Notke's *Totentanz* in Lübeck's Marienkirche (1463), and Holbein's woodcuts (published at Lyon in 1538). Its meaning is twofold: it is a *memento mori* and a leveling. Death respects no rank, and the dance was the only true democracy of the Middle Ages.

Book I is built on exactly this chain. Its most celebrated chapter follows the contagion from hand to hand outward from the Arnette service station. Bill Hapscomb passes the infection to his cousin, a highway patrolman, and the chain runs on from there through strangers who touch for a moment and move on. Later summaries reach instinctively for the period's own figure of exponential relay: in a matter of days the chain-letter spread carries the virus into every part of the country.

The whole social hierarchy joins the dance, up to its summit. The President goes on television while American society is disintegrating, insists the disease is not deadly, and is repeatedly interrupted by his own coughing. This is Holbein's King in the age of television. Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) reconstructed the medieval fiction that distinguished the king's mortal "body natural" from his immortal "body politic," so that the office outlived the officeholder: *le roi est mort, vive le roi*. The coughing President is that fiction collapsing on camera. The body natural infects the body politic, and the sovereign voice chokes as it speaks.

The novel's first Spanish title, *La danza de la muerte*, therefore names Book I precisely (Chapter 1). King himself has cited the rock *danse macabre* of the decade, Blue Öyster Cult's "(Don't Fear) The

Reaper" (1976), among the novel's sources of inspiration. One structural point remains, and it anticipates the climax. The Dance of Death is a chain of joined hands, and contagion passes from hand to hand. Book III ends with a single hand. The novel begins with all hands joined in death and ends with one hand that belongs to no dancer. The whole movement of the book lies between the many hands of the dance and the one Hand of the end.

Two older answers to plague frame the alternatives that the next Books will test.

- **Poe's fortress.** In "The Masque of the Red Death" (1842), Prince Prospero seals himself and a thousand courtiers inside a fortified abbey to wait out the pestilence. The seal fails, and "Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all." Project Blue is Prospero's abbey reversed: it seals the plague *in* rather than out, and its seal fails just as surely.
- **Boccaccio's villa.** In the *Decameron* (c. 1349–53), seven young women and three young men flee the Florentine plague of 1348 to a villa in the hills. There they form a miniature polity under a rotating sovereign, a king or queen for each day, whose office is to regulate the telling of stories. Boccaccio's *brigata* is the first post-plague constitution in European literature: a republic of narrative, founded by survivors, with an elected and limited executive. The Boulder Free Zone is its heir (Chapter 4).

The sealed system and the storytelling republic, Prospero's fortress and Boccaccio's villa: the novel's political alternatives are already drawn.

2.5 Stovington: Bare Life and the First Stand of Stu Redman

At the center of Book I, in a sealed room, the novel places its first stand. Stu Redman is the plague's first discovered immune and the State's most valuable specimen. Officials take him first to the CDC in Atlanta and then to a fictional disease center in Stovington, Vermont. There, he

is periodically injected with the pure strain, his body destroys it each time, and the researchers still cannot derive a cure from him. He is, quite literally, the *60 Minutes* mouse that does not die (Chapter 1): kept under glass, sampled, reinfected, and studied by people who cannot learn from him the one thing they need to know. His immunity goes unexplained to the end of the novel. Stu is science's epistemic remainder, the case its methods cannot reduce.

Michel Foucault's chapter "Panopticism," in *Surveiller et punir* (1975), opens with the regulations for a seventeenth-century town under plague. The town is sealed and divided into segments. Each household is confined to its place; each person is inspected daily at the window; each illness and death is recorded and passed up a pyramid of officials. For Foucault, the plague town is the dream-image of disciplinary power: the utopia of a perfectly governed city, in which every body is fixed, visible, and known. Stovington is that town reduced to one inmate. Stu is segmented, observed, examined, and transcribed. At one point the novel even lets an attending physician dictate a report on him, so that the reader sees one of the main narrators from the outside. The chilling formal effect is that the protagonist briefly becomes a file.

Stu's first resistance is small, and it is precisely calibrated to the disease. Denied information, he answers the examination with a performance: he fakes coughing to needle Deitz whenever he is refused the information he asks for. The gesture deserves more weight than its comedy suggests.

- **A weapon of the weak.** James C. Scott (*Weapons of the Weak*, 1985) taught historians to see resistance in the everyday tactics of subordinates who cannot afford open revolt: foot-dragging, dissimulation, feigned incomprehension. Stu's counterfeit cough is such a weapon, aimed at the knowledge of the strong. He seizes the very symptom the doctors are watching for and turns it into an ironic sign whose message is *you cannot read me*. In a novel whose plague strangles the voice, the first act of resistance is a simulated choking.
- **A claim of consent.** The content of the gesture is a claim that the Nuremberg Code (1947) had made the first principle of research

> ethics: the voluntary consent of the human subject is absolutely essential. In 1972 the exposure of the Tuskegee syphilis study had shown Americans how the State treated subjects whose consent it never sought. Stu's demand to be told what is being done to him is the claim to be a subject and not a specimen.

The same chapter that records the cough also records his first dream of Mother Abagail and the dark man. The examination and the vocation begin together.

As the institution dies, its true structure appears. In Stovington, the hospital has become a prison, and the orderlies now carry guns. Then the State makes its last decision about its last citizen. It sends a man named Elder to kill him. Stu can only suppose that someone has decided he "knows too much." The order is pointless, and that is the point: Stu cannot see why anyone would bother killing him while so many are dying anyway, and suspects it is so the government can deny responsibility, though no government remains. The secret has outlived the State that kept it.

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) names what Stu has become. In archaic Roman law the *homo sacer* could be killed with impunity but could not be sacrificed. He was excluded both from the human law that punishes homicide and from the divine law that governs offerings. For Agamben this "bare life" (*nuda vita*) is the hidden foundation of sovereign power. The sovereign is the one who decides on the exception, the life exposed to that decision is life stripped of every political qualification, and the camp, rather than the city, is modernity's paradigmatic political space. Stovington is a camp in this sense: a space where law has been suspended in the name of emergency, inhabited by a life that may be ended without crime. The order to kill Stu is the sovereign exception in its nakedness. A State that can no longer protect its citizen keeps only the power to dispose of him.

Stu's response is the novel's first stand, and it must be named exactly: it is *Hobbesian*. Hobbes, the theorist of near-absolute sovereignty, still reserved one right that no covenant can transfer. "A Covenant not to defend my selfe from force, by force, is alwayes voyd" (*Leviathan*,

ch. 14). Even a man justly condemned keeps "the Liberty to disobey" a command not to resist those who assault him (ch. 21). The right to resist one's own killing is the irreducible remainder of the state of nature inside the commonwealth, the residue of standing that no sovereign can command away.

Stu exercises that right with cunning before force, an Odyssean *mētis*. He tells the man sent to terminate him to look behind him, the oldest trick in the repertoire. Because the disease has already weakened Elder, Stu is able to overpower him. In the end, he beats Elder to death with a chair and gets out of the facility. The State's last agent was already dying of the State's own weapon. Stu then walks out through a building full of the dead: he is the last living person in the hospital, and the novel devotes a whole chapter to his passage through its dead and dying.

Two points secure this reading.

First, the names are almost too apt. The agent of the dying order is called *Elder*: the old man, the old regime, the presbyter of a church whose god has died. The man who kills him is called *Redman*. Josephus explained the name of the first human being in exactly these terms: "this man was called Adam, which in the Hebrew tongue signifies one that is red, because he was formed out of red earth" (*Antiquities* I.34). Stuart Redman, the steward (Chapter 1) and the red man, is the novel's Adam, the first man of the new world. He enters it by killing the Elder sent to unmake him.

Second, and more important, Stovington sets the baseline against which the novel's climax must be measured. Stu's first stand is the stand of the Hobbesian residue: armed (if only with a chair), self-preserving, and directed against a sovereign who would kill him. The novel's last stand reverses every term. Unarmed men walk *toward* a sovereign who will kill them, renouncing in advance the one right Hobbes declared inalienable, and they do so freely, under no covenant. That freedom is the whole point. Between Stovington and Las Vegas the

novel traces an arc from the inalienable right of self-defense to its voluntary renunciation. This forms a second chiasmus inside the first:

- In Book I, Stu escapes the sovereign who has decided on his death.
- In Book III, he walks toward the sovereign who has decided on his death, and is stopped short not by his own decision but by a fall.

Chapter 7 will show that the novel's theology of the stand can be built only on the ground Stovington clears. The witness's renunciation means something only because the right he renounces was real.

2.6 The Universalization Order and the Death of the *Katechon*

The political climax of Book I is an order, not a battle. Starkey, the professional custodian of the secret, has watched his containment fail. The President removes him from command. He then discovers that the truth has escaped as surely as the virus. The *Los Angeles Times* alone prints tens of thousands of copies exposing the collapse and the government's lies about the superflu. Here the press stands as a third party between State and public, and in doing so it performs the novel's first act of *testimony* in Benveniste's sense (Chapter 1).

Against the press's testimony, Starkey issues his last order. The crisis's internal codes have already escalated through a series of names: the situation passes from "Flowerpot" to "Troy" and at last to "Rome Falls."

- **The order.** Under the final code, the signal "Rome falls" goes out to American agents abroad, who carry vials of the superflu without knowing what they contain and who, on that signal, release it on other continents so that its origin cannot be traced.
- **The agents.** In the novel's Cold War idiom, they are stationed "behind both curtains, iron and bamboo". They received the vials a week earlier, believing the contents to be radioactive tracer particles for satellites to chart.

- **The consequence.** The order ends any hope of containment, guarantees the near-extinction of the species, and makes Starkey answerable for billions of deaths.

In the same scene, Starkey quotes Yeats, the poet whose "rough beast," its "hour come round at last," had already supplied the first jacket's image of Flagg. Then he dies by his own hand.

I call this the *Universalization Order*, and I read it as the death of the *katechon*. The term comes from the most enigmatic passage in the Pauline corpus. Writing to Thessalonians unsettled by rumors that the Day of the Lord had already come, the apostle insists that it cannot come until the "man of sin" is revealed. That revelation is held back by a restraining power, *to katechon* (neuter) or *ho katechōn* (masculine):

> *And now ye know what withholdeth that he might be revealed in his time. For the mystery of iniquity doth already work: only he who now letteth will let, until he be taken out of the way. And then shall that Wicked be revealed, whom the Lord shall consume with the spirit of his mouth, and shall destroy with the brightness of his coming: Even him, whose coming is after the working of Satan with all power and signs and lying wonders.*
>
> (2 Thessalonians 2:6–9)

The patristic tradition identified the restrainer early and almost unanimously as the Roman Empire. Tertullian explains that Christians pray for the emperors "and for the whole standing of the empire" (*pro omni statu imperii*). They do so because "we know that the mighty shock impending over the whole world, the very end of the age threatening horrible calamities, is delayed by the continuance of the Roman empire" (*Romani imperii commeatu scimus retardari*, *Apologeticum* 32.1). Note the stasiological noun at the heart of the formula: what restrains the end is the *status* of the empire.

In the twentieth century, Carl Schmitt (*Der Nomos der Erde*, 1950) revived the concept as the key to Christian political theology. On his reading, the empire, and after it the State, was the historical force that held back chaos and thereby made history possible. Agamben (*Il tempo che resta*, 2000; *Il mistero del male*, 2013) answered that the *katechon* is

something darker: the power that defers the messianic and administers the delay.

The novel's code names give the concept a name the Church Fathers would have recognized. The crisis escalates from *Troy* to *Rome falls*, which is the *translatio imperii* in miniature. The *translatio* was the westward transfer of empire, from fallen Troy to the Rome founded by Aeneas's refugees, which medieval historiography extended through the four monarchies of Daniel. George Berkeley wrote the American coda to that tradition: "Westward the course of empire takes its way." His *Verses on the Prospect of Planting Arts and Learning in America* (written 1726) made the New World the fifth and final act of the drama. In Starkey's mouth, "Rome falls" names the patristic *katechon* and dissolves it in a single phrase. America, the last Rome, takes itself out of the way.

The Pauline sequence then unfolds through the novel's three Books with remarkable fidelity.

1. **The restrainer is taken away (Book I).** The State that restrained the end does not simply fall. It dies by its own hand, and in dying it universalizes the end it was meant to restrain.
2. **The lawless one is revealed (Book II).** The Walkin Dude, who had been moving at the margins of the narrative throughout the plague, emerges as the sovereign of a city. His "power and signs and lying wonders" (2:9) are the eye that rides in crows, the knowledge of distant events, and the ball of fire at his fingertip. The paradox Agamben identified is fully realized: the *anomos*, the lawless one, governs through an exceptionally severe law. Sovereignty in the state of exception is precisely the suspension of law placed in the hands of one person.
3. **The lawless one is destroyed "with the brightness of his coming" (Book III).** The Greek is *tē epiphaneia tēs parousias autou*, "by the epiphany of his presence." In Book III a light brighter than the desert sun rises over Las Vegas. The novel's eschatological climax is a literal epiphany: a radiance that consumes the city of the lawless one.

Table 4 The katechontic sequence and Kant's three ends

2 Thessalonians 2	*The Stand*	Kant, "Das Ende aller Dinge" (1794)
"he who now letteth… taken out of the way" (v. 7)	Book I: the State's suicide; "Rome falls"	The *contranatural* end, "which we ourselves bring about by misunderstanding the final end"
"then shall that Wicked be revealed… with lying wonders" (vv. 8–9)	Book II: Flagg's sovereignty in Las Vegas	The Antichrist's regime, "presumably founded on fear and self-interest," and brief
"destroy with the brightness of his coming" (v. 8)	Book III: the Hand; the light over Las Vegas	The *mystical* (supernatural) end, in the order of efficient causes, "of which we understand nothing"
(the age continues)	Frame: Peter's survival; the road to Maine; "The Circle Closes"	The *natural* end, according to the order of moral ends, intelligible "in a practical respect"

At this point the novel makes a decisive modification, and its political theology becomes original rather than illustrative. In Paul and in Schmitt, the *katechon* is taken out of the way by another: by God, or by the internal decay of the restraining power. In *The Stand* the *katechon* takes *itself* away, and at the moment of its death it turns into its opposite. The State's last sovereign act is not to restrain the end but to *accelerate* it, carrying the plague to every continent. I call this *katechontic inversion*: the restrainer becomes the accelerator through the internal logic of its own security doctrine.

International relations theory has a name for that logic. John Herz (1950) called it the "security dilemma": each State's measures for its own security reduce the security of others and so provoke the escalation they were meant to prevent. In the Cold War, security was understood relationally, as advantage over rivals, rather than absolutely, as the protection of citizens. Given that understanding, the conclusion follows with terrible validity: if we cannot be saved, our rivals must not be spared. It is the logic of Samson in the temple of Dagon: "Let me die with the Philistines" (Judges 16:30).

Hobbes himself foresaw the conditions of this death.

- **Mortality.** His sovereign is "that Mortall God, to which wee owe under the Immortall God, our peace and defence" (*Leviathan*, ch. 17). The adjective is exact: the mortal god can die.
- **Disease.** Chapter 29 catalogues "those things that weaken, or tend to the dissolution of a Common-wealth" as diseases of the body politic.
- **Release.** Chapter 21 states the consequence of the State's death with a clarity that governs the whole of Book II: "The Obligation of Subjects to the Soveraign, is understood to last as long, and no longer, than the power lasteth, by which he is able to protect them."

When the power to protect dies, obligation dies with it. The survivors of Book I are therefore not citizens in exile. Legally and morally they stand in the state of nature, released from every obligation the dead State imposed. That is why the Free Zone's later decision to readopt the old Constitution is a genuine act of founding and not a mere continuation (Chapter 4).

The frontispiece of *Leviathan* (1651), engraved by Abraham Bosse, holds a detail that reads like a prophecy of *The Stand*, and Agamben drew attention to it (*Stasis*, 2015). Above the landscape towers the sovereign, his body composed of the tiny bodies of his subjects. Below him lies a city, and the city is empty. Its streets are deserted except for a few armed guards and two figures in beaked masks: plague doctors. Hobbes's image of the commonwealth already contains a depopulated city under plague, whose people have passed entirely into the body of the sovereign. *The Stand* gives the reverse of the engraving. The sovereign body dissolves; the giant composed of the people falls apart into the dead and the scattered; and the cities are left as Bosse drew them, empty except for the agents of death.

Engels predicted that the State would not be abolished but would "die out" (*er stirbt ab*, *Anti-Dühring*, 1878). King's novel grants the Marxist and anarchist eschatologies their wish in the most literal form

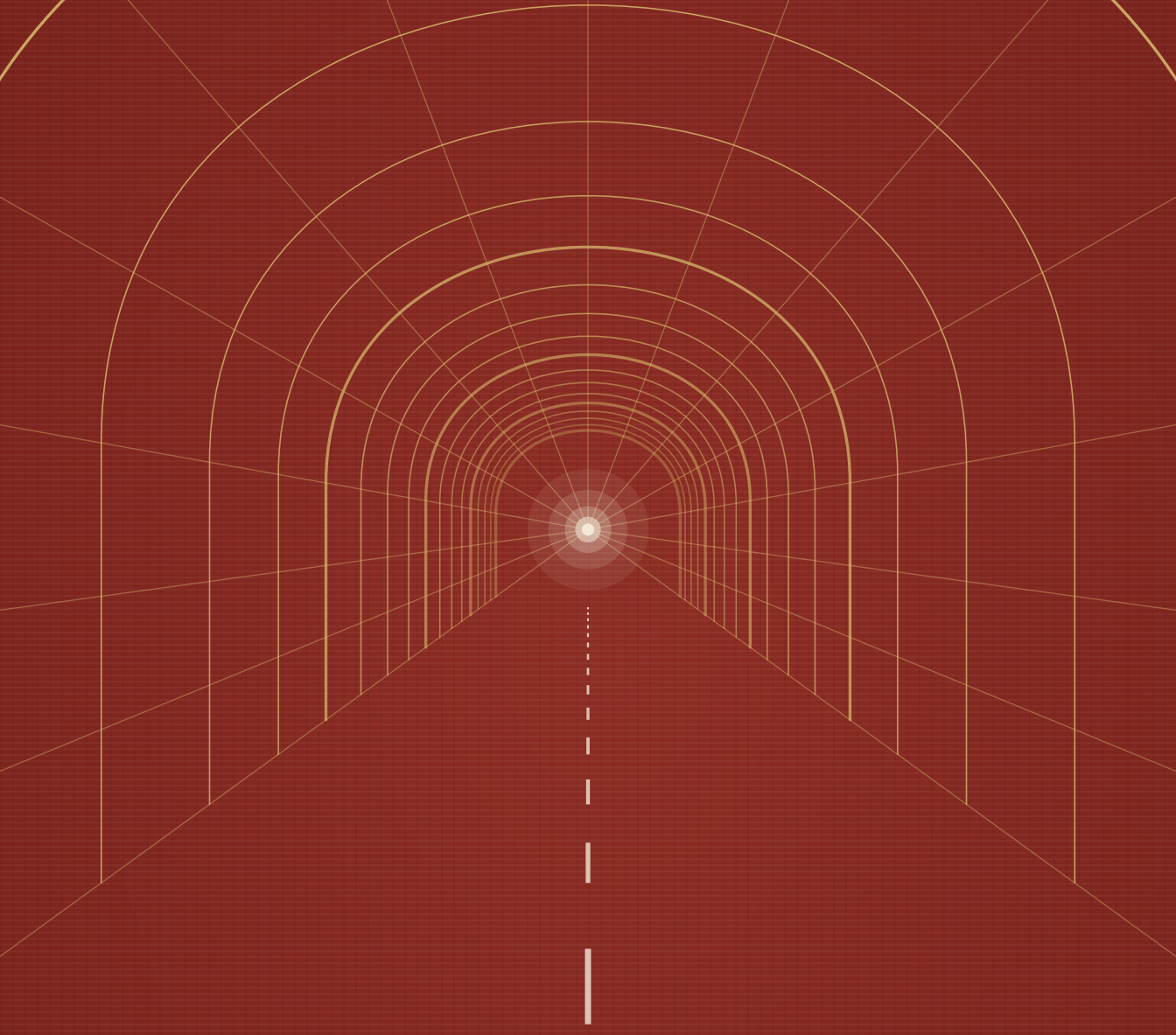
imaginable: the State does not wither, it dies of influenza. The Hearst fragment from which the novel grew (Chapter 1) imagined revolutionaries immune to an apocalypse. The finished novel makes the question of the SLA, and of every revolutionary utopia, its own: once the State is gone, what will the survivors make?

Kant's late essay "Das Ende aller Dinge" (1794) supplies the last frame for Book I and the first frame for what follows. Kant distinguishes three conceivable ends of all things.

1. **The natural end** proceeds according to the order of the moral ends of divine wisdom, which we can understand in a practical respect.
2. **The mystical (supernatural) end** belongs to the order of efficient causes, of which we understand nothing.
3. **The contranatural (perverted) end** is the one "which we ourselves bring about by misunderstanding the final end."

Book I narrates the contranatural end: humanity destroyed by its own misreading of the purpose of its power, with security turned into the instrument of extinction. Kant's essay closes with a political prophecy. If Christianity ever ceased to be lovable, he warns, the Antichrist would begin his regime, one "presumably founded on fear and self-interest" (*vermutlich auf Furcht und Eigennutz gegründet*) and *kurz*, brief. Las Vegas will be that regime: founded on fear, administered through self-interest, and short-lived. Book III will give the mystical end, the Hand, of which the novel's characters understand nothing, and do not claim to understand anything. The natural end, the moral destiny of the species, is never narrated at all. The novel gives only its practical posture: a child, a road home, and a question.

The *katechon* is gone. In its absence, as Paul foretold and Hobbes allowed, the survivors stand in a world without restraint, without obligation, and without the State that once stood for them. Chapter 3 follows them into that world, beginning where every human world has begun: with the dead.



Chapter 3

Humanitas a Humando

Burial, Descent, and the Oneiric Franchise

And humanitas *in Latin comes first and properly from* humando, *"burying."*

(Vico, *Scienza nuova* [1744], §12; my translation)

...ἄγραπτα κἀσφαλῆ θεῶν νόμιμα.

[*...the unwritten and unshakable statutes of the gods.*]

(Sophocles, *Antigone* 454–55)

Between the death of the State at the end of Book I and the founding of the two cities in Book II lies an interval. The novel treats it with a patience that critics have usually mistaken for padding. It consists of solitary journeys across an emptied continent: a woman digs a grave in a Maine garden, a singer crawls through a flooded dark beneath the Hudson, strangers dream the same two dreams, and a retired professor lectures a Texan on the arithmetic of human wickedness.

This chapter reads the interval as a Vichian *ricorso*: humanity's return to its first principles, which Vico identified as religion, marriage, and burial. The argument is simple and, for the novel's political theory, foundational. Before the survivors can *constitute*, they must become human again. The novel narrates that recovery through four operations:

- burial (Fran Goldsmith);
- descent (Larry Underwood);
- vocation (the dreams);
- theory (Glen Bateman).

3.1 The Barbarism of Reflection: Vico's *Ricorso*

Giambattista Vico's *Scienza nuova* (1725; definitive edition 1744) proposed that every nation passes through three ages: an age of gods, an

age of heroes, and an age of men. Each has its own nature, customs, jurisprudence, and language. The course (*corso*) ends when the rational age of men decays, and history then begins its return (*ricorso*) to a new barbarism and a new age of gods. Vico's example was the European Middle Ages, which he read as Rome's "second barbarism."

The decisive passage comes in the work's conclusion (§1106), and it may be the most exact anticipation of Book II of *The Stand* in all of European philosophy. Vico distinguishes two barbarisms.

- **The barbarism of sense** (*barbarie del senso*) belonged to the first humans. It was savage but frank: the open ferocity of beings who knew no better.
- **The barbarism of reflection** (*barbarie della riflessione*) belongs to decadent civilizations at the end of their course. Vico judges it more inhuman. Beneath soft words and embraces, it plots against the lives and fortunes of friends and intimates. It is malice refined by intelligence.

For peoples sunk in this "ultimate civil disease," providence holds an "extreme remedy." Through obstinate factions and desperate civil wars, which is to say through *stasis*, they turn their cities into forests and their forests into the lairs of men. Over long centuries of barbarism, rust eats away the misbegotten subtleties of malicious wits. Vico then describes what remains. The few survivors, finding themselves amid an abundance of the necessities of life, naturally become sociable again. Returned to the primal simplicity of the first world of peoples, they become once more *religiosi, veraci e fidi*: religious, truthful, and faithful.

Every element of this passage has a counterpart in Book II of *The Stand*.

- **Few survivors:** fewer than one in a hundred.
- **Abundance of necessities:** the empty continent's stores lie open to the remnant, the very condition the Hearst fragment greeted with its horribly cheerful line about the end of gas shortages.
- **The return to religion:** the survivors gather around a prophetess.

- **The remedy works through *stasis*:** the civil war of two cities.

The novel departs from Vico at one crucial point, and the departure drives the rest of the book. Vico's remedy needs centuries, and its rust works slowly. King's remedy takes a month: a technologically accelerated *ricorso*. The survivors are stunned, as Vico says such peoples are, but they are not purified. The barbarism of reflection survives the remedy. Vico's portrait of the reflective barbarian (malicious wit, soft words and embraces, plots against friends) describes, three centuries early, the smile of Harold Lauder, who will work on the burial crew by day and fill a ledger with murder by night (Chapter 6). Many others survive the plague only to die of its aftermath: of accident, despair, and grief. Rita Blakemoor, discussed below, is the novel's most fully realized case. In Vico's terms these are the survivors who cannot become *religiosi, veraci e fidi*, those for whom the abundance of the empty world is not a remedy but a vertigo.

Two further Vichian principles organize what follows. The first is Vico's account of providence, which §1108 states in the formula that later theorists, after Wilhelm Wundt, called the "heterogony of ends." Men made this world of nations, Vico writes. Yet the world has issued from a mind "often diverse, at times quite contrary, and always superior" to the particular ends that men proposed to themselves. Providence works through human purposes and against them, using vices to produce institutions their authors never intended. This is the theology of the Hand (Chapter 7) stated a quarter of a millennium in advance. The particular end Flagg proposes, the destruction of Boulder by a weapon carried into Las Vegas, will serve a mind "quite contrary and always superior" to his.

The second is the anthropology of burial. All nations, barbarous and civilized alike, keep three human customs (§333):

- all have some religion;
- all contract solemn marriages;
- all bury their dead.

On the third, Vico offers a thought experiment of extraordinary force (§337). Imagine a feral condition in which human bodies lie unburied on the surface of the earth, food for crows and dogs. Fields would go untilled and cities uninhabited, and men would wander like swine eating acorns among the putrefaction of their dead. This is the America of the plague's summer: cities uninhabited, fields untilled, the dead lying in their cars and beds. The novel has a sovereign of crows. Randall Flagg sends his eye into the crow and commands the wolf. In precise Vichian terms, he is the lord of the unburied.

Table 5 **Vico's three principles of humanity in the two cities**

Vichian principle (§333)	Boulder Free Zone	Las Vegas
Religion	Gathered around a prophetess who will withdraw into the wilderness to atone for her pride	The leader himself worshipped; obedience as cult
Solemn marriage	Fran and Stu enter a marital relationship once settled in Boulder; the anxious wait to learn whether the children of the immune will live	Nadine as the dark man's promised "bride," a union consummated as violation
Burial	Burial details clear the dead from the city	Crucifixion: the body displayed, not interred

The final cell needs commentary, because it shows the deep logic of Las Vegas's signature punishment. In Roman practice, crucifixion was more than a method of execution. It was a denial of burial. The body was often left on the cross for birds and dogs. Horace preserves the proverbial form of this in an exchange with a slave who claims he has murdered no one: "then you will not feed the crows on a cross" (*non pasces in cruce corvos*, *Epistles* I.16.48). Crucifixion is anti-*humando*: the deliberate reversal of the founding gesture of humanity. A city that crucifies is a city that feeds the crows, and the crows are its sovereign's eyes. Las Vegas is the Vichian anti-city, organized around the inversion of the oldest human rite.

Vico's cycle also governs the novel's form. James Joyce built *Finnegans Wake* (1939) on Vico's cycle. The book opens mid-sentence and returns to its beginning "by a commodius vicus of recirculation." The

frame of King's restored text, "The Circle Opens" and "The Circle Closes," is a Vichian *ricorso* of the same kind, one whose final pages bring the reader back to the place where it began (Conclusion). Arnold Toynbee's Vichian history of civilizations, *A Study of History* (1934–61), offers a vocabulary that fits the two cities closely.

- **A "creative minority"** leads by attraction: others follow it by a kind of mimesis, freely.
- **A "dominant minority"** rules by force once its creative power has failed.

Boulder gathers through dreams of invitation; Las Vegas holds through terror. Toynbee's further pattern of "withdrawal-and-return," the creative individual's retreat into solitude and return with new power, will govern Mother Abagail's flight into the wilderness and Stu Redman's sojourn in the ravine (Chapter 7).

One final, specifically American feature of the *ricorso* deserves notice. In 1893 Frederick Jackson Turner opened "The Significance of the Frontier in American History" with a bulletin from the Superintendent of the Census for 1890. Up to 1880, the bulletin said, the country had possessed a frontier of settlement, but there could now hardly be said to be a frontier line. For Turner, the frontier had been the generator of American democracy: "the meeting point between savagery and civilization," where institutions were endlessly reborn. Its closing in 1890 was therefore an epochal event.

The *Complete & Uncut Edition* sets its action in 1990, exactly one century after the census declared the frontier closed. The plague reopens it. The continent becomes free land again, and every survivor in the novel, whichever dream they follow, goes west. Both cities lie beyond the hundredth meridian. Turner's question, what the frontier makes of those who cross it, receives two answers. Boulder gives the democratic answer, the town meeting reborn. Las Vegas gives the answer the Western genre always knew lay in the frontier's shadow: vigilante law, the strongman, the rope and the cross. The American *ricorso*

is the return of the frontier, and the novel discovers that the frontier was never one destiny but two.

3.2 Fran in the Garden: Antigone and the Unwritten Law

The first human act of the new world is a burial, and it is performed by a woman. In Ogunquit, Maine, only Fran Goldsmith and Harold Lauder remain alive once the parking-lot attendant Gus Dinsmore dies on June 30. Her father dies at home, having refused the hospital. Fran prepares his shroud herself and lays him in the garden, the same garden he had been weeding barely a week before.

The novel's geography of this scene is exact and unemphatic. It was in this garden, earlier in Book I, that Fran came out to find her father weeding the peas and beans and told him she was pregnant. The place of annunciation becomes the place of burial. The ground where the daughter announced the coming child receives the father, and the child, when it comes, will bear his name. In the restored text she wraps him for the grave in her mother's best tablecloth, the one reserved for company, a detail whose meaning Section 3.3 will unfold.

The scene's exchange is minimal. Harold, arriving, asks what she means to do, and she answers: "Bury my father." Three words name the whole Vichian anthropology.

The archetype is Sophocles' Antigone. She buries her brother Polynices against the edict of Creon, the new king of Thebes, who has ordered the traitor's body left for dogs and birds. When she is brought before him, she appeals over his decree to "the unwritten and unshakable statutes of the gods" (*agrapta kasphalē theōn nomima*, 454–55). These laws, she says, are not of today or yesterday, and no one knows when they first appeared.

Hegel's reading in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807, §§444–76) made the tragedy the paradigm of a conflict between two ethical powers.

- **The human law** of the State is public, masculine, and universal.

- **The divine law** of the family is private, feminine, and devoted to the singular.

Burial is the supreme duty of the divine law. By burying the dead, the family rescues the dead person from the mere natural process of decay and from the "unconscious appetites" of animals and elements. It raises death from a natural event to a spiritual act. In Hegel's phrase, the family "weds the kinsman to the bosom of the earth" (*vermählt den Verwandten dem Schoße der Erde*, §452).

Fran's act is Antigonean, but its situation reverses Antigone's, and the reversal defines the political theology of the whole *ricorso*. **There is no Creon.** No edict forbids the burial and no State claims the body. The old order, had it survived, would have consigned Peter Goldsmith to the dead-carts that Defoe describes trundling through plague-time London, or to the mass graves of 1918. Its absence turns the meaning of the act around. Antigone's burial is a transgression: the divine law against the human. Fran's burial is a *foundation*: the divine law in the vacancy of the human. Hegel's two laws were in conflict because both were standing. In *The Stand* one has fallen, and the unwritten law, freed from its antagonist, becomes the first law of the new world. What was Antigone's crime is Fran's constitution.

Two refinements complete the reading.

First, the tragic cast is not empty: it has a Haemon. In Sophocles, Haemon is Creon's son and Antigone's betrothed. Maddened by her death, he spits in his father's face, draws his sword against him, misses, and turns the blade on himself (*Antigone* 1231–39). Harold Lauder's trajectory follows Haemon's with uncanny fidelity:

- an unrequited devotion to the woman who buried her father;
- an armed attack on the authority of the new polity, in Stu Redman, which misses its principal target;
- death by his own hand.

Even his first appearance carries the doubleness that will undo him. In the restored text Harold looks at Fran with a predatory avidity even as she stands by the open grave. Yet he understands that she would

want to bury her father alone. The respect and the hunger arrive together. Chapter 6 will anatomize what becomes of them.

Second, the garden tomb has a precise scriptural type. "Now in the place where he was crucified there was a garden; and in the garden a new sepulchre, wherein was never man yet laid" (John 19:41). On the morning of the resurrection, Mary Magdalene mistakes the risen Christ for "the gardener" (John 20:15). The gardener buried in his own garden is a figure of *anastasis*, and the novel fulfills the figure without a miracle. Fran gives birth to a son named Peter after her father, and when the child recovers from the superflu, his survival shows that infants born to immune parents can resist the virus. The name *Peter* is *petra*, the rock: "thou art Peter, and upon this rock I will build my church" (Matthew 16:18). The father goes into the earth of his garden, and the father's name rises from it as the cornerstone of the new world's future. The Conclusion will develop this as the novel's theory of natality.

Fran writes as well as buries, and the two acts belong together. She keeps a journal addressed to her unborn child. It is testimony in Benveniste's second sense: the record of a *superstes*, one who stood over the event and survived to tell it, set down for someone who was not there. The novel's other great private document, Harold's ledger, is its exact antithesis. Fran's journal is written forward, to a child; the ledger is written backward, against enemies. One is the archive of survival and the other the account-book of grievance. Chapter 6 will read the two documents together.

3.3 The Parlor and the Workshop: Two Pieties of the Dead

Before the plague arrives, the novel has already set out a theory of how the living keep faith with the dead, and it has done so in architecture. In the restored text, the chapter of Fran's confrontation with her mother opens with a sentence whose first verb carries the dissertation's title word: "There was a grandfather clock standing in the far corner of the parlor." The chapter then sets the mother's favorite room, the par-

lor, against the father's favorite room, his workshop, and lingers over the comparison for pages. That patience is the reason for what follows. The comparison is a small treatise on piety.

The parlor belongs to Carla Goldsmith. Fran's brother Fred was killed when she was four and he was thirteen. After his death, Carla closed herself off and grew cold, devoting herself to an immaculate parlor, to church and civic duties, and to keeping up appearances. Her husband's diagnosis is three words long: after Freddie died, her views hardened, and as Peter Goldsmith puts it, "she stopped growing." The room is the materialization of that arrest.

- **Time.** Its time is the clock's time: Chronos, ticking off a sequence of identical moments in what the novel calls a "dry age."
- **Blood.** In a remembered childhood scene, Fran comes to her mother hurt, and her mother's first concern is for the room, "where that dry age went on and on and blood was not allowed."
- **Birth.** When the pregnancy is revealed, Carla objects that the baby cannot be christened in the parlor, because Fred's casket lay there.

This last detail is the key to the whole room. The parlor is a funerary chamber. American English had long since given the word its mortuary sense in the "funeral parlor," and the Goldsmith parlor is precisely a domestic funeral parlor in which one death has been made permanent. The word's etymology deepens the irony. *Parlor* descends, through Old French *parleor*, from the medieval *parlatorium*: the room in a monastery where speech was permitted. Carla's parlor is a room of regulated speech, where the child was lectured and the past is curated in silence.

The parlor also refuses the modern road. When a gas station is built within sight of the parlor window, Carla pleads with her husband to hide it; he plants a hedge, and she then presses him to make the hedge grow faster. In a novel whose apocalypse arrives through the pumps of a Texaco station, this comedy of manners carries a metaphysical charge. The parlor hedges out the very institution through which the end of the world will enter.

The theoretical vocabulary for the parlor is threefold.

1. **Melancholia (Freud).** In "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917), Freud distinguished mourning, which slowly withdraws attachment from the lost object, from melancholia, which refuses the loss by identifying the self with what was lost: "the shadow of the object fell upon the ego." Carla's parlor is melancholia furnished. The dead son's shadow has fallen across a room, and the room has become the mother.
2. **Antiquarian history (Nietzsche).** In the second *Untimely Meditation* (1874), Nietzsche named this piety's historical form. Antiquarian history reverently preserves what has been, but "understands only how to preserve life, not how to engender it" (*es versteht eben allein Leben zu bewahren, nicht zu zeugen*). The refusal of the christening is that sentence enacted: the room that keeps the dead son's casket cannot receive the living grandson.
3. **Purity (Douglas and Kristeva).** Mary Douglas (*Purity and Danger*, 1966) defined dirt as matter out of place, and Julia Kristeva (*Pouvoirs de l'horreur*, 1980) defined the abject as what a clean and proper order must expel in order to constitute itself, with blood foremost among its forms. The parlor's exclusion of blood is the exclusion of the bleeding child, of menstrual and generative blood, and of birth. Carla's horror at her daughter's pregnancy is not prudishness. It is the parlor defending its definition.

The workshop belongs to Peter Goldsmith, and his surname names its piety: the *smith*, the maker. If the parlor is melancholia, the workshop is what Freud called *Trauerarbeit*, the work of mourning, literalized as a place of work. Peter has lost the same son. He does not freeze the loss. He works through it and goes on making things, growing things, and talking with his living daughter. In Arendt's distinction (*The Human Condition*, 1958), the workshop belongs to *work*: the fabrication of a durable world that outlasts its makers and gives mortals a home. It is joined to the garden, whose rows of peas and beans tie the father's piety to the oldest sense of *cultus*. Latin *colere* means at once to

till, to dwell, and to worship. Culture and cult share a root, and Peter Goldsmith practices both in a single gesture.

Fran's burial of her father now shows its full significance. She buries the man of the workshop in his garden, wrapped in the tablecloth of the parlor, the one reserved for company and never used. This single gesture reconciles the two pieties. The parlor's object of display is put to use. The relic of antiquarian reverence becomes the instrument of living rite. The dry age admits the earth. The daughter of both rooms takes from each what the other lacked: from the parlor its reverence for what is past, and from the workshop its insistence that reverence must *do* something. Her mother has already died in the hospital, estranged, and the novel lets Fran feel the weight of the unreconciled quarrel. The tablecloth is the reconciliation that came too late for the living and in time for the dead.

The two pieties will become two civic virtues in Boulder.

- **Antiquarian piety** will readopt the Constitution of the dead republic and open the founding assembly with its anthem (Chapter 4).
- **The piety of the workshop** will rebuild the power plant, so that survivors live by electric light again.

The Free Zone needs both, and it will be tempted, as Carla was, to let the first harden into the second's enemy. Las Vegas has neither. Its sovereign has no ancestors ("He came out of time"), keeps no dead, and makes nothing durable except an arsenal. It is the city of a being who has neither parlor nor workshop, and whose only relation to the dead is to display them to the crows.

3.4 The Lincoln Tunnel: Larry Underwood's Dantean Descent

If Fran's passage into the new world is a burial, Larry Underwood's is a descent. When we meet him he is a brash young singer and songwriter whose first single, "Baby, Can You Dig Your Man?", is starting to make

him a real success, but he is deeply self-absorbed. He has run up a debt with a drug dealer in Los Angeles and flees to New York to hide out with his loving but deeply disappointed mother. The plague takes her. The novel's leitmotif for Larry is a verdict passed on him first by a friend and later echoed by his own conscience: *you're no nice guy*. His story asks whether that verdict can be revoked.

He leaves the dead city with Rita Blakemoor, a wealthy, middle-aged Manhattanite who lives on pills. As they set out, Rita marks the occasion by quoting Tolkien, "the way leads ever on", so the novel's Tolkienian ambition (Chapter 1) is spoken aloud at the threshold of its first underworld. The bridges are impassable, and the way out of Manhattan is the Lincoln Tunnel. The two quarrel on the approach; Rita's unsuitable shoes have shredded her feet, and Larry rages at her. He goes ahead alone into the tunnel. Frightened by men she sees prowling, Rita follows and catches up with him in the abandoned tunnel, and there, reunited with her, Larry promises to protect her, a first sign that his life is no longer only about saving himself.

The passage itself is the novel's great set-piece of horror. They climb over abandoned cars and bodies bloated by Captain Trips. The scene is set, as its first adapter observed, in total darkness. Larry loses his only source of light, a Bic lighter. Something seems to move in the dark behind them, and the experience never leaves him: Larry returns to it often in memory and is terrified each time.

Four interpretive traditions converge on this tunnel, and their convergence is the measure of its importance.

Dante. The *Inferno* begins with a man lost in a dark wood "midway in the journey of our life." It descends, in its third canto, to the vestibule where a multitude of the dead streams past, a crowd so long "that I would not have believed / death had undone so many" (*ch'i' non averei creduto / che morte tanta n'avesse disfatta*, III.56–57). T. S. Eliot transposed the line to the commuters crossing London Bridge in *The Waste Land* (1922): "I had not thought death had undone so many." The Lincoln Tunnel is the infrastructure of commuting, built to carry the daily crowd between Manhattan and New Jersey. King literalizes Eliot's fig-

ure. The commuters really are the dead, still in their cars, and the singer must climb over them in the dark.

Orpheus. The archetypal singer goes down among the dead and leads a woman out behind him (Virgil, *Georgics* IV.453–527; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* X.1–85). The condition is that he must not look back, and he loses her when he does. Larry is a singer, and Rita *follows* him out of the underworld. The Orphic loss arrives days later, in a form that is a dark gloss on the myth. After a hard night, he wakes on the Fourth of July and goes outside to sing, anticipating sex when the song is over; when he comes back into the tent, Rita is dead of an overdose of pills. Orpheus loses Eurydice by looking back at her. Larry loses Rita while looking away, absorbed in his own song.

The date is itself an indictment. The private catastrophe falls on the republic's birthday, the singer performing for himself on the day the dead nation would have sung its anthem. Larry's own judgment of the death, "70% accident and 30% suicide," is the accounting of a man who cannot yet tell whether he is guilty. Rilke's "Orpheus. Eurydike. Hermes" (1904) imagined a Eurydice already so filled with her great death that she no longer belonged to the singer who came to fetch her. Rita, filled with her pills, belongs to that Eurydice.

Exodus. The tunnel is a passage *beneath* the waters, on dry ground, out of a city of death. The type is exact. "And the children of Israel went into the midst of the sea upon the dry ground: and the waters were a wall unto them on their right hand, and on their left" (Exodus 14:22). In a tunnel under the Hudson the waters are, literally, a wall overhead. The Red Sea passage is introduced by the verse this dissertation has identified as the hidden charter of the novel's climax: "Fear ye not, stand still, and see the salvation of the LORD" (Exodus 14:13). Larry's passage enacts the verse's first imperative in the negative: he is wholly given over to fear, and he survives anyway.

Its sequel in the conquest of Canaan is more exact still: "And the priests that bare the ark of the covenant of the LORD *stood firm* on dry ground in the midst of Jordan" (Joshua 3:17). The crossing on dry ground requires that *someone stand* in the middle of the river. At this point in the novel no one does, and that absence is precisely Larry's ter-

ror. The tunnel is a Red Sea without a Moses and a Jordan without its standing priests. The Exodus is undergone, but the stand has not yet been learned.

Baptism. Paul interprets baptism as burial and resurrection: "Therefore we are buried with him by baptism into death: that like as Christ was raised up from the dead... even so we also should walk in newness of life" (Romans 6:4). The passage beneath the river is a baptism without water: immersion in darkness and death, followed by emergence on the far shore. That shore is the Jersey side, to the *west*, and every survivor's road runs west from here. Larry goes down in Manhattan and comes up facing the frontier.

The baptism, however, does not complete the conversion, and the novel is honest about the lag. Larry cannot do for Rita what Fran did for her father. He never buries her; he is too afraid to do it. Measured against Vico, he is not yet fully human. He has passed through the underworld but has not performed the founding rite. The aftermath is a collapse into the condition Vico called stupor: tormented by dreams of Flagg, he drifts for days in a semi-catatonic state until he collapses from exhaustion in New Hampshire.

Augustine described the same condition after the death of a friend: "I had become a great question to myself" (*factus eram ipse mihi magna quaestio*, *Confessions* IV.4.9). The novel offers its own aphorism for such passages: "There are no maps of the change, you just come out the other side." William James (*The Varieties of Religious Experience*, 1902) distinguished the "once-born," whose healthy-mindedness passes through life without crisis, from the "twice-born," the sick souls and divided selves who are made whole only through a second birth. Stu Redman is the novel's once-born man: laconic, steady, unconverted because he needs no conversion. Larry is its twice-born man. His second birth takes place under the Hudson, but it is not consummated until he can take responsibility for others: first for a mute, feral child and a strange woman he meets in Maine (Nadine Cross and the boy she calls Joe, with whom he travels to Ogunquit and finds the directions Harold Lauder painted for strangers), and at last for the Free Zone itself.

The man who could not bury Rita will die without a grave of his own, in the fire over Las Vegas. Moses, too, has no known sepulchre (Deuteronomy 34:6). Chapter 7 will argue that the witness's lack of a grave is not a failure of the Vichian rite but its transfiguration.

3.5 The Oneiric Franchise: Immunity as Election, Dream as Vocation

The survivors are sorted twice. The first sorting is biological and without reason. The second is oneiric and requires a response. The novel's soteriology, its implicit doctrine of how anyone is saved, lies in the relation between the two.

Immunity is election without merit. The plague takes ninety-nine of every hundred and spares the remainder for no discoverable reason. Stu's physicians cannot explain his survival, and the novel never does. Its distribution ignores virtue: the spared include a pregnant student and a spree killer, a deaf-mute and a pyromaniac, a saint and a rapist. Structurally this is the Reformed doctrine of unconditional election, the teaching codified by the Synod of Dort (1619) and grounded in Paul: "So then it is not of him that willeth, nor of him that runneth, but of God that sheweth mercy" (Romans 9:16).

The novel, however, separates election from salvation. Immunity elects for *survival* and nothing more, and survival is not grace. The immune are *superstites* in the literal sense, those who stood over the event, and Section 3.4 has shown how many of them die of it anyway. Election here confers neither merit nor safety. It confers only the burden of continuing, and the possibility of being called.

The dream is vocation. The call comes in sleep. Across the emptied continent, survivors begin dreaming the same two dreams. One of them leads people to a 108-year-old woman of faith in Nebraska, and the group that gathers around her later settles in Boulder to begin democracy again. She sits on the porch of her farmhouse in Hemingford Home, playing guitar and singing hymns among the corn. The

other dream is of a dark figure, in Stu's version a faceless man with red eyes, standing on high places, attended by crows and wolves.

The theological term for such a summons is *vocatio*, the call. Luther's translation of it as *Beruf* gave modern German its word for "profession," and Max Weber built *The Protestant Ethic* (1905) on that semantic history. The novel's dreams are *Berufe* in the pre-professional sense: calls to a way of life and a place to live it. The decisive feature of the call is that it can be refused. The Remonstrants of 1610, against the strict Calvinists, insisted that grace is resistible, that the call can be declined. *The Stand* adopts this Arminian position at the level of vocation while keeping the Calvinist position at the level of election. Immunity is unconditional, but the dream must be answered. Survivors feel the pull of both dreams. They choose, and some choose and then choose again: Harold and Nadine will dream toward one city while living in the other (Chapter 6). The novel's soteriology is therefore synergistic in the strict sense: grace given without merit, a call issued without compulsion, and freedom as the residue in which the stand must be chosen.

The dreams are also, precisely, *ekstasis*: standing outside oneself. Their communal character inverts the plague. Section 2.3 called the superflu an anti-Pentecost, breath taken and voices choked. The dreams are the Pentecost that follows. Joel's prophecy, which Peter cited on the day the Spirit fell, reads: "your old men shall dream dreams, your young men shall see visions" (Joel 2:28; Acts 2:17). At Pentecost a scattered people heard one message, each in their own tongue. The plague scatters; the dreams gather. Carl Jung distinguished, after an informant among the Elgonyi, between "little dreams," which belong to the individual, and "big dreams," which come from the collective unconscious and concern the whole people. Every dream in *The Stand* is a big dream. Its two figures are archetypes in the strict Jungian sense:

- the Great Mother, or Wise Old Woman, whose phenomenology Erich Neumann catalogued (*The Great Mother*, 1955);
- the Shadow-Trickster, the dark double who embodies everything the ego refuses.

The dreams also present a choice that is aesthetic as much as moral, and here the novel's political psychology is at its most acute. Edmund Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry into the Origin of our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful* (1757) divided aesthetic experience into two categories.

- **The sublime** arises from terror, power, obscurity, vastness, and privation: darkness, solitude, silence.
- **The beautiful** arises from love, and its qualities are smallness, smoothness, gentleness, and delicacy.

The two dream-figures are Burke's categories personified. The dark man is the sublime: faceless, obscure, powerful, attended by wolves, glimpsed on heights. The old woman is the beautiful in Burke's homely sense: small, frail, kind, singing on a porch. The oneiric franchise is an aesthetic referendum, and its result is not foreordained, since Burke himself held that terror at a safe distance is a source of delight. Walter Benjamin described the political form of that delight in the epilogue to his essay on the work of art (1936). Humanity's self-alienation, he wrote, had reached the point where it could experience its own destruction as an aesthetic pleasure of the first rank. That was his definition of fascism's "aestheticization of politics." Las Vegas will be that pleasure built as a city. Its people will gather, at the climax, to watch an execution as spectacle.

I call the whole mechanism the *oneiric franchise*, and the word is chosen for its etymology. *Franchise*, the right to vote, descends from Old French *franc*, "free," which derives from the name of the Franks, the free people of Gaul. *Frances*, the given name of the woman whose child will vindicate the Free Zone's future, comes from the same root. In the oneiric franchise the dream is the ballot and the journey is the vote. Economists after Charles Tiebout (1956) describe the residential sorting of populations by preference as "voting with one's feet." The survivors of *The Stand* do precisely this, on a continental scale, with

the preference revealed in sleep. Albert Hirschman's triad of *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* (1970) will give Chapter 6 its typology of defection:

- Nadine's exit;
- Harold's "voice," spoken in dynamite;
- Lloyd Henreid's loyalty.

The novel does not ask its readers to believe that the dreams are divine, and its handling of the question is more careful than its critics allow. It stages the reductive hypothesis openly. One survivor has always regarded dreams as merely eliminative, the psyche's way of periodically voiding its waste, a view uncannily close to the "reverse learning" theory that Francis Crick and Graeme Mitchison would propose in *Nature* in 1983, that we dream in order to forget. The novel also stages a more refined skepticism. Discussing the survivors' shared experiences, one voice declines to treat "a little tickle of psychic ability" as proof of divinity, by analogy with eyesight. One can accept the miracle of sight without believing that sight proves anything about God.

The novel's own position lies between belief and reduction, and William James stated it best. In the first lecture of the *Varieties*, James argued that religious experiences must be judged "by their fruits... not by their roots": by what they produce in life, not by the psychology or physiology of their origin (cf. Matthew 7:16). This is precisely the epistemology of *The Stand*. The dreams are never authenticated by their source. They are validated or condemned by the cities they found. Boulder and Las Vegas are the fruits by which the two dreams will be known.

3.6 The Sociology Lecture: Rousseau's *Second Discourse* in Seven Numbers

The theory of the *ricorso* is delivered, appropriately, by a professional theorist. Stu Redman, walking east out of Vermont after Stovington, meets Glen Bateman, a sociologist who taught at a small community college in Woodsville, New Hampshire. At first Glen declines to travel

Figure 2

The oneiric franchise



The survivors' sorting from election through vocation to constitution, with the two cross-currents (apostasy and testimony) that will organize Chapters 6 and 7.

with Stu, then changes his mind and joins him. The order matters: the sociologist chooses society against his own sociology. Glen's account of human association is the most quoted passage in the novel. It is a numerical descent, and it opens with a promise of sanctity: "Show me a man or woman alone and I'll show you a saint."

With two, love follows. With three, "the charming thing we call 'society'". Then four and a pyramid, five and an outcast, six and the reinvention of prejudice, seven and, within seven years, the reinvention of war. A parody of the Gospel frames the lecture. Christ promised that where two or three are gathered in his name, he is in the midst of them (Matthew 18:20). Glen proposes an emendation: when two or three are gathered, some other guy is going to get the living shit knocked out of him. The lecture ends with a theological claim, the one Part I took as the novel's political-theological crux: human society was made in the image of His opposite number.

The lecture's genealogy is Rousseau's *Discourse on the Origin and Foundations of Inequality among Men* (1755), and its seven numbers compress that work's conjectural history with remarkable fidelity.

- **One.** Rousseau's natural man is solitary and good. He is moved by *amour de soi*, the innocent love of self-preservation, and by *pitié*, the natural repugnance at seeing another suffer.
- **Two.** The "first developments of the heart" bring conjugal and paternal love, "the sweetest sentiments known to men."
- **Three.** Nascent society arrives with the first village gatherings, singing and dancing before the huts. There the fatal step occurs: "each began to look at the others and to want to be looked at himself, and public esteem acquired a price." With the gaze comes *amour-propre*, the self-love that lives in comparison.
- **Four.** Metallurgy and agriculture bring the division of labor and its consequence. "It is iron and wheat that civilized men and ruined the human race."

- **Five.** Property follows: "The first man who, having enclosed a piece of ground, bethought himself of saying *This is mine*..." Comparison follows property.
- **Six.** Opinion follows comparison: "this ardor to be talked about, this fury to distinguish oneself."
- **Seven.** At the end, "nascent society gave way to the most horrible state of war."

Glen's arithmetic is Rousseau's, and on the essential point it is anti-Hobbesian. For Hobbes the war of all against all is humanity's natural condition, and society is the cure. For Rousseau, and for Glen, war arrives at the *end* of the sequence. It is society's product, not nature's. The man alone is a saint, not a wolf.

Table 6 Glen Bateman's seven numbers

Number	Glen's institution	Rousseau's stage (*Second Discourse*)	Further genealogy	Enactment in *The Stand*
1	The saint	Solitary man: *amour de soi*, *pitié*	The anchorite (*anachōrēsis*); Aristotle's "god"	Mother Abagail's withdrawal into the wilderness; Stu alone in the ravine
2	Love	"First developments of the heart"	Genesis 2:18	Fran and Stu
3	"Society"	The gaze; public esteem; *amour-propre*	Girard's mimetic triangle	Fran, Stu, and Harold
4	The pyramid	"Iron and wheat": division of labor, inequality	Mumford's megamachine; the Great Seal	Las Vegas's chain of command; the airfield and its jets
5	The outcast	Comparison hardened into exclusion	Girard's "all against one"	Harold's self-exile within the Free Zone
6	Prejudice	Opinion; "the fury to distinguish oneself"	Burke's defense; Gadamer's rehabilitation	The committee's wager that the enemy will discount a mentally disabled spy
7	War (within seven years)	"The most horrible state of war"	Hobbes inverted; Clausewitz	A seven-member committee at war within a single season

Several entries need comment, because in them the lecture stops being a cynic's set-piece and becomes the novel's program.

Three: society begins as a triangle. Glen's third number is society, and the novel's first society is a triangle: Fran, Stu, and Harold, walking west together. René Girard's first book, *Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque* (1961), showed that desire is not a line from subject to object. It is a triangle in which the subject desires what a model or rival desires. Harold desires Fran, Fran comes to love Stu, and Harold's desire is mediated, inflamed, and finally weaponized by the rival who possesses what he wants. Glen's "charming thing we call society" is born at three, because three is the smallest number at which mimetic rivalry becomes possible. Chapter 6 develops the triangle in full.

Four: the pyramid is on the money. Mumford's megamachine raised the first pyramids (2.2). The pyramid also appears on the reverse of the Great Seal of the United States, printed on the back of the dollar bill since 1935. There it stands unfinished, crowned by a radiant Eye of Providence, under the mottoes *Annuit coeptis*, "He has favored our undertakings," and *Novus ordo seclorum*, "a new order of the ages." The second motto is adapted from Virgil's messianic Fourth Eclogue. In the post-plague world the dollar is worthless paper. Its iconography, however, reads like an allegory of the novel. A pyramid of power raised by human hands is capped by an all-seeing eye. In Las Vegas that eye is the dark man's, riding in his crows. The promise of a new order of the ages is the Free Zone's wager. And the divine favor of undertakings is a favor the Hand will grant only on the far side of catastrophe.

Five: Girard's formula in Glen's arithmetic. Five is the first number at which a group can divide four against one, and Girard's formula for the scapegoat mechanism is "all against one" (*tous contre un*), unanimity minus one. The outcast is the community's means of manufacturing its unity. Glen's parody of Matthew 18:20 is, in a single coarse sentence, Girard's whole theory of the founding murder: where two or three are gathered, a victim appears. The novel must eventually answer it. It must show whether any gathering is possible that does not organize itself around a victim. Chapter 4 will argue that Boulder's founding assembly gathers around a living witness, Mother Abagail, rather than a victim. Chapter 7 will show that the climax of the novel sets Las Vegas

gathered to watch a public execution against the Hand that appears over the scaffold.

Seven: the committee reaches Glen's number. The Free Zone's founding committee has seven members, which is the number at which, by Glen's arithmetic, war is reinvented. The novel does not wait seven years. Within a single season the committee is sending spies into enemy territory, and one of its members is being stalked by a former traveling companion with a ledger and a key to a closet full of dynamite.

The man alone: beast or god. The novel also tests Glen's first proposition, and the result is more interesting than either confirmation or refutation. Aristotle held that the human being is by nature a political animal. He who cannot live in a community, or who needs none because he is sufficient to himself, "must be either a beast or a god" (*Politics* I.2, 1253a). Glen's "saint" is Aristotle's god, and Hobbes's wolf is Aristotle's beast. The novel divides the Aristotelian alternative between its two great solitaries. Mother Abagail will withdraw alone into the wilderness to confront her own pride, on the god-ward side. The dark man is "always outside," belonging to no community and native to none, on the beast-ward side.

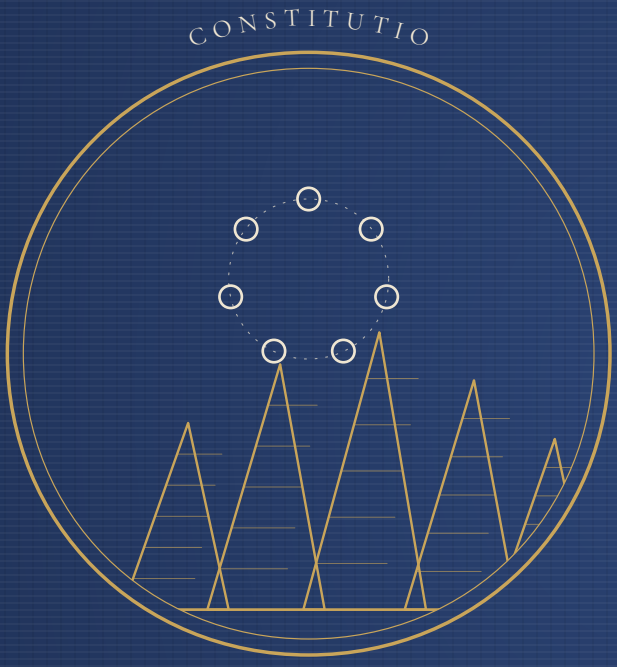
The novel's most ordinary man alone is neither. After Stovington, walking through the empty roads of New England, Stu discovers that he is neither saint nor wolf but lonely. What he wants is another human voice: someone to whom he could turn and point out the meteor shower he had watched alone, and ask whether they saw it too. This is the novel's quiet counter-anthropology. The origin of society is not contract, as in Hobbes and Locke, nor comparison, as in Rousseau, nor violence, as in Girard. It is the need for a *co-witness*: a third (*testis*) before whom a perception becomes real because it is shared. Arendt argued that the reality of the common world depends on the simultaneous presence of many perspectives. Stu's unspoken question under the meteor shower is the minimal form of that world, and of the testimony on which the novel's last stand will rest.

Glen's lecture ends where Christian political realism in America began. In *Moral Man and Immoral Society* (1932), Reinhold Niebuhr

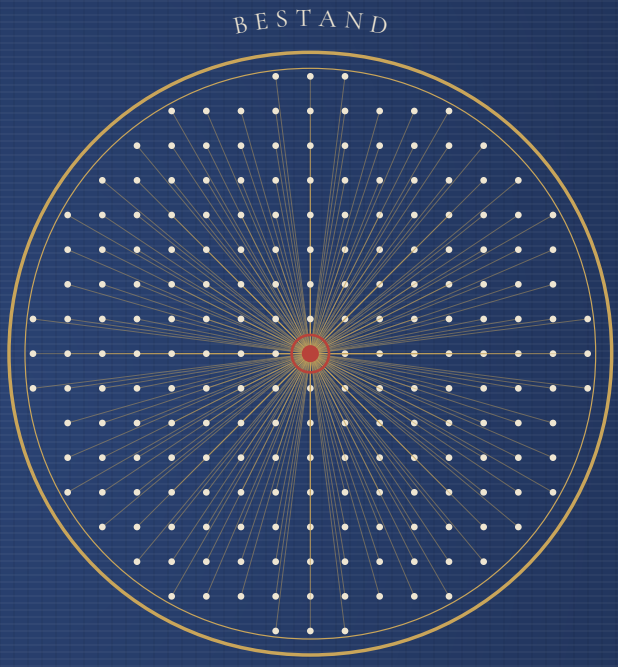
argued that individuals can transcend self-interest, while groups (classes, nations, collectives) cannot. The group is always more egoistic than the individuals who compose it. The title is Glen's lecture in four words. Niebuhr's wartime book took its title from Luke 16:8, "the children of this world are in their generation wiser than the children of light," and its argument anticipates the two cities of *The Stand* with almost diagrammatic clarity. *The Children of Light and the Children of Darkness* (1944) argued that the children of light, the democratic idealists, are foolish because they underestimate the power of self-interest. The children of darkness are wise because they know that power and exploit it. Its most famous sentence states the paradox on which the Free Zone will be founded and on which it will nearly founder: "Man's capacity for justice makes democracy possible; but man's inclination to injustice makes democracy necessary."

The survivors have buried their dead, passed beneath the river, and been sorted by dreams. They have heard, from a sociologist who chose society against his own science, that every gathering contains the seed of war. They now arrive at the two places where the children of light and the children of darkness will each try to build a world. Chapter 4 follows them there.





Boulder



Las Vegas

Chapter 4

Two Constitutions

Boulder, Las Vegas, and the American Jeremiad



Fecerunt itaque civitates duas amores duo: terrenam scilicet amor sui usque ad contemptum Dei, caelestem vero amor Dei usque ad contemptum sui.

[*Two loves, then, have made two cities: the earthly, by love of self even to contempt of God; the heavenly, by love of God even to contempt of self.*]

(Augustine, *De civitate Dei* XIV.28)

For we must consider that we shall be as a city upon a hill. The eyes of all people are upon us.

(John Winthrop, "A Model of Christian Charity," 1630)

Book II of *The Stand*, "On the Border," is a treatise on *constitution* in both senses English gives the word. A constitution is the charter by which a people sets itself up (*con-stituere*, to make stand together). It is also the bodily makeup whose strength or weakness decides whether an organism survives infection. Book I attacked constitutions in the second sense; Book II attempts them in the first. The survivors, sorted by their dreams (3.5), arrive at two places and build two polities.

Critics have usually described these polities in the categories the first jacket supplied: Good and Evil, the old woman's city and the dark man's. This chapter argues that the moral polarity, though real, rests on a political polarity that is more precise and more troubling. Boulder and Las Vegas are the two solutions that modern political theology offers a people released from the State (2.6):

- ***constitutio***: standing-together by repetition, with legitimacy borrowed from the dead;
- ***Bestand***: standing-reserve, with order imposed by command.

Each has a characteristic virtue and a characteristic failure. Boulder has love without sufficient order; Las Vegas has order without love. Neither is the stand.

The argument runs in six sections.

1. **4.1** reads the Free Zone's founding through Arendt, Burke, Paine, Locke, Tocqueville, and Bellah.
2. **4.2** reads its two-part structure of prophet and committee through Gelasius, Cicero, Weber, Schmitt, and Donoso Cortés.
3. **4.3** reads its intellectual center, a deaf-mute, through Aristotle, Rancière, and Exodus.
4. **4.4** reads Las Vegas through Hobbes, Plato, Dostoevsky, Augustine, Popper, Arendt, and Heidegger.
5. **4.5** reads Las Vegas's signature punishment through Girard, Foucault, and the ancient historiography of the cross.
6. **4.6** reads both cities as the two poles of an American jeremiad, Winthrop's city on a hill and John's Babylon, whose customary resolution the novel refuses.

4.1 *Constitutio*: The Free Zone and the Ratification of the Dead

The Free Zone exists first as a call. The settlement takes its name from the call-sign Ralph Brentner used in the radio broadcasts that guided survivors toward Boulder. Before it was a place, it was a transmission sent into an empty continent for anyone who could hear. Greek names an assembly constituted by being called out *ekklēsia*, from *ek-kalein*. The Free Zone is an *ekklēsia* in this etymological sense, and its constitution begins as a *con-vocation*: the political sequel to the vocation of the dreams (3.5).

The place itself was available for a reason Girard would have savored. The novel explains that Boulder holds far fewer corpses than other cities. Early in the plague, a false rumor that the outbreak had begun at a Boulder research facility emptied the town. The city of the good was cleared by an accusation it did not deserve. The scapegoated city, the stone the builders rejected, becomes "the head stone of the corner" (Psalm 118:22).

The Free Zone's founding is precisely dated and staged. In the Chautauqua Auditorium on August 18, 1990, the assembled survivors ratified the Constitution and the Bill of Rights, and they opened the meeting by singing the national anthem. The site is not neutral. The Chautauqua movement was founded on Lake Chautauqua, New York, in 1874 and planted in Boulder in 1898. It was the American institution of the improving assembly: Protestant in origin, civic in purpose, a summer school of the republic, "the most American thing in America," in a phrase often attributed to Theodore Roosevelt. Robert Bellah's "Civil Religion in America" (1967) described the cult through which the republic makes its documents, anthems, and martyrs sacred. The Free Zone founds itself as a congregation of that religion, in one of its temples, with its hymn and its scriptures.

Hannah Arendt's *On Revolution* (1963) argued that the American Revolution was distinctive because it ended not in terror but in a *constitutio libertatis*, a founding of freedom. Its authority, she argued, derived from no absolute (God, Nature, the General Will). It derived from the act of foundation itself, which each later generation augments by reaffirming it. She recalled that Roman *auctoritas* comes from *augere*, "to augment," and that Roman *religio* meant being bound back (*re-ligare*) to the founding. The Free Zone's founding is an act of Roman piety in exactly this sense. It is not a new beginning but an augmentation of the old one, performed by people who bind themselves back to a beginning they did not make.

That choice places the Free Zone in a quarrel as old as the republic it revives.

- **Jefferson** wrote to Madison in 1789 that "the earth belongs in usufruct to the living," and that no generation may bind its successors.
- **Paine** denounced "the vanity and presumption of governing beyond the grave" as "the most ridiculous and insolent of all tyrannies" (*Rights of Man*, 1791).
- **Burke** had already defined society as a partnership "between those who are living, those who are dead, and those who are to be born" (*Reflections*, 1790).

- **Chesterton** later called tradition "the democracy of the dead": "giving votes to the most obscure of all classes, our ancestors" (*Orthodoxy*, 1908).

The Free Zone turns Chesterton's metaphor into literal arithmetic. Its electorate is a remnant of six in a thousand, and the dead are a majority of ninety-nine and four-tenths percent. This ratification is the only election in history in which the dead win by overwhelming majority and the living merely countersign. The third party to Burke's contract is present with unusual urgency: the unborn, whose survival is the open question of Book II (3.2). The Free Zone chooses Burke over Paine. I call its founding *the ratification of the dead*.

The founding conceals an irony that the novel plants with care. The ad hoc committee is confirmed wholesale as the Permanent Free Zone Committee on a motion made by Harold Lauder. Its members are Stu Redman, Frances Goldsmith, Glen Bateman, Nick Andros, Ralph Brentner, and Susan Stern, joined later by Larry Underwood. Harold himself is not among them. Nick has denied him a seat, sensing something unsettling and false in his perpetual grinning and glad-handing. The man excluded from the governing body is the author of the motion that constitutes it.

Derrida's "Declarations of Independence" (1976) observed that a people's founding signature is undecidable. "We the People" signs in the name of a people that does not exist until the signature calls it into being, so the founding act must presuppose the authority it creates. The Free Zone adds a Girardian supplement to Derrida's paradox: the signature that constitutes the body comes from the one the body has expelled. Glen's arithmetic (3.6) is fulfilled at the founding itself. The committee numbers seven, the number at which war is reinvented. The outcast stands outside them, and he has drafted the motion. Chapter 6 will follow him.

Locke's *Second Treatise* (§§124–126) names three things the state of nature lacks:

1. "an established, settled, known law";

2. "a known and indifferent judge";
3. "power to back and support the sentence."

The Free Zone supplies all three. The ratified Constitution provides the law. The Zone has a judge in Richard Farris, a retired Illinois jurist who joined Larry's party. For an executive, Stu becomes the committee's spokesman and the Zone's first Marshal.

The Zone's subsequent conduct then reveals the order of priorities that war imposes on every polity. The judge is not seated on a bench. He is sent west as a spy and dies at the hands of Flagg's sentries. The indifferent judge, Locke's guarantor of justice among citizens, is spent on intelligence against an enemy. Before the Free Zone has tried a single case, its security function has consumed its judicial function. A reader who remembers Starkey (2.1) recognizes the pattern.

Below the level of high constitutional drama, the Free Zone's daily life is what Tocqueville admired in the New England township. "Town meetings are to liberty," he wrote, "what primary schools are to science." The committee spawns subcommittees: a Power Committee, led by Brad Kitchner, to restore electricity, and a Burial Committee, led by Chad Norris, to inter the dead. The new republic's first two public works are the two pieties of Chapter 3, the workshop and the grave. Tocqueville also named the danger peculiar to democracies. It is not tyranny but a soft despotism, "an immense and tutelary power" that keeps its citizens in permanent childhood. The Conclusion will show where the Free Zone's tutelary instincts lead.

4.2 The Committee and the Prophet: Schmitt, Donoso Cortés, and the Kenotic Exception

Above the committee stands a prophetess. Mother Abagail was born in 1882 to parents freed from slavery. She is the Zone's titular head, and she declines to interfere in its secular, day-to-day business but insists on being consulted in every matter touching Flagg. The committee formally gives her a veto over anything it proposes. One account of the novel

states the motive bluntly: the committee, all of whose members are white, grants her absolute veto power so that it will not seem to be wresting authority from her.

The tableau deserves to be seen plainly. A Black woman, the daughter of the formerly enslaved, is formally sovereign over a white council that hopes she will never use her sovereignty. The veto is at once reverence and management. Chapter 7 takes up the critique of Abagail as a racial trope. Here what matters is the constitutional form the arrangement produces, which is older than the American republic.

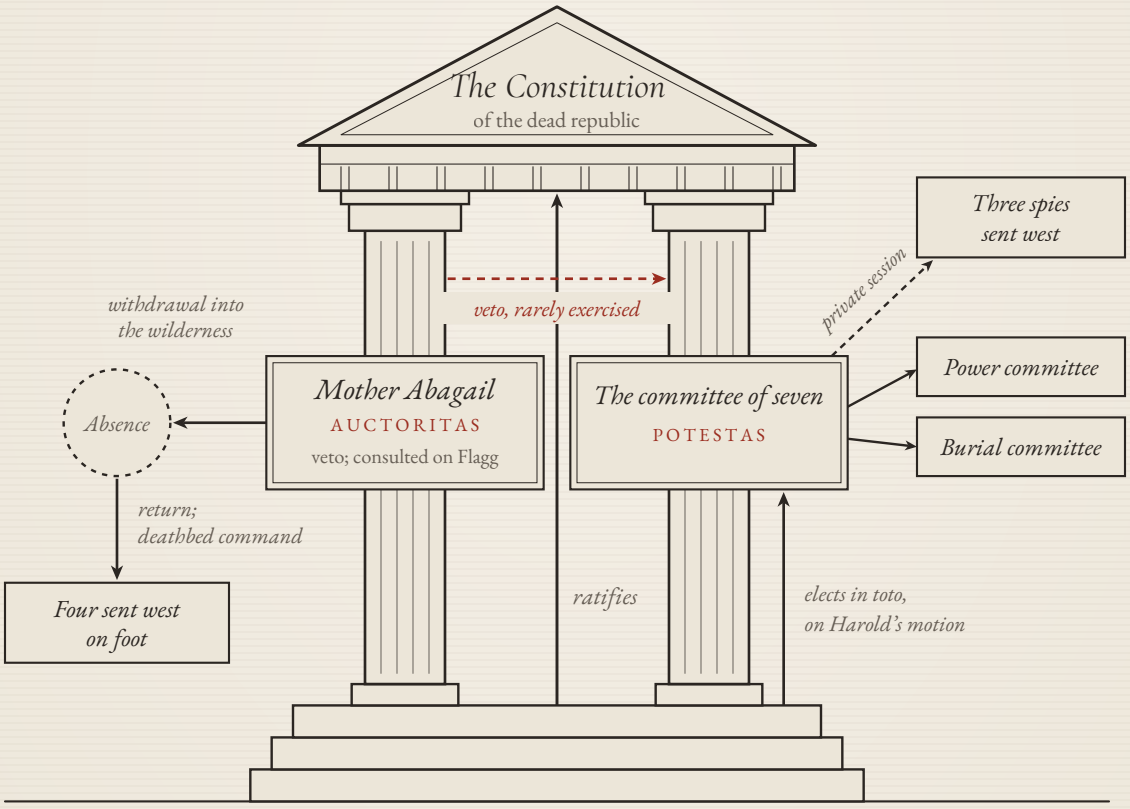
In 494, Pope Gelasius I wrote to the Emperor Anastasius that "two there are, august emperor, by which this world is chiefly ruled: the consecrated authority of priests and the royal power" (*auctoritas sacrata pontificum, et regalis potestas*). Cicero had already distinguished the two: "power in the people, authority in the senate" (*cum potestas in populo, auctoritas in senatu sit*, *De legibus* III.28). *Auctoritas* is not power. It is the weight that counsels power without commanding it. The Free Zone is a Gelasian constitution: it places *auctoritas* in the prophet and *potestas* in the committee.

Max Weber gave the structure its dynamics. Authority rests on one of three grounds: tradition, legal-rational rule, or charisma, the extraordinary gift of a person. Charisma cannot remain extraordinary. It undergoes *Veralltäglichung*, "routinization," passing into offices, procedures, and committees. Weber also distinguished the *emissary* prophet, who proclaims a divine command as duty, from the *exemplary* prophet, who shows a way by living it. Abagail is both. Her charisma gathered the Free Zone through dreams, and the committee is its routinization.

The novel makes the prophet herself the agent of the first crisis. She enjoys the attention, slips into pride, and in doing so draws the committee away from its real business, which is Flagg. She withdraws into the wilderness in what Toynbee called withdrawal-and-return, the pattern of Elijah at Horeb and of the forty days in the desert. Routinization then proceeds without her. The committee, which conducts private sessions as well as public town meetings, decides behind closed doors to send spies. Nick raises Abagail's warning that the survivors are

Figure 3

The Gelasian constitution of the Free Zone



The assembly of survivors

Chautauqua Auditorium, 18 August

Authority and power in Boulder. The prophet's withdrawal leaves the committee's power to operate alone, and in private. Her return converts authority into a final command.

pieces in a contest between good and evil, and the committee names three scouts: Judge Farris, Dayna Jurgens, and Tom Cullen. Within weeks of its founding the Free Zone has reinvented the *Amtsgeheimnis*, the official secret of Chapter 2.1. The *arcana imperii* have returned to the republic of the remnant.

Carl Schmitt's *Political Theology* (1922) opens with its most famous sentence: *Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet*, "sovereign is he who decides on the exception." The exception in jurisprudence, Schmitt argued, is analogous to the miracle in theology. Liberal constitutionalism banished the exception from the State just as deism banished miracles from the world.

Schmitt took from the Spanish counterrevolutionary Juan Donoso Cortés a portrait of the liberal bourgeoisie as a *clasa discutidora*, a "discussing class." Asked to choose between Christ and Barabbas, it would move to adjourn or appoint a commission of inquiry. In its committee phase the Free Zone is Donoso's discussing class: subcommittees, procedures, motions, minutes. King's own account of how he broke the manuscript's block (Chapter 1.4) amounts to Donoso's diagnosis. The survivors had grown complacent and were rebuilding the old world's errors, and the bomb broke the stalemate. Inside the fiction, the dying prophetess reads the bomb the same way. God, she says, permitted it because the committee had busied itself with petty politics and neglected the confrontation with the dark man.

Abagail's last command is, formally, an exception. It suspends the ordinary procedure of deliberation. It is not debated but obeyed, and in that sense the Free Zone's last constitutional act is Schmittian. Its content inverts Schmitt entirely. The sovereign exception concentrates force; the prophetess's exception empties it. The men are to go on foot, without provisions and without arms. She herself does not know what will become of them. She foresees only that one will fall by the way and that the rest will be brought before Flagg.

Paul's hymn in Philippians supplies the verb: he "made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant" (Philippians 2:7), *heauton ekenōsen*, "he emptied himself." I call this the *kenotic exception*: a decision that suspends the normal order not to seize power

but to renounce it. In *The Stand* the exception belongs to no one in the political field:

- not to the committee, which discusses;
- not to Flagg, whose exceptions are crucifixions (4.5);
- only to a God whose will the prophetess transmits without owning it.

Schmitt's formula receives its theological answer in Book III. Sovereign is He who decides on the Hand (Chapter 7).

4.3 Nick Andros and the Mute *Logos*

The Free Zone's intellectual center cannot speak. Nick Andros is a twenty-two-year-old deaf-mute drifter from Caslin, Nebraska, who is robbed and beaten outside Shoyo, Arkansas, as the epidemic begins. He reads lips and writes his side of every conversation on a notepad, having never learned to sign. Orphaned young, he grew up in an orphanage. He is, in every social respect, a person without a part: disabled, kinless, propertyless, a vagrant first encountered as a victim and then as a prisoner.

His first office is the last office of the dying State. Sheriff John Baker, a decent man, takes up the assault. Nick wants to press charges, and the sheriff arrests three of his four attackers before the superflu takes him. With no one else healthy enough to serve, Nick becomes Shoyo's newest deputy. He watches two of the prisoners die alongside the sheriff, lets the third go, and nurses the sheriff's wife until her death. Nick takes the deputyship with complete seriousness and becomes, in effect, mayor of a ghost town. In the restored text, the fourth attacker, Ray Booth, returns for him. Booth nearly takes one of Nick's eyes, and in his panic Nick fires the gun on his belt before drawing it, grazing his own leg. Nick kills the weakened Booth, but the wounds leave him in an eye patch for most of the story.

Book I contains two jails at the hour of the State's death, and the novel sets them against each other with structural deliberateness.

- **Shoyo.** A deaf-mute holds the keys, and he uses them to *loose*: he releases the surviving prisoner.
- **Phoenix.** A starving murderer is locked in and fixated on the key he does not have. A stranger arrives carrying a black stone that becomes a key, opens the cell, and offers to make him his right hand.

The keys of the kingdom carry the power of binding and loosing: "whatsoever thou shalt loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven" (Matthew 16:19). The prophet's commission is "to proclaim liberty to the captives, and the opening of the prison to them that are bound" (Isaiah 61:1; Luke 4:18). The two jails prefigure the two cities. Boulder will be the city of loosing. Las Vegas, with its cages and crosses, will be the city of binding, and its first citizen will be a man let out of prison in exchange for his soul.

Aristotle grounded the political nature of human beings in a distinction between *phōnē* and *logos*. Animals have voice, enough to signal pleasure and pain. Humans alone have *logos*, speech that can declare the useful and the harmful, the just and the unjust, and this is why humans form cities (*Politics* I.2, 1253a). Nick is the purest instance of the distinction the literature affords: *logos* without *phōnē*, the political animal without the animal sound.

Jacques Rancière (*La Mésentente*, 1995) built a theory of politics on this Aristotelian passage. Politics occurs, he argued, when those whom the social order counts as producing mere noise force their speech to be counted as *logos*, when "the part of those who have no part" (*la part des sans-part*) appears. Nick's elevation is that event. The vagrant whose groans the assault could not even make audible becomes the Free Zone committee's leading thinker, the mind that proposes the spies and reads Flagg most clearly.

His speech requires a mouth, and the novel supplies one with scriptural exactness. Ralph Brentner, the farmer who picked up Nick and Tom on the road in Kansas, serves as Nick's "voice," reading his notes

aloud to the others at committee meetings. The type is Exodus. Moses protests that he is "slow of speech, and of a slow tongue." God appoints Aaron: "he shall be to thee instead of a mouth, and thou shalt be to him instead of God" (Exodus 4:10, 16). Nick is the lawgiver who cannot speak, and Ralph is his Aaron. That Ralph is also the radio man whose call-sign named the Zone completes the figure: the people's broadcaster is the lawgiver's mouth. The bomb that kills Nick costs Ralph the third and fourth fingers of his left hand, as though the explosion struck the mouth's hand in striking the mind.

A third figure completes the economy of the letter. Tom Cullen, the gentle, intellectually disabled man Nick meets in Oklahoma, cannot read, so Nick's notes are useless to him. It is Ralph who first tells Tom Nick's name. Between them, Nick and Tom divide speech in two. One has the letter without the voice; the other has a voice that cannot decode the letter, and whose own signature tic, spelling M-O-O-N, is a voice reaching after letters.

Derrida's critique of Western "phonocentrism" (*De la grammatologie*, 1967), the metaphysical privilege of the living voice over writing, finds an unlikely test case here. The Free Zone's logos is *written*. Its founding document is a written constitution, and its leading mind exists for the others only in script. The novel states the principle as a maxim of its own: thought remains incomplete until it is articulated. Nick completes thought in writing. Flagg, by contrast (Chapter 5), rules by voice, grin, and presence: the charismatic *phōnē* of the demagogue.

Nick's fate seals the political allegory. He dies in Harold's bomb, which Nadine plants in the house he shares with Ralph. Within the novel's design he was meant to lead the stand against Flagg, so the bomb removes the stand's intended leader. Afterward Nick returns to Tom as a spirit, at last able to speak, and guides him to the means of saving Stu's life. The mute *logos* speaks only after its death.

The Epistle to the Hebrews supplies the type: "By faith Abel offered unto God a more excellent sacrifice than Cain... and by it he being dead yet speaketh" (Hebrews 11:4). The typology extends further than the verse. Abel was murdered by his brother, and Cain "builded a city" (Genesis 4:17). Augustine made this the founding scene of the

earthly city: Cain founded a city, while Abel, a pilgrim, founded none (*De civitate Dei* XV.1). Harold's motion founded the committee; Harold's bomb killed its pilgrim-mind. The Free Zone's politics is grounded in the speech of the speechless, its tragedy is the murder of its *logos* by its Cain, and its future depends on a voice that speaks from beyond the grave.

4.4 Las Vegas as *Bestand*-City: Order Without Love

If Boulder's danger is drift, Las Vegas's achievement is efficiency. The novel takes care to make Flagg's city work. His followers reorganize quickly and restore the city's power, aided by the many technicians who have migrated there. The novel observes that the Las Vegas people labor constantly within a strong, harsh structure, while some in the Free Zone loaf. Las Vegas establishes schooling and a weapons program, and its pilots and ordnance men ready jets at the air base at Indian Springs.

Its law is simple and severe. Flagg leads by false flattery and fear, and he crucifies anyone who uses drugs or defies him. His method of recruitment is precise: he gathers outcasts like the Trashcan Man and Lloyd Henreid and makes them feel prized, when in truth everyone is disposable.

The 2020 adaptation misreads this city instructively. It rebrands it "New Vegas," where officially sanctioned sin and debauchery cloak a ruthlessly enforced order. The novel's Las Vegas is the reverse of Sin City. It is a work camp with neon: sober, drug-free, disciplined, purposeful. Its evil is not orgiastic but managerial. This dissertation's fourth claimed contribution (Introduction, §III) rests on the difference.

Hobbes provides the first frame, and it is more disquieting than it looks. *Leviathan* distinguishes two forms of commonwealth. A commonwealth *by institution* arises when people agree among themselves to submit to a sovereign (ch. 18). A commonwealth *by acquisition* arises when the sovereign power is acquired by force, as when the van-

quished, "to avoid the present stroke of death," covenant obedience to the victor (ch. 20). Hobbes held that both are legitimate, because covenants extorted by fear are obligatory (ch. 14).

The Free Zone is a commonwealth by institution and Las Vegas a commonwealth by acquisition. The first citizen of Las Vegas makes his covenant in exactly Hobbes's circumstances. Lloyd Henreid, starving in a cell, pledges himself to the man with the key "to avoid the present stroke of death." By Hobbes's own standards, Lloyd's loyalty is perfectly legitimate. The novel's distinction between the good city and the evil one is therefore not a Hobbesian distinction. On the question that matters most, the novel and the philosopher of sovereignty part company. Legitimacy by covenant does not suffice. A polity can be lawful, orderly, and evil.

Plato supplies the second frame. In the *Republic*, Socrates first sketches a "healthy city" of simple needs. Glaucon dismisses it as a "city of pigs" (372d), and Socrates turns to the "feverish city" (*phlegmainousa polis*, 372e), whose appetites outrun its land and which therefore requires an army. "We have found the origin of war," Socrates says (373e). Las Vegas inverts the sequence. It is not luxurious; amid the post-plague abundance it has nothing it lacks. Its war against Boulder arises not from appetite for land but from the sovereign's need for an enemy.

In this, Las Vegas is closer to the *Republic*'s other city, the *Kallipolis* governed by guardians and a noble lie, rewritten as a demonic parody:

- a ruler who claims total knowledge;
- a security apparatus of guardians;
- a myth of the ruler's divinity;
- a class of producers who do not ask questions.

Karl Popper's polemic *The Open Society and Its Enemies* (1945) read Plato's ideal state as the archetype of the "closed society": tribal, authoritarian, and governed by a *magical* attitude toward social order. It is a striking coincidence that the closed society of *The Stand* is ruled by a sorcerer.

Dostoevsky supplies the third frame. In the "Grand Inquisitor" chapter of *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880), the Inquisitor tells the returned Christ that humanity cannot bear freedom. It will gratefully exchange freedom for bread, and it will be ruled by three powers: "miracle, mystery, and authority." Las Vegas is administered on exactly these principles. It offers bread in its provisioning and its work. It offers miracle in Flagg's wonders, and mystery in his absences and his omniscience. Its authority is the cross.

The Inquisitor, however, claims to love humanity; his tyranny is a perverse charity. Flagg loves no one. Augustine's briefest definition of virtue is *ordo amoris*, "the order of love" (*De civitate Dei* XV.22). Las Vegas is *ordo sine amore*, order without love, while Boulder is love not yet adequately ordered. That is Niebuhr's antithesis (3.6) in Augustine's terms: the children of darkness are wise in their generation, and the children of light are not.

Augustine supplies one further diagnosis. "Justice being taken away," he asks, "what are kingdoms but great robber bands?" (*remota itaque iustitia quid sunt regna nisi magna latrocinia?*, *De civitate Dei* IV.4). He illustrates with the pirate who told Alexander that the only difference between them was the size of their fleets. Las Vegas makes the formula literal. Its chief administrator is a petty armed robber: Lloyd's career, before the plague, culminated in a convenience-store holdup with his partner Poke Freeman that went catastrophically wrong. The robber band does not imitate the kingdom. It *becomes* the kingdom.

Hannah Arendt supplies the deepest frame. The final chapter she added to *The Origins of Totalitarianism* in 1958, "Ideology and Terror," identified the experiential ground of totalitarian rule. It is not poverty, ignorance, or wickedness but *loneliness*. Loneliness, once a borderline experience suffered in particular circumstances, had become the everyday experience of masses uprooted from any common world. That condition is what prepares people for organized terror.

The novel's prophetess gives the same diagnosis in her own idiom. Flagg's call, she says, draws not only the wicked but the weak, the lonely, and those who have shut God out of their hearts. The novel thus offers two answers to the loneliness the plague created. Stu, alone

on the New England roads, wants a co-witness to the meteor shower (3.6): loneliness seeking a shared world. Las Vegas gathers the lonely and organizes their loneliness, binding each to the center while isolating them from one another. In Arendt's analysis, totalitarian movements are built like an onion, with concentric layers of sympathizers, members, and elite formations surrounding a leader at the core. Las Vegas has that structure: Flagg at the center, Lloyd's inner circle, the security men, the work crews, the sentries on the distant borders. Chapter 5.4 will ask what lies at the center of the onion.

Heidegger supplies the material frame, and here the history of Las Vegas becomes almost allegorical. Heidegger's paradigm of *Bestand* was a hydroelectric plant that turns a river into a supplier of power (2.2). Modern Las Vegas exists because of exactly such a plant. The Colorado River was dammed at Black Canyon under the Boulder Canyon Project Act of 1928, and the dam itself was officially named *Boulder Dam* from 1933 until Congress renamed it for Hoover in 1947. Its electricity and its reservoir made the desert city possible.

The nominal coincidence is not evidence of design, and nothing in the argument depends on it. It is nonetheless a gift to interpretation. The Bestand-city of *The Stand* rises on power drawn from a river named for the state that houses the Free Zone, held back by a dam that for fourteen years bore the name of the Free Zone's city. Las Vegas, the city that Venturi, Scott Brown, and Izenour celebrated as pure communication (*Learning from Las Vegas*, 1972) and that Hunter S. Thompson called "the heart of the American Dream" (1971), becomes under Flagg a city of production. Its signs no longer advertise; its casinos house workshops; its lights burn for an air force. *Bestand* has reclaimed the city of simulation.

4.5 Crucifixion as Founding Murder

Las Vegas's signature punishment is the cross. The novel names its victims. Hector "Heck" Drogan, caught with drugs, is crucified under the city's code, and the crosses stand as the regime's public argument.

René Girard's *Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde* (1978), published the same year as *The Stand*, argued that human culture is founded on a collective murder. Its title comes from Matthew 13:35, "things which have been kept secret from the foundation of the world." The founding murder is the victim whose expulsion resolves the community's crisis, followed by the forgetting of his innocence. Rome begins with Romulus killing Remus (Livy I.7). The first city in Scripture is built by the first murderer (Genesis 4:17), and Augustine paired the two foundations explicitly (*De civitate Dei* XV.5). Girard's further claim was that the Gospels undo the mechanism. The Passion narratives tell the story from the victim's side and so expose the innocence of the one the crowd unanimously condemns. On this reading the cross is the anti-sacrifice, the revelation that makes sacrifice impossible to believe in.

Las Vegas re-veils what the Gospels revealed. Its crucifixions are presented as justice: the crucified are guilty under the city's law. Like every sacrificial order, it must repeat its foundation. One founding murder is not enough, because the mechanism has to be renewed by ritual. The crosses are therefore serial. They culminate in a spectacle the novel builds toward through all of Book III. Flagg plans to execute the captured Free Zone men by tearing them apart before the whole assembled city, a unanimous crowd gathered around its victims. Chapter 7 will argue that the Hand intervenes at precisely this point: at the instant of unanimous collective violence, where Girard located the hidden origin of every sacred order.

Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* opens not with the plague town discussed in Chapter 2 but with the scaffold. In 1757 the regicide Damiens was dismembered in public in Paris. Foucault called this the "spectacle of the scaffold": the exercise of sovereign power on the body of the condemned, staged so that the crowd would see the sovereign's might written in flesh. Foucault later distinguished the old sovereign right "to take life or let live" from modern biopower, which "makes live and lets die."

The Stand runs this history backward.

- **Book I** was biopolitical: Stovington's examinations, samples, and quarantines, a power devoted to making live, even at the price of bare life (2.5).
- **Book II's Las Vegas** returns to the scaffold. Its power is the sovereign's ancient right to make die, and its instrument is the spectacle.

The *ricorso* (3.1) restores the oldest form of punishment along with the oldest forms of piety.

The ancient historiography of the cross explains what the spectacle is for. Martin Hengel's *Crucifixion in the Ancient World* (1977) gathered the evidence. Cicero called crucifixion "the cruelest and most hideous punishment" (*crudelissimum taeterrimumque supplicium*, *In Verrem* II.5.165). It was the *servile supplicium*, reserved for slaves and rebels and designed for display. After the revolt of Spartacus, six thousand of the captured were crucified along the road from Capua to Rome (Appian, *Civil Wars* I.120). The body was often denied burial and left to the birds. Horace's *non pasces in cruce corvos*, "you will not feed the crows on a cross" (3.1), records the proverb. Crucifixion is deterrence by exhibition and anti-burial by design. It sets the body up as a sign to be read by the living and eaten by the crows.

That phrase, *sets the body up*, opens the deepest stasiological reading of the cross. Heidegger chose his term for the essence of technology from ordinary German, and he acknowledged its everyday senses. *Gestell* commonly means a rack or frame, an apparatus such as a bookstand, and it also names a skeleton. A cross is a *Gestell* in the most literal sense: a frame on which a body is set up (*gestellt*) and made to stand. Crucifixion is *Ge-stell* made flesh. It is the coerced standing of Chapter 2.2 carried to its terminal form, a human being converted into a standing sign, held upright on a rack for the instruction of others.

The Greek *stauros*, the upright stake of Table 3, here meets its German counterpart. The road from the *statio* Campion deserted (2.1) runs through Las Vegas as a Via Crucis without resurrection: stations of the cross that lead nowhere but to the crows. Against this, the nov-

el's other city has a Burial Committee. Boulder puts the dead into the ground; Las Vegas sets the dead up in the air.

4.6 The Errand Rerun: Bercovitch's Jeremiad and the Two Cities

Augustine's two cities are not two populations. They are two loves, and in this age they are *perplexae… invicemque permixtae*, "entangled and intermixed with one another" (*De civitate Dei* I.35). *The Stand* honors this *permixtio* with a rigor its Manichaean jacket concealed.

- **Boulder harbors the earthly city.** Harold Lauder works on its burial crews and builds its bomb, and Nadine Cross lives in its houses while she belongs to Flagg.
- **Las Vegas harbors the heavenly city.** Dayna Jurgens restores its streetlights as a spy and dies rather than betray the third. Tom Cullen walks its streets unseen. Whitney Horgan, a cook in Flagg's own kitchen, will find his voice at the end (Chapter 7).

The two loves are distributed across both places. The geographical sorting of the oneiric franchise (3.5) is real, but it is not final. The cities are where the loves gather, not where they are confined.

Each city nonetheless inherits a typology, and together the typologies make the novel an American jeremiad. Boulder is Winthrop's "city upon a hill." It sits at the foot of the Flatirons, more than a mile above the sea, and is founded on a covenant to be "knit together in this work as one man." Winthrop attached a warning to the covenant: "if we shall deal falsely with our God in this work we have undertaken… we shall be made a story and a by-word through the world." Las Vegas is Babylon, "the great city" of Revelation 17–18, whose judgment comes "in one hour" and whose end is to be "utterly burned with fire" (18:8). The kings and merchants of the earth watch that burning from a distance:

> *Standing afar off for the fear of her torment, saying, Alas, alas that great city Babylon, that mighty city! for in one hour is thy judgment come.*
>
> (Revelation 18:10)

The verb returns three times in the chapter (18:10, 15, 17). Those who watch Babylon burn are those who stand afar off. Chapter 7 will develop what this passage contributes to the novel's theology of the stand: the one man who will watch the great city burn, from a ravine in Utah, is the man who was meant to walk into it and could not.

The form that binds the two typologies is the one Sacvan Bercovitch anatomized in *The American Jeremiad*, published, like *The Stand*, in 1978. The Puritan jeremiad was a sermon of lament for declension. It recited the community's failures, warned of divine chastisement, and called for renewal of the covenant. Bercovitch's insight was that the American version is fundamentally optimistic. It laments in order to reaffirm the errand, converts crisis into mission, and absorbs dissent into what he called a ritual of consensus. The lament for falling short is a way of insisting on the destiny.

Perry Miller had earlier traced the founding text of the genre to Samuel Danforth's election sermon of 1670, *A Brief Recognition of New-England's Errand into the Wilderness*. Miller's "Errand into the Wilderness" (1952; collected 1956) noted the ambiguity of *errand*. An errand is a mission performed on behalf of another, as when an errand-boy is sent by his master. It can also be a mission undertaken on one's own account. The Puritan errand, he argued, slid from the first sense into the second once England ceased to watch.

Mother Abagail's deathbed is a jeremiad in exact form:

1. **Declension.** The committee, absorbed in petty politics, has neglected its duty.
2. **Chastisement.** The bomb was *permitted*.
3. **Renewal.** An errand into the wilderness is commanded.

The errand restores Miller's first and older sense. The four men are not founders or colonists. They are messengers, *angeloi*, sent on another's business into the desert between the cities. They are to carry nothing and expect nothing, and they do not know the outcome.

The novel's theology also sets a strict limit on the jeremiad's logic. The Puritan jeremiad read every calamity as chastisement. *The Stand*

refuses to read the plague that way, because its cause was human (2.3). One of the novel's survivors delivers the verdict in the book's own vernacular: "That wasn't any act of God. That was an act of pure human fuckery." Providence enters the novel only after the plague, and only in two modes:

- **Permission:** the bomb in Boulder.
- **Action:** the Hand over Las Vegas.

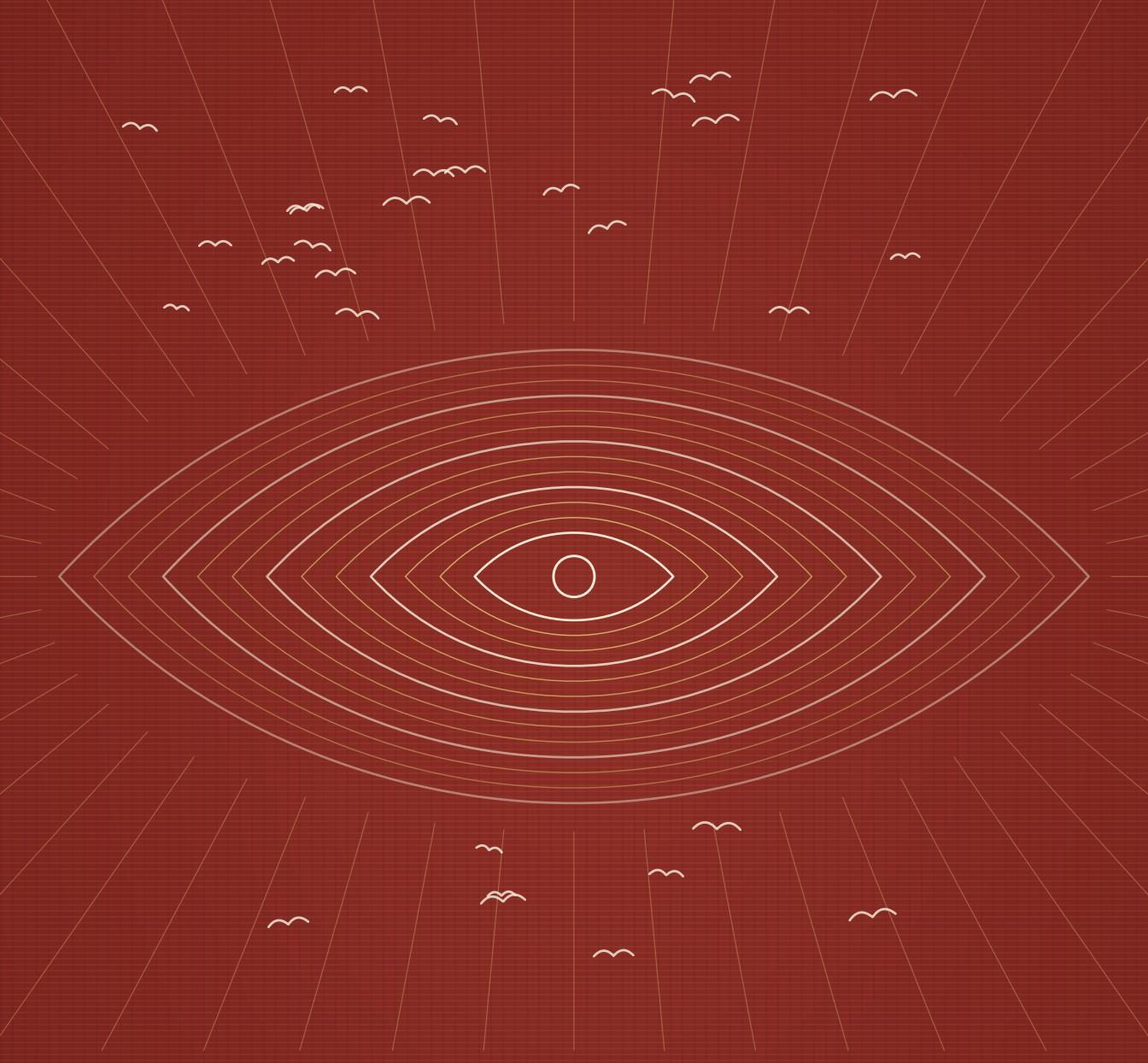
God did not send the pestilence. God allows the consequences of human freedom within the city of the good, and acts directly only against the city of the lawless one. The novel's jeremiad is therefore a restricted jeremiad: chastisement without authorship of the catastrophe, and judgment without vengeance on the victims.

The jeremiad's last term, the ritual of consensus, is the one the novel will refuse. Bercovitch's jeremiad ends by reaffirming the covenant: the people return to their errand, and the city on the hill rises again. *The Stand* ends differently. Its protagonists leave the city on the hill, and the man who survived the errand answers the decisive question with "I don't know." The Conclusion will argue that this refusal is not a failure of nerve but the novel's most demanding political act.

Table 7 The two constitutions

Dimension	Boulder Free Zone (*constitutio*)	Las Vegas (*Bestand*)
Founding act	Ratification of the dead republic's charter by assembly	Covenant extorted under threat of death (Lloyd's key)
Hobbesian form	Commonwealth by institution	Commonwealth by acquisition
Seat of authority	Gelasian: *auctoritas* in the prophet, *potestas* in the committee	Monocratic: authority and power fused in one person
Law	Written constitution; procedure; debate	Edict; exception; spectacle
Characteristic punishment	(None administered; its judge is spent as a spy)	Crucifixion: the body set up as a sign
Relation to the dead	Burial Committee; Burke's partnership; the democracy of the dead	Anti-burial: the crucified fed to the crows
Labor	Uneven; some idle; power restored slowly	Constant; technical; an air force readied

Dimension	Boulder Free Zone (*constitutio*)	Las Vegas (*Bestand*)
Speech	Written *logos* (Nick), read aloud by a proxy (Ralph)	Charismatic *phōnē*: the leader's voice and grin
Answer to loneliness	The co-witness; the town meeting	Organized isolation; the onion structure
Typology	Winthrop's city upon a hill; Abel's pilgrimage	Babylon; Cain's city; the *magnum latrocinium*
Philosophical models	Arendt, Burke, Locke, Tocqueville, Gelasius	Hobbes (ch. 20), Plato's *Kallipolis* as parody, the Grand Inquisitor
Characteristic failure	Love without sufficient order: drift, secrecy, the unguarded closet	Order without love: brittleness before free acts



Chapter 5

The Last Magician of Rational Thought

Flagg and the Nothingness of Evil



Ein Teil von jener Kraft,
Die stets das Böse will und stets das Gute schafft.
...Ich bin der Geist, der stets verneint!

[*Part of that power which always wills evil and always works good. ...I am the spirit that always denies!*]

(Goethe, *Faust I*, 1335–38)

Nemo igitur quaerat efficientem causam malae voluntatis; non enim est efficiens sed deficiens.

[*Let no one, then, seek an efficient cause of an evil will; for it is not efficient but deficient.*]

(Augustine, *De civitate Dei* XII.7)

Randall Flagg is the most durable creation in King's work. He first appeared in *The Stand* and has since appeared in at least nine of King's novels. His recurrences have made him a franchise antagonist of the late twentieth century, sorcerer of an "Outer Dark" whose powers include influence over animals and people and whose aim, from book to book, is the collapse of civilizations. Criticism has tended to approach him through his analogues (Sauron, Satan, the Antichrist) and to ask which of them he *is*. This chapter asks a different question: what kind of being he is, and what the novel's treatment of him says about the being of evil.

The answer, developed across six sections, is that Flagg personifies not a substance but a *privation*. More specifically, he personifies the privation characteristic of modernity: instrumental reason without ends, power without a self, technique in search of a will. The novel itself, in a phrase that its readers have rightly refused to treat as decoration, calls him "the last magician of rational thought."

5.1 The Walkin Dude: Genealogy of a Political Chameleon

Flagg's genesis predates the novel. In college King wrote a one-page poem, "The Dark Man," about a nameless rider of the rails who confesses to murder and rape; *Ubris* printed it in 1969, and King has called it the seed from which Flagg grew. He has described the figure behind it as an image that "came out of nowhere": a man walking the roads in cowboy boots, jeans, and a denim jacket. In *Danse Macabre* he first credited Donald DeFreeze, the leader of the cell that kidnapped Patty Hearst (Chapter 1.1).

The novel introduces him on foot: "Randall Flagg, the dark man, strode south on US 51". He is a "tall man of no age" with an old Boy Scout knapsack, his jacket pockets crammed with pamphlets from dozens of fringe splinter groups. His past is vague even to himself. He says that at some point he simply "became." What he does remember reads like a catalogue of postwar American extremism:

- service as a Marine;
- membership in the Klan;
- service with the Viet Cong;
- a hand in the kidnapping of Patty Hearst;
- a meeting with Lee Harvey Oswald in New Orleans;
- an acquaintance with DeFreeze;
- a Nebraska origin, including classes at school alongside Charles Starkweather.

The list is a political chameleon's résumé. It pairs right and left (Klan and Viet Cong), State and anti-State (Marine and SLA), lone assassin and spree killer. Flagg is not a partisan of any cause. He is the *form* of fanatical commitment, emptied of content and transferable to any cause.

Two American theorists of the 1950s and 1960s had already described this form. Eric Hoffer's *The True Believer* (1951) argued that mass movements are fundamentally interchangeable. The fanatic's

need is for faith as such, so the same temperament can pass from communism to fascism to any cause that promises to dissolve the self in a collective. Hoffer added an aphorism that could serve as an epigraph for Las Vegas: "Mass movements can rise and spread without belief in a God, but never without belief in a devil." Richard Hofstadter's "The Paranoid Style in American Politics" (1964) traced the recurrent American imagination of a vast conspiracy directed by a demonic enemy. Flagg is both figures at once. He is the true believer who changes faiths, and he is the devil whom every faith requires. The paranoid style's phantom has acquired a body, a knapsack, and a pair of boots.

His literary genealogy is the genealogy of the walking adversary, and its American line is long.

- **Job.** The figure begins in Scripture. When the LORD asks the Satan where he has come from, the answer is: "From going to and fro in the earth, and from walking up and down in it" (Job 1:7; 2:2). The adversary of the New Testament "walketh about, seeking whom he may devour" (1 Peter 5:8).
- **Cain.** The first murderer is sentenced to be "a fugitive and a vagabond... in the earth" (Genesis 4:12).
- **Hawthorne.** "Young Goodman Brown" (1835) gives the devil the form of a respectable traveler on the forest road, carrying a staff like a serpent and resembling the traveler's own forefathers.
- **Melville.** *The Confidence-Man: His Masquerade*, published on April Fools' Day 1857, sends a shape-shifter through a succession of disguises aboard a Mississippi steamboat named, with perfect irony, the *Fidèle*. Melville makes the American devil a con man.

Flagg descends from both. He is the walker of Job and Cain, and he is the confidence man of the open road. His nickname, the Walkin' Dude, condenses the whole lineage into two words of American slang.

Table 8 The genealogy of the walking adversary

Figure	Source	Mode	What Flagg inherits	What Flagg lacks or alters
The Satan of Job	Job 1:7	"Walking up and down" in the earth; prosecutor in God's court	The walk; the testing of the righteous	The Satan of Job is a servant of the court; Flagg serves no one
Cain	Genesis 4	Fugitive and vagabond; founder of a city	The wandering; the founding of a city on blood	Cain bears a protective mark; Flagg bears none
Milton's Satan	*Paradise Lost* (1667)	Heroic rebel turned self-diminishing liar	The charisma; the self-degradation	Satan has a past, a fall, a memory; Flagg "doesn't know himself"
Mephistopheles	Goethe, *Faust* (1808)	The spirit that always denies; the bargain	The bargain (Lloyd's key); the service of a higher purpose against his will	Mephisto's wit and self-knowledge
Hawthorne's traveler	"Young Goodman Brown" (1835)	The devil as respectable kin on the road	Familiarity; ordinariness	Puritan ambiguity: Flagg is not a dream
The Confidence-Man	Melville (1857)	Serial disguise; the con	The many names; the grin; the con as metaphysics	Melville's comedy of credulity
Stavrogin	Dostoevsky, *Demons* (1871–72)	Charismatic emptiness at the center of a cell	The void at the center (Chapter 1)	Stavrogin's suffering and suicide
Cipolla	Mann, "Mario and the Magician" (1930)	Hypnotist-showman dominating a crowd	The stage magic of domination	Cipolla's bodily frailty and humiliation
Sauron	Tolkien (1954–55)	The disembodied Eye; the dark lord	The Eye; the lieutenants; Mordor as Las Vegas	Sauron's fixed seat and single name

5.2 Myth Is Already Enlightenment

The novel's epithet for Flagg is "the last magician of rational thought." The phrase is a paradox only for a reader who still believes that magic and rationality are opposites. Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno's *Dialektik der Aufklärung* (1944; 1947) was written in American exile during the war. It opens on the thesis that dissolves the opposition:

Schon der Mythos ist Aufklärung, und: Aufklärung schlägt in Mythologie zurück. Myth is already enlightenment, and enlightenment reverts to mythology. Myth was already an attempt to explain, name, and control nature. Enlightenment, by reducing reason to an instrument for dominating nature, ends by dominating human beings as well, and reproduces the fatalism and the sacrificial logic it set out to abolish. Their paradigm is Odysseus bound to the mast, the cunning self-preserver who masters the Sirens by sacrificing his own freedom to hear.

Flagg is that dialectic personified. His powers are of two kinds, and the novel makes them indistinguishable.

- **The sorcerous:** the eye that rides in crows, the knowledge of distant events, the ball of fire at his fingertip.
- **The technical:** a restored power grid, technicians and helicopter pilots, jets and ordnance, and finally the search for an atomic weapon.

He is a wizard with an air force. Max Weber's "Wissenschaft als Beruf" (1917; 1919) defined modernity by the *Entzauberung der Welt*, the disenchantment of the world. The modern person need no longer resort to magic to master or implore the spirits, because technical means and calculation perform the service. Flagg re-enchants the disenchanted world *by technical means*. His magic is the technician's dream of total control in its most direct form. He is the last magician because he is the culmination of the rationality that was supposed to put magicians out of business.

James Frazer had already blurred the boundary from the other side. *The Golden Bough* (1890) defined magic as a "false science," "the bastard sister of science." Like science, magic assumes that nature is governed by fixed laws, and it errs only in its account of those laws. Magic and technology share a single aspiration, the domination of nature by knowledge of its regularities. Flagg's sympathetic magic (the crow as his distant eye) and his technical program (the jet as his distant fist) are one project.

Thomas Mann gave this project its political allegory in "Mario und der Zauberer" (1930). The hypnotist Cipolla dominates a seaside audience by sheer will. He humiliates them one by one, demonstrates that the attempt to resist by *not willing* is no defense at all, and is shot dead by the young waiter Mario, whom he has publicly degraded. The novella was read at once as a parable of fascism: politics as stage magic, the crowd's complicity, and the tyrant undone by his own humiliated instrument. Flagg, too, rules a crowd by spectacle and will. He too will be undone by an instrument he cannot master, the Trashcan Man, the fire-spirit he summoned and could not dismiss. That figure is Goethe's "Der Zauberlehrling" (1797), "the spirits that I called, I now cannot get rid of," with no old master returning to stop the brooms.

The texture of Flagg's magic also betrays its emptiness, and the novel takes care to show it. When the Free Zone spy Dayna Jurgens, brought before him in his office, lunges with a knife hidden on her person, Flagg turns the blade into a banana. The scene is a joke, and the joke is the point. The "lying wonders" of 2 Thessalonians 2:9 (2.6) are, at their summit, a vaudeville trick. The dark lord's sorcery has the structure of a prank. Jung's essay on the Trickster (1954), written for Paul Radin's study of the figure (1956), described an archetype of boundless appetite and mischief, cunning without wisdom, whose tricks recoil on himself. Flagg is the Trickster raised to sovereignty. A prankster can command an air force; the novel will show that he cannot command a free act.

5.3 *Gestell* Personified: The Eye, the Crows, and the Jets on the Runway

In Heidegger's essay on technology, the airliner standing on the runway is the image of *Bestand* (2.2). It is not an object that stands over against us but stock, held ready to secure the possibility of transport. In *The Stand*, Heidegger's image has a precise counterpart. Jets stand on the runway at Indian Springs, readied with their ordnance to fly against Boulder. They are Flagg's standing-reserve of force: the *Gestell* of Las

Vegas in its most concentrated form, the whole city ordered toward a capacity held on call.

They are destroyed by the most perfect human embodiment of *Best-and* the novel contains. The Trashcan Man's fire destroys a great deal of military equipment and kills key technicians. The Trashcan Man is the man whose whole being has become availability. His salute, taken up by Flagg's worshipers, is "My life for you!" In Heidegger's terms he is a person converted into stock. The novel's insight, which Heidegger never quite allowed himself, is that stock does not remain inert. The standing-reserve is volatile, and a human being reduced to pure availability is available to fire. The *Gestell* is destroyed by its own most ordered component.

Flagg's surveillance is the second face of *Gestell*. Like Sauron, he is an Eye. He can enter crows and other creatures to watch the survivors, and in the dreams he is a faceless man with red eyes. Bentham's Panopticon (1791) and Foucault's reading of it imagined a power that sees without being seen and therefore produces in its subjects the self-surveillance that makes force unnecessary. Flagg aspires to this. His eye is everywhere, his subjects fear it, and Las Vegas's discipline is the fear of being seen.

The novel's theology of this eye lies in its blindness. Three times in Book III the panoptic power fails.

1. **The Judge.** Flagg orders his sentries to kill the Free Zone's judge without damaging his head, so that the head can be sent back to Boulder as a warning. In the shootout the head is obliterated, and Flagg kills the surviving sentry for his failure.
2. **Dayna.** Flagg foresees her assassination attempt and thwarts it. He does not foresee her suicide. She drives her head through the plate glass of his window rather than be forced to reveal the third spy, and with her death goes his chance of learning who it is.
3. **Tom.** The third spy is Tom Cullen. Flagg tells Dayna that whenever he reaches for the third spy, he sees only the moon.

The eye sees everything except *freedom* and *innocence*: the act that no calculation predicts and the soul that has no hidden interior to read. Boethius taught that divine knowledge does not impose necessity, because God sees all times in an eternal present, as a spectator sees a man walking without compelling him to walk (*Consolatio* V, prose 6). Flagg's knowledge is the opposite kind: calculative foreknowledge, which free acts defeat because they are not consequences of anything it can compute.

Tom's opacity has a scriptural form. "God hath chosen the foolish things of the world to confound the wise... and things which are not, to bring to nought things that are" (1 Corinthians 1:27–28). In the eyes of Las Vegas, Tom is among *ta mē onta*, "the things that are not": a slow man, a simpleton, nobody. The eye that sees everything cannot see what it has already classified as nothing. And under hypnosis, the Free Zone discovers that this "nothing" sees as Mother Abagail sees, speaking of himself as "God's Tom." The image Flagg receives in Tom's place is the moon, which in Tom's spelling tic stands for every important thing. The moon is a light that is not its own. The Church Fathers made the moon a figure of the Church, which shines only by reflecting the sun (Ambrose, *Hexameron* IV.8.32; the patristic *mysterium lunae* reconstructed by Hugo Rahner in 1939–40). Flagg's eye, looking for the third spy, finds a reflected light, and cannot look past it.

The crows invite one more genealogy. Odin's two ravens, Huginn and Muninn, "Thought" and "Memory," fly over the world each day and return to tell him what they have seen. In the *Grímnismál* (20) the god confesses his fear: he fears for Thought, that it may not return, and fears still more for Memory. Flagg is a sovereign whose sight travels in black birds. As Book III proceeds, the novel describes what he loses as his power fails, and among the first things to go are "organized reflection" and memory (5.4). Odin's fear is realized in Flagg. His ravens do not come back.

5.4 *Privatio Boni* and *das Nichtige*: The Onion Without a Kernel

At the height of his crisis the novel gives Flagg its most precise metaphysical image: "He was like an onion, slowly peeling away one layer at a time". What peels away is the trappings of humanity itself: organized reflection, memory, perhaps even free will, if he ever possessed it. The image has a canonical source. In the fifth act of Ibsen's *Peer Gynt* (1867), the aging Peer sits on a hillside and peels a wild onion, naming each layer after one of the roles he has played: shipwrecked man, gold-digger, prophet, emperor. He searches for the core. In William Archer's translation:

> *What an enormous number of swathings! Isn't the kernel soon coming to light? I'm blest if it is! To the innermost centre, it's nothing but swathings—each smaller and smaller.—Nature is witty!*

Ibsen's play turns on the difference between two mottoes. The human motto is "Man, to thyself be true!" The troll motto, which Peer adopted in the hall of the Mountain King, is "Troll, to thyself be—enough!" Peer has lived as a troll: self-sufficient, self-satisfied, and therefore selfless in the most damning sense. At the end the Button-Moulder comes to melt him down in his casting-ladle. Peer was never wicked enough for hell. He was never himself at all.

Flagg is Peer Gynt without the possibility of Solveig. Of him it is said that "he doesn't know himself," and the novel's onion has no kernel because there was never anyone at the center.

The Western theological tradition had already named the ontology that Ibsen and King render as an image.

- **Augustine.** Having passed through Manichaeism, Augustine concluded that evil is not a substance but *privatio boni*, a privation of the good. "Whatsoever things are, are good," and evil is the corruption of a good nature, with no being of its own (*Confessions* VII. 12.18; *Enchiridion* 11). He denied that an evil will has an efficient cause. Its cause is *deficient*, a defection rather than an effect, and to

seek it is "like trying to see darkness or hear silence" (*De civitate Dei* XII.7).

- **Aquinas.** Thomas formalized the point: evil has no formal or final cause of its own, and is caused only accidentally, as a defect in some good (*Summa theologiae* I, qq. 48–49).
- **Boethius.** Philosophy concludes that *malum nihil est*, "evil is nothing," because God, who can do all things, cannot do evil (*Consolatio* III, prose 12). The wicked, she teaches, are therefore *powerless*. Their power is a power to fail, and in abandoning the good they cease, in a sense, to be (IV, prose 2).

The novel's antagonist is the narrative form of this tradition. His face cannot be seen: he is the faceless man of the dreams, and seeking his face is like seeing darkness. His power is a power to fail: every free act defeats it. His ending is not a defeat but a diminution, a peeling down toward the nothing that was always there.

Karl Barth's doctrine of *das Nichtige*, "nothingness" (*Kirchliche Dogmatik* III/3, §50), gives the tradition its twentieth-century Protestant form. For Barth, *das Nichtige* is neither God nor creature. It is what God *rejected* in creating, the chaos God did not will, and it "is" only as the object of that divine No. It is real as opposition but has no substance and no future. Christ has already defeated it, so it can be neither ignored nor feared as a second god.

Barth also distinguished *das Nichtige* from the "shadow side" of creation, the finitude, limitation, and suffering that belong to good creatures as creatures. The distinction illuminates the novel's moral geography. The Free Zone's suffering (grief, pride, error, death) is the shadow side. Flagg is *das Nichtige*: opposition without being, a chaos with a grin. Barth insisted that the right response to *das Nichtige* is neither terror nor indifference but a kind of sovereign disregard grounded in its defeat. Chapter 7 will argue that Glen Bateman's laughter before Flagg is exactly this response: the one moment in the novel when a human being sees the nothing for what it is.

Hannah Arendt arrived at the same conclusion from the opposite direction, by way of the Eichmann trial rather than dogmatics. Reply-

ing to Gershom Scholem in July 1963, she withdrew her earlier talk of "radical evil." Evil, she now held, is never radical, only extreme. It has neither depth nor any demonic dimension, and it can lay waste the whole world because it "spreads like a fungus on the surface." "Only the good," she concluded, "has depth and can be radical."

The image binds Flagg to the plague (2.2). The superflu was a surface phenomenon of the same kind, spreading by contact, with no interior, no meaning, and no depth. Flagg is its moral analogue. In *The Eyes of the Dragon* he is described as a "sickness" that resurfaces in Delain wherever there is something worth destroying. The onion is all surface. Kant had located "radical evil" in a propensity rooted in the maxims of the will (*Religion innerhalb der Grenzen der bloßen Vernunft*, 1793). Flagg is not radical in this sense, because he has no root: "He came out of time." His evil is the fungus, not the tree.

Milton gave the tradition its greatest literary figure of self-diminishing evil. "Which way I fly is Hell; myself am Hell" (*Paradise Lost* IV.75). C. S. Lewis's *A Preface to Paradise Lost* (1942) traced Satan's degradation across the poem. He descends from hero to general, from general to politician, from politician to secret agent, then to a voyeur at windows, then to a toad, and at last to a snake. Flagg's arc in Book III follows Lewis's descent. The sovereign of a city becomes a raging tyrant who kicks the corpse of the spy who outwitted him and orders it burned. He becomes a failing magician whose subordinates disobey and whose eye goes blind, and finally a vanishing figure, absent at the moment of his city's destruction. Evil does not fall in *The Stand*. It shrinks.

Goethe's Mephistopheles supplies the providential counterpoint (see the epigraph). He is "the spirit that always denies," and also "part of that power which always wills evil and always works good." The formula is Vico's heterogony of ends (3.1) spoken by the devil. It is the theology of the Hand (Chapter 7) in a single couplet. Flagg wills the destruction of Boulder, and the weapon he wills it with will destroy his own city instead. Bulgakov placed the same couplet as the epigraph of *The Master and Margarita* (written 1928–40; published 1966–67), whose Woland serves justice despite himself. Flagg has none of Wo-

land's dignity, but he shares Woland's function. Evil in the novel is a nothing that providence turns to account.

5.5 *Homo Homini Lupus*: Flagg's Distributed Body

Flagg has no body of his own in any stable sense. His appearance shifts between man, demon, and animal, and his power exists in what it possesses. He commands wolves and can enter ravens and other creatures to watch the survivors. Wolves rescue the Trashcan Man, who in return pledges his life to the dark man. His human instruments are extensions of the same distributed body. Lloyd is his right hand. The Trashcan Man is his fire. The sentries on the borders are his reach, and the crucified are his signs.

The frontispiece of *Leviathan* showed a sovereign whose body was composed of the bodies of his subjects (2.6). Flagg is a demonic Leviathan, whose body is composed of animals and minions and has nothing at its center. When the extensions fail, as when the sentries disobey, the spy chooses death, and the Trashcan Man burns the jets, Flagg weakens, because he *is* nothing apart from them.

Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari (*Mille plateaux*, 1980) opposed the *pack*, a multiplicity of wolves organized by contagion and border rather than by hierarchy, to the *State apparatus*, which captures packs and turns them into armies. Flagg is the pack captured by a State that is itself a void. He holds together, in a single figure, the contagious multiplicity of the plague and the hierarchical capture of the city.

The wolf has a precise political genealogy, and the novel enacts it. In the eighth book of the *Republic*, Socrates explains how the people's champion becomes a tyrant by way of a myth from the shrine of Lykaian Zeus in Arcadia. Whoever tastes human entrails mixed with the sacrificial meat is inevitably turned into a wolf. So the champion who has tasted the blood of his own kin "becomes a tyrant, a wolf instead of a man" (565d–566a). Ovid tells the same story of Lycaon, the Arcadian tyrant who served human flesh to Jupiter and was turned into a wolf (*Metamorphoses* I.209–243).

Lloyd Henreid's initiation takes place at exactly this threshold. Abandoned in his cell as the plague kills the guards, he exhausts his food and eats a rat, and he begins to contemplate eating the leg of a dead fellow prisoner named Trask. Some readings of the scene have him cross the line rather than merely approach it. At that moment the dark man arrives with the key. The tyrant's lieutenant is made, as Plato said tyrants are made, at the edge of anthropophagy. Flagg's name, as Chapter 1.6 noted, may be read as "shield-wolf." Lloyd is the wolf-man made at the Lykaian altar, and the wolves that run at Flagg's command are the metamorphosed tyrants of the oldest Greek political myth.

Boethius completes the Platonic thought with a moral zoology (*Consolatio* IV, prose 3). Whoever abandons goodness, Philosophy teaches, ceases to be human and is turned into a beast. *Avaritia fervet alienarum opum violentus ereptor? Lupi similem dixeris*: is he a violent robber burning for other men's wealth? Call him a wolf. The restless brawler is a dog, the secret schemer a fox, the wrathful man a lion, the coward a deer, the sluggard an ass, and the lustful man a pig. Lloyd was an armed robber before he was a lieutenant, so in Boethius's bestiary he is already a wolf.

The novel sets the wolves against a single dog. Glen Bateman's Irish setter, Kojak, one of the plague's rare canine survivors, is attacked by wolves at Mother Abagail's empty farmhouse and still walks, wounded, all the way to the Free Zone. Fidelity survives the pack.

Hobbes himself paired the wolf with its opposite. The dedicatory epistle of *De Cive* (1642; English 1651) begins: "To speak impartially, both sayings are very true; That Man to Man is a kind of God; and that Man to Man is an arrant Wolfe." The two cities of *The Stand* divide Hobbes's pair between them. In Boulder, *homo homini deus*: the mutual aid of the remnant, the prophetess's charity, and the dog that keeps faith. In Las Vegas, *homo homini lupus*. Aristotle's alternative from Chapter 3.6 (the solitary must be "either a beast or a god") returns here in political form. The dark man is the beast, and the beast, Plato taught, is the tyrant.

5.6 Serial Evil: Flagg's Afterlives

The restored text of 1990 does not let Flagg die. In its epilogue, "The Circle Closes," he awakens on a beach somewhere in the Southern Hemisphere under a new name, Russell Faraday, and begins gathering followers among a people the novel describes as preliterate and dark-skinned, a primitive tribe ready to fall under his influence. The circle closes, and the wheel (Introduction, Figure 1) turns again.

The epilogue must be read critically before it can be read theologically. In "An Image of Africa" (1977), Chinua Achebe indicted Conrad's *Heart of Darkness* for using Africa as a setting and backdrop that eliminates the African as a human factor. The continent's people appear as a dark mass against which a European drama of conscience is staged. King's epilogue repeats Conrad's gesture in miniature. It imagines the "primitive" as the dark man's natural next audience, as though a people without writing were by that fact more available to evil. The irony is sharp, and the novel does not notice it. In the Free Zone, writing was the medium of *logos* (4.3), while Flagg ruled literate Americans by voice. The novel's own evidence contradicts its epilogue's anthropology. Its cosmology of recurrence needed a new shore, and it reached, unreflectively, for an old colonial trope.

Flagg's recurrence is nonetheless the clearest evidence for the cosmology this dissertation attributes to the novel. His names multiply across King's work, usually carrying the initials R.F.: Richard Fry, Robert Franq, Ramsey Forrest, Russell Faraday, Richard Fannin, Walter o'Dim, Marten Broadcloak, and others.

- **The Eyes of the Dragon (1984).** He is the court magician of the kingdom of Delain. He has counseled at least four successive monarchs, has aged only ten years in seventy, and was first seen in Delain more than five centuries before. His stated ambition is "a thousand years of bloody anarchy, give or take a few months".
- **The Dark Tower (1982–2004).** He is the man in black of the cycle's first sentence ("The man in black fled across the desert, and the gunslinger followed"), and he dies, ignominiously, in its final

> volume. The cycle supplies a belated origin: he was born Walter Padick, son of a miller, set out on the road at thirteen, and was raped there by a fellow wanderer.

The cycle's own cosmology insists that even his death is not final, since the quest repeats. Flagg is evil in serial form.

Seriality is the form his ontology requires. Umberto Eco's "Il mito di Superman" (1962) analyzed the "iterative scheme" of serial fiction. The serial character cannot be consumed by his adventures. Time is suspended around him, and each episode begins as though the last had left no trace, so the figure becomes a myth without a history. Flagg is an iterative villain in Eco's precise sense. He wakes on each new shore with no memory, no growth, and no consequence, because the onion had no kernel to remember with.

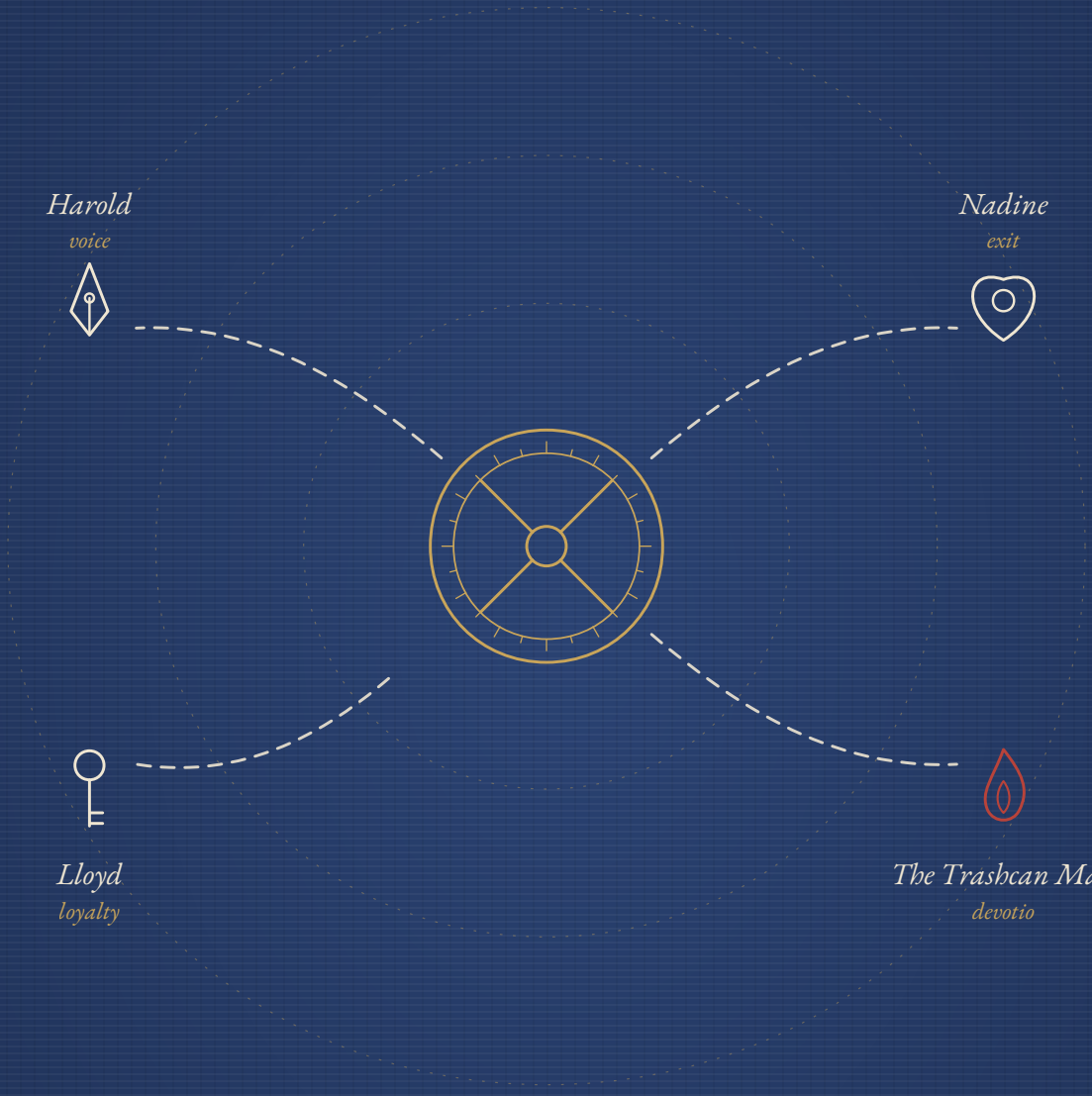
Kierkegaard distinguished recollection from *repetition* (*Gjentagelsen*, 1843). Recollection moves backward toward what has been. Genuine repetition is "recollected forward," the free renewal through which a self becomes itself in time. By this standard Flagg has neither. He has lost memory (5.4), and he cannot repeat, because repetition requires a self that wills its own continuity. What he has is mere *recurrence*: the wheel's return without anyone on it.

Nietzsche's eternal return (*Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* §341) asked whether one could will the endless return of one's life and so affirm it with *amor fati*. Flagg does not will his return. It happens to him, so he is the passive patient of recurrence, the exact opposite of the one who affirms it.

Boethius supplies the final image. The wheel of Fortune grips hardest those who live on its rim, and it loosens its hold as one approaches the unmoving center, where providence rather than fate governs (Introduction, §III). Flagg is "always outside." He lives on the rim, and so he recurs, on the beach, in Delain, in the desert of Mid-World. This is the deepest reason the novel's cosmology needs him to survive. Evil recurs because it has no self to end. The stand does not recur because it is an act and not a substance: something done once, by someone, at the hub.

The witnesses who walk into Las Vegas will not wake on another shore. Their stand is unrepeatable, and its unrepeatability is its meaning. Before turning to them, however, the dissertation must examine those who chose the rim: the four apostates who gave Flagg the bodies he did not have.





Chapter 6

The Anatomy of Apostasy

Harold, Nadine, Lloyd, and the Trashcan Man



For it is impossible for those who were once enlightened, and have tasted of the heavenly gift... If they shall fall away, to renew them again unto repentance; seeing they crucify to themselves the Son of God afresh, and put him to an open shame.

(Hebrews 6:4, 6)

So farewel Hope, and with Hope farewel Fear,
Farewel Remorse: all Good to me is lost;
Evil be thou my Good.

(Milton, *Paradise Lost* IV.108–10)

Chapter 5 concluded that the dark man has no body of his own. He exists in what he possesses: wolves, crows, and the human beings who lend him their hands (5.5). This chapter is about the lenders. Four figures in *The Stand* stand away from one city and toward the other, and the novel gives each of them more interiority than it gives any of its saints. The disproportion is deliberate. The good in *The Stand* is narrated chiefly in acts, while evil is narrated in motives. Evil is privation (5.4), so it must be explained by what it lacks, and lack has a psychology that plenitude does not. The four case histories therefore form the novel's most sustained moral psychology. I shall argue that they make up a complete typology: four ways of standing away, four forms of despair, and four inversions of the principles on which Chapter 3 founded the human world.

6.1 *Apostasis*: Four Ways of Standing Away

Greek *apostasis* (Table 3) was a political word before it was a religious one. In Thucydides the verb and its noun name the defection of subject allies from Athens, such as Euboea (I.114) and Lesbos (III.2). Only in the Septuagint and the New Testament does it come to mean a falling-away from God (Joshua 22:22 LXX; Acts 21:21). The two senses

meet in the Pauline text that Chapter 2 made the frame of the whole narrative. The Day will not come, Paul writes, "except there come a falling away first", *hē apostasia*, "and that man of sin be revealed, the son of perdition" (2 Thessalonians 2:3).

Table 4 omitted this step, and it must now be supplied. Between the death of the *katechon* in Book I and the revelation of the lawless one in Book III stands the apostasy of Book II. The novel follows Paul's order exactly: the dark man's power becomes manifest only after those who stood away have lent it to him. Paul calls the lawless one "the son of perdition," and John's Gospel gives the same epithet to Judas (John 17:12). Section 6.3 will show that the novel noticed.

Chapter 3.5 announced Albert Hirschman's *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* (1970) as a frame. Hirschman distinguished three responses open to a member of a declining organization: leave it, protest within it, or stay. *The Stand* distributes them among its apostates with diagrammatic clarity:

- **Nadine Cross exits.**
- **Harold Lauder exercises voice,** and his voice is dynamite.
- **Lloyd Henreid embodies loyalty,** Hirschman's third term turned inside out. In Hirschman, loyalty restrains exit from a failing institution. Lloyd's loyalty binds him to an institution that is itself a failure.
- **The Trashcan Man escapes the triad.** He neither leaves, protests, nor merely stays. He *devotes* himself, in a sense Section 6.6 will recover from the Roman law of war.

The four also each invert one of the principles on which Vico founded humanity, and on which Chapter 3 founded the novel's *ricorso*:

- **Nadine inverts marriage.** She keeps herself for a bridegroom who is nothing.
- **Lloyd inverts burial.** He survives by feeding on the dead, and later burns the desecrated body of a woman he slept with.

- **The Trashcan Man inverts religion.** His creed has four words: "My life for you."
- **Harold inverts the fourth thing the novel adds to Vico's three:** testimony, the written record kept for another. His ledger is the antithesis of Fran's journal (3.2).

Finally, each apostasy is chosen, and the novel has one apostate say so in so many words: "My name is Harold Emery Lauder. I do this of my own free will." Set this beside Moses before the rebellion of Korah: "for I have not done them of mine own mind" (Numbers 16:28). The prophet disclaims his will; the apostate asserts it. Augustine held that the evil will has no efficient cause, only a deficient one (5.4). Harold's formula is the deficient cause announcing itself as efficient: the void signing its name.

Table 9 The four apostates

	Harold Lauder	Nadine Cross	Lloyd Henreid	The Trashcan Man
What is stood away from	Acceptance in Boulder (the name "Hawk")	The child who trusted her; the man who refused her	Nothing: he never stood anywhere	Powtanville's mockery, and at last the self
Hirschman's mode	Voice (in dynamite)	Exit	Loyalty	Beyond the triad: *devotio*
Vichian principle inverted (3.1)	Testimony: the ledger against the journal	Marriage: the bride of nothing	Burial: he eats from the dead and burns the desecrated	Religion: "My life for you"
Kierkegaardian despair	Defiance: willing despairingly to be oneself (the demonic)	Weakness: not willing to be oneself, until a last act of will	Spiritlessness: despair ignorant of itself	Despair of necessity: a self that is only compulsion
Philosophical frame	Nietzsche, Scheler, Girard, Aristotle (*Politics* V.4)	Kierkegaard, *The Sickness unto Death*	Royce, Fromm, Arendt	Anders, Bachelard
Type	Judas; Cain; Haemon; the Underground Man; Satan on Niphates	The Bride of Revelation inverted; the aborted Antichrist-mother	The flock of the hireling who flees (John 10:12)	The scapegoat (Leviticus 16); Gollum; Empedocles; Decius Mus
Instrument	The pen, then the detonator	The planchette, then her body	The gun	Fire, then the warhead

	Harold Lauder	Nadine Cross	Lloyd Henreid	The Trashcan Man
End	Gangrene; a note signed "Hawk"; a self-inflicted shot	Thrown from the penthouse, smiling	Consumed beside a master who vanishes	Consumed in the fire he brought

6.2 Harold Lauder I: The Ledger and the Smile

Harold Emery Lauder is sixteen when the plague leaves him and Fran Goldsmith the last two living people in Ogunquit. He is an outcast and insufferably articulate. His older sister, Amy Lauder, is Fran's friend. He is a would-be writer who prefers a typewriter. He is the novel's other young writer from coastal Maine, and it is hard not to read him as his author's shadow: the boy at the typewriter (Chapter 1) as he might have become if his grievances had found no form but grievance.

Harold's first act of writing in the new world is an act of hospitality. He paints a message on Moses Richardson's barn, which overlooks the road most travelers would take into town, saying they have gone to the Stovington plague center and giving road directions. He signs both his name and Frannie's, and writing hers nearly makes him fall off the roof. Larry Underwood later congratulates him on the signs, and the directions they lay down draw separate parties into a single westward stream. At its origin, the gathering that becomes the Free Zone is a gathering in Harold's hand: the convocation of Chapter 4.1 begins as his signature. His first fall is also a fall from writing her name.

His second writing begins by violating the first. Rifling through Frannie's possessions, he finds a journal she was keeping for her unborn child, and Frannie does not always speak kindly of Harold in it. He becomes consumed with hate for Frannie, who rejected his affections, and for Stu, who took her after saying he wasn't interested. He vows revenge but pretends to accept their relationship. The novel then records the method of the pretense in one of its quietly appalling sentences: "For the next fifteen minutes, Harold practiced smiling. He was getting VERY good at it." Hamlet has already given the moral: "one may smile, and smile, and be a villain" (I.5.108).

Nietzsche's portrait of the man of *ressentiment* (*Zur Genealogie der Moral* I.10, 1887) reads like a case note on Harold in Boulder: "His soul squints; his spirit loves hiding places, secret paths and back doors... he understands silence, not-forgetting, waiting, provisional self-diminishment and self-abasement." Max Scheler's *Das Ressentiment im Aufbau der Moralen* (1912; 1915) supplied the mechanism. *Ressentiment* grows where a desire for revenge is joined to impotence and to habitual comparison. It ends by devaluing what it cannot possess, so the beloved becomes a target. The first entry in Harold's ledger enacts Scheler's devaluation in a single clause: the woman becomes an afterthought to the rival's murder. The sentence opens "My great pleasure this delightful post-Apocalypse summer will be to kill". The diction is that of a boy writing about his summer holiday, wrapped around a homicide. Vico predicted this style. The barbarism of reflection, he wrote, "under soft words and embraces" plots against the lives of friends (3.1). Harold's ledger is that barbarism's prose.

Chapter 3.2 promised a comparison between this ledger and Fran's journal, and the comparison cuts deep.

- **Direction.** The journal is written forward, to a child who does not yet exist. The ledger is written backward, against debts already incurred.
- **Grammar.** One is in the dative of love, the other in the accusative of grievance.
- **Genre.** The word "ledger" is exact. A ledger is an account-book, and Nietzsche's second treatise located the origin of the moral concept *Schuld* (guilt) in the commercial concept *Schulden* (debts). He traced the creditor's ancient right to compensate himself for an unpaid debt with the debtor's flesh, and the festival of cruelty that the right licensed (*Genealogie* II.4–6). Harold keeps the books of humiliation and means to settle them in blood. The ledger is the genealogy of morals in miniature: the creditor's reckoning disguised as a diary.

The surname completes the diagnosis. *Lauder* is the one who praises, or who craves praise, and Augustine devoted much of the fifth book of the *City of God* to the Roman *amor laudis*, the love of praise (V.12–19). He conceded that this love restrained the Romans from worse vices, and he refused to call it a virtue. Boulder gives Harold exactly what *amor laudis* craves. He volunteers for the hardest work, including the removal of the dead. The men on the work crews, respecting him, start calling him "Hawk." The man who buries the city's dead by day writes its murders by night: Vico's reflective barbarian assigned to the Burial Committee of Chapter 4.1. The praise does not suffice, because *amor laudis* is a love of comparison, Rousseau's *amour-propre* (3.6), and comparison always finds a rival above the one it praises.

The smile deceives Boulder, but not everyone in it. Nick refuses to give him a place on the committee because he thinks there is something unsettling and fake in Harold's constant grinning and glad-handing. Mother Abagail doesn't like him either. The detail is structurally exact. Nick reads lips and writes on a pad of paper to communicate, so he is the one man in Boulder whose disability has trained him to watch mouths. The mute *logos* of Chapter 4.3 reads the false *phōnē* of the smile. The child Leo, who perceives without reasoning, has one word for what he feels near Harold: "Scared."

Dostoevsky's Underground Man (*Записки из подполья*, 1864) is the Western canon's first full portrait of this figure. He is spiteful, hyperconscious, humiliated, and a writer of notes nobody asked for, and he humiliates the one woman who offers him love. He opens with a self-description that Harold would have written in a more grandiloquent register: "I am a sick man… I am a spiteful man. I am an unattractive man." In the second chapter he names his sickness precisely: "to be too conscious is an illness, a real, thoroughgoing illness." As Section 6.3 will show, Flagg's verdict on Harold uses almost the same words.

6.3 Harold Lauder II: The Love-Quarrel and the Refusal of Grace

Aristotle's catalogue of the causes of *stasis* includes a sentence that might stand as the epigraph to Book II: factions arise "not about small things but from small things" (*ou peri mikrōn all' ek mikrōn*, *Politics* V. 4, 1303b17–18). His first example is a love-quarrel. Long ago in Syracuse, two young men in office fell out because one seduced the other's beloved while he was away, and the injured man retaliated by seducing his rival's wife. They drew the governing class into their quarrel, and the constitution was overthrown (1303b20–26). The Free Zone's *stasis* follows Aristotle's Syracusan pattern. It begins as a private erotic grievance between two members of the founding party and ends with dynamite in the committee's meeting room.

Chapter 3.6 announced that René Girard would supply the mechanism. In Girard's terms Harold's desire is *internally mediated*: the rival who blocks it inhabits the same world, close enough to be imitated and therefore hated. Harold does imitate Stu. In Boulder he becomes useful, respected, and admired, a "Hawk" beside the Marshal, and the imitation sharpens the rivalry instead of resolving it. Girard read the Underground Man as the paradigm of internal mediation, and he acknowledged Scheler's analysis of *ressentiment* as a precursor of his own (*Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque*, 1961). The Haemon of Chapter 3.2 thus acquires his psychology: the Antigonean devotion has curdled into Girard's "monstrous double."

What separates Harold from the Underground Man is that the novel offers him grace twice and narrates both refusals.

1. **The first offer is recognition.** In a moment of clarity, Harold understands that he is accepted and valued in the new world, and that he is free to choose a new life in it. He sets the knowledge aside.
2. **The second offer is opportunity.** Searching the foothills for the missing Mother Abagail, he readies the gun in his pocket to kill Stu and does not pull the trigger.

Only then does Nadine Cross come to him. The sequence matters theologically. The novel does not present Harold as seduced into evil; it presents him as having refused good before the seducer arrives. Milton gave this refusal its definitive form in Satan's soliloquy on Mount Niphates, the one moment in *Paradise Lost* when the adversary considers repentance:

> *is there no place*
> *Left for Repentance, none for Pardon left?*
> *None left but by submission; and that word*
> *Disdain forbids me...*
>
> (*Paradise Lost* IV.79–82)

Pardon is available to Harold only through submission: accepting Fran's choice, Stu's happiness, and his own place among people who like him. Disdain forbids it. The Epistle to the Hebrews names what follows with uncanny exactness: "lest any root of bitterness springing up trouble you, and thereby many be defiled" (Hebrews 12:15). Seven people die in the explosion. In Kierkegaard's typology (*Sygdommen til Døden*, 1849), this is the highest and worst form of despair, *defiance*. In it the self wills despairingly to be itself. In its demonic intensification it would rather remain in its torment than accept help, because accepting help would refute its grievance against existence. Harold's ledger is the written form of demonic despair: a self that has made its wound the proof of its existence.

The novel then disposes of him with a coldness that says as much about Las Vegas as about Harold. As Harold and Nadine flee, Flagg causes Harold's motorcycle to crash, and he falls over the edge of a cliff, severely breaking his leg. The cause is an oil slick on the road, arranged, the novel implies, because Flagg distrusted Harold as "too full of thoughts." The tyrant's verdict and the Underground Man's self-diagnosis are the same diagnosis. Las Vegas wants loyalists like Lloyd and fire like the Trashcan Man. It has no use for the barbarism of reflection that delivered Boulder into its hands. The totalitarian city prefers the barbarism of sense (3.1).

Harold's leg breaks, and the leg is the organ of standing. The man who stood away can no longer stand, and the wound rots. As his leg turns gangrenous, he realizes the harm he has done, writes a note of apology, and commits suicide. Two details of the death complete the typology.

First, he signs the note "Hawk." He knows he cannot be forgiven and expects no reply. In signing with the name the work crews gave him, he dies as the self that grace had briefly made of him, and that he had refused to become.

Second, the death is precisely Judas's. Matthew's Judas "repented himself" (*metamelētheis*, a word of regret rather than of conversion), confessed "I have sinned in that I have betrayed the innocent blood," and "went and hanged himself" (Matthew 27:3–5). Augustine judged that Judas added to his crime by killing himself, because he had despaired of God's mercy (*De civitate Dei* I.17). The patristic tradition set Judas's remorse against Peter's repentance. Both men betrayed their master. Peter "wept bitterly" (Matthew 26:75) and was restored (John 21:15–17); Judas despaired.

The novel holds both figures in one book. The betrayer dies by his own hand in a ravine. The child who will be named Peter, the rock (3.2), is born in Boulder and survives the plague. The "son of perdition" of 2 Thessalonians 2:3 and John 17:12 meets his foil in the son of the rock.

One last scene belongs to Harold, and it sets up the climax. On their way west, the four men sent by Mother Abagail find his body. They do not bury it; they carry nothing to bury it with. Stu gently takes the gun from the dead boy's mouth, calls the whole thing a waste, and finds himself wanting to avenge Harold along with the other dead when he meets Flagg. The would-be murderer has become, in his intended victim's eyes, one of the dark man's victims. The pity is real, and so is the desire for vengeance that rides on it. Chapter 7.3 will show that the novel removes that desire from Stu's hands.

6.4 Nadine Cross: The Sickness unto Death and the Bride of Nothing

Her name is a sentence. *Nadine* comes, through French, from the Russian *Nadezhda*: hope. *Cross* is the *stauros* of Table 3. Hope crossed out: the name holds the inscription over Dante's gate, *Lasciate ogne speranza, voi ch'intrate*, "abandon every hope, you who enter" (*Inferno* III. 9). Nadine's apostasy is the abandonment of the virtue her name personifies.

She teaches at a private school in New Hampshire and has kept her virginity because of a vague but powerful sense that she is destined for something "dark and unique." The sense has a source. She later surrenders to Flagg completely and talks with him through a Ouija board, which echoes the terrifying Ouija session in college when Flagg first touched her. One reader summarizes that first message as a planchette promising to keep her alive and love her if she stayed pure and clean for Him. The body bears the sign: she is pretty, with dark hair turning prematurely white.

The planchette deserves a moment, because Chapter 7 will turn on a Hand that writes. A Ouija board is a writing device worked by human fingers that disown their own motion. The message appears to come from elsewhere, and the hands that spell it out deny that they are spelling. It is the counterfeit of Daniel 5, where "fingers of a man's hand" write a judgment on the palace wall. On the board, a judgment of a different kind is written through a woman's own fingers.

Nadine's virginity also has a precise place in this dissertation's vocabulary. It is *Bestand* (2.2): a body held in reserve and kept on call for its owner. The dark man's bride is the inversion of the Bride of the Lamb, "made ready" (Revelation 19:7) and "adorned for her husband" (21:2), whom Paul hoped to present "as a chaste virgin to Christ" (2 Corinthians 11:2). The sacred image of the Church's purity becomes, in Nadine, the purity of a stockpile. When she gives herself to Harold as the instrument of Flagg's plan, the reserve is held back. She will not do "that one little thing" with him, though they are evidently

free to engage sexually in any other way they wish. Everything else is spent; the owner's portion is kept.

Before the end, she makes two attempts at rescue, and both are directed at other human beings.

1. **The child.** After the superflu breaks out, she finds an emotionally damaged boy she calls "Joe," who has regressed to a savage state but trusts her and stays with her. She meets Larry Underwood when Joe finds him asleep and is working up the courage to kill him, and she intervenes. Then, at Hemingford Home, Joe introduces himself as Leo Rockway, which upsets Nadine, in whom Mother Abagail perceives a dark presence. The child recovers his voice in the prophetess's presence and so no longer needs the woman who saved him. Her motherhood was her last tie to the Free Zone, and his healing loosens it.
2. **The man.** In desperation, Nadine makes a final attempt to seduce Larry, an act that would break her virginal commitment to Flagg and free her. By then Larry is firmly committed to Lucy Swann and rejects her.

The second refusal is the novel's most painful case of the heterogony of ends (3.1) in the moral sphere. Larry's fidelity to Lucy is the sign of his conversion from the "taker" his mother named. That good act seals Nadine's fate. The novel does not make Larry responsible, and it does not pretend the consequence is not terrible. Kierkegaard explains why no other outcome was available. His formula for the self free of despair is that it "rests transparently in the power that established it." The Danish verb is *satte*: the power that *set* it. No finite person can be that power for another, not the child and not the singer. Nadine, despairing in weakness and unwilling to be herself, looks for a human being to establish her. Failing, she gives herself to the antipower, which cannot establish anything, because it can only set things up as stock.

The consummation is the novel's darkest scene. Nadine leaves Harold for dead and meets Flagg in the desert, where he rapes and impreg-

nates her while revealing his true demonic form. The experience leaves her semi-catatonic. The bridegroom proves to be what Chapter 5.4 said he was: a nothing with a body borrowed for the occasion. Her end, however, is not the ending the nothing intended. She recovers enough to taunt Flagg about his inevitable failure until, enraged, he throws her off the penthouse sundeck and she dies in the fall. Nadine smiles as she falls, and Flagg realizes afterward that she taunted him hoping he would kill her.

Two smiles bracket the apostasy of Book II.

- **Harold's** was practiced in a mirror. It was a mask over a will to kill.
- **Nadine's** is the first expression of hers that the novel shows unmasked. She wears it at the moment she turns her own death against the dark man and denies him his heir.

Her last act belongs to the class Chapter 5.3 identified as Flagg's blind spot: the free act that no calculation predicts. In that one respect, the apostate's last movement repeats the martyr's. Dayna Jurgens had died to deny Flagg a name, and Nadine dies to deny him a son.

The comparative point is sharp. The decade of *The Stand* was the decade of the Antichrist's nativity: Ira Levin's *Rosemary's Baby* (1967; filmed by Polanski in 1968) and *The Omen* (1976) made the devil's child a popular myth of the age. King aborts the myth. The dark man's only child dies unborn with its mother, and the only child whose birth the novel narrates is Fran's. The Conclusion will develop this asymmetry as the novel's theory of natality.

6.5 Lloyd Henreid: Loyalty Without a Cause

One sentence returns in variants throughout Lloyd's chapters and sums up his moral biography: "Small shit was the worst he would have done without Poke." Lloyd is the follower as such, a man whose capacity for evil has always been set by whoever is leading him. Before the plague the leader is Andrew "Poke" Freeman. They go on a killing spree that ends with six murders, Freeman dead, and Lloyd in a

Phoenix jail awaiting trial on death row. Their first killing deserves notice in a novel whose plague strangles the voice (2.3). Lloyd and Poke tape shut the nose of a bound and gagged man and watch him suffocate. Lloyd's first murder is a stopping of breath, an anti-Pentecost on the scale of a single body. The State answers with its own instrument, the electric chair, which the novel's idiom calls riding the lightning. The phrase gave Metallica an album title. Its significance here is that Lloyd will escape the State's lightning only to die in another.

Then the State abandons him. The superflu kills all the prison guards and most of the inmates, and Lloyd is left in his cell to starve. Eight days after the last meal, he has eaten all his stored food. He kills a rat and saves it, telling himself he won't get that desperate, then eats it, and begins to think about eating the leg of Trask, the nearest dead inmate. Plato's account of how a tyrant is made placed this threshold at the Lykaian altar (5.5). Lloyd's mind fixes on a single object: he dwells on THE KEY, the symbol of control and freedom, and grows to hate whoever holds it. Flagg arrives, opens the cell with a mysterious key, and offers to make Lloyd his right-hand man. Once the cell is open, the key becomes a black stone with a red flaw, and Lloyd wears it around his neck for the rest of the novel.

Chapter 1 promised that Lloyd would carry the Hearst analogy, and this is where it is paid. The heiress was kidnapped in February 1974, kept blindfolded in a closet, and re-emerged as "Tania," a member of her captors' cell. At her 1976 trial the defense called psychiatrists, among them Robert Jay Lifton, whose *Thought Reform and the Psychology of Totalism* (1961) had analyzed "coercive persuasion." The phrase "Stockholm syndrome," coined after the Norrmalmstorg bank siege of 1973, had just given the public a name for the captive's attachment to the captor. Lloyd's case is structurally more exact than Hearst's. The State confined him, the State abandoned him, and the deliverer who opens the cell is the one to whom he binds himself.

The key then performs its theology. Chapter 4.3 contrasted the two jails of Book I: Shoyo, where a deaf-mute deputy uses the keys to loose, and Phoenix, where they bind (Matthew 16:19). Here the instrument of opening becomes a token of binding. Flagg does not free Lloyd. He

moves him from an iron cell to a stone one and hangs the new lock around his neck.

Josiah Royce's *The Philosophy of Loyalty* (1908) supplies the normative frame and the indictment. Royce defined loyalty as "the willing and practical and thoroughgoing devotion of a person to a cause," and called it the supreme virtue, the principle that gives a scattered life a center. He added a criterion that separates loyalty from fanaticism. A cause is worthy only insofar as it furthers loyalty in others, which he called "loyalty to loyalty." A predatory cause, one that destroys the loyalties of others, corrupts the very devotion it commands. Lloyd's loyalty is entirely genuine, and that is its horror. Its object is a city that crucifies its own and a master who loves no one (4.4). Flagg even makes him smart enough to serve as his right-hand man. The intelligence is the competence of the instrument, capacity without thought.

Two further frames sharpen the diagnosis.

- **Fromm.** Erich Fromm's *Escape from Freedom* (1941) described the authoritarian character, who escapes the burden of freedom by attaching himself to what Fromm called a "magic helper." The phrase is psychological in Fromm and literal in King: Lloyd's magic helper is the last magician of rational thought (5.2).
- **Arendt.** Lloyd's loyalty is Arendt's *thoughtlessness* (Eichmann's, in her report of 1963) in its plainest American form. It is not demonic depth but the inability to imagine anything from another person's standpoint.

Royce's moral core survives, nonetheless, at the margins of the predatory cause, and the novel takes care to show it. Lloyd is tender toward a small boy in the Las Vegas camp. When his friend Whitney Horgan plans to slip away, Whitney tells him that he and a small party of defectors mean to flee to South America before things go really bad. Lloyd declines to go, but he lets Whitney leave without telling Flagg or anyone else. Loyalty to a person survives inside loyalty to the cause, and quietly subverts it.

The executioner's moment completes the portrait. Flagg orders Lloyd to shoot Glen Bateman, and Glen's last words are addressed not to the master but to the servant: "It's all right, Mr. Henreid... you don't know any better." Section 7.5 will read this sentence fully. Here it is enough to say that it pronounces Lloyd's condition. Kierkegaard's lowest form of despair is *spiritlessness*, despair that does not know it is despair. Lloyd, shaken, reaffirms that he belongs to Flagg forever.

At the end he dies in the fire beside the master's empty place, because the master vanishes (7.7). The Good Shepherd discourse described the hireling who "seeth the wolf coming, and leaveth the sheep, and fleeth" (John 10:12). In Las Vegas the wolf is the shepherd, and he flees from his own flock.

6.6 The Trashcan Man: The Promethean Gap and the Gift of Fire

Donald Merwin Elbert's childhood is a catalogue of the State's violence and of the State's medicine.

- **His father.** Wendell Elbert, deteriorating mentally, shot a bartender, came home, and killed his three older children. He kept firing at his wife and five-year-old son until his cheap gun exploded in his face, and Sheriff Greeley shot him dead. With Wendell in the ground, Sally Elbert took a job at the Powtanville Cafe, and her one remaining child began setting fires in people's trashcans and running away.
- **His stepfather.** The sheriff who killed his father then married his mother. The structure is *Hamlet*'s with the law cast as Claudius: the man who killed the father wins the mother's hand, and the killer is the State itself.
- **Terre Haute.** After the boy burned down an abandoned house, he was institutionalized in Terre Haute, where extensive electroshock permanently damaged his memory and cognition.

- **Powtanville.** On his return the town made him its outcast, the fifth of Glen Bateman's numbers (3.6). "I set old lady Semple's pension check on fire. I got sent to the reformatory for it. I also burned down the Methodist Church in Powtanville, Indiana." The town's chorus never forgets: "Hey, Trash, what did old lady Semple say when you torched her pension check?"

He survives the plague as a prison trusty, caring for the dying in the infirmary, and then simply walks out free. He burns the Powtanville oil tanks and then Gary, Indiana: fire turned against the industrial infrastructure of the father who never protected him.

His destination has a name older than the nation. He thinks of the Kid, who by rights should be with him as they drive into Cibola together, but the Kid has proved unworthy, and Trash has been sent on alone into the wilderness. In 1539 Fray Marcos de Niza reported a city of gold in the northern desert, Cíbola. In 1540 Coronado's expedition reached it and found the mud-walled Zuni pueblo of Hawikuh. The Trashcan Man is the last conquistador of the Seven Cities, and he finds the gold the conquistadors never did, in neon. It is almost dawn on August 5 when he enters Cibola, otherwise known as Vegas. He throws himself into the fountain of the MGM Grand and passes out on a gaming table.

The Kid deserves a textual note. He was among the major cuts of 1978, which kept only his corpse; the 1990 restoration returned his story (Chapter 1.5). He abuses Trash, assaults him, and boasts that he will usurp Flagg. Flagg answers with wolves. The pack traps the Kid among the stalled cars of the Colorado Rockies and leads Trash through the Eisenhower Tunnel, which the Army had blockaded and which he had been too afraid of the dark to enter alone.

This is the novel's second tunnel, and it inverts the first (3.4). Larry crossed under the Hudson in terror toward a vocation he had not yet found. The Trashcan Man crosses under the Continental Divide behind a psychopomp of wolves. The tunnel bears the name of the president who signed the 1956 Act creating the National System of Interstate and Defense Highways (2.1). In his Farewell Address of January

1961, the same president warned the nation against the "military-industrial complex." The man who will carry that complex's ultimate product into Cibola passes under the mountains through Eisenhower's name. I offer this as a resonance, not a claim about intention; the novel's geography makes it available.

Las Vegas gives him, for the first time, somewhere to belong. Las Vegas first sets him to winding copper wire at Hoover Dam, the hydroelectric plant on which the *Bestand*-city depends (4.4). He is deliriously happy, which is Arendt's thesis about organized loneliness (4.4) in its most touching form. His initiation follows the same day. Lloyd gives him a black stone with a red flaw, and he helps nail the drug-user Heck Drogan to a cross. Complicity in killing is the bond, and this is Nechayev's method as Dostoevsky dramatized it in *Demons* (Chapter 1): the cell is bound by a murder in which every member has a hand. Flagg then receives him with the reassurance that "his dreams are true dreams" and the promise to "set him to burn."

The next movement belongs to Günther Anders. *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen* (1956) opens with an essay on "Promethean shame": the shame human beings feel before the perfection of the machines they have made. It diagnoses the "Promethean gap" (*prometheisches Gefälle*), the widening distance between what we can produce and what we can imagine or feel about it. Anders's correspondence with Claude Eatherly, the reconnaissance pilot who gave the weather signal over Hiroshima and broke under his guilt, was published as *Burning Conscience* (1961). The Trashcan Man is the anti-Eatherly. He feels no guilt for fire. When his guilt comes, it is for having destroyed instruments of destruction.

The occasion repeats his childhood. The teasing of his fellow workers throws him back among the jeering tormentors of his youth in Powtanville, and he snaps. He begins covertly sabotaging the fuel trucks and helicopters at the Indian Springs airfield. The explosions destroy equipment and, more importantly, kill Flagg's experienced pilots. He destroys Flagg's air force before Flagg can destroy Boulder, then leaves Las Vegas to atone by finding a more powerful weapon for Flagg.

Here the novel performs an inversion of Leviticus 16 that is entirely its own. On the Day of Atonement, the high priest lays both hands on the head of the living goat, confesses over it all the iniquities of the people, and sends it away "by the hand of a fit man into the wilderness," to bear them "unto a land not inhabited" (16:21–22). Girard read this rite as the domesticated memory of the founding expulsion (4.5). The Trashcan Man has twice been sent alone into the wilderness, after the Kid and after the jets. Unlike every scapegoat in the sacrificial tradition, he comes back, carrying the iniquity of the age into the city that expelled him. In the desert he weighs immolating himself and judges suicide too small a penance. He finds a nuclear warhead at an Air Force range northwest of Indian Springs and winches it out of the ground. He hauls it across the desert on a trailer behind an all-terrain vehicle and contracts a lethal radiation sickness, which is terminal by the time he reaches Las Vegas.

Gaston Bachelard's *La Psychanalyse du feu* (1938) named the two complexes this figure unites.

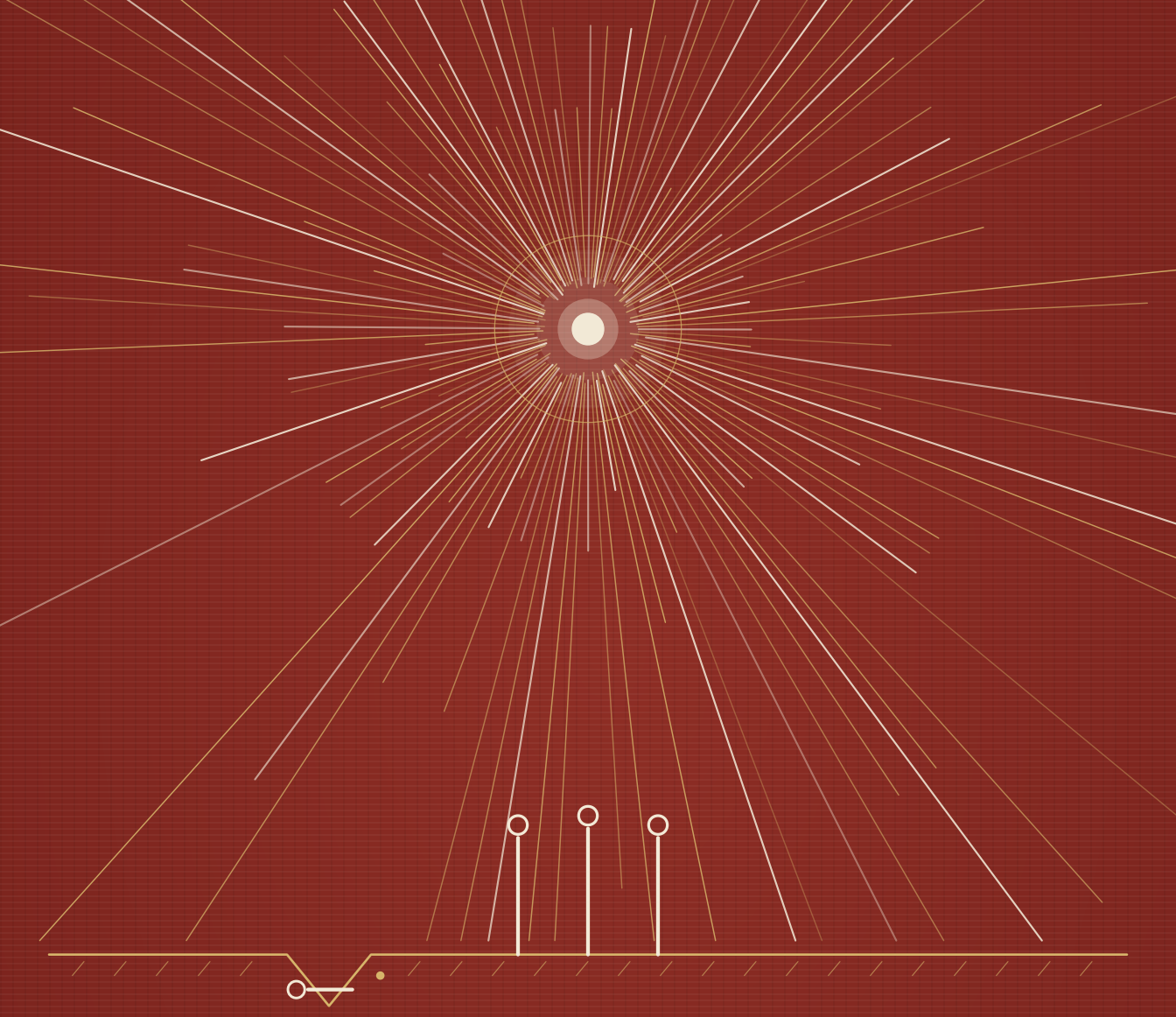
- **The Prometheus complex** is the drive to know and possess as much as one's fathers, and more. It is the orphaned arsonist's whole biography.
- **The Empedocles complex** joins the love of life and the death-instinct in fire. Its emblem is the philosopher who threw himself into Etna. The Trashcan Man will die in the fire he brings.

Chapter 1.3 identified Gollum in him: spared for his usefulness rather than out of pity, and bound to his master by a formula. His formula is "My life for you!", the cry of those who worship Flagg.

That formula has a more exact antecedent in the Roman law of war. In 340 BCE, before the battle near Vesuvius, the consul Publius Decius Mus performed a *devotio*. He pronounced the formula by which a commander consecrated himself, together with the enemy's army, to the gods below: *legiones auxiliaque hostium mecum deis Manibus Tellurique devoveo*, "the legions and auxiliaries of the enemy, together with myself, I devote to the divine Manes and to Earth" (Livy VIII.9.8). He

then rode into the enemy line to die. "My life for you" is a *devotio*, and like Decius Mus's it consecrates the devotee and a city to the fire together. The heterogony of ends (3.1) and Mephistopheles's couplet (Chapter 5, epigraph) converge here: the devotee's offering, meant for the dark god, consecrates the dark god's own city.

Four ways of standing away have now been examined. Each ends in a fall, a fire, or a cell, and each ends with its subject on the wheel's rim, outside the hub where the next chapter must go. Chapter 7 turns to those who stood.



Chapter 7

The Stand Proper

Kenosis, Testimony, and the Hand



If it be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of thine hand, O king. But if not, be it known unto thee, O king, that we will not serve thy gods, nor worship the golden image which thou hast set up.

(Daniel 3:17–18)

Nah ist
Und schwer zu faßen der Gott.
Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst
Das Rettende auch.

[*Near is, and hard to grasp, the God. But where danger is, grows the saving power also.*]

(Hölderlin, "Patmos," 1803)

Late in the novel, *The Stand* offers the only definition of its title it ever gives: "The place where you made your stand never mattered. Only that you were there... and still on your feet." The sentence names two conditions and denies a third.

- **Presence.** *That you were there.* This is the condition of the witness, the *testis* who was present.
- **Posture.** *Still on your feet.* This is the condition of the *superstes*, the one still standing after.
- **Not place.** Place does not matter.

The denial is the novel's last word on its two cities. Boulder's *constitutio* is a politics of place: the city on a hill (4.6). Las Vegas's *Bestand* is a politics of position: the stockpile, the airfield, the runway (4.4). The stand is neither. It is a posture, not a position, and the posture is one of presence. Heidegger's *Da-sein*, being-there, and his late coinage *Inständigkeit*, "in-standing," for a steadfast standing within the open, are the nearest philosophical words for what the novel describes without them.

This chapter follows the stand through eight movements:

1. **7.1** The prophetess who commands it, and the critique her figure demands.
2. **7.2** The mission discourse.
3. **7.3** The one who fell by the way.
4. **7.4** A theory of the unarmed witness.
5. **7.5** Glen Bateman's laughter.
6. **7.6** Whitney Horgan's dissent.
7. **7.7** The Hand.
8. **7.8** The completion of the chiasmus.

7.1 Mother Abagail: Prophecy, Pride, and the Problem of the Trope

She was born in 1882 and guides the survivors as the novel's figure of the good. Her parents, John and Rebecca, had been enslaved. Before the Civil War, John's owner was Sam Freemantle of Lewis, South Carolina, and like many freedmen John took his former owner's surname. He moved his family to Hemingford Home, Nebraska, and in 1902 he was admitted to the farmers' Grange by what the novel treats as a landmark vote. His youngest child outlived three husbands and all seven of her own children. When the plague comes, her dozens of grandchildren and great-grandchildren presumably die with the world. She is Job after the messengers (Job 1:18–19). She is Rachel "weeping for her children" (Jeremiah 31:15; Matthew 2:18). The woman whose own lineage the plague has erased becomes *Mother* to the survivors.

Her names carry the theology of the stand before she speaks a word of it.

Abagail. In 1 Samuel 25, Abigail rides out to meet David, who is marching to destroy the household of her husband Nabal for an insult. She restrains him. David answers: "blessed be thou, which hast kept me this day from coming to shed blood, and from avenging myself with

mine own hand" (25:33). Ten days later, "the LORD smote Nabal, that he died" (25:38). The human hand is withheld and the divine hand acts. Three further details fit:

- The rabbis counted Abigail among the seven prophetesses of Israel (b. *Megillah* 14a).
- The Hebrew *nabal* is the fool of Psalm 14:1, who "hath said in his heart, There is no God."
- The deathbed command of Section 7.2 sends four men to the fool's city with nothing in their hands.

Freemantle. The obvious reading is prophetic. Elijah casts his mantle on Elisha (1 Kings 19:19). With it he smites the Jordan so that the two cross on dry ground, and when Elijah is taken up, Elisha takes up the fallen mantle and parts the waters again (2 Kings 2:8, 13–14). The Jordan crossing in Joshua required priests who "stood firm on dry ground" (3.4). But the name is also the record of ownership: the surname of the man who held her father as property. The prophetic sense is written over the scar. In 1952 Malcolm X discarded "Little" as a slavemaster's name and took "X" in its place. King's novel does not comment on its prophetess's surname. The critic must, because both layers are in the text and neither cancels the other. A further detail the novel leaves undeveloped deepens the palimpsest: one of the dark man's aliases is "Richard Freemantle," a name the novel associates with her own family. The opposite numbers share the owner's name.

Her first stand comes before Boulder, and it is literal. On her two-day walk to a neighboring farm to kill chickens for the travelers she knows are coming, Flagg sends a horde of weasels against her. She holds her ground and faces them down. Her second ordeal is subtler and graver. She is the titular head of the Boulder committee. She declines to interfere in the Zone's secular day-to-day business but insists on being consulted on everything concerning Flagg. Her duty is to gather everyone and point the way, but she enjoys the attention so much that she falls into pride and leads the council away from its real duty, Flagg. She notices that the survivors' awe is turning into worship. God falls silent,

and she is "praying into a dead phone." She concludes that her own hubris is at fault, leaves a note, and goes into the wilderness to fast and pray.

The diagnosis is Augustinian, and the remedy is apostolic.

- **Diagnosis.** *Initium omnis peccati superbia*, "pride is the beginning of all sin" (Ecclesiasticus 10:13; Vulgate 10:15). Augustine made this verse the hinge of his account of the angels' fall (*De civitate Dei* XII.6; XIV.13).
- **The warning.** Luke records the end of Herod Agrippa. He accepted the crowd's acclamation, "It is the voice of a god, and not of a man," and was struck "because he gave not God the glory" (Acts 12:22–23).
- **The remedy.** When the people of Lystra take Paul and Barnabas for Zeus and Hermes and prepare sacrifices, the apostles tear their clothes and cry out, "We also are men of like passions with you" (Acts 14:11–15).

Mother Abagail's flight is the Lystra gesture: a refusal of worship. This distinguishes the two "opposite numbers" more precisely than any opposition of good and evil. One flees acclamation. The other demands prostration, and Section 7.5 will show him demanding it from a man on his knees. The withdrawal follows a pattern far older than Toynbee's "withdrawal-and-return" (3.1). Elijah fasted forty days and nights to Horeb and heard there not the wind, the earthquake, or the fire, but "a still small voice" (1 Kings 19:8–12). The prophetess's silence is that of 1 Samuel 3:1, when "the word of the LORD was precious in those days; there was no open vision."

Her return saves lives without a word being spoken. In her absence Harold Lauder builds a dynamite bomb, and Nadine Cross plants it in the house Nick Andros shares with Ralph Brentner. Just before it goes off during a committee meeting, word of Abagail's return is called out from outside, and most of those present rush out to hear the news. The prophet's return functions as a sign before it functions as a message. She returns ruined by exposure and starvation, gives her last command

(7.2), and dies at sunrise, as she foretold. She had long known that she would die far from the land she loved, among strangers. Moses, too, saw the land and died outside it (Deuteronomy 34:4–5).

The critique must now be stated without evasion, because it is just. Salon and Gizmodo have criticized Mother Abagail as an instance of the "Magical Negro." The term was popularized by Spike Lee in 2001 for the Black character endowed with supernatural wisdom whose narrative function is to serve white protagonists. Toni Morrison's *Playing in the Dark* (1992) had already anatomized the "Africanist presence" in American literature: the figures through whom white writers stage their own fears and their own redemptions. The evidence against the novel is plain.

- **Her people.** She gathers white survivors, sanctifies their polity, and dies so that their mission can begin.
- **Her authority.** The committee, all of whose members are white, gives her absolute veto over its decisions, lest it look as though they are trying to wrest power from her. Her authority is honored as a form and managed as a fact.
- **The pattern.** King's corpus repeats it in Dick Hallorann (*The Shining*, 1977) and John Coffey (*The Green Mile*, 1996).

The counter-evidence is also real. The novel gives Abagail what the trope by definition withholds: a soul with its own drama. She resents having outlived her family. She is afraid. She sins, recognizes her sin, flees, and suffers the silence of God from the inside. Hers is the only spiritual crisis in the Free Zone that the novel narrates as a crisis before God, not merely before other people.

The honest conclusion does not split the difference. The novel's theology requires Abagail's kenosis. The novel's sociology makes that kenosis fall on a Black woman, the daughter of the enslaved, on behalf of white survivors. The theological and the social meanings coincide, and neither may absolve the other. The coincidence reaches back into the founding. The Free Zone ratified a Constitution (4.1) that carries both the three-fifths clause of Article I and the Thirteenth Amend-

ment, under which her father ceased to be property and stayed on as a paid laborer. The republic refounded around her is the republic that enslaved her parents and then freed them. The ratification of the dead ratified her family's history as well.

7.2 The Mission Discourse: "In the Clothes You Stand Up In"

On her last night she summons the five surviving members of the committee. God, she tells them, did not spare them from the plague and gather them so that they could rebuild society. He did it so that they would confront the dark man. The four men are to go west "this very day, and in the clothes you stand up in." They are to carry neither food nor water and to travel on foot. One of them will "fall by the way," though she does not know which. The others will be brought before Flagg. She can promise neither their survival nor their victory, only that it is God's will. The four (Stu, Larry, Glen, and Ralph) are to journey west on foot and confront Flagg directly.

The idiom deserves the attention this dissertation has given to every other use of its title word. "In the clothes you stand up in" means *with nothing but what you are wearing*. The prophetess's charge places the verb of the title inside the command to renounce. It is the kenotic exception of Chapter 4.2, put into words: "he... emptied himself" (Philippians 2:7).

The charge is a mission discourse, and its Gospel originals are exact in every particular.

- **Provisions.** "Take nothing for your journey, neither staves, nor scrip, neither bread, neither money" (Luke 9:3).
- **Wolves.** "Behold, I send you forth as lambs among wolves. Carry neither purse, nor scrip, nor shoes: and salute no man by the way" (Luke 10:3–4). The wolves of the dark man (5.5) are waiting.
- **Purpose.** "And ye shall be brought before governors and kings for my sake, for a testimony against them" (Matthew 10:18). *Eis martyrion*, "for a testimony," names the purpose of being "brought be-

fore." Abagail's prophecy that the survivors will be brought before Flagg repeats the formula, and Section 7.4 will draw out its consequence. The stand is not a battle. It is testimony.

Fran opposes the journey; Lucy Swann supports it. The disagreement maps onto the central argument of Kierkegaard's *Frygt og Bæven* (1843). Problema I asks whether there is a "teleological suspension of the ethical." Kierkegaard sets the "knight of faith" against three tragic heroes, Agamemnon, Jephthah, and Brutus. Each of the three sacrifices a child for the universal, the State, and so remains within the ethical. His sacrifice can be explained, mourned, and honored. Abraham's cannot, because it serves nothing universal.

The four men cannot be tragic heroes, because Abagail has expressly removed the universal justification. They have not been spared to rebuild society. Their walk will not save the Free Zone by any calculable means, since they carry no weapons and have no plan. Fran's protest is the ethical in its full dignity: the claims of a wife, an unborn child, and a polity that needs its leaders. The men's departure suspends it. Problema III adds that the knight of faith cannot explain himself. Abraham's only words to Isaac, "God will provide himself a lamb" (Genesis 22:8), are true and say nothing. Section 7.3 will find those words in Stu Redman's mouth.

Jephthah links Kierkegaard to Locke. The *Second Treatise* grounds its doctrine of the "appeal to Heaven" in Jephthah's words to the Ammonites: "the LORD the Judge be judge this day" (Judges 11:27; *Second Treatise* §21). Where people "have no appeal on earth, then they have a liberty to appeal to heaven" (§168). "Where there is no judge on earth, the appeal lies to God in heaven" (§241). The appeal is the Lockean right of revolution, and in Locke it is armed: heaven judges by the outcome of war. The American Revolution flew it as a flag. In October 1775 Joseph Reed, Washington's military secretary, proposed for the colonial cruisers a white field bearing a tree and the motto *An Appeal to Heaven*.

The four walk west under Locke's appeal against a man whose name is *Flagg*, the standard of Table 3, but they walk unarmed. Aba-

gail's charge purifies the Lockean appeal of its war. There is no earthly judge between the cities, so the appeal is made in the only way that remains when the sword is renounced: the appellants present themselves and let heaven judge.

The scriptural paradigm of such an appeal comes from the rebellion of Korah, and it is the matrix this dissertation promised. Numbers 16 gathers in one chapter every element of the novel's climax.

1. **Rebellion.** Korah, Dathan, and Abiram rise against the anointed.
2. **The appeal without arms.** Moses refuses to judge his own cause and submits it to God: "I have not done them of mine own mind. If these men die the common death of all men... then the LORD hath not sent me. But if the LORD make a new thing, and the earth open her mouth" (16:28–30). The words "of mine own mind" stand against Harold's "of my own free will" (6.1).
3. **Fire.** "And there came out a fire from the LORD, and consumed the two hundred and fifty men that offered incense" (16:35).
4. **Plague.** Wrath goes out and the plague begins (16:46).
5. **The stand.** Aaron runs with his censer into the midst of the dying, "and he stood between the dead and the living; and the plague was stayed" (16:48).

Rebellion, an unarmed appeal to heaven, fire from God, plague, and a man who stands between the dead and the living: this is *The Stand* in a single chapter of the Torah. Section 7.7 will show that Walter Benjamin chose Korah as his paradigm of divine violence.

The road west lays out the false alternatives the four have renounced. They pass two corpses.

- **Harold's** (6.3) is the stand of despair: the apostate's last stand, made with his own hand against himself.
- **The Kid's** is the stand of arms. He died surrounded by the wolves, having shot several and strangled the one that killed him, so that the four find a dead man still gripping a dead wolf. It is *homo hom-*

ini lupus (5.5) as a tableau: the armed, Hobbesian last stand, which killed and was killed and changed nothing.

The 1978 text kept this corpse without its story, an emblem without a narrative. The 1990 restoration supplied the narrative and made the emblem legible (Chapter 1.5). The unarmed men pass the two false stands on the way to the true one.

7.3 The One Who Fell: Stu Redman in the Ravine

Stu breaks his leg in Utah and has to stay behind. He tells the others to go on, saying God will provide for him if that is meant to happen. Kojak stays with him. Ralph persuades Larry to leave him. Larry leads the party after Stu's injury, and he and Ralph eventually die in Las Vegas in the nuclear explosion caused by the Trashcan Man. The three camp sixteen miles west of where they left Stu and move on toward Las Vegas, while Kojak catches a rabbit for Stu. Stu develops pneumonia. Lying in the ravine, he witnesses the destruction of Las Vegas from afar.

The prophecy said that one would "fall by the way." The phrase is the parable of the sower: "some seeds fell by the way side, and the fowls came and devoured them up" (Matthew 13:4). In *The Stand* the fowls belong to the dark man; they are his eyes (5.3). The seed that falls by the way is not devoured, because a dog keeps watch beside it. Chapter 8 will take up the parable again, through Octavia Butler's novel of that name.

The novel's design doubles the prophecy, and the doubling is the strongest single proof that its structure is chiastic. Two men on the road west to Flagg fall into ravines and break their legs.

Table 10 The two ravines

	Harold Lauder	Stu Redman
Direction of travel	Toward Flagg, in flight and in service	Toward Flagg, in obedience and in witness
Cause of the fall	An oil slick laid by the master he served	The terrain: nothing but finitude

	Harold Lauder	Stu Redman
Companion	Nadine, who abandons him after he fires at her	Kojak, who stays, hunts, and keeps watch
Instrument in hand	A pistol	Nothing
Writing	A note of remorse, signed "Hawk"	None; he will testify in speech
Wound	Gangrene: privation of the body	Pneumonia: the plague's own organ, the breath, tested again
Visitation	None	A dream (in 1994, Abagail's charge to witness); Nick's voice guiding Tom
End	Death by his own hand	Rescue by Tom Cullen; return through the winter
Type	Judas in the field of blood (Acts 1:18)	Abraham on Moriah: "God will provide"

The doubling has a moral as well as a formal function. Stu set out with a desire the stand forbids. Having found Harold's body, he wanted to avenge the dead boy, together with all the other dead, when he met the dark man. The fall takes his vengeance out of his hands. The novel's prophetess bears the name of the woman who kept David "from avenging myself with mine own hand" (1 Samuel 25:33), and the leg does for Stu what she did for David. Paul's verse follows: "Vengeance is mine; I will repay, saith the Lord" (Romans 12:19).

Stu's words in the ravine echo Moriah. Abraham's "God will provide himself a lamb" (Genesis 22:8) was answered by a ram caught by its horns in a thicket (22:13). In the badlands of Utah the ram has become a rabbit, brought by a dog. The comedy is part of the theology. Elijah was fed by ravens at the brook Cherith (1 Kings 17:4–6). Stu is fed by the antitype of Flagg's crows, a dog in the line of Argos (2.2). Kojak keeps Stu alive until Tom Cullen comes, and a dog that seemed a reminder of destruction becomes, once a female is found, the hope of a species.

Milton supplies the posture's paradox. The sonnet on his blindness ("When I consider how my light is spent," written in the 1650s, published 1673) ends with Patience's answer to the poet who fears his gift is wasted: "They also serve who only stand and wait." In Milton, *stand*

carries a courtly sense. The angels "stand" in attendance before the throne, as courtiers wait on a king. The protagonist of *The Stand* does not stand at the stand. He lies in a ravine with a broken leg, and in Milton's sense he stands and waits.

Heidegger, the philosopher of *Bestand*, gave this waiting its counter-technological name. In *Gelassenheit* (1959), "releasement toward things" and "openness to the mystery" are named as the comportment that might withstand *Gestell*. The country-path dialogue distinguishes *waiting* (*Warten*), which leaves open what it waits for, from *awaiting* (*Erwarten*), which has already fixed its object. Stu's ravine is the site of *Gelassenheit*. He releases his companions, releases his own outcome to whatever is meant to happen, and waits without an object. Chapter 2.2 described *Bestand* as standing-by: being on call for further ordering. Stu stands and waits, which is attendance without commandeering.

Chapter 4.6 noted that in Revelation 18, those who watch Babylon burn are those "standing afar off." The one human being in *The Stand* who watches the great city burn is the man who was supposed to walk into it. The kings and merchants of John's vision stand afar off to lament what they have lost. Stu watches as a witness. The 1994 adaptation, scripted by King, makes this explicit: there, Mother Abagail comes to Stu in a dream to tell him that he must witness what is about to happen and carry the news back to Boulder. In that version Tom Cullen rescues Stu, and the two watch the distant explosion together before returning to Boulder in winter. The fall makes the *superstes*. Someone had to remain on his feet in the only sense that still mattered: alive, and able to tell.

7.4 *Testis*, *Superstes*, *Martys*: A Theory of the Unarmed Witness

Émile Benveniste's *Le Vocabulaire des institutions indo-européennes* (1969) distinguished the two Latin words for "witness," and Chapter 1 made them two of the senses of the root **steh₂-*.

- ***Testis*** derives from **tri-st-i-*: the one who stands as a third between two parties to a dispute.
- ***Superstes*** is the one who "stands over" an event. He has lived through it to its end and survives it, and so can bear witness to it.

Giorgio Agamben's *Quel che resta di Auschwitz* (1998) added a third term, *auctor*: the witness whose testimony completes and validates something that existed before him. *Auctor* is the root of the *auctoritas* that Chapter 4.2 located in the prophetess. Greek offers a fourth word, *martys*, "witness." It hardened into "martyr" in the second century, when the *Martyrdom of Polycarp* used it for one who testifies by dying.

Scripture gives the theory its setting. In the trial speeches of Isaiah 40–48, the LORD summons the false gods to court: "let them bring forth their witnesses... Ye are my witnesses, saith the LORD... that I am God" (43:9–12). The cosmic lawsuit between the true God and the idol needs witnesses, not soldiers. Numbers 16 supplies the archetype of the *testis* in the strict sense. Aaron, the third party, "stood between the dead and the living" (16:48). The witness is one who stands between.

The novel distributes the four forms of witness among its characters with a completeness that no previous reading has noticed.

Table 11 **The economy of witness**

Form	Etymology	Bearer(s)	Mode of testimony
Auctor	One who augments; whose word completes a prior act	Mother Abagail	The command that authorizes the walk; the prophecy the walk completes
Testis	**tri-st-i-*: the third who stands between	Larry, Ralph, Glen	Presence before the dark man's tribunal, in the cosmic lawsuit of Isaiah 43; "brought before... for a testimony"

Form	Etymology	Bearer(s)	Mode of testimony
Martys	The witness who testifies by dying	Dayna Jurgens; Glen; Larry and Ralph; Judge Farris; Nick Andros	Death that denies the adversary what he seeks: a name, submission, a sign, a voice
Superstes	One who stands over an event, survives it, and can tell it	Stu Redman; Tom Cullen	Survival; the return to Boulder; the report

The martyrs repay closer attention, because each denies Flagg a different thing.

- **Judge Farris.** Flagg wanted his head unmarked so that it could be sent to Boulder as a sign. The head is destroyed, and the martyr cannot be turned into a message (5.3).
- **Dayna Jurgens.** She dies rather than name the third spy. Her free act is the beginning of Flagg's unraveling (5.3). Her armed hand failed when the knife became a joke. Her empty hand succeeded. Deborah, "a mother in Israel," had foretold that "the LORD shall sell Sisera into the hand of a woman" (Judges 4:9; 5:7), and the novel gives Dayna the role of Jael with the weapon taken away.
- **Nick Andros.** He was meant to lead the stand, and Harold's bomb removed him. He becomes, in Hebrews' phrase about Abel, one who "being dead yet speaketh" (4.3) when his voice guides Tom to the medicine that saves Stu.

Two literary genealogies show that the economy of witness is a design and not an accident.

The first is Melville's. Glen Bateman's middle name is *Pequod*, the name of Ahab's ship. *Moby-Dick* ends with a single survivor floating on a coffin, and its Epilogue carries a sentence from Job as epigraph: "And I only am escaped alone to tell thee" (Job 1:15–19). It is the formula of the messengers who come one after another to report catastrophe, and it defines the *superstes*. The same first chapter of Job gives the adversary his walk "to and fro in the earth" (1:7; 5.1). One chapter of Scripture thus supplies both the walking adversary and the escaped witness, and

the novel takes both. Glen bears the doomed ship's name and goes down with it. Stu is the Ishmael.

Melville's rescue completes the pattern. Ishmael is found by "the devious-cruising *Rachel*, that in her retracing search after her missing children, only found another orphan." In *The Stand*, Tom Cullen is far to the east of the ravine when a prophetic dream sends him back to find the man who fell. He performs the *Rachel*'s retracing search, and Rachel's name, the mother weeping for her children, belongs to the bereaved prophetess (7.1).

The second genealogy is Agamben's, and it sets out the novel's darkest structural truth. Primo Levi wrote in *I sommersi e i salvati* (1986) that the survivors are not the true witnesses. The complete witnesses are the drowned, who saw the bottom and did not return. Agamben made this "lacuna" the essence of testimony: the witness testifies on behalf of those who cannot.

Ask who saw the Hand. Ralph Brentner is the first to notice the "Hand of God" as it descends from the sky to detonate Trashcan Man's nuclear weapon, killing everyone present. Ralph and Larry saw it, and they were consumed. Stu, in the ravine, saw the light but not the Hand. Tom had left at moonrise. The only being who saw the Hand and walked away is the one whom the novel's simplest witness described, under hypnosis: "He came out of time. He doesn't know himself." A witness without a self is no witness. The Hand therefore has no surviving human witness inside the fiction. Its testimony reaches us through the narrating voice alone, addressed to the reader King calls "Constant," *con-stans*, the one who stands with (Table 3). The last *superstes* of *The Stand* is its reader.

7.5 Glen Bateman's Laughter

A few days after leaving Stu, the others are captured by Flagg's men. Imprisoned in Las Vegas, Glen goads Flagg. Enraged, Flagg orders Lloyd to shoot him, and Lloyd does. The adaptation keeps the defiance

whole. Glen is executed after openly defying Flagg. The scene has three movements: a naming, a demand, and a laugh.

The naming. Before his men, Glen names the master they dare not name. He calls him by his current name and his epithets, then Beelzebub, Nyarlathotep, Ahaz, Astaroth, Anubis, and finally Legion. The litany is a sociologist's comparative religion, and it is an exorcism, because in the Gospel exorcisms the demon's power breaks when its name is spoken: "What is thy name? And he answered, saying, My name is Legion: for we are many" (Mark 5:9). Two of the names are exact.

- **Nyarlathotep.** In H. P. Lovecraft's prose poem of 1920, Nyarlathotep is a dark herald who comes out of Egypt and tours the cities before the world ends. "He spoke much of the sciences—of electricity and psychology," and his exhibitions of power left audiences speechless. A showman of electrical wonders whose coming portends collapse is the last magician of rational thought (5.2), down to the ball of electricity at his fingertip.
- **Ahaz.** The king of Judah who "made his son to pass through the fire" (2 Kings 16:3). This is the father who gives his child to the flames, and the novel's dark father loses his unborn child to the fall of its mother (6.4).

The demand. Flagg offers Glen his life on one condition: "For a favor of this magnitude, I really think you ought to get down on your knees." He asks an arthritic old man to kneel. The scriptural paradigm of refusal is the one this chapter took as its epigraph. Nebuchadnezzar makes a golden image, and the Aramaic of Daniel 3 repeats one causative verb about a dozen times: the image is the thing the king *hēqîm*, "caused to stand" (*qûm*, "to stand"). The officials of the empire "stood before the image," and at the sound of the music all must fall down. The three Judeans refuse to fall, which is to say they remain standing. "Who is that God that shall deliver you out of my hands?" the king asks (3:15), and they answer: "But if not..." (3:18).

The idol of Daniel 3 is precisely a *Gestell* (4.5): a thing set up so that others must fall before it. The stand is the refusal to fall before what

has been set up. Mordecai's refusal belongs to the same type: he "bowed not, nor did him reverence" (Esther 3:2). Glen's refusal stands in the same lineage, and his "but if not" has no rescuer. In Daniel the three walk unharmed in the fire with a fourth figure "like the Son of God" (3:25). In *The Stand* the fire will consume the righteous, and the "form of the fourth" will appear not as a deliverer walking in the furnace but as a Hand that kindles it (7.7).

The laugh. Glen laughs at Flagg for being so transparent, and he says the sentence that ends the dark man's metaphysics: "We made such a business of you!" The tradition of laughing at the devil is old and precise.

- **Elijah on Carmel.** He mocks the prophets of Baal: "Cry aloud: for he is a god; either he is talking, or he is pursuing, or he is in a journey, or peradventure he sleepeth" (1 Kings 18:27). Then "the fire of the LORD fell" (18:38). In the Carmel narrative, mockery precedes the fire, and the novel keeps that order.
- **Luther and More.** C. S. Lewis set two sayings at the head of *The Screwtape Letters* (1942). Luther: "The best way to drive out the devil, if he will not yield to texts of Scripture, is to jeer and flout him, for he cannot bear scorn." More: the devil, "that prowde spirite," cannot endure to be mocked.
- **Bakhtin.** *Tvorchestvo Fransua Rable* (1965) theorized laughter as a victory over fear: over the cosmic terror and official seriousness by which power governs.
- **Barth.** The right response to *das Nichtige*, the nothingness of Chapter 5.4, is neither terror nor indifference but a sovereign disregard grounded in its defeat.

Glen's sentence is that disregard, put in the vernacular. The *business* made of the dark man (the dread, the dreams, the crosses, the jets) was the substance of his power. Seen clearly, the onion has no kernel. *Malum nihil est*. Psalm 2 had already placed this laughter in heaven. "The kings of the earth set themselves… against the LORD." The Hebrew *yityaṣṣĕbû* means precisely "take their stand." "He that sitteth

in the heavens shall laugh" (2:2, 4). The kings take their stand against God, and heaven laughs. In Las Vegas the laughter comes from the prisoner's cell, and it answers the stand of a king of the earth.

Glen's lecture in Chapter 3.6 ended by claiming that human society was made in the image of His opposite number. At the end, the sociologist meets the opposite number in person and discovers that the image was of a nothing. The theory that society is modeled on the adversary yields, in the presence of the adversary, to laughter.

His last sentence is addressed downward, to the gunman: "It's all right, Mr. Henreid... you don't know any better." It fuses three traditions of the dying word.

1. **Socratic.** No one does wrong knowingly (Plato, *Protagoras* 345d–e; 358c–d).
2. **Dominical.** "Father, forgive them; for they know not what they do" (Luke 23:34).
3. **Protomartyrial.** Stephen's prayer as the stones fall: "Lord, lay not this sin to their charge" (Acts 7:60).

The professor's last act is a diagnosis that is also an absolution. He forgives his executioner by means of the theory of his executioner's ignorance. That ignorance is exactly what Chapter 6.5, after Arendt, called Lloyd's condition.

7.6 Whitney Horgan, or Abdiel in Babylon

Augustine's two cities are entangled (4.6), and the novel proves it at the last possible moment with a cook. Whitney Horgan, an ex-Army cook and butcher, had planned to escape the city with a few others and had asked Lloyd to come (6.5). He stayed, for reasons the novel does not give. At the execution, the crowd, subdued and afraid, gathers for a brutal spectacle: Larry and Ralph shackled in cages, to be torn apart as a public warning. Whitney interrupts, loudly condemning Flagg's cruelty and appealing to the crowd's lost humanity, and for a moment stirs dissent. Flagg silences him with a supernatural ball of fire. He is

the only person in Las Vegas who stands up and denounces the proceedings as barbaric. He tells the crowd "we was Americans once," says this is not how Americans act, and takes them to task for going along with it because a murdering freak in cowboy boots wills it. His words fail to spark a revolt. Flagg flicks an energy-ball at him that seals his mouth shut, then his eyes.

Milton gave this figure its definitive form in the seraph Abdiel. Abdiel alone among Satan's legions answers the rebel's oration, and then he leaves:

> *So spake the Seraph* Abdiel *faithful found,*
> *Among the faithless, faithful only hee;*
> *Among innumerable false, unmov'd,*
> *Unshak'n, unseduc'd, unterrifi'd*
> *His Loyaltie he kept, his Love, his Zeale;*
> *Nor number, nor example with him wrought*
> *To swerve from truth, or change his constant mind*
> *Though single.*
>
> (*Paradise Lost* V.896–903)

The Miltonic parallel is exact in its terms and inverted in its order. Abdiel speaks and then departs. Whitney had resolved to depart, "Come out of her, my people" (Revelation 18:4), and stayed in order to speak. Three phrases of Milton's carry the dissertation's whole vocabulary.

- **"His Loyaltie he kept."** This is Royce's virtue (6.5) with a worthy object. Lloyd's loyalty and Whitney's stand side by side in the same scene and point in opposite directions.
- **"His constant mind."** *Constans*, standing-with, the reader's epithet (Table 3).
- **The battle that follows.** God praises Abdiel because he "single hast maintaind / Against revolted multitudes the Cause / Of Truth, in word mightier then they in Armes" (VI.30–32). *In word mightier than they in arms* is the definition of the unarmed witness.

Flagg's answer is the anti-Pentecost of Chapter 2.3 performed by hand. The plague closed throats; the sorcerer seals a mouth. The last voice of the dead republic's civil religion in Babylon belongs to a cook, and the State that had choked its citizens has an heir who silences them with fire.

In *Eichmann in Jerusalem* (1963), Hannah Arendt told the story of Anton Schmid, the German sergeant executed for helping Jews escape. She drew a lesson in which this dissertation's political theology finds its humane minimum. Under conditions of terror, most people comply, but some do not. Nothing more is required, and nothing more can reasonably be asked, for the earth to remain a place fit for human beings to live. Whitney Horgan is the novel's Anton Schmid. His words fail, as the novel insists, and they change nothing in the crowd. Yet they change everything in the order of causes. The ball of fire Flagg conjures to silence the dissenter is the instrument the Hand will take up. The witness does not cause the judgment. He occasions it.

7.7 The Hand

The sequence can be reconstructed from the novel's account:

1. **The arrival.** As Flagg's control wavers, the crowd begins to panic and scatter, because the Trashcan Man has arrived driving an electric cart with a nuclear bomb, his body ravaged by radiation sickness, a figure of impending apocalypse. Flagg's supernatural powers cannot master the situation.
2. **The ball.** Distracted, Flagg loses concentration on his ball of electricity, which drifts away. Flagg panics and tries to make the Trashcan Man get rid of the bomb.
3. **The cry.** Then one of the men sent to challenge Flagg screams "The Hand Of God!" and points.
4. **The end.** The ball of energy Flagg summoned against Whitney becomes the "hand of God" and detonates the weapon, destroying Las Vegas and vaporizing everyone at ground zero. Flagg vanishes.

> The novel's sentence on the end of Babylon is this: "Silent white light filled the world. And the righteous and unrighteous alike were consumed in that holy fire."

Six scriptural texts converge on this page, and each contributes something the others lack.

The finger of God (Exodus 8:19). Pharaoh's magicians matched Moses's first two plagues with their enchantments. At the third, lice from the dust, they failed and confessed to their king: "This is the finger of God." The Hand defeats a magician's power with power that is not magic. The confession is made by the victims of the last magician of rational thought. Ralph Brentner had lost the third and fourth fingers of his left hand to Harold's bomb (the explosion destroyed the house he shared with Nick, and though he survived, it cost him the third and fourth fingers of his left hand). The man whose hand was maimed by a human bomb is the first to see the divine Hand over a nuclear one. Luke's Jesus uses the same phrase of exorcism: "if I with the finger of God cast out devils" (Luke 11:20).

The writing on the wall (Daniel 5). At Belshazzar's feast, "came forth fingers of a man's hand, and wrote." The king's knees "smote one against another" (5:5–6): the king of Babylon loses his stand. The writing is a reckoning. "MENE; God hath numbered thy kingdom, and finished it. TEKEL; Thou art weighed in the balances, and art found wanting" (5:26–27). Las Vegas, the city of odds and house edges, is numbered. "In that night was Belshazzar the king of the Chaldeans slain" (5:30). The Babylon typology of Chapter 4.6 finds its verdict here. The counterfeit writing of Nadine's planchette (6.4) is answered by the true one.

Satan as lightning (Luke 10:18). "I beheld Satan as lightning fall from heaven." Flagg's ball of electricity is his lightning, and the Hand takes it out of his grasp and turns it to its own use. Shakespeare's proverb is here literal: "'tis the sport to have the engineer / Hoist with his own petard" (*Hamlet* III.4). The engineer of *Bestand* is lifted by his own bomb, but the match is struck by another hand. Lloyd, who had

once escaped riding the State's lightning in the electric chair (6.5), dies in this one.

The chariot of the Son (*Paradise Lost* VI.832–55). Milton's Son drives against the rebel angels "in his right hand / Grasping ten thousand Thunders." Then comes the restraint: "Yet half his strength he put not forth, but check'd / His Thunder in mid Volie, for he meant / Not to destroy, but root them out of Heav'n." The novel keeps Milton's restraint. The Hand consumes the city but does not annihilate the adversary. Flagg vanishes and wakes on another shore (5.6). He is rooted out of America, not destroyed. Evil is expelled, not abolished, which is why the wheel turns.

The fire on the camp of the saints (Revelation 18:8; 20:9). Babylon is "utterly burned with fire: for strong is the Lord God who judgeth her." The armies gathered against "the camp of the saints… and the beloved city" are devoured by "fire… from God out of heaven." The air strike Las Vegas was preparing against Boulder ends in fire on Las Vegas itself.

The righteous with the wicked (Genesis 18:23–25; Matthew 5:45). The novel's sentence of judgment inverts the Sermon on the Mount, where the Father "maketh his sun to rise on the evil and on the good, and sendeth rain on the just and on the unjust." The indiscriminate gift becomes an indiscriminate fire. This is Abraham's nightmare at Sodom: "Wilt thou also destroy the righteous with the wicked?… Shall not the Judge of all the earth do right?" At Sodom the righteous man was led out before the fire fell (Genesis 19:16, 24). In Las Vegas the righteous are the reason the fire falls, brought there as witnesses and consumed with the wicked. The novel does not answer Abraham's question. Its final answer to every such question is "I don't know" (Conclusion).

The adaptation flinches where the novel does not. In 1994, as the Hand descends, Mother Abagail's voice announces that the promise has been kept as God willed, and she bids Larry and Ralph come home. The novel offers no voice and no welcome: only silent white light, and the righteous consumed.

Walter Benjamin's "Zur Kritik der Gewalt" (1921) supplies the theory that makes the scene intelligible, with Korah (Numbers 16; 7.2) as its paradigm. Benjamin distinguished two kinds of violence. *Mythic violence* posits and preserves law. *Divine violence* annihilates it. In his own antitheses (my translation from the German): "If mythic violence is law-positing, divine violence is law-annihilating. If the former sets boundaries, the latter boundlessly destroys them. If mythic violence brings guilt and atonement at once, divine violence expiates. If the former threatens, the latter strikes. If the former is bloody, the latter is lethal in a bloodless way." His example of mythic violence was Niobe, turned to stone and left as a boundary-mark. His example of divine violence was God's judgment on the company of Korah, which strikes the privileged without warning or threat, does not stop short of annihilation, and in annihilating expiates.

Las Vegas and the Hand fall on the two sides of Benjamin's distinction, term for term.

- **The crosses** of Las Vegas (4.5) are mythic violence in its pure form. They posit Flagg's law, they are bloody, and they threaten, since they stand as warnings.
- **The Hand** is divine violence in every term. It annihilates the law of the city. It strikes without threat; no one in Las Vegas is warned. It is lethal without bloodshed: silent white light. It is expiatory: the Trashcan Man's penance (6.6) and the narrator's "holy fire" agree on this.

Benjamin insisted that divine violence is never available to human beings as a means. In "Force of Law" (1989–90), Jacques Derrida worried that the essay could license the worst, that "divine violence" might be claimed by human annihilators. *The Stand* answers the worry structurally. No human being in the scene wields the Hand. The men sent from Boulder carry nothing, and the humans present are its objects, the righteous among them. The appeal to heaven (7.2), purified of war, is the only human act compatible with divine violence. It does not invoke it as a means. It stands where it may fall.

Hölderlin's lines, quoted by Heidegger in the very essay that defined *Bestand*, now read as a commentary on this page. "Where danger is, grows / the saving power also." For Heidegger the danger was *Gestell*, and the saving power was to grow within it. In *The Stand* the saving power literally grows out of the danger: the Hand is formed from the dark man's own ball of fire, and its instrument is the supreme product of *Gestell*, the warhead. The poem's opening lines belong here too: "Near is, and hard to grasp (*schwer zu faßen*), the God." *Fassen* is to grasp with the hand. The God who cannot be grasped appears, for an instant, as a Hand.

A final genealogy shows why the image arrived in 1978. Adam Smith's first use of "the invisible hand" was not economic. In the essay on the history of astronomy (published posthumously in 1795), he describes how early polytheists explained nature. Regular events were left to their own causes, "nor was the invisible hand of Jupiter ever apprehended to be employed in those matters." "But thunder and lightning, storms and sunshine, those more irregular events, were ascribed to his favour, or his anger." The invisible hand began as the hand that throws lightning, the explanation of the irregular event, the "act of God."

Smith later secularized it into the providence of the market (*Theory of Moral Sentiments* IV.1, 1759; *Wealth of Nations* IV.2, 1776). In 1977, the year before *The Stand*, Alfred Chandler's *The Visible Hand* argued that the managerial corporation's planning had replaced the market's invisible hand. Las Vegas is Chandler's visible hand in apocalyptic form: the managed city of technicians, crews, and logistics (4.4). King's Hand returns Smith's metaphor to its origin. It is the hand of Jupiter, the hand of lightning, made visible for one instant over the managerial city, as the act of God par excellence.

7.8 The Chiasmus Completed

The thesis stated in the Introduction can now be stated in full. Book I and Book III are the two arms of a chiasmus.

- **Book I:** a human artifact produces the appearance of an act of God. The plague is engineered, and its scale lends it the face of *force majeure*.
- **Book III:** an act of God works through a human artifact. The Hand detonates the warhead.

At the crossing point, the hub of the wheel of Figure 1, stands the stand.

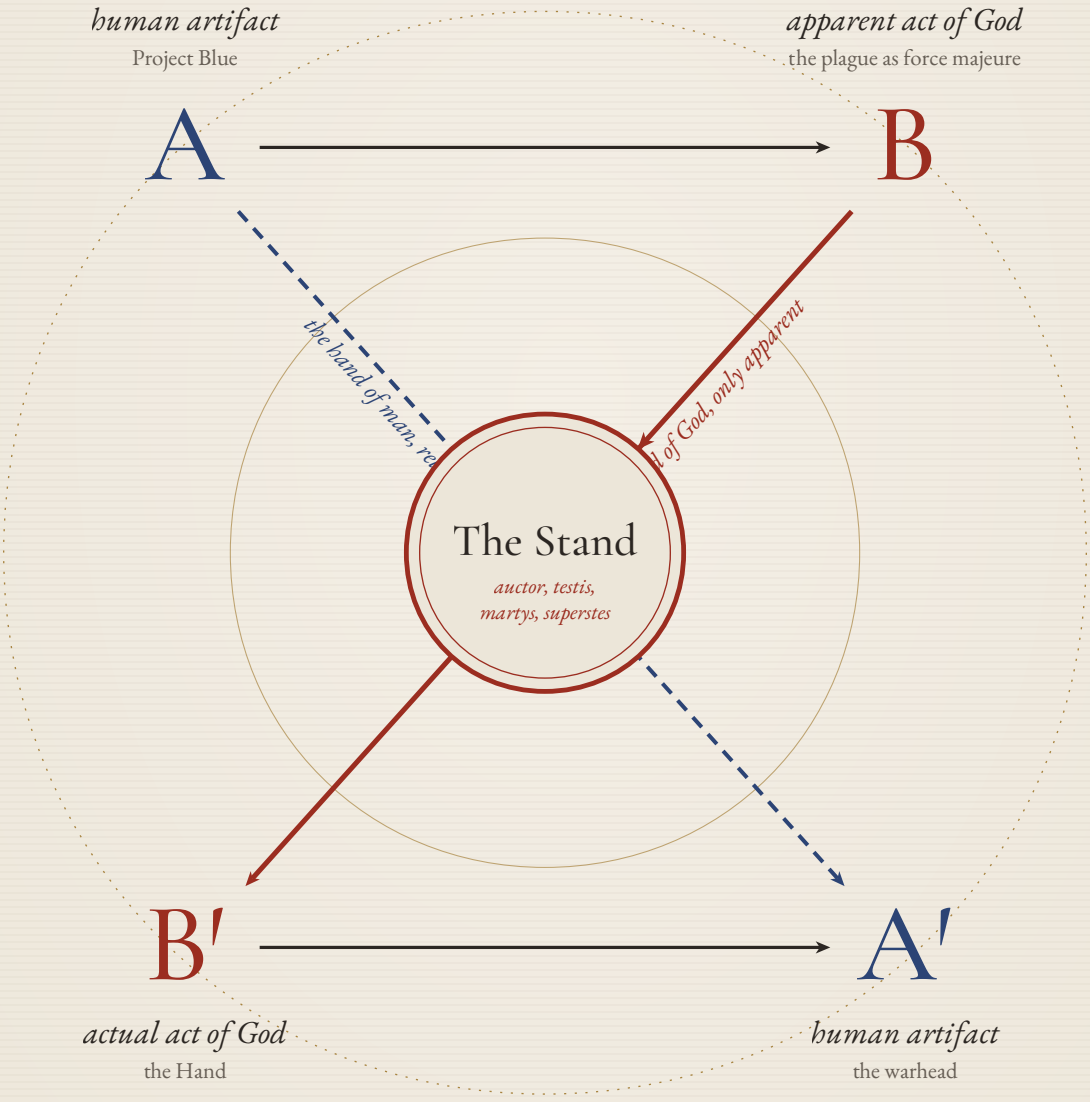
Scripture had already drawn this figure, and the novel inverts it. When David sinned by numbering Israel, he was offered three punishments, and he chose the plague: "let us fall now into the hand of the LORD; for his mercies are great: and let me not fall into the hand of man" (2 Samuel 24:14). In Scripture the plague *is* the hand of the LORD. Its mercy is that it is stayed. The angel stretches out his hand over Jerusalem, and the LORD says, "It is enough: stay now thine hand." The angel stands at the threshing floor of Araunah (24:16). The Chronicler identifies that threshing floor as Mount Moriah, where the Temple would be built (2 Chronicles 3:1). Moriah is where Abraham's hand, raised over Isaac, was stayed: "Lay not thine hand upon the lad" (Genesis 22:12). By the tradition of the canon, the place of the stayed hand is one place, twice. The plague-angel's hand and the father's hand are stayed on the same mountain.

The Stand reverses every term of this scriptural figure.

- **The plague** is the hand of man (2.3), and no one stays it. The State's last act is to spread it (2.6).
- **The human hands** that matter are stayed instead. The four men carry nothing. The prophetess, like her namesake, keeps them from avenging themselves with their own hands (7.1). The fall in the ravine stays Stu's hand (7.3).
- **The divine hand** is not stayed. It falls.

Figure 4

The chiasmus completed



The A–B–B′–A′ structure of the novel. The outer terms are artifacts of the same military-scientific order. The inner terms are an apparent and an actual act of God. The stand occupies the crossing, the only point at which the two hands meet.

Scripture's mercy is a stayed hand of God. The novel's mercy, harder to bear, is a stayed hand of man and a released hand of God. "It is a fearful thing to fall into the hands of the living God" (Hebrews 10:31).

The motif of the hand runs through the entire novel, and its catalogue is the visible form of the chiasmus.

Table 12 The hands of *The Stand*

Hand	Bearer	Act	Mode	Type
The many joined hands	The infected	Contagion passed from hand to hand (2.4)	The plague as the hand of man	The *danse macabre*; 2 Samuel 24 inverted
The writing hand	Harold	The barn sign; the ledger; the note signed "Hawk"	Hospitality, then *ressentiment*, then remorse	"The hand of him that betrayeth me is with me on the table" (Luke 22:21)
The planchette hand	Nadine	Messages spelled through disowned fingers	Counterfeit writing	Daniel 5 inverted
The "right hand"	Lloyd	The crosses; the shot that kills Glen	Mythic violence	"Their right hand is a right hand of falsehood" (Psalm 144:8)
The armed hand	Dayna	A knife turned into a banana; then the empty hand's free act	The weapon mocked; the witness vindicated	Jael (Judges 4:9, 21)
The burning hands	The Trashcan Man	Fire; the winched warhead	*Devotio*	The hands laid on the scapegoat (Leviticus 16:21)
The maimed hand	Ralph	Reads Nick's notes aloud; first to see the Hand	Mouth of the mute *logos*; first confessor	"This is the finger of God" (Exodus 8:19)
The withheld hands	The four	Carry nothing; avenge nothing	The appeal to heaven without arms	Abigail and David (1 Samuel 25:33)
The nursing hands	Tom Cullen	Binds and tends the one who fell	Mercy on the road	The Samaritan (Luke 10:34)
The Hand	—	Detonates the warhead	Divine violence	Exodus 8:19; Daniel 5; Luke 10:18

Augustine gave the theology that the chiasmus enacts its classic formula. God "judged it better to bring good out of evil than to permit no evil to exist" (*melius enim iudicavit de malis bene facere quam mala nulla esse permittere*, *Enchiridion* 27). Joseph said to his brothers: "ye

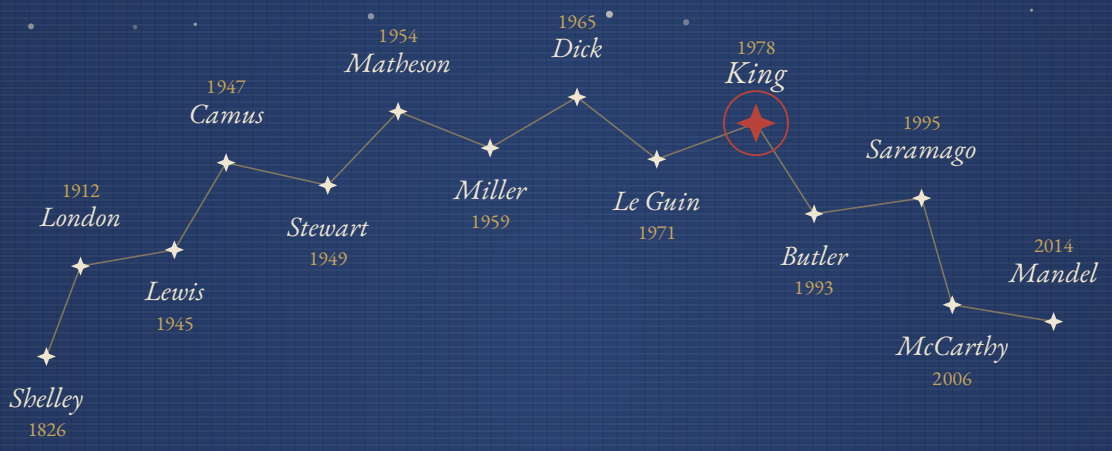
thought evil against me; but God meant it unto good" (Genesis 50:20). Vico's heterogony of ends (3.1), Goethe's Mephistopheles (Chapter 5), and Hegel's "cunning of reason," which "lets the passions work for it," are the philosophical forms of the same thought.

The novel's providence differs from all of them in one decisive respect: visibility. Smith's hand is invisible, Hegel's reason is cunning, and Vico's mind works behind human purposes. *The Stand*'s providence is invisible for eleven hundred pages and visible for one instant. It shows its Hand once, and the only human beings who see it are consumed by the seeing.

That instant is the stand's temporality, and it confirms this dissertation's temporal thesis. The parlor clock of Chapter 3.3 measured *chronos*, the "dry age" of identical moments. The Hand belongs to *kairos*: "In a moment, in the twinkling of an eye" (1 Corinthians 15:52). Kierkegaard's *Begrebet Angest* (1844) called this *Øieblikket*, the blink of an eye: the ambiguous instant in which time and eternity touch. Benjamin's last theses (1940) called it the strait gate through which, in any second of time, the Messiah might enter.

The wheel of Figure 1 has a rim, where Fortune turns her captives and the dark man recurs, and a hub, where providence holds still. The witnesses reach the hub and are consumed, not recycled. Only the third posture escapes the wheel of *stasis*, and only for an instant.

Then the wheel turns. A man of no age wakes on a beach under a new name. A man with a mending leg and a man who spells every important word M-O-O-N walk east through a Rocky Mountain winter, carrying the only report of what happened. In Boulder a child named for a buried gardener has fallen sick with the plague, and no one yet knows whether he will live. The circle is not yet closed, and before the Conclusion can close it, the dissertation must set the novel among the literature of the end with which it has quarreled, and to which it belongs.



TERRA IN AETERNUM STAT

Chapter 8

Who May Abide

The Stand *and the Literature of the End*



Behold, I will send my messenger, and he shall prepare the way before me... But who may abide the day of his coming? and who shall stand when he appeareth? for he is like a refiner's fire, and like fullers' soap.

(Malachi 3:1–2)

Generatio praeterit et generatio advenit, terra vero in aeternum stat.

[*One generation passeth away, and another generation cometh: but the earth standeth for ever.*]

(Ecclesiastes 1:4, Vulgate; Douay-Rheims)

Chapters 2 through 7 read *The Stand* from within. This chapter reads it from without, against the literature of the end: thirteen authors, from Mary Shelley's *The Last Man* (1826) to Emily St. John Mandel's *Station Eleven* (2014). In the spring of 2020 these books were read as forecasts. A pandemic canon assembled itself within weeks. Camus's *La Peste* returned to the bestseller lists of Europe, Shelley's long-neglected novel found a new public, and King had to assure his own readers that the new coronavirus was "NOT like THE STAND." Forecasting is the least interesting thing these books do. Each is also an answer to a question older than any of them, and that question is this dissertation's title.

Revelation's "who shall be able to stand?" (6:17) gathers three prophetic precedents:

- Joel, of the day of the LORD: "who can abide it?" (2:11).
- Nahum: "Who can stand before his indignation? and who can abide in the fierceness of his anger?" (1:6).
- Malachi 3:2, the fullest of the three.

Malachi is the last book of the Christian Old Testament, and its name means "my messenger." In the space of two chapters it supplies every coordinate along which the literature of the end has located itself:

- it sends a messenger (3:1);

- it asks who may abide and who shall stand (3:2);
- it promises a refiner's fire (3:2–3);
- it declares that the LORD does not change (3:6);
- it records a "book of remembrance" (3:16);
- it foretells a day that "shall burn as an oven" (4:1);
- it sends Elijah to "turn the heart of the fathers to the children, and the heart of the children to their fathers" (4:6);
- and in Hebrew it ends on a single word, *ḥērem*: the ban, the devotion of a place to destruction.

The comparison runs along three axes:

1. **Aetiology.** What ends the world: nature, artifact, God, or nothing nameable.
2. **Posture.** What the survivor does: abide, stand, preserve, carry, found, perform, or walk away.
3. **Figure of time.** What shape the end describes: line, cycle, latency, spiral, or instant.

The comparison is typological, not genealogical. Two of the works stand in documented relation to King, and those relations are noted. The rest matter as rival answers, not as sources. Section 8.11 gathers the answers into a typology and locates *The Stand* within it.

8.1 The Malachian Hinge: *Earth Abides* and the Standing Earth

Tolkien gave King his epic form (1.3). Within the genre of the plague novel, the one model King has acknowledged is George R. Stewart's *Earth Abides* (1949), which he has said inspired *The Stand*. The kinship is usually described through plot: a plague, a male survivor who crosses the continent, a community gathered in the West, a long coda of generations. The deeper relation is philological. To my knowledge it has not been noticed.

Stewart's title page quotes Ecclesiastes 1:4 in compressed form: "Men go and come, but earth abides." The verb is the King James Version's ("but the earth abideth for ever"). It is not the verb of the original.

- The Hebrew reads *wəhā'āreṣ lə'ôlām 'ōmādet*, the participle of *'āmad*, "to stand."
- The Septuagint renders it ἔστηκεν, and the Vulgate *stat*.
- The Douay-Rheims accordingly reads "the earth standeth for ever."

In every Bible but the one Stewart quoted, his title reads *The Earth Stands*.

'Āmad is also the verb of the second question in Malachi 3:2, where the King James translators set their two English verbs side by side: "But who may abide the day of his coming? and who shall stand when he appeareth?" The second clause is *ûmî hā'ōmēd*, "and who is the one standing?" The two novels' titles are one Hebrew verb, refracted by the English Bible into two English words. Malachi 3:2 is where the refraction becomes visible, as parallelism.

The eighth contribution claimed in the Introduction can now be stated exactly:

- In English, *Earth Abides* answers Malachi's first question (who may abide?).
- In Hebrew, it answers the second (who stands?), and its answer is not a person but the earth.
- *The Stand* asks the second question of persons.

Table 13 **One verb, two titles: Ecclesiastes 1:4 and Malachi 3:2 in the versions**

	Hebrew (Greek for Revelation)	Septuagint	Vulgate	King James (1611)	Douay-Rheims
Eccl 1:4	*wəhā'āreṣ lə'ôlām 'ōmādet*	καὶ ἡ γῆ εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα ἔστηκεν	*terra vero in aeternum stat*	"but the earth abideth for ever"	"but the earth standeth for ever"

	Hebrew (Greek for Revelation)	Septuagint	Vulgate	King James (1611)	Douay-Rheims
Mal 3:2a	*ûmî məkalkēl 'et-yôm bô'ô*	καὶ τίς ὑπομενεῖ ἡμέραν εἰσόδου αὐτοῦ;	*et quis poterit cogitare diem adventus eius?*	"But who may abide the day of his coming?"	"And who shall be able to think of the day of his coming?"
Mal 3:2b	*ûmî hā'ōmēd bəhērā'ôtô*	ἢ τίς ὑποστήσεται ἐν τῇ ὀπτασίᾳ αὐτοῦ;	*et quis stabit ad videndum eum?*	"and who shall stand when he appeareth?"	"and who shall stand to see him?"
Rev 6:17	καὶ τίς δύναται σταθῆναι;	n/a	*et quis poterit stare?*	"and who shall be able to stand?"	"and who shall be able to stand?"

The ancient versions do more than confirm that the verb is the same. Each divides Malachi's double question along a line this dissertation has already drawn.

The Greek sets *hypomonē* against *hypostasis*.

- The first question asks who will *hypomenein*, "remain under," that is, endure. The same word names the saints' "patience" in Revelation (13:10; 14:12).
- The second asks who will *hyphistasthai*, "stand under," that is, withstand. This verb belongs to the root $*steh_2$-. Its noun, *hypostasis*, means foundation, substance, and in later doctrine "person."
- The Greek Malachi therefore asks who has substance enough to stand in the day. Chapter 5 answered no for the dark man, an onion without a kernel (5.4). Chapter 7 answered yes for the witnesses.
- The Epistle to the Hebrews joins the two terms. Faith is the *hypostasis* of things hoped for (11:1), and the chapter that defines it closes on a "cloud of witnesses," *martyrōn* (12:1).

The Latin divides the questions into knowledge and sight.

- Jerome's first question is epistemic: who will be able to *think* the day of his coming? It anticipates the novel's last answer, "I don't know" (C.6).

- His second is testimonial: who will stand *ad videndum*, in order to see him? This is almost word for word the definition of *testis* and *superstes* given in 7.4: one who stands so as to see.

The English divides them into two novels. Table 3 must therefore gain one entry: the earth's *stat*, the standing of what has no self.

The same difference runs through every structural member of the two novels: endurance without testimony, set against testimony.

The subject. Stewart had already written novels whose protagonists were a storm (*Storm*, 1941) and a forest fire (*Fire*, 1948). Half of *Earth Abides* belongs to a protagonist of the same kind: the ecology of a continent without people, narrated in italic interchapters. Its law is stated by its geographer-hero: when anything gets too numerous, it is likely to be hit by some plague.

Stewart's plague is natural. His prefatory epigraph is a 1947 warning from the virologist W. M. Stanley that a mutant virus, carried by modern rapid transport, could kill millions. King's plague travels by the same vector, the interstate highway of 2.1, but it leaves a laboratory first.

Stewart's earth is a *superstes* that cannot testify. It outlasts everything and tells nothing, and the interchapters lend it the narrating voice it lacks. *The Stand* has no such interchapters. Its only witness to the whole is human, or else the reader (7.4).

The mother. Ish, whose name is Hebrew for "man," reads Ecclesiastes and realizes he has been throwing his life away. He takes Emma, called Em, as his wife. Stewart made her at least partly African American, and Ish comes to think of her as the "Mother of Nations." They become Ish and Em, and the fact that she has some Black genealogy is suddenly an irrelevance.

Stewart was writing in Berkeley within months of *Perez v. Sharp* (1948), in which the California Supreme Court became the first state high court to strike down a ban on interracial marriage. *Loving v. Virginia* was nineteen years away.

Stewart and King thus both make a Black woman the Mother of the post-plague community, but they give her different things.

- **Em** has a body, a marriage, children, a vote, and a decisive voice in old age: she persuades Ish to admit a neighboring band into the Tribe. She is the mother of a lineage.
- **Abagail** has prophecy, a managed veto, and a death (7.1). She is the mother of a polity whose own lineage the plague erased.

Stewart's construction does not answer the critique of 7.1, but it measures it. In 1949 a white novelist could imagine the Black mother of the new world as a wife who bears children. In 1978 a white novelist imagined her as a prophetess past childbearing who dies for others' mission.

The founding killing. In the Tribe's twenty-second year, two of the older boys return from a cross-country trip with a stranger named Charlie, whom the adults immediately distrust; when it is discovered that he carries multiple dangerous diseases, Ish and the other survivors vote to execute him to prevent transmission. The vote is unanimous, and he is hanged. But something of his legacy exacts its toll: he also brought disease with him, and it takes five, including Joey, the one child who learned to read. Bereft, Ish questions all of his plans to rebuild society, wondering if the death is divine punishment for killing Charlie.

This is Glen Bateman's number five, *tous contre un* (Table 6), enacted as democratic procedure. It is also Girard's founding murder in its most disturbing variant, because the victim really did carry the plague. Stewart grants the persecutors' myth a factual basis: Oedipus is guilty after all. Theodicy returns at once in its most primitive form (is the child's death a punishment for the execution?), and Stewart declines to answer.

King reverses every term.

- Boulder executes no one. Its murderer executes himself in a ravine (6.3).
- The victims of Las Vegas are innocent (4.5).

- The scapegoat sent into the desert comes back carrying the plague of his age, radiation, into the city that expelled him (6.6).

The hammer and the thunder. One day, Ish asks for his hammer, which he habitually carries around, and finds the children are afraid to touch it as it is a symbol to them of the old times; the long-dead "Americans" of the old world are now viewed like gods, including Ish, and only Joey is willing to touch it. Ish presides at meetings, his hammer being a symbol of his status.

Golding's conch (1954) is a democratic token; Stewart's hammer is a theocratic one. In it Vico's first principle, religion, is born again from a tool. Vico derived the first religion from thunder: the giants, terrified by lightning, imagined a Jove who spoke in it (§§377–379). Stewart's Tribe sacralizes a hammer, the instrument of Thor, over two generations of slow superstition. Its hunters tip their arrows with heads beaten from the coins of the dead republic, so the sovereign's image (Matthew 22:20) survives as a hunting point. Stewart's *ricorso* is fulfilled in Vico's sense. The Tribe becomes *religiosi, veraci e fidi* (§1106), which Chapter 3.1 found that King's accelerated *ricorso* fails to produce.

The two novels part ways at the power station.

- **Stewart:** the electricity, supplied by an automated hydroelectric plant, fails. The lights go out, and the gods return as a hammer.
- **King:** Boulder's Power Committee turns the lights back on (4.1), so the gods must break in from outside, as a hand of lightning (7.7).

Vico placed the thunderbolt at the origin of the human world. King places it at the end of a cycle, as a ball of electricity in the adversary's hand which the Hand takes up. The *ricorso* closes with the thunder that opened the *corso*.

The ending. Decades pass, and every original member of the tribe dies except Ish, leaving him as "the Last American." Ish collapses while crossing the San Francisco–Oakland Bay Bridge. Dying, he chooses his great-grandson Jack as heir to the hammer, and his last thought is Ecclesiastes: men go and come, but earth abides.

The Stand ends with a question about whether people ever learn, and a confession of ignorance. Stewart answers the question of the wheel ecologically: the generations come and go, and the earth stands. King refuses both the ecological answer and the eschatological one, and says he does not know.

The original last man. One of Stewart's reviewers observed that Ish recalls Ishi, the last surviving Yahi. Ishi walked out of the hills near Oroville in 1911 and spent his last five years at the University of California's museum of anthropology. The name the anthropologists gave him also means "man."

The American literature of the last man therefore has a historical original, and his catastrophe was not a future plague but a completed one: epidemic disease, settler violence, and the extermination campaigns of the California genocide. Kyle Powys Whyte has argued that Indigenous peoples already inhabit what their ancestors would have recognized as dystopia. The empty West into which Stewart's and King's survivors migrate had been emptied once before. This qualifies two earlier readings: Turner's frontier, reopened in 1990 (3.1), and Cibola, a pueblo before it was a casino (6.6).

It also prepares 8.10. The anthropologist who brought Ishi to the museum was Alfred Kroeber, father of Ursula K. Le Guin.

8.2 The Last Man and the Lacuna: Mary Shelley

The genre's founding text arrived at the end of a brief vogue for lastness. Before it came Grainville's *Le Dernier Homme* (1805), Byron's "Darkness" (1816), and Thomas Campbell's "The Last Man" (1824). In May 1824 Mary Shelley wrote in her journal that she might well describe "that solitary being's feelings," feeling herself the last relic of a beloved race. Her husband had drowned in 1822; Byron died in April 1824.

The Last Man (1826) is elegy cast as prophecy, and its frame makes this literal. Shelley states that in 1818 she discovered, in a cave near Naples, prophetic writings painted on leaves by the Cumaean Sibyl,

and that she has edited these writings into the narrative of a man living at the end of the 21st century, commencing in 2073 and concluding in 2100. Virgil's Aeneas had begged the same Sibyl not to trust her songs to leaves, lest the winds whirl them away: *foliis tantum ne carmina manda, / ne turbata volent rapidis ludibria ventis* (*Aeneid* 6.74–75). Shelley's novel gathers the scattered leaves. Its witness testifies from the future to the past: the *superstes* of an end that has not yet happened, read by people who will not live to see it.

Three structural features make the novel the necessary foil to King's.

First, the false prophet without a true one. The Impostor, unnamed, is a false prophet from ambition rather than fanaticism who creates a radical religious sect in opposition to Adrian while in France; Juliet, a young noblewoman who joins his party to support her baby, is later killed revealing his imposture. He promises his followers that they will be saved from the disease, hides the plague's effects from them, and kills himself when the deception fails. His followers rejoin the main body of exiles.

The sect is the first literary Las Vegas:

- a community constituted by a false promise of immunity (election without merit, 3.5);
- held together by the concealment of death (the *arcanum imperii*, 2.1);
- led by a man whose creed is ambition (form without content, 5.1).

Shelley has no Mother Abagail. Her good is Adrian, son of England's last king and the novel's portrait of Percy Shelley: republican, philosophical, philanthropic. He is the Boulder committee in one person, and the sea takes him.

One critical line contrasts Verney against the false prophet of Paris and reads him, upon his recovery, as a failed prophet, unable to foresee the future or understand the present, not from any personal shortcoming but because prophecy is impossible when the fate of humanity rests upon no rational cause. Shelley gives prophecy only to the Impostor

and to the Sibyl's leaves. King restores the true prophet and makes her fallible. That is the theological difference between Morton Paley's formula for Shelley, "apocalypse without millennium," and the judgment without millennium of Chapter 7.

Second, the State that dies on its stores. When the plague reaches England, Ryland, the popular democrat just elected Lord Protector, is unprepared, flees north, and dies alone among his stockpiled provisions. A head of state perishing beside his hoard is the first literary emblem of *Bestand* (2.2): the sovereign as custodian of stock, dying in the warehouse. Starkey's suicide at Project Blue (2.6) is its American descendant.

Third, the immunity and its donor. Verney becomes immune through an act Shelley narrates as horror. In a darkened house a dying Black man seizes him in a convulsive embrace, and the disease passes to him with the stranger's breath. Verney sickens, recovers, and outlives everyone.

Critics have read the scene both as an indictment of racism and empire and as a symptom of them. Olivia Murphy reads the novel as a whole as showing that imperial Europe's belief in its racial immunity is unfounded. For this dissertation the scene matters as genealogy. In the founding text of the plague genre, the white survivor's continuation passes through a dying Black body; in *The Stand*, so does the white survivors' mission. Chapter 7.1 called this coincidence of theological and social meaning one that neither meaning may absolve. It proves to be as old as the genre.

The ending is the purest image of the lacuna in testimony (7.4). By the novel's close, Verney is alone in Rome with a dog for a companion; he visits libraries and monuments and finds writing materials, by which he writes a book dedicated to the Illustrious Dead. He ascends St Peter's and inscribes on its topmost stone "the aera 2100, last year of the world!", then takes a boat with provisions, his dog, and books including Homer and Shakespeare, and leaves Rome in search of a companion. On his way he leaves messages: in three languages, that Verney, last of the race of Englishmen, had taken up his abode in Rome; and in Italian, "Friend, come! I wait for thee."

The dedication summons the book's only readers: "SHADOWS, ARISE, AND READ YOUR FALL!" The final sentence names its only spectators:

> Thus around the shores of deserted earth, while the sun is high, and the moon waxes or wanes, angels, the spirits of the dead, and the ever-open eye of the Supreme, will behold the tiny bark, freighted with Verney—the LAST MAN.

The last man is a *superstes* without the function of a *testis*. He is a survivor whose testimony has no living addressee: written for the dead, seen only by the ever-open eye. Here Agamben's lacuna is absolute, because the only complete witness is God.

The Stand is built to forbid this solitude. Its *superstites* must go back: Stu and Tom walk east through the winter because the report is owed to Boulder. Verney sails away from the city of the apostles toward nowhere. Stu returns to the community and then to his place of origin. Both men have a dog. The difference between them is the difference between a witness who has someone to tell and one who has only the eye of heaven.

8.3 Two Wheels Before King: *The Scarlet Plague* and *A Canticle for Leibowitz*

A Berkeley school of the end deserves a name.

- Jack London, briefly a student at the university in 1896, made the narrator of *The Scarlet Plague* (serialized 1912; book 1915) a former professor of English literature at the University of California.
- Stewart taught at Berkeley when he wrote *Earth Abides*, whose hero is one of its graduate students (8.1).
- Philip K. Dick opens *Dr. Bloodmoney* in a Berkeley television shop (8.6).
- Le Guin grew up the daughter of the university's most famous anthropologist (8.10).

The university at the western terminus of the continent, beyond which *translatio* could go no further (2.6), became the American imagination's observatory of its own extinction. London's novel, and Walter M. Miller Jr.'s from far outside that school, share the figure of time that King's 1990 coda made his own: the wheel.

London. In 2073, sixty years after the Scarlet Death of 2013, James Howard Smith, called "Granser," tells the story of the plague to grandsons who speak a degraded English and doubt nearly every word. London's socialism demanded a class allegory, and he supplies one. The world had been ruled by a Board of Industrial Magnates. After the plague, a brute called the Chauffeur takes Vesta Van Warden, widow of one of them, as his slave.

The novel's conclusion is the genre's first explicit theory of recurrence. Granser foresees that gunpowder will be rediscovered, that men will multiply and fight, and that civilization will be raised again on the bodies of the many by the old "eternal types—the priest, the soldier, and the king." The triad is older than London: Adalbero of Laon's three orders (*orant, pugnant, laborant*, c. 1030), and later Georges Dumézil's three Indo-European functions (1958). Granser's wheel is a Dumézilian wheel, the eternal return of the three functions.

The Stand divides these functions between its cities. Boulder reconstitutes the first and the third: prophetess and committee, Power Committee and work crews (Figure 3). Las Vegas concentrates the second: the soldier-king with an air force. The 1990 coda's wheel (Figure 1) is Granser's law with one amendment: King's wheel has a hub.

Granser is also a second kind of *superstes* without the function of a *testis*. Verney had no one to tell. Granser has listeners, but they cannot understand him, and they laugh.

Miller. Walter M. Miller Jr. flew combat missions over Italy and took part in the bombing of the Benedictine abbey of Monte Cassino on 15 February 1944. He entered the Catholic Church after the war. *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) can be read as the airman's penance: a novel in which monks preserve what bombers destroyed. Its three parts span eighteen centuries after a nuclear "Flame Deluge" and a "Simplification" in which mobs burned books and murdered the learned.

They are titled *Fiat Homo*, *Fiat Lux*, and *Fiat Voluntas Tua*. The tripartite architecture rhymes with King's three books, and the last titles coincide in sense: "Thy will be done" (Matthew 6:10) is the whole content of Mother Abagail's charge (7.2).

Four of Miller's figures bear directly on King's.

1. **The archive without understanding.** The Albertian Order of Leibowitz copies and illuminates "Memorabilia" it cannot read, among them a blueprint and a grocery list ("Pound pastrami, can kraut, six bagels"). This is Malachi's "book of remembrance" (3:16) as monastic labor. Flagg has lost his memory (5.3). Boulder remembers too fluently, ratifying the Constitution of a dead republic in a single meeting (4.1).
2. **The lamp and the crucifix.** In *Fiat Lux* a monk builds an electric arc lamp in the abbey's cellar library, and to hang it the community must move the crucifix. The light of reason literally displaces the cross. Figure 3's Gelasian diagram is the political form of the same question: Boulder's Power Committee answers to a committee, and the committee to a prophetess. *The Stand* turns the lights back on (4.1) while its prophetess goes into the wilderness (7.1).
3. **Lucifer.** In the third part, the renewal of nuclear testing reaches the abbey as "Lucifer is fallen." Isaiah's taunt-song, "How art thou fallen from heaven, O Lucifer, son of the morning!" (14:12), was "a proverb against the king of Babylon" (14:4). Miller names the bomb after the fallen king; King makes the bomb the instrument of the king's fall. Luke 10:18, read in 7.7 as Satan falling like lightning, is Isaiah 14 fulfilled in the Gospels. *The Stand* fulfills it again in Babylon, through the very weapon Miller christened Lucifer.
4. **The two immortals.** An old Jewish hermit, Benjamin, implied to be the Wandering Jew, appears across the centuries, waiting for the one who is to come. Miller's immortal is a witness who waits at the hub of history. King's immortal is an adversary who walks the rim and wakes on another shore (5.6; Table 8). The two novels frame

their cycles with opposite figures of the undying: patient expectation, and serial evil.

As the second war begins, Miller's abbot asks whether humanity is doomed to "do it again and again and again," and he names the cycle with a bird, the Phoenix. Miller allows the cycle two exits.

- **Vertical and technological:** a starship carries monks and children toward Alpha Centauri under the motto *Quo peregrinatur grex, pastor secum* ("where the flock wanders, the shepherd goes with it").
- **Sacramental:** Rachel, the long-dormant second head of a mutant woman, wakes in the ruins innocent of original sin and gives the dying abbot communion instead of receiving baptism from him.

The Stand refuses both. Its remnant does not leave the earth. Its new child is not preternaturally innocent and not born of the ruins: he is delivered by caesarean in Boulder, catches the flu, and recovers. King's only exit from the wheel is the instant of the Hand, and after it the remnant goes home to Maine.

8.4 The Plague Without a Hand: Camus and Saramago

"Notre XXe siècle est le siècle de la peur," Camus wrote in 1946, in the first article of "Ni victimes ni bourreaux." He then wrote the century's plague twice: as a novel, *La Peste* (1947), and as a play, *L'État de siège* (1948). I propose to read *The Stand* as Camus's diptych compressed into a single book, with Book I as the novel and Book III as the play. The comparison shows exactly where King leaves Camus.

The novel. *La Peste* is a chronicle, and its chronicler reveals himself only at the end. Dr. Rieux says he has written *pour témoigner en faveur de ces pestiférés*, to bear witness on behalf of the plague-stricken. He is a

testis without God (7.4). Every element of Book I has its counterpart in Oran:

- **The failure of the State.** The authorities temporize and refuse to name the disease. King's Starkey and Camus's prefect both hesitate before the word.
- **The prophet.** Father Paneloux's first sermon is the jeremiad in its classic form: *Mes frères, vous êtes dans le malheur, mes frères, vous l'avez mérité.* After he watches a child die, his second sermon demands that one believe everything or deny everything. He dies of an illness that Rieux files as a "doubtful case," having at first refused a doctor. A prophet who withdraws and dies after a crisis of theodicy is Mother Abagail's type in Oran (7.1). Camus refutes the jeremiad that King only restricts (4.6).
- **The two writers.** Joseph Grand, a municipal clerk, spends the epidemic rewriting the first sentence of a novel about an elegant horsewoman in the Bois de Boulogne. Rieux proposes him as the chronicle's insignificant hero, if it must have one. Harold Lauder writes a ledger. The innocent writer cannot get past his first sentence; the guilty one writes fluently toward murder.
- **The profiteer of catastrophe.** Cottard, facing arrest before the epidemic, is happy during it, because everyone now shares his fear. He ends shooting into the street from his window. Harold's ledger opens by calling the catastrophe a "delightful post-Apocalypse summer", which is Cottard's joy written down.
- **Decency.** Rieux tells the journalist Rambert that the struggle is a matter not of heroism but of *honnêteté*. Tarrou asks *peut-on être un saint sans Dieu*. Stu Redman has Rieux's decency without Tarrou's question.
- **Latency.** The chronicle ends on Rieux's knowledge that the bacillus never dies, and that one day *la peste réveillerait ses rats et les enverrait mourir dans une cité heureuse*. Camus's figure of time is latency, the end sleeping in the furniture and the linen. King's coda is a wheel; Camus's is a bacillus.

The play. *L'État de siège* moves from the event to the sovereign. It premiered on 27 October 1948 at the Théâtre Marigny in Paris, directed by Jean-Louis Barrault, with music by Arthur Honegger. In Cádiz, at no defined time, a mysterious illness appears after a comet passes.

- A tyrant who has sprung from nowhere seizes the quiet city, whose Governor wishes only that nothing should happen; the opportunist is named the Plague, and he is accompanied by his secretary, Death.
- She keeps the notebook of erasures from life.
- Under their threats the authorities capitulate or join the Plague within hours, and the city tips into terror.
- As the Governor departs, the play states the transfer of sovereignty in a formula: "Puisqu'il s'en va, c'est la Peste qui est l'État." This is the katechontic inversion of 2.6 and the Las Vegas of 4.4, staged three years after Hiroshima.
- The Plague is aided by henchmen recruited on the spot: a servile official, an accomplished nihilist, and a corrupt judge. The nihilist is Nada, a cynical drunk who resembles Diogenes and whose name means "nothing." He is the nothingness of 5.4 given a speaking part: Lloyd's servility without Lloyd's loyalty. The Secretary's notebook is Harold's ledger made an instrument of state.

The play turns on a confession by Death herself. She admits that « il a toujours suffi qu'un homme surmonte sa peur et se révolte pour que leur machine commence à grincer », and adds that she does not say the machine stops, far from it, but that it creaks, and sometimes really does seize up. The Plague offers to let Victoria live if Diego abandons the struggle and leaves the city; Diego refuses and dies, but his death revives Victoria and frees Cádiz.

The Secretary's sentence describes Flagg's unraveling exactly (5.3). The Judge's head is obliterated through a sentry's disobedience, Dayna dies free, Whitney speaks, and Glen laughs. In each case one person overcomes fear, and the machine creaks. Camus's Death says it does

not stop, and in King it does not stop either: after every failure, Las Vegas still has armor and a spring campaign.

Camus allows that human revolt sometimes jams the machine, and for him that suffices. King agrees that revolt is necessary and denies that it is sufficient. The machine stops only when the Hand takes up the sovereign's own lightning (7.7). This is the decisive theological difference between the two authors, and it can be stated in Camus's own terms. *L'Homme révolté* (1951) opens: *Qu'est-ce qu'un homme révolté? Un homme qui dit non*. The rebel's refusal, Camus continues, *affirme l'existence d'une frontière*. King's middle book is titled "On the Border." The stand is a Camusian revolt: a no that is also a yes, and that draws a line. It is also what Camus would not grant: a revolt whose completion is not human.

Saramago. José Saramago's *Ensaio sobre a cegueira* (1995) radicalizes Camus's immanence. An epidemic of white blindness, a milky sea, falls on a nameless city.

- **The camp.** The State interns the first victims in an empty asylum, guarded by soldiers who shoot those who approach. This is Stovington (2.5) as Agamben's camp. Inside, a ward of armed men seizes the food and then demands the women.
- **The witness.** One woman can see: the doctor's wife, who feigned blindness to follow her husband into quarantine. She is the novel's *testis* in Jerome's exact sense, standing *ad videndum*. The epigraph, from an invented *Livro dos Conselhos*, is her law: *Se podes olhar, vê. Se podes ver, repara* ("If you can look, see. If you can see, observe").
- **The armed hand.** She kills the armed ward's leader with a pair of scissors. Saramago endorses the armed hand that King mocks (Dayna's knife, Table 12).
- **The blindfolded God.** In a church she finds every image with its eyes bandaged, and imagines the priest committing the boldest sacrilege of all time: blinding God because God no longer deserved to see.
- **The dog.** A stray dog attaches itself to her and licks her tears.

- **The return.** Sight returns as inexplicably as it went. When the doctor's wife and her husband ask why they went blind, the answer begins *Não sei*, "I don't know." It ends in her verdict that they are *cegos que, vendo, não vêem*, blind people who see but do not see.
- **The sequel.** In *Ensaio sobre a lucidez* (2004) the State needs a culprit for a "plague" of blank ballots, fixes on the one woman who never lost her sight, and has her killed. The witness becomes the scapegoat. Girard's mechanism returns precisely where no Hand intervenes.

Saramago's white and King's white face each other across the corpus. The "silent white light" of Las Vegas (7.7) and the white sea of the blind are both indiscriminate; neither spares the righteous. For Saramago, indiscriminate whiteness is the human condition made visible, a blindness that was always there. For King, it is the scandal of divine violence, a light that consumes the witness together with the crowd.

Both novels end on "I don't know." Saramago's is the learned ignorance of an atheist who will not explain the plague. King's (C.6) belongs to a novel that has shown the Hand and still declines to explain it.

8.5 Belbury and Babylon: Lewis's *That Hideous Strength*

C. S. Lewis called *That Hideous Strength* (1945) a "tall story" about devilry, with a serious point behind it. He had made the point in *The Abolition of Man* (1943): "Man's conquest of Nature turns out, in the moment of its consummation, to be Nature's conquest of Man."

The N.I.C.E. (National Institute of Co-ordinated Experiments) at Belbury is the first *Bestand*-city in English fiction conceived as a theological object.

- Its scientists vivisect animals and dream of ridding the planet of organic life.
- Its police stage a riot in the university town of Edgestow to justify emergency rule, the manufactured exception of 4.2. Its newly re-

cruited sociologist drafts the newspaper accounts of the riot before it happens.

- Its true directors are disembodied intelligences that speak through the severed, artificially sustained head of an executed scientist, Alcasan. The Head is the counterpart of Flagg's frustrated wish to send Judge Farris's head to Boulder as a message (5.3; 7.4). Lewis's demons speak through a severed head; King's dark man is denied even a head to send.

The correspondences are close enough to count as structural.

- **The oneiric franchise.** Jane Studdock's true dreams, of Alcasan before his execution and of an ancient sleeper under the earth, summon her to the company at St. Anne's, just as the survivors' dreams summon them to Hemingford Home (3.5).
- **Two sociologists.** Jane's husband, Mark Studdock, the sociologist who drafted those riot reports, is a sociologist as Glen Bateman is. He is drawn into Belbury by what Lewis's 1944 lecture called the longing for "the Inner Ring." That longing combines Harold's *amor laudis* (6.2) and Lloyd's loyalty (6.5) in one academic careerist. In Belbury's "Objective Room," a chamber of calculated distortions built to destroy the sense of the normal, the scientist Frost orders Mark to trample a crucifix as an exercise in objectivity. Mark refuses. It is his first free act and the beginning of his conversion. One sociologist refuses to trample, the other refuses to kneel (7.5). Both refusals fix a point that will not be bent.
- **The false priest.** The Reverend Straik, an apostate clergyman, preaches that the N.I.C.E. will bring the Kingdom of God on earth by force. He is Belbury's counterfeit Abagail, the prophet of *Bestand*.
- **The instrument.** The heavenly powers, the planetary intelligences, descend into the revived Merlin. At Belbury's banquet he pronounces the curse of Babel on the technocrats: *Qui Verbum Dei contempserunt, eis auferetur etiam verbum hominis* ("They that have despised the Word of God, from them shall the word of man

also be taken away"). Speech dissolves into gibberish. The animals of the vivisection laboratories break loose among the diners. Frost sets himself on fire, and Edgestow is swallowed by the earth. Here divine violence works through a human vessel. This is the second arm of the chiasmus (7.8): an act of God through a human body, where King has it work through a human weapon.

Lewis's title comes from Sir David Lyndsay's description of the Tower of Babel: "The Shadow of that hyddeous strength / Sax myle and more it is of length." Babel and Babylon are one word in Hebrew, *Bābel*. The city of Genesis 11 is the archetype of the *Bestand*-city: "let us build us a city and a tower, whose top may reach unto heaven; and let us make us a name" (11:4). It is a city that stands itself up.

The two cities are judged by different punishments. Belbury receives Babel's original one, the confusion of tongues. Las Vegas receives Babylon's, the fire of Revelation 18:8. The difference matters, because Lewis's judgment discriminates. The company of St. Anne's is far from Belbury when it falls, as Lot was led out of Sodom before the fire (Genesis 19:16). King's judgment consumes the righteous with the wicked, and Abraham's question at Sodom (Genesis 18:25) receives no rescue (7.7). Of all the works in this chapter, only Lewis grants what King grants, an unveiled divine agency and a judgment. Only King makes the judgment indiscriminate.

8.6 The Survivor as Monster, and the Empire That Never Ended: Matheson and Dick

King has repeatedly named Richard Matheson among his principal influences, and he dedicated *Cell* (2006) to Matheson and George A. Romero. *I Am Legend* (1954) is the last-man novel turned inside out.

Robert Neville survives alone in Los Angeles after a bacillus, spread by dust storms in the wake of war, has turned humanity into vampires. He spends his days staking the sleepers and his nights at a microscope, reducing myth to bacteriology: "myth is already enlightenment" (5.2), in a laboratory. For weeks he coaxes a wounded stray dog into his

house; it dies of the infection days after he wins it. The infected who still live have organized a new society. They capture him, and he understands that to them he is what the vampires were to his kind, the terror that walks by day and kills the sleepers. "Normalcy was a majority concept, the standard of many and not the standard of just one man." The novel ends: "Full circle... I am legend."

Matheson's inversion is the photographic negative of King's.

- In *I Am Legend*, the survivor of the old world becomes the devil of the new.
- In *The Stand*, the walker of the old world is the devil of the new, as he has been of every world (5.6).

Neville is what Flagg would be if Flagg had a self: a solitary killer who becomes legend. The new society founds itself by executing him, which is Girard's founding murder (4.5) in its purest form. Boulder executes no one. Its devil is not put to death by the community; the Hand removes him.

Philip K. Dick's *Dr. Bloodmoney, or How We Got Along After the Bomb* (1965) moves the chiasmus's first arm inside a mind.

- In 1972, Dr. Bruno Bluthgeld (German for "Blood-Money") had led a project testing nuclear weapons, and a miscalculation caused an atmospheric nuclear accident leading to widespread fallout and mutations. When the war comes, Bluthgeld is convinced that he caused the strike in response to a universal conspiracy against him. In Book I, a human artifact wore the appearance of an act of God. In Dick, that appearance becomes a scientist's paranoid conviction that his own mind is the god whose wrath fell.
- The tyrant of the post-war settlement is a disabled man. Hoppy Harrington is a phocomelus with psychokinetic powers and the ability to perfectly imitate voices; having faced discrimination before the war, he seeks power and respect through his work as a mechanic and his plot to replace Walt Dangerfield. He kills Bluthgeld, and one character begins to worry that he will set himself up as a vindictive little tin god.

- He is undone from inside a child. Bill, who also has psychic powers, uses them to transfer minds with Hoppy, which kills the novel's antagonist. Bill is a homunculus twin living inside his sister Edie's body.

The Stand's disabled and simple figures are thus redistributed. Nick Andros, whose body denies him a voice, becomes his community's *logos* (4.3). Hoppy, who can imitate any voice, becomes his community's sovereign. Tom Cullen, unseen by the Eye (5.3), is the type of Bill, unseen inside a child, who undoes the tyrant.

Dick's community is constituted by a voice from the sky. Walt Dangerfield's satellite broadcasts serve as a crucial link for the fractured community, providing a sense of unity through music and literature; the community gathers to hear him transmit a reading of Maugham's *Of Human Bondage* from orbit. This is the Free Zone's radio call-sign (4.1) and Mother Abagail's dreams (3.5) remade as a disc jockey. Like Stewart's Tribe, Dick's settlement kills: it feels free to execute Mr. Austurias for "lying," believing he joined the community to seek out and kill Bluthgeld. And Bluthgeld's dog Terry is capable of imitating simple human speech: the animal witness reduced to mimicry.

Dick returned to the human authorship of wrath twice more.

- In *Deus Irae* (1976, with Roger Zelazny), post-war believers worship the man who launched the war as the God of Wrath, and a limbless painter is sent across the wasteland to find his face for a mural. The chiasmus's first arm, the artifact received as divine wrath, here becomes a church. *The Stand* refuses that church in its restricted jeremiad (4.6).
- In *VALIS* (1981), Dick compressed his late gnosis into a sentence that answers Starkey's code word (2.6) directly. The Universalization Order says "Rome falls." Dick says "The Empire never ended." The Conclusion's reading of Boulder's new sheriff arming the police (C.3) will side with Dick.

Dick also supplies, in a lecture of 1978, the cleanest available test of Chapter 5's thesis: "Reality is that which, when you stop believing in it,

doesn't go away." Apply it to the dark man. Glen Bateman stops believing ("We made such a business of you!"), and the business falters. By Dick's criterion Flagg is not reality but privation sustained by belief (5.4). The Hand arrives from the opposite direction. No one in Las Vegas believes in it until Ralph cries out and points (7.7). By the same criterion, it is real.

8.7 The Counter-Text: Octavia E. Butler's *Parables*

If any work in this corpus is *The Stand*'s counter-text, it is Octavia E. Butler's diptych, *Parable of the Sower* (1993) and *Parable of the Talents* (1998). It answers the novel's theology and its politics, and above all the problem that 7.1 left open.

Lauren Oya Olamina is a Black teenager, a Baptist minister's daughter, living in a walled enclave outside Los Angeles in 2024. Society is collapsing slowly and from many causes: climate, debt, privatization, and a drug called "pyro" that makes watching fire more pleasurable than sex. Its users, the "paints," burn neighborhoods for the ecstasy of the blaze. This is the Trashcan Man (6.6) as a social epidemic, Bachelard's two complexes as a market. When the enclave burns, Lauren walks north on the freeway with a growing multiracial band. In Humboldt County she founds a community, Acorn, on the faith she has been composing in her journal: Earthseed, whose first verse ends "God is Change."

Each element answers *The Stand* point for point.

The prophetess. Mother Abagail is a Black woman whose prophecy serves white survivors, whose veto an all-white committee manages, and who dies so that their mission can begin (7.1). Lauren writes her own scripture, founds her own community, narrates her own story, marries, bears a child, carries a gun, and lives into old age to see her vision begin to be realized. Butler answers the trope with a construction rather than a critique. Where King's novel needs a prophetess, Butler's needs a founder, and she gives that founder authority and authorship at once: the *auctoritas* of 4.2 and the *auctor* of Table 11 in one woman.

The journal. Fran Goldsmith's journal is written forward, to a child (3.2). Lauren's is written forward, to a people, and becomes scripture: *Earthseed: The Books of the Living*. Harold's ledger, Fran's journal, and Lauren's Books are the three ways of writing in a catastrophe the literature of the end knows: grievance, love, and foundation.

The theology. "God is Change" is the direct antithesis of Malachi 3:6: "For I am the LORD, I change not; therefore ye sons of Jacob are not consumed." It is also the antithesis of the stand. Earthseed's deity is the wheel itself, made an object of faith, and its ethic is to shape change, not to withstand it. The stand resists the wheel for an instant. Earthseed rides the wheel and gives it an outward direction: its Destiny is to take root among the stars, as Miller's starship does (8.3).

The arms. Lauren is armed and kills when she must; Butler's realism refuses King's kenotic disarmament (7.2). In *Parable of the Talents*, her armed community is crushed by a larger armed power.

- President Andrew Steele Jarret's "Christian America" campaigns under "Make America Great Again." The slogan's later career has given Butler a reputation for prophecy she never sought.
- His Crusaders seize Acorn, turn it into "Camp Christian," and hold its members in electronic slave collars. Boulder's civil religion of anthem and Constitution (4.1), Winthrop's city upon a hill (4.6), turns into a camp. This is the dark future of the American jeremiad at which 4.6 could only gesture.
- Lauren's daughter is taken and raised inside Christian America, and in the frame narration she judges her mother. The heart of the child is not turned to the parent: Malachi 4:6 fails.

The sower. Butler's title is the parable of Matthew 13 and Luke 8, whose first loss is the seed that "fell by the way side" (Luke 8:5). Chapter 7.3 read Mother Abagail's prophecy that one of the four would "fall by the way" through this verse, and promised to return to it here.

- In King, the seed that falls by the way is not devoured, because a dog keeps watch beside it.

- In Butler, seeds are trampled, devoured, and choked, and some fall on good ground, which is the only miracle the parable promises.

The Stand's providence is a Hand. Butler's is a harvest, won within and against what Rob Nixon would later call "slow violence," without a single instant of grace. In the economy of witness (Table 11), Lauren is the *auctor* who is never consumed. In the typology of ends (8.11), she holds a place no other figure in the corpus occupies: a founder whose founding does not repeat the old constitution. Butler asks King's last question, whether people ever learn, and gives a qualified yes that King withholds.

8.8 Carrying the Fire: McCarthy's *The Road*

Cormac McCarthy's *The Road* (2006) begins where *The Stand* ends. Its catastrophe is a light: the clocks stop at 1:17, there is a long shear of light, then low concussions. Its cause is never given. In Greek, *apokalypsis* means "unveiling," and *The Road* is an apocalypse without *apokalypsis*: the end without revelation. *The Stand* gives its reader the opposite: one instant of revelation, the Hand unveiled over Las Vegas, after which the narrative must continue without it.

What remains after McCarthy's light is a father and son walking south through ash, a moral community of two. They are "the good guys," and they are "carrying the fire." Their enemy is cannibalism: the Lykaian wolf of 5.5 made into a social order, Lloyd at Trask's leg (6.5) extended across a continent. The mother has already chosen death. The father keeps a pistol with two cartridges, later one, reserved for the boy.

The prophet of this world is an old man on the road, the novel's only named character, who says, "There is no God and we are his prophets." Mother Abagail prays into a dead phone and returns from the wilderness with a command (7.1). Ely is the prophet of the dead phone itself: he prophesies the silence.

The father's heart is wholly turned to his child, as Malachi 4:6 asks. In the opening pages he holds the boy as his warrant: "If he is not the word of God God never spoke." The child is the *logos*, as Nick's notes

were (4.3) and as Tom's hypnotic self, "God's Tom," was (5.3). When the father dies, a family that says it too is carrying the fire takes the boy in. The woman speaks to him of God; he speaks instead to his father, and does not forget. The minimal Boulder of *The Road* is a single household.

"Carrying" names a posture distinct from standing, and Latin shows why the distinction matters here. *Tradere*, "to hand over," yields both *traditio* (tradition) and *traditor* (traitor). The Vulgate names Judas *qui et tradidit eum*, "who also betrayed him" (Matthew 10:4). The literature of the end is about what is handed on. *The Stand* is about both what is handed on and what is handed over: Harold hands over the committee (6.3); Tom carries the fallen witness, and the report, home. McCarthy keeps only the handing-on, with a father's pistol held in reserve.

McCarthy's earlier masterpiece completes the comparison. *Blood Meridian* (1985) gave American fiction its other walking adversary, Judge Holden: huge, hairless, polyglot. Holden declares that "whatever in creation exists without my knowledge exists without my consent," and at the novel's end he dances, saying that he will never die. He is Flagg's nearest literary sibling (Table 8). His sentence about knowledge and consent is the Panopticon of 5.3 as a theory of property: to know everything is to own it.

McCarthy thus splits King's two figures between two novels: the walking adversary who never dies, and the carried child who might. *The Stand* holds both in one book and adds a third term McCarthy never grants, the Hand. McCarthy ends with brook trout in mountain streams, their backs patterned with maps of the world in its becoming, a thing that could not be put back or made right again. That figure of time is an irreversible line. King's coda says the wheel always comes round to the same place again. McCarthy says nothing comes round.

8.9 Survival Is Insufficient: Mandel's *Station Eleven*

Emily St. John Mandel's *Station Eleven* (2014) descends from Boccaccio's *brigata* (2.4). Twenty years after the Georgia Flu, the Traveling Symphony carries Shakespeare and music among the settlements of the Great Lakes, and its lead caravan bears a line from *Star Trek: Voyager*: "Survival is insufficient." The sentence is this chapter's most compact statement of a problem *The Stand* solves differently. Survival makes a *superstes*, and something more is required. For Mandel the more is art; for King it is testimony.

Mandel's antagonist is Flagg demythologized. The Prophet is Tyler Leander, son of a film star who died on stage playing King Lear the night the flu arrived.

- His mother believed the Georgia Flu was a form of divine judgment and that she and her son had survived for a reason.
- As the Prophet he preaches that everything happens for a reason and calls the epidemic a "cleansing." He runs his town as a cult leader and takes child brides. He has a dog named Luli.
- He preaches in lines from the *Dr. Eleven* comics, which his father had once sent him. After his death his New Testament is recovered, its margins full of his notes, with a single page from the first issue of *Dr. Eleven*.
- While his father led a cult of personality as a celebrity, Tyler becomes a literal cult leader.

His doctrine is exactly the theodicy that Book I forecloses (2.3). King severs cause from meaning, so that the plague is a human artifact and not a judgment. The Prophet fuses them again, making the dead impure and the living elect.

The Prophet's death answers the Hand with a hand. A younger cult sentry, having a crisis of faith, shoots and kills the Prophet before taking his own life. The false prophet dies by his own follower's apostasy, the apostasy Lloyd never commits (6.5). Kirsten then puts the folded page of *Dr. Eleven* in the dead man's hand, a mercy the witness extends

to the false prophet that *The Stand* never extends to Flagg, who simply vanishes. She adopts the Prophet's dog, Luli. The dog's name has passed from the life of the comic's creator into the comic, from the comic to the Prophet's dog, and from the Prophet to the witness: from art into life, and from the false prophet to the true survivor.

Mandel's final images place the novel within this chapter's coordinates. At the airport where the Prophet's mother had sheltered, another survivor has created a Museum of Civilization featuring artifacts from the time before the collapse. An airport is the type of Marc Augé's *non-lieu*, the place without memory, and the Museum converts it into a *lieu de mémoire* in Pierre Nora's sense. It is Malachi's "book of remembrance" (3:16), shelved in a terminal. From the airport's control tower, through a telescope, the curator shows Kirsten a town to the south with electric lights, suggesting that civilization is beginning to take root again.

The novel ends where Boulder began, with the lights coming back on (4.1). *The Stand* takes the step *Station Eleven* does not: in Boulder the lights come back, and so do the guns (C.3).

8.10 The Lathe of Heaven and the Ones Who Walk Away: Le Guin

The anthropologist who brought Ishi to the University of California's museum in 1911 (8.1) was Alfred Kroeber. His wife, Theodora Kroeber, wrote *Ishi in Two Worlds* (1961). Their daughter, Ursula K. Le Guin, grew up in the household where the last man of the Yahi remained a remembered presence. Her two contributions to this chapter's typology are among its most exact.

***The Lathe of Heaven* (1971)** gives the plague a dreamer. George Orr's dreams change reality, retroactively. His psychiatrist, the utilitarian dream researcher William Haber, uses a machine to steer those dreams toward improving the world. Told to dream away overpopulation, Orr dreams a world in which a plague killed billions decades earlier. The plague is the benevolent technocrat's dream: *Bestand*-thinking

(2.2) achieving through the unconscious what Project Blue achieved through the laboratory.

Orr himself practices *wu wei*, action without forcing, and wants only to stop dreaming effectively. He is Heidegger's *Gelassenheit* (7.3) in the person of a Portland draftsman, and Stu's posture in the ravine.

Le Guin's epigraph, from Zhuangzi 23, reads: "To let understanding stop at what cannot be understood is a high attainment. Those who cannot do it will be destroyed on the lathe of heaven." The Chinese behind "lathe" is *tiān jūn* (天鈞), Heaven's potter's wheel. Zhuangzi 2 sets the sage at rest upon it (休乎天鈞). The same chapter names the "pivot of the Way" (道樞), which, once set in "the center of the ring" (環中), responds without end. From the far end of Eurasia, Le Guin's title thus supplies both figures with which this dissertation must conclude: the wheel with its still hub (Figure 1; C.5), and an understanding that stops at what it cannot understand, the "I don't know" (C.6).

"The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) is subtitled "Variations on a theme by William James." The theme is a hypothesis from James's "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891): millions kept permanently happy on the single condition that "a certain lost soul on the far-off edge of things should lead a life of lonely torture." James held that the hideousness of accepting such a bargain is felt at once, before any calculation. Le Guin found her city's name by reading "Salem, Oregon" backward on a road sign, and she made the hypothesis a city.

The happiness of Omelas depends on a child kept in filth in a cellar, whom every citizen is shown once. Most accept the bargain. A few walk away, alone, toward a place the narrator cannot describe. Behind the story stands Ivan Karamazov, who returns his ticket to a harmony bought with one child's tears; behind Ivan stands Girard's founding victim (4.5).

The story maps precisely onto the dissertation's two cities and its witnesses.

- **Omelas** hides its single victim. **Las Vegas** displays its many on crosses along the boulevard: mythic violence that threatens (7.7).
- **The walkers of Omelas** refuse complicity by exit, Hirschman's first term (6.1), and walk alone. **Mother Abagail's four** walk together toward the city of crosses in order to testify against it.
- Le Guin's walkers leave; King's arrive. Both are unarmed, and both walk.

Boulder appears to have no cellar. The Conclusion (C.4) will ask whether the moment its new sheriff arms the police is the moment the cellar is dug, and whether Stu and Frannie, carrying their son east to Maine, are the ones who walk away from Boulder.

8.11 A Typology of Ends

Malachi's chapters, set out at the head of this chapter as its method, can now be set beside the works that occupy them.

Four Greek terms make the comparison exact:

- ***Katastrophē***: the overturning, the end as event.
- ***Apokalypsis***: the unveiling of the agency behind the end.
- ***Krisis***: judgment, the separation of righteous from wicked.
- ***Chiliasmos***: a restored order of peace after the end.

Every work in the corpus has a *katastrophē*; that is what places it in the corpus. The works differ in what they add.

Figure 5

Malachi 3–4 (Hebrew 3:1–24) as the generative matrix of the literature of the end



Malachi 3–4 (Hebrew 3:1–24) as the generative matrix of the literature of the end. Each verse names a co-ordinate, and each work occupies one or more of them. The Stand occupies more than any other single work: seven of the eight.

Table 14 A typology of ends

Work	Cause of the end	*Apokalypsis*	*Krisis*	Posture of the survivor	Figure of time
Shelley, *The Last Man* (1826)	Plague under cosmic portents (a black sun)	None: prophecy is impossible	None	Abiding alone; writing for the dead	A line to extinction: apocalypse without millennium
London, *The Scarlet Plague* (1912)	A natural bacillus	None	None	Remembering, unheeded	A cycle: priest, soldier, and king return
Lewis, *That Hideous Strength* (1945)	Technocracy possessed	Yes: the planetary powers	Yes, discriminating	Refusing; obeying (St. Anne's)	Recurrent war of Logres and Britain
Camus, *La Peste* (1947); *L'État de siège* (1948)	Plague; the Plague as tyrant	Refused	Refused (Paneloux)	Decency; chronicle; revolt	Latency: the bacillus sleeps
Stewart, *Earth Abides* (1949)	A natural virus	Ecological law only	None (Ish's unanswered doubt)	Abiding: the earth stands	Slow *ricorso*; geological time
Matheson, *I Am Legend* (1954)	A bacillus after war	Scientific, not divine	Inverted: the new society judges the last man	Hunting; becoming legend	"Full circle"
Miller, *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959)	Nuclear war, twice	None within history	None within history	Preserving; waiting	Phoenix cycle, with exits to the stars and to grace
Dick, *Dr. Bloodmoney* (1965)	Nuclear accident and war	Paranoid: the scientist believes he is the cause	None: a hidden twin deposes the tyrant	Listening; repairing	Bricolage
Le Guin, *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971); "Omelas" (1973)	A dreamed plague; a hidden victim	None	None	Releasement; walking away	The potter's wheel of heaven
King, *The Stand* (1978/1990)	An engineered plague	Yes, for one instant: the Hand	Yes, indiscriminate	Standing: testimony	A wheel with a hub; *kairos*
Butler, *Parable of the Sower* (1993); *Talents* (1998)	Slow collapse from many causes	None	None	Founding; shaping change	A spiral outward: "God is Change"

Work	Cause of the end	*Apokalypsis*	*Krisis*	Posture of the survivor	Figure of time
Saramago, *Ensaio sobre a cegueira* (1995)	White blindness, unexplained	None: "Não sei"	None	Seeing	Return of sight without explanation
McCarthy, *The Road* (2006)	An unexplained light	None	None	Carrying the fire	An irreversible line
Mandel, *Station Eleven* (2014)	A natural influenza	None: the "cleansing" is refuted	None: a boy's hand	Performing; archiving	Recovery: lights to the south

The animals of the corpus form a second, quieter typology. Emmanuel Levinas told of Bobby, a stray dog who appeared at the forced-labor camp where he was held as a Jewish prisoner of war. The guards treated the prisoners as subhuman, but each evening Bobby greeted them with joy, as men. Levinas called him "the last Kantian in Nazi Germany" ("Nom d'un chien ou le droit naturel," 1975). The dog is the witness's witness, the one who recognizes the human when the human order has ceased to. Argos, who knew Odysseus through his disguise (2.2), is the type.

Table 15 **The animal witness in the literature of the end**

Work	Animal	Office	Fate
Homer, *Odyssey* 17	Argos	Alone recognizes the disguised master	Dies at the moment of recognition
Shelley, *The Last Man* (1826)	A sheepdog met on the road to Rome	Last companion of the last man	Embarks with him, with Homer and Shakespeare
Lewis, *That Hideous Strength* (1945)	Mr. Bultitude, a bear	Household animal of St. Anne's, seized for Belbury's laboratories	Loosed with the menagerie on the technocrats' banquet
Stewart, *Earth Abides* (1949)	Princess	Adopts Ish in the empty city	Companion of the solitary phase, before the Tribe
Matheson, *I Am Legend* (1954)	A stray	The last man's last attempt at companionship	Dies of the infection days after it is won
Dick, *Dr. Bloodmoney* (1965)	Terry, Bluthgeld's dog	Imitates human speech	Mimicry without *logos*

Work	Animal	Office	Fate
Levinas, "Nom d'un chien" (1975)	Bobby	Greets prisoners as men	Driven off by the guards
King, *The Stand* (1978/1990)	Kojak, formerly Big Steve	Fights the wolves; crosses the continent; hunts for and guards the fallen witness	Lives sixteen more years; a female is found
Saramago, *Ensaio sobre a cegueira* (1995)	The dog of tears	Licks the tears of the one who sees	Stays with the witness
McCarthy, *The Road* (2006)	A dog heard, never seen	The boy begs that it be spared	Never found
Mandel, *Station Eleven* (2014)	Luli	Passes from art into life, and from the false prophet to the witness	Adopted by Kirsten

In each work the dog's fate indexes the work's judgment on whether community is possible:

- **Matheson's dog dies:** there will be no community for the last man.
- **Shelley's embarks:** community exists only as hope, across a sea.
- **McCarthy's is never found:** the companion is withheld.
- **Mandel's passes from the false prophet to the witness:** the community reclaims what the false prophet had taken.
- **Kojak lives sixteen years, and a female is found:** the novel's most concrete promise is canine. Before anyone in Boulder knows whether people ever learn, the novel has guaranteed that there will be dogs.

The comparison yields five findings.

1. **Of the fourteen entries in Table 14, only two grant both *apokalypsis* and *krisis*: Lewis's and King's.** Only King makes the judgment indiscriminate. Saramago's whiteness is equally indiscriminate, but it is neither unveiled nor a judgment. Lewis's judgment is unveiled, but it discriminates. *The Stand*'s scandal, a revealed divine judgment that does not spare the just (7.7), belongs to it alone.

2. ***The Stand* is the hinge between the novel of abiding and the novel of witness.** Before 1978, the canonical answers to Malachi's questions belong to the earth (Stewart), the last man (Shelley), and the unheeded elder (London). After 1978, they belong to the seeing woman (Saramago), the founder (Butler), the carrier (McCarthy), and the performer (Mandel). King's novel turns the survivor from *superstes* into *testis*: from one who outlives into one who stands in order to see and to tell. The turn is built into its design. Its last *superstites* must return to Boulder to make their report (7.3–7.4), against Verney's solitary bark and Ish's last thought of the abiding earth.
3. ***The Stand* is the only work in the corpus that contains all seven postures and ranks them:**
   - **Abiding:** the earth and the dog, Kojak's sixteen years.
   - **Preserving:** Fran's journal; the ratified Constitution.
   - **Founding:** Boulder.
   - **Performing:** Larry's song; the anthem at Chautauqua.
   - **Carrying:** Tom bearing the fallen witness east.
   - **Walking away:** Stu and Frannie at the end (C.4).
   - **Standing:** the four.

   Only the last reaches the hub. The other six are necessary to the human world, and none of them escapes its *stasis*. This is the comparative proof of the thesis stated in the Introduction: only testimony escapes the wheel, and only for an instant.
4. ***The Stand* alone joins the corpus's two undying figures to a single Hand.** Miller's Wandering Jew waits at the hub of history. McCarthy's Judge dances at its rim, as Flagg walks it. King keeps the dancer on the rim, puts the Hand at the hub, and lets the witnesses reach it for a single instant.
5. **The novel ends on the penultimate.** Malachi ends on *ḥērem*. Ecclesiastes ends on judgment: "For God shall bring every work into judgment... whether it be good, or whether it be evil" (12:14). Jewish liturgical custom lets neither book end there. When they are

read aloud, the penultimate verse is repeated after the last. For Ecclesiastes this is "Fear God, and keep his commandments: for this is the whole duty of man" (12:13). For Malachi it is the promise of Elijah (4:5; Hebrew 3:23). Isaiah and Lamentations, the other books under the mnemonic יתק"ק, are read the same way: at the end, the reader turns back to the verse before the end.

This is the liturgical form of the 1990 coda, the wheel that "always, at the end, came round to the same place again." It is also where King's last chapter stands. After the ultimate, the Hand, comes a return to the penultimate: a child, a dog, a road east, and a question. Dietrich Bonhoeffer, writing his *Ethik* in the years before his execution at Flossenbürg on 9 April 1945, distinguished *die letzten und die vorletzten Dinge*, the last things and the things before the last. He held that the penultimate must be preserved for the sake of the ultimate, as the preparing of a way. That is Malachi's own verb: "he shall prepare the way before me" (3:1). Boulder after the Hand is the penultimate, preserved. Whether it prepares any way is the question the Conclusion must take up. The novel does not answer it.





Conclusion

The Hub of the Wheel

Witness, Natality, and Learned Ignorance

It shall be established for ever as the moon, and as a faithful witness in heaven. Selah.

(Psalm 89:37)

ἀλλὰ γὰρ ἤδη ὥρα ἀπιέναι, ἐμοὶ μὲν ἀποθανουμένῳ, ὑμῖν δὲ βιωσομένοις· ὁπότεροι δὲ ἡμῶν ἔρχονται ἐπὶ ἄμεινον πρᾶγμα, ἄδηλον παντὶ πλὴν ἢ τῷ θεῷ.

[*But now it is time to go away, I to die and you to live. Which of us goes to the better thing is unclear to everyone except the god.*]

(Plato, *Apology* 42a)

The preceding chapters followed *The Stand* up to its instant. The Conclusion follows it past that instant, because the novel itself does not stop there. The apocalypses it inherits end in judgment; this one does not. The Hand consumes Las Vegas in a light that no human witness survives to report whole (7.4; 7.7), and then the story runs on for most of a year. These are the least studied pages in the book. In them a simple-minded man carries a sick one across the Utah winter. An infant catches the superflu and lives. The Free Zone grows to the size of a county seat and arms its deputies. A man and a woman leave for Maine, stop on a dead prophetess's porch, and exchange a question for a confession of ignorance. In 1990 the adversary wakes on a beach, and the narrator lays down the wheel.

These pages do not trail after the argument. They test it. If the stand is the only posture that escapes the wheel of *stasis*, and escapes it only for an instant (Introduction; 8.11), then the pages after the instant must do two things: show the wheel turning again, and show what the instant left behind. Seven things remain:

1. an unseen witness (C.1);
2. a child and a stone (C.2);
3. a standing army (C.3);

4. a departure (C.4);
5. a hub (C.5);
6. a sentence of ignorance (C.6);
7. a reader (C.7).

C.1 The Faithful Witness in Heaven: Tom Cullen and the Theology of the Unseen

No figure in *The Stand* has been reduced to a device more often than Tom Cullen, and none is more central to its theology. King gives him a childish idiom, peppered with "My laws!" and "Laws, yes!", a habit of referring to himself in the third person, and the belief that whatever matters is spelled "M-O-O-N." King also gives him a second self. Nick, Stu, and Glen hypnotize him to plant the post-hypnotic suggestion that will make him the Free Zone's third spy. Under hypnosis they find that he has the same kind of foresight as Mother Abagail, and that he calls himself both the Tom whom Nick met in Oklahoma and "God's Tom."

The committee's use of Tom is Boulder's one unambiguous act of instrumental reason, and the novel does not hide what it costs. Kant forbids using humanity, in one's own person or in another's, *niemals bloß als Mittel*, "never merely as a means" (*Grundlegung*, AA 4:429). Everything depends on *bloß*. The committee meant to use a means. In trance it met a person larger than the one it had planned to use: the instrument turned out to be a prophet.

The cover story the trance installs is nonetheless damning. Tom is to convince himself, almost, that the Free Zone drove him out so that he would not father a child who might be born like him. The lie is credible in Las Vegas because it was once law in America. *Buck v. Bell* (1927) upheld Virginia's compulsory sterilization statute with Holmes's sentence "Three generations of imbeciles are enough," and some sixty thousand Americans were sterilized under such laws. Boulder needed a story the dark man's city would believe, so it imagined itself as the old republic at

its most eugenic. That plausibility is the first room of the cellar that C. 4 goes looking for.

In Las Vegas the Eye cannot find him. Flagg tells Dayna Jurgens that every time he tries to see the third spy, all he sees is the moon, which confirms Dayna's own earlier sighting of Tom on the work crews. Dayna kills herself rather than submit to further questioning. When the full moon rises over Las Vegas, it triggers Tom's post-hypnotic suggestion, and he starts back to Boulder with "M-O-O-N, that spells moon."

The Eye's blindness is categorical, not accidental. Chapter 5 identified the Eye as *Gestell* personified (5.3): a seeing that reveals everything as standing-reserve, available on call. Such a seeing cannot reveal what has no place in the order of call. Tom is the one survivor whom no inventory would count. He cannot be employed or conscripted, and the eugenic state would have culled him. His surname sounds the verb itself: *cull*, from Old French *cuillir*, from Latin *colligere*, "to gather, to select." Paul's account of election ends on exactly this ontology. God chose "things which are not, to bring to nought things that are" (*τὰ μὴ ὄντα, ἵνα τὰ ὄντα καταργήσῃ*, 1 Cor 1:28). The dark man is privation (5.4), and privation registers only what the world counts. The man the world does not count is simply not there for the Eye.

What Flagg sees instead is the most overdetermined image the novel could have chosen. Three traditions converge on it.

1. **The Psalter's witness.** Psalm 89 promises that David's throne "shall be established for ever as the moon, and as a faithful witness in heaven" (89:37). The Hebrew, *kəyārēaḥ yikkôn ʿôlām wəʿēd baššaḥaq neʾĕmān*, gives the moon two offices. It is what is established (*yikkôn*, from *kûn*, "to stand firm," a verb of standing that Table 3 must now admit), and it is the *ʿēd*, the witness. Flagg goes looking for the third witness and finds the Psalter's emblem of faithful testimony.
2. **The fathers' *mysterium lunae*.** Ambrose wrote that the Church shines *non suo sed Christi lumine*, "not with her own light but with Christ's" (*Exameron* IV.8.32). Hugo Rahner gathered this

patristic tradition under the name *mysterium lunae*. A moon is a mirror. Where Tom should be, the Eye meets reflected light, the borrowed shining of a sun the dark man cannot look at.

3. **Fortune's moon.** *O Fortuna, / velut luna / statu variabilis*: "O Fortune, like the moon, variable in *status*" (*Carmina Burana* 17). Tom is the man the wheel of Fortune set lowest, as low in *status* as a survivor can sit.

The moon therefore joins two things this dissertation has kept apart until now: the wheel (Figure 1) and the witness (Table 11). The man at the bottom of the rim is the witness established for ever.

The theological tradition sets a second gaze against the Eye. In 1453 Nicholas of Cusa sent the monks of Tegernsee a painted face *omnia videntis*, whose eyes follow every beholder as if each were the only one. The accompanying treatise names what such a gaze is: *videre tuum est amare*, "your seeing is loving" (*De visione Dei* 4). The novel's two gazes divide exactly along Cusanus's line. The gaze that orders cannot see Tom. The gaze that loves sees "God's Tom."

Tom then becomes the carrier of the last witness. He finds Stu suffering from pneumonia in both lungs. The two shelter in a hunting lodge in Green River, Utah, where Tom treats the pneumonia on the advice of Nick's ghost, who helps him find antibiotics and tells him how to nurse Stu back to health. Stu fights the pneumonia for two weeks. They wait out the month in a Holiday Inn, find a snowmobile, crash it, and continue the trek back to Boulder.

The scene of the medicine is the novel's own commentary on the *Phaedrus*. There Theuth offers writing as a *pharmakon* for memory, and Thamus answers that it is a drug for reminding, not for remembering (274c–275b). Derrida built "La pharmacie de Platon" on that ambiguity. In King the *logos* had been split between two men:

- **Nick** is writing without voice: deaf, mute, a man of notes.
- **Tom** is voice without letters.

The dead writer, who "being dead yet speaketh" (Heb 11:4; 4.3), prescribes the *pharmakon*, and the unlettered speaker administers it. Writ-

ing heals because it is joined to the one person the old world declared unable to read it.

Chapter 7.4 called Tom the *Rachel* of Melville's epilogue, "the devious-cruising Rachel, that in her retracing search after her missing children, only found another orphan." The comparison now completes itself. The man the Free Zone used, and sent away under a story of expulsion, carries its last witness home: "The stone which the builders refused is become the head stone of the corner" (Ps 118:22). C.2 begins from that stone.

C.2 Peter, Natality, and the Rock

Book III contains two miracles, and only one of them is visible. Everyone sees the Hand for an instant. Almost no one sees the second. Fran's son is named Peter, after his grandfather. He is the first baby born in the Free Zone to survive the plague. When he catches the superflu and recovers, he proves that babies born to immune parents can develop resistance to the virus. Everything after the Hand depends on that recovery, because a remnant that cannot reproduce itself is only a delay. By the last chapter, Fran is pregnant again, with Stu as the father.

The adversary has no such future. His heir died with Nadine when he threw her from the penthouse (6.4). Natality is the asymmetry that the duel between Boulder and Las Vegas concealed. Tom says the dark man "came out of time." As far as the novel lets us know, then, he was never born, and a being who was never born can recur but cannot begin. His serial returns (5.6) are repetitions without an origin.

Arendt staked her political thought on this difference. *The Human Condition* calls natality the miracle that saves the world of human affairs from its natural ruin. It reads the Gospel announcement "A child has been born unto us" as the most succinct expression of faith in the world (§34). The 1958 edition of *The Origins of Totalitarianism* closes on the claim that "every end in history necessarily contains a new beginning." Its warrant is Augustine: *initium ut esset, creatus est homo, ante quem nullus fuit*, "that there might be a beginning, man was cre-

ated, before whom there was none" (*De civitate Dei* XII.21). *The Stand* turns Arendt's sentence into plot. The end of history in Las Vegas contains a beginning in Boulder, and that beginning nearly dies of the plague that ended history.

The child's name opens onto a constellation the novel never remarks on and everywhere assumes. The good city is named for a stone. The bad city is named for grass: *las vegas*, "the meadows," after the spring-fed pastures of a desert valley. Scripture had already sorted stone and grass into opposite fates.

- **The grass.** Isaiah writes: "The grass withereth, the flower fadeth: because the spirit of the LORD bloweth upon it: surely the people is grass... but the word of our God shall stand for ever" (Isa 40:7–8). The First Epistle of Peter quotes the passage (1 Pet 1:24–25).
- **The refraction of its last verb.** The versions split this verb exactly as Table 13 recorded for Malachi.
  - Hebrew *yāqûm* means "shall rise, shall stand."
  - The Septuagint renders it *μένει*, "abides."
  - The Vulgate has *stabit* in Isaiah and *manet* in Peter.
  - The King James Version has "shall stand" in Isaiah and "endureth" in Peter.

  One sentence, in two Testaments, is once standing and once abiding.
- **The wind.** Isaiah's grass withers because the *rûaḥ* of the LORD blows on it. In King's account of the novel's origin, a reporter remarked of the Utah chemical accident that "If the winds had been blowing the other way, there was Salt Lake City." Hebrew has a single word for the wind that is chance and the wind that is spirit. This is the scriptural ground of the horizontal theology set out in the Introduction.
- **Rock and sand.** The house "founded upon a rock" stands. The house on sand falls, "and great was the fall of it" (Matt 7:24–27). Las Vegas is the house on sand. Its electricity came from a dam first named for the other city (4.4).

Table 16 Stone and grass: the lithic constellation of *The Stand*

Term	In the novel	Text	Reading
Boulder	The Free Zone, a city named for stone	Matt 7:24–25	The house "founded upon a rock"
Las Vegas, "the meadows"	The dark man's city, raised on desert sand	Isa 40:6–8; Matt 7:26–27; 1 Pet 1:24	Grass that withers when the *rûaḥ* blows; the house whose fall is great
Peter	Fran's son; the first Free Zone child to survive; sickens and recovers	Matt 16:18	Natality as foundation
Leo Rockway	The mute boy "Joe," who gives his true name at Mother Abagail's farm	Rev 2:17	The name restored with the voice
The black stone with the red flaw	The dark man's token to his lieutenants (6.5)	Rev 2:17, inverted	Investiture without a name: the white stone bears "a new name written"; the black stone bears none
Tom Cullen	The man sent west under a story of expulsion	Ps 118:22; 1 Pet 2:7	The rejected stone made head of the corner
Hugh Petrella	The Marshal who campaigned for the star; the deputies armed	Matt 26:52	The little rock of force
The Hand	Judgment over Las Vegas	Dan 2:34, 45	The stone "cut out without hands" that smites the image (7.5)

On reaching Mother Abagail's farm, the boy Nadine called "Joe" introduces himself as Leo Rockway, which upsets Nadine. The lithic names are scattered through the novel the way the forms of **steh₂-* are scattered through its lexicon (Table 3). The pattern does not depend on intention, and it comes to its crisis in the closing chapters. Stu's successor as Marshal of the Free Zone is Hugh Petrella. *Petrella* is the Italian diminutive of *petra*: "little rock." The novel's last founding is therefore divided between two rocks, the child carried east and the officer who stays.

Matthew 16:18 asks which rock the *ekklēsia* will be built on. In Boulder, whose constitution began as a town meeting (4.1), the question is literal. The Petrine tradition supplies the criterion.

- **Peter's church** is built on a man who denied three times, "went out, and wept bitterly" (Matt 26:75), and was restored by a threefold charge to feed the sheep (John 21:15–17).
- **The dark man's counterfeit investiture** (6.5) gives Lloyd a key, promised in a Phoenix cell, and a black stone. It builds on a man who never falls away.

Loyalty without a fall is the rock of Las Vegas. Fidelity that has fallen and been restored is the rock of the *ekklēsia*. Petrella is neither. He is an office, and offices do not weep. The child is a beginning. Whether Boulder will be built on its Peter or its Petrella is the question C.3 must leave open.

King's 2021 coda shows that the author felt the weight of this choice. In it, Frannie gives birth not to Peter but to a daughter she names Abigail, after Mother Abagail. The gesture is reparative. Section 8.1 described the prophetess as the mother of a polity whose own lineage the plague erased, and the coda gives her a namesake. The novel's own choice remains Peter.

C.3 Standing Armies: The Marshal, the Guns, and Soft Despotism

The Free Zone the remnant returns to is not the one it left. It has survived the winter and grown rapidly, to about nineteen thousand people. Its tensions now concern governance and a growing push for law enforcement and control, with the arming of deputies as the symbol. Stu reflects on how fragile the new society is and on how organization can lead to authoritarianism. Stu was a reluctant Marshal and finally leaves for New England. His successor actively campaigned for the post. At the last Free Zone meeting the novel reports, Boulder is ready for a sheriff and ready for guns. The polity that ratified a dead re-

public's Constitution over its dead (4.1) now ratifies the very institution that republic's founders feared most.

English has a name for what is being founded, and the name belongs to this dissertation's lexicon: a *standing* army. In this phrase, "standing" means permanent, maintained in peacetime, kept on call. A standing army is *Bestand* in uniform, force as standing-reserve. The Anglo-American political tradition was born in fear of it:

- **1697.** Trenchard and Moyle's *An Argument Shewing, that a Standing Army Is Inconsistent with a Free Government*.
- **1776, the Declaration of Independence.** It charges the king with keeping "among us, in times of peace, Standing Armies without the Consent of our legislatures."
- **1776, the Virginia Declaration of Rights.** It holds that "standing armies, in time of peace, should be avoided as dangerous to liberty" (§13).
- **29 June 1787, Madison at the Convention.** "A standing military force, with an overgrown Executive will not long be safe companions to liberty."
- **The Second Amendment.** The militia it names is necessary to "the security of a free State," that is, of a *status*.

The novel opened with the State's fall (2.6). It closes with the State's first gesture of standing up again. Weber defined the state as the human community that successfully claims, within a territory, the monopoly of legitimate physical violence (*Politik als Beruf*, 1919). Hobbes had said it more briefly: "Covenants, without the Sword, are but Words" (*Leviathan* 17). When Boulder arms its deputies, it becomes a state in Weber's sense for the first time.

Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" separated the crosses' mythic violence from the Hand's divine violence (7.7). The same essay contains a theory of the police, and it applies here with unsettling precision.

- In the police, the separation between law-making and law-preserving violence is suspended (*aufgehoben*).

- The police intervene "for security reasons" wherever no clear legal situation exists.
- Their violence is therefore *gestaltlos*, "formless like its nowhere-tangible, all-pervasive, ghostly presence in the life of civilized states."

Each term returns the dark man: formless (5.4), everywhere and nowhere (5.6), spectral (5.3). The Hand removed his person from Las Vegas. It did not abolish his office, and the office does not need a person.

Popular criticism files Stu under the Cincinnatus type, and the classification is better than its source. Livy's Cincinnatus left his plough for the dictatorship, saved Rome, and laid the office down after sixteen days (III.26–29). The American republic made this a ritual when Washington resigned his commission at Annapolis on 23 December 1783. Stu's resignation belongs to that lineage. His successor's campaign belongs to another, which Latin named after a walk: *ambitio*, from *ambire*, "to go around," the canvasser's circuit of the forum. Ambition is, literally, the motion of the rim. The dark man walks the wheel's rim (5.6). The man who canvasses for the star walks it in miniature.

Aristotle wanted a polis to be *eusynoptos*, surveyable at a glance. He asked who could serve as herald to an excessive multitude "unless he had the voice of a Stentor" (*Politics* VII.4, 1326b). At nineteen thousand, the Free Zone has outgrown its heralds. Nick, the voiceless *logos*, is dead (4.3). Larry, the singer, died in Las Vegas. A polity of voice is becoming a polity of administration, and its administration is armed.

Tocqueville drew the most exact portrait of what Boulder is becoming, and he drew it by contrast with what Las Vegas was. In the chapter on the kind of despotism democratic nations have to fear (*De la démocratie en Amérique* II.4.6), he imagines a crowd of like and equal men who *tournent sans repos sur eux-mêmes*, "revolve without rest around themselves." Above them stands *un pouvoir immense et tutélaire*, an immense and tutelary power, absolute, detailed, regular, provident, and

mild. Its features can be taken one by one, each with its counterpart in this dissertation:

- **It keeps its subjects children.** It would resemble paternal authority if it prepared men for manhood. Instead it seeks *à les fixer irrévocablement dans l'enfance*, "to fix them irrevocably in childhood." Against it stand a man the world judged a child, who carried the witness home (C.1), and a child who will grow (C.2).
- **It shapes rather than breaks.** It does not break wills. It softens, bends, and directs them.
- **It prevents beginnings.** *Il ne détruit point, il empêche de naître*: "it does not destroy; it prevents being born." This is the precise antonym of natality.
- **It herds.** It reduces each nation to *un troupeau d'animaux timides et industrieux, dont le gouvernement est le berger*, "a flock of timid and industrious animals, of which the government is the shepherd." This is the hireling of John 10:12, whom 6.5 unmasked as the wolf.
- **It is a false center.** The revolving crowd is the rim (C.5), and the tutelary power is a counterfeit hub.

Las Vegas was hard despotism: crosses on the boulevard (4.5). Boulder's danger is the soft kind: security, provision, an ordered peace, deputies armed for everyone's good. Chapter 8.6 promised that this reading would side with Philip K. Dick. General Starkey's code was "Rome falls" (2.6). Dick's answer, from *VALIS*, describes the novel's last pages more accurately: "The Empire never ended." It came back to the Free Zone wearing a badge.

The kenotic disarmament of the four (7.2) is so radical that even the author could not leave it standing. The 2021 coda hands Fran an old-fashioned revolver and gun belt, christening the witness a gunslinger in the line of Roland Deschain. The 1978 novel would not arm its witnesses. The 2021 coda arms its witness.

C.4 The Ones Who Walk Away from Boulder

Fran is homesick and wants to return to Maine, and she and Stu plan a move east in July, once the babies are old enough to travel. They take the road of the four in reverse and stop where the whole convocation began. Months later, Stu and Frannie are at Mother Abigail's home with their son Peter, sitting on the porch as the sun goes down. Abagail died at sunrise (7.1). The novel's last human scene takes place on her porch at sunset.

Chapter 8.10 promised this section its title. Le Guin's walkers leave Omelas one at a time, each alone, going west or north toward the mountains, and they seem to know where they are going. King's last walkers reverse every term. They go together, east, away from the mountains, toward the sea, and toward a known place. The four had walked west over the Rockies to testify (7.2). The two walk back toward a home. Fran is going back to Maine. Book I found her in Ogunquit, a name usually glossed from the Abenaki as "beautiful place by the sea." Like Stewart's empty West (8.1), it was named by an earlier remnant.

Does Boulder have a cellar? Le Guin's question finds four rooms.

1. **The trance.** The first room is the trance and its eugenic cover story (C.1).
2. **The managed veto.** The second is the all-white committee's management of the prophetess's veto (7.1).
3. **The four.** The third is the four men whose deaths bought Boulder's safety (7.2). This room has a door. The four went freely, the city hid nothing, and one of them came back. Omelas depends on concealment; Boulder's sacrifice was public.
4. **The jail.** The fourth room is still being dug. Omelas keeps its child in a basement beneath one of its public buildings. A Free Zone with armed deputies will need a room with a lock, and that room's first prisoner will be the first inmate of Boulder's cellar.

The novel does not sanctify departure. Hirschman's central argument in *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* (1970) is that exit by the members most sensitive to decline deprives an organization of the voice that might have arrested it. The ones who walk away leave the cellar to the ones who stay. When Stu leaves, Petrella stands unopposed.

The novel's two exits differ in kind. Nadine's (6.1) was apostasy, a movement toward a master. Stu and Fran's is a *nostos*, a movement toward a home. Still, no exit is innocent of what it leaves behind. N. K. Jemisin answered Le Guin with "The Ones Who Stay and Fight" (2018). In it the just city of Um-Helat defends its justice against a contagion of hateful ideas and does not pretend the defense is gentle. *The Stand* holds both answers and absolves neither. The ones who stay will arm. The ones who walk away will leave the arming to them.

The porch, finally, has an etymology of its own. Greek *stoa*, "colonnade," is a word most etymologists trace, by way of its rows of standing pillars, to the root of Table 3. Zeno taught under the Painted Stoa, and Stoicism took its name from that porch. Its virtue was *constantia*, which Justus Lipsius, writing during the wars of the Low Countries, defined as *rectum et immotum animi robur, non elati externis aut fortuitis, non depressi*: "a right and immovable strength of mind, neither lifted up nor pressed down by external or chance things" (*De constantia* I. 4). The novel's last human words are spoken on a porch, but they are not Stoic. The porch at Hemingford Home hears the learned opposite of the immovable mind's certainty (C.6).

C.5 The Wheel and Its Hub

In 1990 King set *The Stand* inside a circle. The restored text opens with "The Circle Opens," in which Campion deserts his post (2.1). It closes with "The Circle Closes," in which the adversary wakes on a beach among strangers and begins again (5.6). Its last sentence is the wheel: life was such a wheel "that no man could stand upon it for long," and it "always, at the end, came round to the same place again." This dissertation has read the novel as a chi inscribed in that circle (Introduction;

Figure 1). The Conclusion can now say where in the circle the stand is located.

A turning wheel has exactly one point at rest: its axis. The narrator's sentence is true of the rim, where no one can stand for long. It is false of the hub, the only place on a wheel where one can stand. The tradition knew this before physics did.

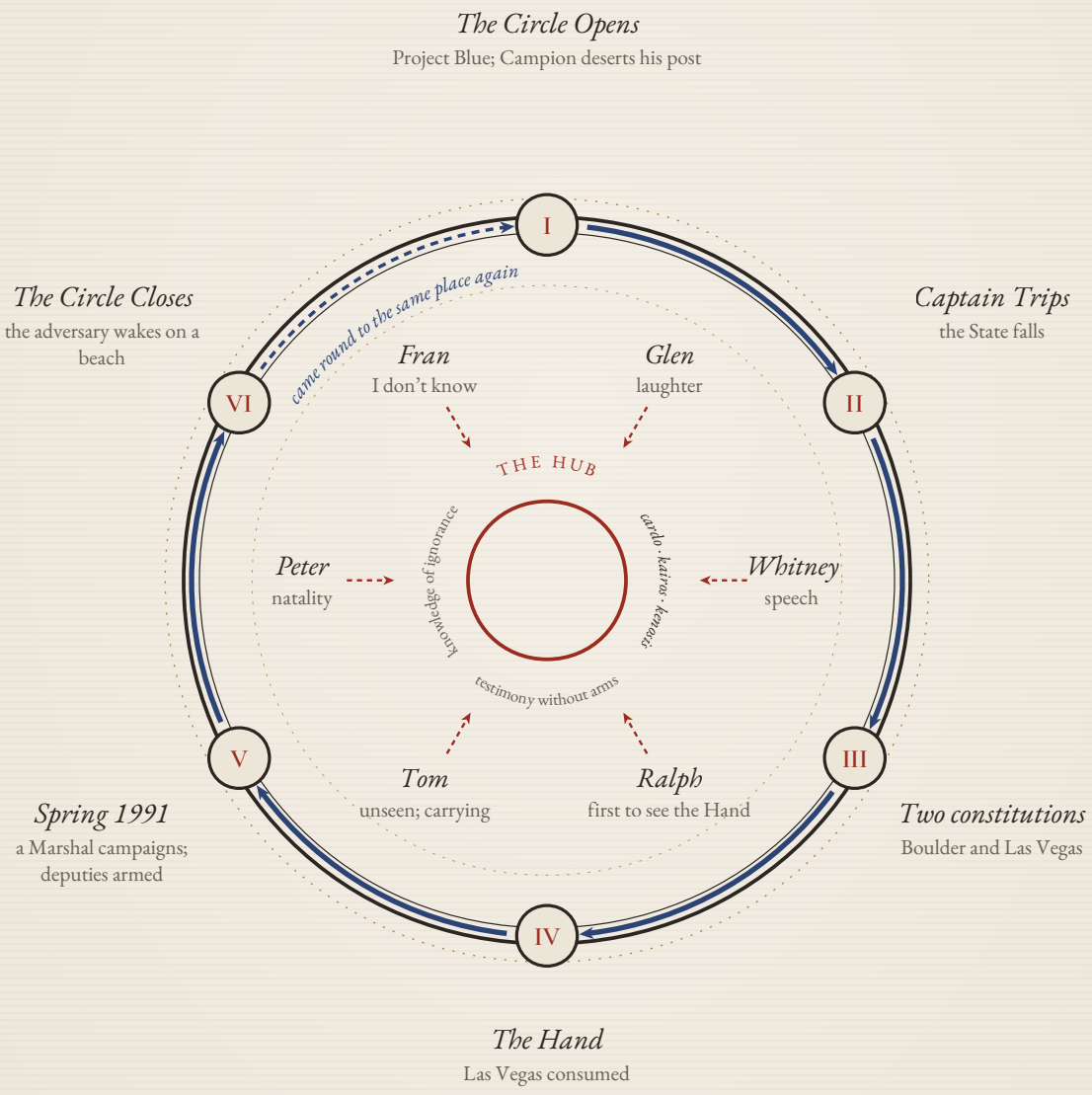
1. **Boethius.** Fortune speaks for the rim: *rotam volubili orbe versamus, infima summis summa infimis mutare gaudemus*, "we turn the wheel in its spinning orbit, and delight to change the lowest to the highest and the highest to the lowest" (*Consolatio* II pr. 2). Climb if you like, she adds, but do not call it an injury when the rules of the game bring you down. Philosophy answers for the hub. Fate and providence are related as concentric circles turning about a single *cardo*, a hinge. The outermost circle wheels widest, and *tanto aliquid fato liberum est quanto illum rerum cardinem vicinius petit*: "a thing is free of fate in proportion as it seeks nearer to that hinge of things" (IV pr. 6). Flagg spends the whole novel on the rim. The witnesses, for an instant, reached the hinge.
2. **Laozi.** The *Daodejing* adds what Boethius lacked: "Thirty spokes share one hub; it is in its emptiness that the use of the cart lies" (三十輻共一轂，當其無，有車之用, ch. 11). The hub is not a sovereign center but a void, and it works because nothing occupies it. This is the Taoist form of the kenotic exception (4.2; Phil 2:7). The witnesses reach the hub by emptying themselves of weapons, of mission, and of knowledge (7.2). Zhuangzi's "pivot of the Way" in "the center of the ring" (8.10) is the same still point.
3. **Ezekiel.** The prophet's throne-chariot moves on "a wheel in the middle of a wheel" (Ezek 1:16). Its rims are "full of eyes round about" (1:18), and "the spirit of the living creature was in the wheels" (1:20). In Ezekiel the eyes belong to a rim that the spirit animates. The dark man's Eye (5.3) is a rim full of eyes with no spirit in the wheels.

4. **Dante.** The *Commedia* ends on the image King's sentence reverses. The pilgrim's desire and will are turned *sì come rota ch'igualmente è mossa*, "like a wheel that is evenly moved," by *l'amor che move il sole e l'altre stelle* (*Par.* XXXIII.143–45). King's wheel throws everyone off. Dante's turns evenly, because love turns it from the hub. Eliot named the same place "the still point of the turning world."
5. **Nietzsche.** In "The Convalescent," Zarathustra's animals sing the eternal return: *ewig rollt das Rad des Seins*, "eternally rolls the wheel of being," and *Die Mitte ist überall*, "the center is everywhere." Zarathustra calls their song a barrel-organ tune, a *Leier-Lied*. He mocks the wheel without a hub as mere repetition.
6. **Cusanus.** Cusanus supplies the theorem that makes these images cohere. The world-machine "has its center everywhere and its circumference nowhere, for God is its circumference and center" (*De docta ignorantia* II.12). As a circle's diameter grows, its curvature diminishes, until the maximal circle is minimally curved and therefore maximally straight (I.13). Seen from infinity, the wheel is a road. The Conclusion therefore need not choose between the novel's two figures of time, the 1990 wheel and the road east that Stu and Fran take. In Cusanus's geometry they are one figure seen at two magnitudes.

Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843) supplies the temporal grammar. Recollection and repetition, he argues, are the same movement in opposite directions. What is recollected has been, and is repeated backward; genuine repetition is recollected forward. The dark man's recurrence is a third and degenerate case: repetition with no recollection at all. In the 1990 coda he wakes not knowing where he is and takes a new name (C. 6), so he cannot even repeat backward. He simply recurs. This is Eliade's eternal return without its consolation: archaic cyclical time served as a defense against the "terror of history," and the Hand is that terror breaking into the cycle. The witnesses' return is repetition forward. They go back to Hemingford Home and to Maine to begin, not to repeat. One child has recovered, and another is coming.

Figure 6

The wheel completed



The wheel completed. The rim carries the novel's history from "The Circle Opens" to "The Circle Closes," and every station on it is a form of stasis*; the broken arrow is the narrator's last sentence. The hub is empty, as Laozi's must be. No event on the rim reaches it; only postures do: laughter, speech, sight, carrying, birth, and the confession of ignorance. This figure is the closure of Figure 1.*

The hub, then, is not a place but a posture. The novel said so at the threshold of the stand: the place where you made your stand never mattered (Chapter 7, opening). Cusanus's theorem says the same: the center is everywhere. The hub is wherever someone stands without arms and without certainty. It is Socrates at his post (C.6), Abagail in the wilderness (7.1), Glen in a Las Vegas cell (7.5). It is also a woman on a porch in Nebraska, for as long as it takes to say three words.

C.6 *Docta Ignorantia*: "I Don't Know"

King has described his struggle to reach a satisfactory conclusion to the final scene, in which Frannie and Stu put their son to bed and ponder what their struggle meant. Stu asks Frannie whether she thinks "people ever learn anything." She replies, reluctantly, "I don't know." She struggles to say more and can only say it again. King has explained that he could find nothing else for her to say that would not ring shallow, and that he did not believe the novel had a moral. Most readers take the ending as a shrug. This dissertation takes it as the novel's last and most exact act of thought. In the tradition gathered here, "I don't know" is not the absence of an answer. It is the oldest form of wisdom.

Diotima. Who speaks matters first. The question of learning (*mathēsis*) is put to a pregnant woman, at dusk, on the prophetess's porch. Plato gave Socrates' wisdom about *eros* to such a woman. Diotima of Mantinea teaches three things.

- *Eros* dwells *μεταξὺ σοφίας καὶ ἀμαθίας*, "between wisdom and ignorance" (*Symposium* 203e).
- No god philosophizes, because the gods are wise; nor do the ignorant, because ignorance is content with itself (204a).
- *κυοῦσιν… πάντες ἄνθρωποι*, "all human beings are pregnant, in body and in soul" (206c), and generation is the mortal's share in immortality (206e–207a).

Fran on the porch is Diotima's doctrine embodied. She is pregnant, she stands between wisdom and ignorance, and she knows that she

stands between. Eric Voegelin made Diotima's *metaxy* his name for the structure of human existence: suspended between knowledge and ignorance, time and the timeless, and betrayed whenever it is closed in either direction. Las Vegas closed it toward knowledge, toward the Eye and the dark man's gnosis. The jeremiad closes it toward a national telos (4.6). Fran's sentence holds it open.

Socrates. Diotima's pupil made the *metaxy* a method. Before his judges, his superiority over the man reputed wise is only this: "he thinks he knows something when he does not, whereas I, as I do not know, do not think I know either" (*Apology* 21d). The *Apology* also contains the philosophy of the stand. Wherever a man has stationed himself, thinking it best, or has been stationed by his commander, "there he must remain and run the risk" (*μένοντα κινδυνεύειν*, 28d). Socrates had held his post at Potidaea, Amphipolis, and Delium, and he will not desert the post the god assigned him (28e). Alcibiades remembers that at Potidaea Socrates stood (*εἱστήκει*) lost in thought from one dawn to the next, then prayed to the sun and went away (*Symposium* 220c–d). The philosopher's all-night stand ends at sunrise with a prayer, as Abagail's life ended at sunrise (7.1). The *Apology* closes on the god who alone knows which goes to the better, the dying or the living (42a; this Conclusion's epigraph). The founding text of Western philosophy ends on "I don't know," spoken by a witness who is about to die.

Cusanus. Cusanus made the Socratic confession a theology. *De docta ignorantia* (1440) begins from the principle that nothing more perfect can happen to the most studious man than to be found most learned in the ignorance proper to him: *et tanto quis doctior erit, quanto se sciverit magis ignorantem*, "the more he knows himself ignorant, the more learned he will be" (I.1). Its image of knowledge is a wheel. The intellect stands to truth as a polygon inscribed in a circle: the more angles it has, the more it resembles the circle, but it never becomes equal to it, even if its angles are multiplied to infinity (I.3). Human knowledge of the wheel is always polygonal, and "I don't know" is the polygon admitting that it is not the circle. Cusanus says the insight came to him at sea, returning from Greece, as a gift "from the Father of

lights." It taught him to embrace incomprehensibles incomprehensibly. Learned ignorance was the fruit of a journey home, as Fran's is.

Freud. In 1930 Freud asked Stu's question. *Das Unbehagen in der Kultur* ends by naming the species' fateful question (*die Schicksalsfrage der Menschenart*): whether, and how far, cultural development will master the disturbance of communal life by the human drive to aggression and self-destruction. Men now control the forces of nature so completely that they could easily exterminate one another *bis auf den letzten Mann*, "to the last man." That phrase is Shelley's title (8.2), and the possibility it names is the plot of Book I.

In the 1931 edition, with Hitler's menace already apparent, Freud added a final sentence. Eternal Eros will exert himself to hold his ground (*sich zu behaupten*) against his "equally immortal adversary": *Aber wer kann den Erfolg und Ausgang voraussehen?* "But who can foresee the success and the outcome?" The sentence maps onto the novel term by term:

- *Sich behaupten* is to hold one's ground, to stand.
- The equally immortal adversary is the novel's walker on the rim, whose immortality the 1990 coda confirms.
- Freud's fifth chapter supplied the *homo homini lupus* of 5.5.
- The pregnant woman on the porch speaks for Eros.

Freud's last sentence is "I don't know" in German, written in the shadow of the event that made the twentieth century the century of fear (8.4).

Boethius. Boethius completes the typology by distinguishing two ignorances. Philosophy diagnoses her patient: *quid ipse sis, nosse desisti*, "you have ceased to know what you yourself are." Because he does not know the end of things, he takes wicked and lawless men to be powerful and happy (*Consolatio* I pr. 6). Tom Cullen's one theological pronouncement diagnoses the dark man in the same terms: "He came out of time. He doesn't know himself." Flagg has Boethius's disease without Boethius's consolation. His is *ignorantia indocta*, ignorance of the self, which mistakes the rim for the world. Fran's is *docta ignor-*

antia, knowledge of the limit, which refuses to mistake any polygon for the circle.

This yields a structural finding about the two editions:

- **1978** ends on learned ignorance: a woman's "I don't know" on a porch.
- **1990** ends on unlearned ignorance: the adversary waking on a beach, unsure where he is and taking a new name, followed by the narrator's wheel.

The completed novel contains both, in the right order. The witness's learned ignorance comes first, and the adversary's unlearned ignorance is consigned to the rim.

Abraham and Job. "I don't know" also answers the question 7.7 left open. When the Hand consumed the righteous with the wicked, Abraham's question at Sodom returned without its ancient reprieve: "Shall not the Judge of all the earth do right?" (Gen 18:25). The novel gives the only answer it can honestly give. Job gave the same answer after the whirlwind: "therefore have I uttered that I understood not; things too wonderful for me, which I knew not" (Job 42:3). So did Ecclesiastes, the book that gave Stewart his title (8.1): though a wise man think to know the work of God, "yet shall he not be able to find it" (Eccl 8:17).

Table 17 Endings in learned ignorance

Text	Date	Closing words	Speaker and situation	What remains unknown
Plato, *Apology* 42a	399 BCE (dramatic)	"...unclear to everyone except the god"	Socrates, condemned	Whether death or life is the better
Job 42:3	—	"things too wonderful for me, which I knew not"	Job's final speech, after the whirlwind	The justice of the Judge of all the earth
Boethius, *Consolatio* V pr. 6	c. 524	"...you act before the eyes of a judge who discerns all things"	Philosophy, to a prisoner awaiting execution; the narrative frame never closes	The prisoner's fate, which the book does not tell
Cusanus, *De docta ignorantia*	1440	To embrace "incomprehensibles incomprehensibly"	The author, returning by sea from Greece	God, the maximum

Text	Date	Closing words	Speaker and situation	What remains unknown
Wittgenstein, *Tractatus* 7	1921	*Wovon man nicht sprechen kann, darüber muß man schweigen*	The author, at the war's end	What can only be shown
Freud, ***Das Unbehagen in der Kultur***	1930; last sentence 1931	*Aber wer kann den Erfolg und Ausgang voraussehen?*	The analyst, as Hitler rises	The outcome of Eros against his immortal adversary
King, ***The Stand***	1978/1990	"I don't know"	Fran Goldsmith, pregnant, on Mother Abagail's porch	Whether people ever learn anything

Boethius's final sentence deserves particular notice: *Magna vobis est… necessitas indicta probitatis, cum ante oculos agitis iudicis cuncta cernentis*. The *Consolation* ends on the counter-Eye, a gaze that discerns everything and orders nothing. It is the gaze Cusanus painted, and the gaze before which Tom is visible (C.1).

The 2021 answer. In 2021 the author supplied an answer. King returned to his story by writing the series' final episode himself. In it, Frannie and Stu still leave Boulder for Maine and still stop at a version of Mother Abagail's old home. There King builds a short side narrative around the farm's well: with Stu away for supplies, Frannie falls into the darkness and makes her stand against a dreamlike Flagg whose spirit persists after his defeat. She is rewarded with a vision of Mother Abagail and with an apparently reincarnated Abagail, who emerges from the corn, pulls her from the well, heals her wounds, and disappears. At the end of the journey, on a beach in Maine, Frannie repeats the words Abagail gave her as the answer to the novel's unanswered question. The words are: "The wheel turns, the struggle continues, and the command is always the same. Be true. Stand."

It is tempting to read the coda as a retraction of 1978, learned ignorance traded in for a moral. That reading misses the structure. The three endings answer three different questions. Kant enumerated them, adding a fourth that gathers them, in the *Logik* (1800): What can I know? What ought I to do? What may I hope? What is man? He noted that the first three refer to the last.

Table 18 The endings of *The Stand* and Kant's four questions

Kant's question	Ending	Words	Speaker	Posture
Was kann ich wissen?	1978, retained 1990	"I don't know"	Fran, on Abagail's porch	*Docta ignorantia*
Was soll ich tun?	2021	"Be true. Stand."	Fran, on a beach in Maine, repeating Abagail	Testimony as command
Was darf ich hoffen?	1978/1990	A fever that breaks; a second pregnancy	Unspoken	Natality (C.2)
Was ist der Mensch?	1990	The wheel "no man could stand upon... for long"; the adversary who "doesn't know himself"	The narrator; Tom	The creature that can stand only at the hub (C.5)

The command does not cancel the ignorance; it presupposes it. No one who could guarantee the outcome would need to command a stand. Flagg offers exactly such a guarantee in the well: that she can return to her body and her daughter, and that Stu will not be crushed changing a tire on the way back, in exchange for one kiss. The stand is the ethical form of learned ignorance: knowing that one does not know, and standing anyway. Socrates at his post (28d) and Milton's servants who "only stand and wait" (7.3) are its patterns.

The coda also repeats a problem this dissertation has refused to drop. Stu learns that Frannie is at the bottom of the well from a young African American girl living in a tent in the cornfields, who sings the same song Mother Abagail sang. Abagail then appears as an old woman who draws the white heroine from the pit, heals her, and vanishes. The scene has a shape older than the trope. Jeremiah, the jeremiad's eponym, was let down into a cistern and sank in the mire, and Ebed-melech the Ethiopian drew him up with cords and old rags (Jer 38:6–13). The older shape does not discharge the trope. Chapter 7.1 found that Abagail's theological and social meanings coincide, and that neither absolves the other. That finding holds in 2021 as it did in 1978.

The author's late answer is testimony, in Wimsatt and Beardsley's sense, not law. It shows what the book meant to its maker four decades

later. It cannot overrule the sentence he wrote in 1978, which keeps its place at the hub.

C.7 Contributions and Coda

The Introduction claimed nine contributions. The chapters have discharged them and added several the Introduction could not foresee.

Table 19 **Contributions of this dissertation**

No.	Contribution	Principal locus	Consequence
1	The stasiological lexicon: the distributed polysemy of **steh₂-* (*status*, *ekstasis*, *constitutio*, *Bestand*, *apostasis*, *testis*/*superstes*, *anastasis*), completed by the earth's *stat* (8.1), the Psalter's *yikkôn* (C.1), Isaiah's *yāqûm*/*stabit* (C.2), the *stoa* (C.4), and *con-stans* (C.7)	Introduction; Ch. 1; Table 3	The title names a field of meanings, not a battle
2	The misremembered Dugway accident, and the reporter's wind, as the seed of a horizontal theology	Introduction; Ch. 2; C.2	Catastrophe travels by road and wind before judgment falls vertically; Isaiah's *rûaḥ* unites chance and spirit
3	The Millerite text: the novel read within the American adventist tradition of date-setting and disappointment	Introduction; C.7	The novel is a fiction of the morning after
4	Plague as *Bestand*; Las Vegas as the *Bestand*-city	Chs. 2, 4, 5	The adversary is standing-reserve given a face; the Eye cannot see what is not stock (C.1)
5	The chiasmus of plague and Hand	Ch. 1; 7.8; Figure 4	Augustinian and Josephine providence (evil turned to good), visible for one instant
6	A theory of the unarmed witness (Benveniste's *testis* and *superstes*)	7.4; Table 11	The stand is testimony, not combat; the last *superstes* is the reader
7	Locke's appeal to Heaven and Benjamin's divine violence made literal, with Korah (Numbers 16) as shared model	7.2; 7.7	Divine violence that no human wields; Derrida's worry answered
8	Malachi 3:2 as the hinge between *Earth Abides* and *The Stand*	8.1; Table 13; Figure 5	One Hebrew verb, two English titles; extended to Isaiah 40:8 and 1 Peter 1:25 (C.2)
9	"I don't know" as *docta ignorantia*	C.6; Tables 17–18	The ending is the novel's most exact act of thought

No.	Contribution	Principal locus	Consequence
10	A comparative typology of ends	8.11 (typology of ends)	Only *The Stand* unites revealed judgment with indiscriminate judgment; it turns the survivor from *superstes* into *testis*
11	The lithic constellation: Boulder and "the meadows"; Peter and Petrella	C.2; Table 16	The last founding is divided between a child and an office
12	The theology of the moon: Tom as the "faithful witness in heaven"	C.1	The wheel and the witness are joined in one image
13	The two ignorances and the two editions	C.6	1978 ends in *docta*, 1990 in *indocta ignorantia*
14	The hub as emptiness and posture	C.5; Figure 6	The stand escapes the wheel by occupying the one point that does not turn

Sacvan Bercovitch's *The American Jeremiad* appeared in 1978, the same year as *The Stand*. Its thesis is that the American jeremiad was "a ritual designed to join social criticism to spiritual renewal." Its denunciations were absorbed into a consensus they finally reaffirmed, so that dissent became the national liturgy. Chapter 4.6 called King's version a restricted jeremiad: it performs the criticism and withholds the renewal. The last chapter completes the refusal. The novel ends neither on America, nor on mission, nor on a city upon a hill. It ends on a departure and a confession of ignorance, spoken on the porch of a farmhouse in the Nebraska corn by a woman who is leaving.

Festinger, Riecken, and Schachter opened *When Prophecy Fails* (1956) with the Millerites. They observed that when a predicted end fails to arrive, the faithful often proselytize harder, to quiet the dissonance. King's remnant has seen the end arrive, and it does the opposite: it does not proselytize; it goes home. This dissertation refuses the ritual too. It will not supply the moral its author declined in 1978 and has handled with care ever since. It offers no consensus, only a posture.

This dissertation is dated 22 October. On that night in 1844 the followers of William Miller waited for the end. Samuel S. Snow had fixed the date from Daniel 8:14: "Unto two thousand and three hundred

days; then shall the sanctuary be cleansed." The night became the Great Disappointment. Hiram Edson remembered: "We wept, and wept, till the day dawn." On the morning of the twenty-third, crossing a cornfield, Edson saw, as he later recounted, that the end had been misplaced, not cancelled. The sanctuary to be cleansed was in heaven, and the event had taken place there, unseen.

The adventist tradition was born in a cornfield on the morning after. *The Stand* was conceived, by King's own account, under a wind that might have blown the other way over a Utah valley (C.2), and it closes on a summer evening in a Nebraska cornfield. It refuses both Millerite options: the end fulfilled on earth (the millennium) and the end relocated to heaven (the invisible sanctuary). It shows the end visibly, for one instant, over one city. Afterward it declines to say what that instant means for the rest of time.

The novel calls its last witness by name. King addresses his reader as "Constant Reader," and *constans* is the present participle of *con-stare*, "to stand together, to stand firm." Lipsius made *constantia* the virtue for times of civil war; King made it a form of address. Chapter 7.4 concluded that no human witness of the Hand survives with full sight. Ralph and Larry were consumed, Stu saw only light, Tom was elsewhere, and Flagg has no self to remember with. The last *superstes* of Las Vegas is the one who has read to the end and is still holding the book. Testimony requires an addressee, as Shelley's last man learned in a Rome without readers (8.2). *The Stand* has made its reader that addressee.

Who shall be able to stand? The answer can now be given in the novel's own terms. Not the State, which stands itself up and falls (2.6). Not the city of *Bestand*, which stands everyone in reserve and burns (4.4; 7.7). Not the city of *constitutio*, which stands together over its dead and then arms its deputies (4.1; C.3). Those who stand at the hub: unarmed, unknowing, there and still on their feet for as long as the light takes to fall. After the light, they go home, where someone must be born.

The wheel turns, as the narrator said it would. It is dusk on a summer evening in Nebraska. On the porch of a dead woman's house, a

man asks whether people ever learn anything, and a woman carrying a child says she does not know. For as long as she is saying it, the wheel has a hub.



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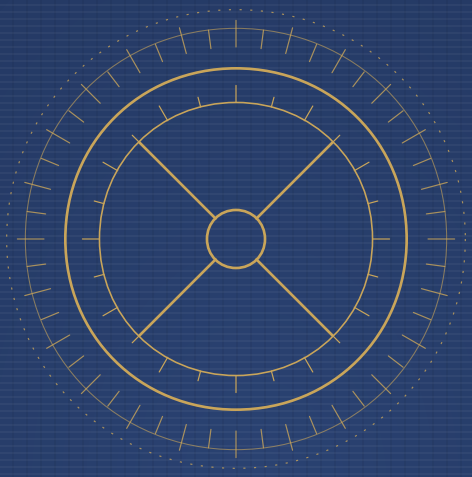
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